Knight Avant!

Renee Greene



DeBokton Book

Find your hero within!

DeBokton.com

Copyright © 2024 by Renee Greene

DeBokton Book

All rights reserved. No part of this book may be reproduced or transmitted in any form or by any means, electronic or mechanical, including photocopying, recording, or by any information storage and retrieval system, without written permission from the publisher or author.

ISBN: 9798320194585

Dedicated to:

Tom MacDonald and Nova Rockafeller

who were the inspiration for the hero and heroine of this adventure.

Tom and Nova,

I have been trying for the last year to get this to you, so I hope it gets there this time. I'm having it sent directly from Amazon kdp, so instead of autographing it and sending a note, I'm writing it here in a proof copy. Please let me know if you get it. My email is darkhairedhalfling@yahoo.com.

Please accept this as a gift from a fan. I hope you read it and enjoy it. I'd love to hear what you think of it. I write obsessively as a hobby, and really thought the two of you would make great heroes in a fantasy novel, as you are so heroic and inspiring in real life.

I hope I bring some joy to you and puts a smile on your faces. The two of you have helped me through some hard times, and I've learned I need to build my castle from the sticks and the stones.

Happy reading!

-- Renee Greene


Renaud
Roifort
Freedom Faction
Lamagi
Montlier


Arwood
Varoux
Fletcher's Field
Tamur
Bellemar
Chesterfield
N
W
E
S

Table of Contents

Chapter 1: Fists, Fights, and a Really Dangerous Bet.....9

Chapter 2: Fire, Flips, and a Serious Threat.....23

Chapter 3: Ale, Songs, and One Hard Punch.....29

Chapter 4: A Challenge, Disappointment, and a Hangover ..... .45

Chapter 5: A Story, A Brawl, and a Pretty Dance Partner ..... .53

Chapter 6: Market, The Great Hall, and an Offer that Couldn't Be Refused.....69

Chapter 7: Beasts, Blood, and a Cute Little Girl.....79

Chapter 8: A Fish, a Backdoor, and a Really Inaccurate Tale.....87

Chapter 9: A Meeting, a Secret Plot, and Cooked Herring ..... .97

Chapter 10: Another fight, a Truthful Song, and a Round of Ale.....106

Chapter 11: Captives, Fire, and an *Intimidating* Duke. 116

Chapter 12: A *Gati, A Sprite, and A Beautiful Faunen*. 127

Chapter 13: Misery, Mistakes, and a Spiked Whip.....136

Chapter 14: Recovery, a Goal, and a Suitor.....146

Chapter 15: A Song, an Argument, and a Spicy Lime. .154

Chapter 16: A Raid, A New Guild, and A Lifeless Halo ..... .161

Chapter 17: A Song, a Hint, and a Big Coincidence.....167

Chapter 18: A Legend, History, and a Mock Sword Fight ..... .173
Chapter 19: Good News, A Mother, and a Meeting with a Lord.....184
Chapter 20: A Chimera, An Exposing Song, and An Unwanted Order.....189
Chapter 21: A Deal, A Beating, and a Long Shot.....201
Chapter 22: A Secret Meeting, an Open Meeting, and a Demotion..... .208
Chapter 23: Singing, Dancing, and Big Threats.....220
Chapter 24: A King, A Threat, and a Wishy-Washy Verdict.....228
Chapter 25: A Beast, A Faunen, and a Rhyme War……239
Chapter 26: A Trap, Mercenaries, and a Lord's Guards251
Chapter 27: A Really Bad Song, A Game, and A Spy...259
Chapter 28: The Mine, A Secret Passage, and Glowing Green Moss.....273
Chapter 29: Boar Meat, a Sassy Girl, and an Unfinished Tale.....285
Chapter 30: Sunlight, A Story of Corruption, and An Unexpected Kiss..... .294
Chapter 31: A Dungeon Break, Mutton Sandwiches, and a Proud Woman.....307
Chapter 32: A Morose Song, A Panicked Faunen, and an Unsuccessful Lie.....317
Chapter 33: Lies, More Lies, and a Challenge to the Death.....326
Chapter 34: A Bloody Battle, Tied Prisoners, and a Bunny Guard..... .339

Chapter 35: A Coward, A Winner, and a Magic Trick. .347
Chapter 36: Demands, Whining, and a Killer Raccoon362
Chapter 37: A Medal of Honor, An Insult, and a Juggling War.....369

Chapter 1: Fists, Fights, and a Really Dangerous Bet

Allistair clasped his hands nervously as he watched the gruesome fight on the field the crowd was gathered around, knowing he would be next.

His best friend, Hartley, a lanky man with pointy Elven ears and a monkey tail that was flicking a restless rhythm against the wooden barrier he was leaning against, slapped his hand on Allistair's shoulder and encouraged, "Don't worry. If you win this, you walk out with a fat purse. If not, you'll likely be dead, so you won't feel a thing."

"Feckin' brilliant," Allistair quipped. "Remind me again why I keep you around."

"Because I'm the only one who tells you the truth to keep your head on straight," Hartley grinned, flicking his tail. "I'm just trying to lessen the nerves. You can beat

either of these men. You have a massive size advantage over the cat-boy, and the giant is huge, but the bigger they are, the harder they fall."

Allistair wished he shared Hartley's confidence. He looked out at the men fighting. An eight-foot tall giant, named Theo, grabbed at a man two-and-a-half feet shorter than him with cat ears on the top of his head and a tail. The cat-man, from a race called the Crevan – a breed where everyone carried at least one animal trait – was quick, ducked out of the way, and struck with his sharp claws. As he did, he dropped to the ground and swept Theo's leg, hoping the giant would fall.

The crowd cheered, but Allistair tensed, seeing the mistake the crevan had made.

Theo fell with a giant thud, but as he did, he was able to turn, fall beside the crevan, and elbow him in the face, knocking him out cold and sending more blood spattered on the ground.

Gasps from the crowd rose, as the crevan was obviously injured, and Allistair could feel his heart beating in his chest. He'd have to fight Theo next, and he could end up as broken as the crevan. Allistair stared at Theo, who was roaring to the crowd with his fists pumped high in the air. Theo was terrifying, a mountain of muscle, with a jaw like an anvil, and a manner more beast than man.

A heraldic trumpet sounded victory for Theo. Some in the crowd, mostly filled with commoners watching from the stands, cheered wildly for him, while others booed, hoping to see the underdog win. Allistair wished the crevan had won. Fighting the giant would be hard. He'd rather have fought the crevan. Crevan often had

hyper-senses due to their animal, so that gave them very quick reflexes, but Allistair would rather fight that than Theo, the most colossal giant Allistair had ever laid eyes on.

Everyone in the stands had favorites, as they watched tournaments often. After all, tourney games were allowed in all cities in the kingdom of Renaud and were a favorite pastime in the town of Chesterfield.

Chesterfield was a striking coastal town, encompassed by rolling meadows, dense woods, and a sweeping view of the mountains in the distance. From high in a tree, the distant battlements of Roifort could be seen. Roifort, the capital city where the king held court, towered majestically above the surrounding lands.

The beautiful scenery and the cool breeze didn't really matter to most of the people at the tourney that day. They cared about the brutal competitions at hand.

The crowd was all excited as, after a short break for the champion to rest, the herald announced the final match of the day. The normal townfolks and tourney champions weren't allowed to do jousting, as that was a knight's event, so they had sword fighting with wooden swords, where the fighters fought until one surrendered, staff fighting, which was done on several logs with the object being to knock the opponent off. The biggest event was the wrestling matches. There were few rules, so really it was more grappling than wrestling. Many people called it that.

The herald announced, "Attention, everyone! This is the big event everyone has been waiting for! Our final two competitors are Theo, the giant, verses Allistair, the Mokos." He was going to say more, but the crowd went

wild, their screams of excitement ringing through the air, so his voice could not be heard.

Theo the giant came out first, roaring to the crowd and pumping his fists, urging on the grand chorus of cheers that rang out for him. That wasn't encouraging to Allistair. Those same people would be rooting for him to lose, possibly die.

Next it was Allistair's turn. He waited nervously at the side as Theo went out, bouncing around a bit to pump himself up with energy. When it was time, he ran out, raised his hands high, and called out, "Make some noise! I'm fighting this for you!"

The crowd gave an eager "huzzah" and cheered as if he'd just defeated a bull, as he stepped over and faced off with Theo.

Allistair was not short, as he was part-giant himself and stood a little over six feet tall, but still, he had to lean his head back to look up at Theo. The eight-foot-tall opponent was as intimidating as facing a massive beast. Theo obviously was full giant, which was rare. Allistair's main race was that of mokos. The mokos had the trait that their skin was marked with markings they earned. Allistair had a marking on his right forearm, a rampant centaur carrying a torch. That was fitting, as the centaur represented passion, and the rampant position showed he was passionate about his fighting. The torch represented zeal for life, truth, and intelligence.

Hopefully his energy and passion would help him defeat an opponent so much larger and fiercer than he was.

Theo glared down at him and taunted, "Prepare to die!"

“Please, don’t kill me,” Allistair pleaded. “I am rather fond of being alive.”

To his surprise, Theo kept his hard expression, but responded, “I won’t, but I will put on a good show, and I will win, which I warn you may hurt.” He then called to the crowd, “Watch me kick him to Roifort!” and gestured with his hands to encourage them to cheer. They did, very vociferously.

Allistair stared at Theo in utter shock. Was Theo not really as out for blood as he appeared? Was there a side to Theo that he didn’t show to the public? Apparently, to Theo the contest was more show than fight, perhaps because Theo never lost. Allistair took a breath, trying to focus. Hopefully, he could make Theo see what it felt like to lose.

Allistair held his fist up to the crowd, and received mighty cheers to, but were they for him or due to the crowd wanting to see a good opponent for Theo to crush?

Allistair breathed deeply. The fight wasn’t to the death, but it would likely be to knock-out. Concession was allowed, but not respected, so there was no way Allistair would humiliate himself and concede.

“I’m going to break you,” Theo threatened, but Allistair ignored him, hoping Theo was trying to intimidate him and put on a show for the crowd.

Instead of throwing a taunt back, Allistair jumped around a bit for show as he punched the air. That time the crowd roared as if he’d just fought a lion. It was good to have the support of the fans, but they had much greater faith in him than he did himself. Theo was going to be a tough opponent, like a rogue warhorse who trampled his own master, so Allistair would likely leave in pain.

At the sound of a horn, he suddenly stopped dancing around and took his stance to start. He could feel his heart beating. He needed to win. The prize for winning wasn't huge, but winning tournaments put food on the table, and he didn't want to let the people down either.

The herald then unleashed a piercing blast of his trumpet to signal the start of the fight.

Theo lunged forward, trying to jump on Allistair and crush him beneath his massive weight, but where Theo had the size and strength advantage, Allistair had the dexterity advantage. He hit the blood spattered ground, rolled cleanly out of the way and back up to his feet. As soon as he stood up, he kicked viciously at Theo. Theo grabbed his foot and threw him, hoping to shatter him against the ground, but Allistair flew back and did a flawless back tuck, landing solidly on his feet.

Theo tried to pound Allistair with both fists, but Allistair turned straight into him, grabbed both wrists, and used his lower center of gravity to throw Theo to the ground.

Theo fell with a bone-rattling thud, and Allistair jumped on top of him. Unfortunately, Theo surged forward, rolling over on top of him and viciously pounding on him with his massive knuckles. Each punch felt like getting hit with a sledgehammer, and Allistair feared his head would crack open. The headache alone made him feel as if his skull would split from the raw agony. Why the feck was he having to fight a giant? Fighting crevan, other mokos, or even rhys would have been better, and rhys were dragon people who could create fire in their hands.

Allistair jammed the heel of his hand directly into

Theo's chin, pushing back with every ounce of leverage he could muster until Theo was forced to move back, giving Allistair just enough room to roll out from under him.

Allistair's head was spinning, but he had to focus. He jumped up and came down hard on Theo, driving his elbow into the giant's back. Theo let out an audible "oof" and tried to knock Allistair off his back, but Allistair grabbed his arm and pulled it back into a brutal lock.

"Give up," Allistair urged, his voice a tight snarl. "I could break your arm."

Theo didn't submit, but leveraged his massive bulk to roll over and break free.

As the giant started to sit up. Allistair slammed a foot on his shoulder and quickly flipped back, surprising Theo by landing squarely on his chest and knocking him down again. Allistair then pulled his fist back and unleashed a finishing blow that knocked Theo instantly unconscious.

The crowd went wild, and Allistair raised his fists in victory. Then he put his foot on Theo and posed, forcing his muscles to lock so the searing pain wouldn't show. The roar of the excited crowd always gave him such a surge of excitement that he could work the crowd despite the pain of the bruises and the blood running down his face. With all the excitement and the dizziness, he hadn't even noticed that Theo had severely cut his ear.

The herald blew the horn again, so the crowd stopped cheering, and Allistair stepped up to receive the award.

The tournaments in Chesterfield didn't have huge prizes, as they were local, small-scale events hosted by a mere lord, Lord Urvan. He lacked the fortunes of the

dukes who rule the big cities, let alone the bottomless wealth of the king. Tournaments in the capital city of Roifort definitely paid better.

Still, Allistair was handed a leather pouch containing twenty copper coins by a strikingly beautiful maiden whose face was instantly recognizable. Everyone in the province knew who she was – Lina, the captivating minstrel. Her main race was that of a sprite. Sprites looked fairly normal, except that they could change their coloring at will. That day, she had long, yellow hair with pink tips that showed off her bright icy blue eyes. Sprites excelled at any sort of art. Lina's voice could put a nightingale to shame. She performed as a minstrel often, and everyone knew and loved her, as her bubbly personality always seemed to brighten everyone's day. Lord Urvan liked to have her help with the tournaments as people would join the crowd just to see her and hear her perform during breaks.

"You didn't die out there – well done," she complimented, her eyes dancing with mischief as she handed Allistair the pouch. She then chuckled and teased, "Honestly, you looked half-decent. Good thing for you I wasn't a contestant today, or you would have been the one eating dirt."

"Right," Allistair chuckled. "You weigh what, a hundred pounds soaking wet? Come on."

"I'd still beat you," she teased back. "You're way too much of a gentleman to actually hit a girl."

Allistair shook his head and chuckled as he conceded, "All right. Fair enough. You have me there." Then he winked and whispered, "I wouldn't knock you out, but it wouldn't take much to scoop you up, set you

gently on the ground, and sit on you so you couldn't get up and have to concede."

"You keep thinking that. I'm full of surprises," she teased back. "Are you ticklish?"

She winked at him, took his hand, raised it to the crowd, and called out, "Clap unless you think you can beat him!" The crowd laughed at her comment, and once again cheered for Allistair. He basked in the glory, the prize, the beautiful girl, and the approval of the crowd making the pain worth it.

The cheers stopped, instantly silent, as a man with a commanding presence walked out on the field, Sir Elliot. He was a lesser knight serving as an ambassador from Roifort to Chesterfield, thought his primary duty was to collect taxes for the king. He was part crevan and part rhys. Sometimes rhys were referred to as dragon people. They didn't genuinely resemble dragons, but they were given the name because they had horns on their heads and could produce fire from their hands. They couldn't control the fire or throw fireballs, but they could catch a haystack on fire or burn an enemy with a touch, a truly intimidating ability. Sir Elliot had ram horns instead of the normal rhys horns, as his crevan animal was a ram. He did have the rhys ability of lighting his hands on fire, but lacked the common rhys trait of having a tail. His look was as terrifying as an executioner, and his temperament as merciless as the headsman's axe.

No one cheered as Sir Elliot took the field, the crowd paralyzed, knowing his appearance there meant something grim was about to happen.

He marched directly up to Allistair and Lina and hissed, "Move aside. It's my turn."

Allistair stepped in front of Lina to protect her and, without a trace of fear, quipped back, “Did you know your nose is crooked? Hold still a second, I think I can punch it back in place.”

“Don’t threaten me, lad!” Elliot seethed.

“It was just an offer,” Allistair replied, sounding as casual as if Elliot had just offered him some mead. He then suggested to Lina, “Let’s go.”

Before Lina walked off, she peeked around Allistair and quipped to Elliot, “Your nose is crooked. I guess it matches the rest of you.” She then smiled at him, nodded, and walked off with Allistair.

Sir Elliot threw his nose in the air, turned away from them, and addressed the crowd. “Lords, Ladies, and peasants, I, Sir Elliot, ambassador from the king, have been instructed by King Didier to announce that there will be a small increase in taxes, just a trifle.”

The crowd began to boo, but Sir Elliot put his hand on his sword, and hissed, “You will obey me as you do the king. I speak in his name!”

Silence instantly fell on the crowd, cold silence that send shivers of fear through everyone. Elliot was feared, known not just for his ruthless demeanor, but for his skill with a sword, and his willingness to make an example of anyone who crossed him. He also could call for help from the knights of the noble houses, who were known for backing the local knights, no matter what mischief they were involved in. The only group of knights the people really had faith left in was the Knight Avants, a special force directly under the king’s command. Their reputation described them as noble, brave, and defenders of the people. One day, Allistair hoped to join them.

Not even a breath could be heard from the crowd as Sir Elliot continued in a sugary tone, “Peasants, know that King Didier cares about you. I do too. We do not delight in seeing peasants suffer, but the tax is necessary. Our kingdom is at threat of war. The kingdoms across the mountains are building armies. There are other needs too, and every citizen must do his part to help the kingdom as a whole. So in one week, the town of Chesterfield will pay an additional tax of five-hundred silver pieces.”

A wave of horrified gasps broke the silence of the crowd. Five hundred silver pieces was a king’s ransom. The town of Chesterfield only had about two thousand people in it total, so that amounted to about a quarter of a silver piece for each person. Large families would be hit hard, as a silver piece was worth ten coppers, and two coppers was considered a fair day’s wage.

The excitement of the fights was suddenly dampened, a fog of despair sticking to everyone.

Allistair stepped right into Elliot’s space, squaring his shoulders. “Tell you what – let’s make a deal? You and me, right here, right now, a straight grapple. If I win, you scrap the extortion. We pay nothing. If you win, we toss in ten extra silver pieces.”

Elliot waved his gauntleted hand flippantly. “I have my orders. The tax is five hundred silver.”

“What, you scared?” Allistair mocked, a sharp, cynical grin cutting across his face. “Afraid that without your fancy sword and your little knights backing you up that you can’t actually beat me in a fair fight?”

Elliot glared at him, his jaw tightening. “I’m not afraid of you. I am a knight. I could crush you easily.”

“Then prove it. Step up and take the challenge,”

Allistair barked. He spun around to face the crowd, throwing his arms wide as he called out, “What do you say? Do you want to see this big bad knight grapple with me?”

The crowd began cheering wildly until it broke out chanting, “Fight! Fight! Fight!”

“Double the tax if I win,” Elliot countered.

“That’s highway robbery, and we both know it,” Allistair shot back, shaking his head. “Twenty extra silver pieces if I lose. Take it or leave it.”

“Fifty,” Elliot hissed. “But if I lose, the tax is only cut in half.”

Allistair turned to the crowd, spreading his arms wide and projecting his voice over the noise. “Listen up! This cur, the crown’s favorite lapdog, wants fifty extra silver out of your pockets if I go down, but will only cut his rotten tax by half if I win. Are we taking these rigged odd or what?”

That was an obvious choice for the crowd. They again chanted, “Fight! Fight! Fight!”

“Deal,” Allistair agreed with a confident smile. “Step into the dirt.”

“One more condition,” Elliot corrected. “I get to use my sword.”

Allistair’s heart began racing, pounding as if trying to escape his chest,, and he could feel the palms of his hands sweating. “The challenge was a straight grapple, coward,” he snapped.

“If you want the chance at two-hundred and fifty for the tax, you have to meet my conditions,” Elliot sneered.

He stepped closer, hissing in Allistair's face, "Are you afraid?"

Was he afraid? Of course he was afraid. He'd be a feckin' fool not to be afraid. Yet, he met Elliot's glare without flinching. "If I win, the tax lowers to two-hundred."

Elliot laughed a mocking laugh. "If you win? This is a death wish for you. I have fire, horns, and a sword. You cannot beat me."

"Quit stalling, two hundred?" Allistair pressed.

Elliot chuckled. "Two-hundred silver, but not a copper less."

Allistair turned to the crowd. He clasped his hands together for a moment to keep them from shaking, hiding the tremor behind a showman's bravado. Then he took a breath, raised his hand to the crowd, and called out, "He wants to bring steel to a wrestling match! Two-hundred silver if I beat a man with fire, horns, and a blade. Do we do it?"

"Huzzah!" the crowd cheered.

"I'm unarmed. I could actually die!" Allistair called back, half-hoping the people would come to their senses.

"Huzzah!" the crowd cheered again. "Do it!" Once again the erupted into chanting, "Fight! Fight! Fight!"

Allistair smiled back at the crowd, forcing a grin across his face so they wouldn't see how much it hurt to have them calling for his likely death. Sure, it would save them money, and they really didn't understand how brutal fights really were, not every having felt the bite of steel or the pounding of fists. To them, blood on the field was just cheap entertainment. Still, he'd hoped he was worth

more than three hundred silver pieces to the people he was trying to protect.

He sighed, shaking his head at their blind, reckless expectation. They had way too much faith in him.

He turned his back on the cheering stands, rolling his shoulders as Elliot's sword cleared its scabbard with a sharp, metallic hiss.

Allistair raised his empty, calloused, bare knuckles, knowing he was about to bleed for a crowd that loved his name, yet still valued silver more than his life.

Chapter 2: Fire, Flips, and a Serious Threat

Allistair started to turn to take his place in the dirt, trying to relax his muscles for the fight, when a sudden blur approached, stopping in front of him to reveal it was Lina. She shoved a battered flask straight against his chest.

“Drink up, big guy!” she offered as she handed it to him, her eyes wide, bright, and filled with energy. “You just fought a mountain, and now you are going to dance with a fire-breathing snake. You must be parched. Chug it before you drop.”

Allistair thanked her, took the flask, and guzzled the yeasty table ale, surprised by the sharp, cooling bite of peppermint infused into the brew. As he drank, Lina rattled on, “You can win this if you fight smart. Don’t let this crooked-nose knave get inside your head. He’s wandought, incredibly weak. Sure, he has steal and fire, but a sword only does much good if he doesn’t know how to use it.”

“I think he knows the pointy end goes in the enemy,” Allistair grunted, wiping his mouth with the back of his hand. “Wprd is he’s lethal with a blade.”

“Hang reputations! They are just noise made to scare people,” Lina countered, her words tumbling out fast and fierce. “Elliot is a coxcomb, a fool. His words boast of his might, but he’s a coward underneath. Disarm him, and it’s a fair fight. You can win that. There is no better grappler in Chesterfield than you.”

“Disarm him?” Allistair scoffed. “That is my plan, sweatheart, but have you ever tried grabbing a man’s burning hand holding a broadsword?”

“No,” Lina admitted, flashing a reckless grin. “Honestly, you champions tend to make fights look fairly easy. Do you really think if people realized the danger you are in or the pain of fights that they would look at it as entertainment?”

She had a point – people loved a hero right up until the blood stained their boots. Honestly, he wished he could stay there and talk to her. After all, talking to a beautiful maiden was much more pleasant than stepping into a fight with a man who was trying to butcher him.

Yet, he handed the flask back to Lina, nodded, and stepped over to take his place. He bent his knees and widened his stance, as he always did before grappling. No, that wouldn’t work. He shifted to a lighter stance built for dodging. Why had he accepted the conditions? It was feckin' foolish. Elliot was part crevan, specifically ram. That meant that he’d be strong and take a hit well. Plus the curved horns looked like they could gore a horse. He also was part Rhys, so he would be able to light his hands on fire. Plus, he had a sword. Allistair was no

match for that. He had good intuition from his mokos half, and raw strength from his giant blood and brutal training. Still, he knew he'd likely be dead soon. He looked over at the crowd. He was fighting for them, for people like Lina. He didn't even know her, but she believed in him. He had to be the people's champion.

The herald stepped in front of the stands and blew his trumpet, the brassy note cutting through the air as the entire crowd erupted into cheers for Allistair.

Elliot immediately drew his sword. Allistair had hoped to get a strike in before he cleared the sheath, but failed. All he could do was run away.

Allistair jumped back. Elliot swung strike after strike, the heavy blade whistling inches from Allistair's chest, and Allistair could do nothing but retreat.

The crowd was chanting "Fight… Fight… Fight," but Allistair knew better than to act rashly. He quickly glanced around, his thoughts flipping rapidly, trying to take in the surrounding to get an idea, and spotted the split-rail fence the people sat behind. That would do it.

His thoughts distracted him, so he dodged a split second too late. Elliot grazed him with his sword, the cold steel slicing open his side. The cut was shallow, but warm blood immediately soaked into his tunic, bringing a sharp, stinging ache.

At least Allistair wasn't dead. He pressed his hand against the wound to stem the bleeding and sprinted toward the fence. Of course Elliot charged after him, lowering his horns like a battering ram.

With Elliot right on his heels, Allistair planted a boot on the bottom rail of the fence, vaulted upward, and executed a clean backflip over Elliot. The instant

Allistair's boots hit the dirt behind Elliot, he grabbed Elliot and slammed him hard against the ground.

As Elliot fell, Allistair kicked the sword from his hand and dove on top of him. Allistair had the strength advantage, but Elliot clamped his burning hands onto Allistair's arm, the smell of blistered skin hit Allistair's nostrils instantly, and the searing pain made focusing on the fight almost impossible.

Allistair felt like the fire was coursing straight through his veins, cooking him like a roasted boar, but he couldn't let Elliot win. He gritted his teeth in agony, twisted around, and rolled backward to break the grip. As he scrambled up, Elliot did too. They both faced off, both with eyes burning with determination.

"Now you die!" Elliot seethed, flaring his hand with roaring flames and lowering his horns to charge again.

Allistair's right arm was burned badly. He couldn't throw a hit with it, so he jumped up, wrapped both legs around Elliot's shoulders, and used his own weight to pull him down to the ground.

Elliot grabbed Allistair's right leg and started burning it, searing through his trousers, but Allistair planted his foot firmly on the ground and drove a brutal kick with his left heel straight into Elliot's temple, knocking him out cold.

Allistair stumbled and almost fell to the ground, but he caught himself with one hand in the dirt and pushed himself up quickly. Then he turned to the crowd and raised his good fist in victory. The crowd roared, and he tried to keep a smile on his face so they wouldn't see the agony of the burns and bruises.

A short, brown-haired maiden with green eyes and

delicate, translucent wings fluttered out onto the field. That was expected. The brown-haired, green-eyed, winged race was the faunen. They weren't strong, but had a great touch with nature. Their gardens produced well, and although they couldn't speak to animals, they had a way with them. Their best quality was that they could also heal. That was what the maiden was coming to do. She went first to Elliot, as he was unconscious.

While she healed him, the crowd came onto the field and surrounded Allistair. He really didn't feel well enough to handle the crowd. He'd been burned and cut, the world spinning around him, his head so disoriented that he had a hard time standing, but he put on a good face as Lina and Hartley ran over, helped him up, and hooked his arms over their shoulders to steady him.

"Good job," Hartley assured him, grinning. "You won. I guess I don't get to go loot your room after all."

"Very funny," Allistair rasped through clenched teeth. "I'd come up with a sharp comeback, but my brain is cooked. I need to sleep."

"We need to get you to the faunen," Lina insisted, her voice tight with worry. "You need healing."

"Feckin' brilliant," Allistair mumbled. "Let's go see the magic fairy."

"Let him through," Lina called to the crowd, planting her free hand on her hip. "Don't make me have to force any of you back." No one took that comment as a threat, as she said it with a smile and looked as if a strong breeze could knock her over. After all, she was a beautiful, petite sprite.

The crowd did part to let Allistair through, and he forced a smile for them as he limped by. But his smile

suddenly died as the crowd parted to reveal someone blocking his path.

Allistair suddenly found himself face to face with Elliot.

Their eyes met in silent combat until Elliot threatened in a low, venomous voice, “You are going to regret this. I promise you will. I am a powerful man and a bad enemy to have.”

Chapter 3: Ale, Songs, and One Hard Punch

Allistair didn't find the faunen in the crowd, and she didn't find him, so he and Hartley headed to the Red Wolf Tavern and Inn. They'd been there many times. Jacob, the owner of the tavern, would be expecting them to come after the tournament.

Allistair and Hartley walked in the door with Allistair's side still trickling blood and his arm and leg visibly burned.

"Do you want to go to a room and get cleaned up?" Jacob asked, the lines around his eyes showing his age, but his broad shoulders showing he was still strong. "You aren't looking so good. I understand how that goes. I had my share of fights when I was your age. I was a champion too. Have I told you about the time I stopped the stampede of wild boars and we cooked them up and feasted?"

"Only about a hundred times, old man," Allistair muttered, leaning heavily against a timber bar to keep his

legs from buckling. “Look, I love a good pork story as much as the next guy, but I’m currently bleeding all over your floor. Unless one of those boars is gonna carry me upstairs, skip the tale and get me a bed.”

“Sorry,” Jacob mumbled. “Yet, those were the days… Before chimeric beasts and high taxes.” He glanced around the room before whispering, “Do you know there were actually still some wizards then?”

That caught Allistair’s attention. Magic had been destroyed over a hundred years ago. There had been rumors of a few remaining sorcerers, but they were feared, hunted down, and killed. People feared to even talk of sorcery. Yet, Allistair mumbled, “Weren’t wizards evil, or is that just more nonsense the crown feeds us?”

“Some were,” Jacob admitted. “Yet, some were very benign. Magic still exists north of the mountains north of Arwood. Yet, I shouldn’t mention it.” He leaned even closer, his voice barely audible. “I had a fairy who worked for me. There was a time where a drunken man tried to force himself on her, and she cast a spell on him and turned his head into that of a donkey.” He sighed. “It wore off, but those two weeks were incredible. Unfortunately, she had to flee back up north for her life.” He glanced around again, as a nervous mouse watching for a cat. “I shouldn’t talk of magic. You fought well today, and saved the town three hundred silver pieces. Your first drink tonight is on me.”

Allistair was stumbling toward the stairs to go to a room to clean up, when the same faunen who had healed Elliot walked into the tavern. “I’ve come to heal you,” she offered in a bright, joyful voice, as she walked right up to him.

“I won’t turn down a pretty magic fairy healing me,” Allistair grunted, leaning against a wooden wall. “Turns out getting cut and roasted alive hurts a bit.”

She took him to a room and had him take off his blood-stained shirt and lie on a bed. When he did, she eyed his muscles and commented, “This isn’t going to be a bad way to earn a copper piece.”

“What?” Allistair mumbled, too delirious from the loss of blood to get too worried. “Hold on… Are you charging me? I’m flat broke.”

“No” the faunen assured him. “You owe me nothing.”

“What? Somebody’s actually helping just to be kind?” Allistair slurred, his face buried in the bed.

“Oh, no,” the faunen corrected. “I’m getting paid, just not by you. Lord Urvan hired me to come to the tournament and heal anyone who needed healing there. I bargained for an extra copper for you since I had to come here.”

That surprised Allistair. She looked so innocent with her long brown hair, deep green eyes, and iridescent wings, as if she’d heal anyone just from the goodness of her heart. He tried to shake his head, but it made him dizzy. “Feckin’ little mercenary.”

She shrugged innocently. “A girl has to make a living.”

Then she put her hands on his wounds, as that was the normal way faunens healed. The only other race who had healing ability was the elves. They healed by holding crystals and blowing on people. It would stabilize someone, but not heal as well as faunens could.

“This is better than burning,” Allistair sighed as a healing warmth spread from her palms through him. “Though I gotta say, I’d recover twice as fast if you healed with kisses.”

“I get that request often,” the faunen smirked. “If I could, it would cost a lot more than a copper to get me to heal you.”

“What?” Allistair blurted out. “Did I hear you right? You have a price tag? You little minx.”

“I’m joking,” she assured him. “I am not the type who can be paid for favors. I’m no doxy. I am glad I heal the way I do. I would not want to have had to kiss Elliot today. Trust me that Urvan could not have paid me enough to do that.”

“He’s tough enough to heal on his own,” Allistair grunted. “If not, he deserves some pain.”

The faunen shrugged. “Perhaps. Perhaps not. You kicked him hard.” She smiled demurely and added, “You are very strong,” as she continued to gently glide her warm hands across his toned chest.

Allistair let out a long, slow, relaxing breath as the searing pain began to fade. “If I can’t get a kiss, how about at least telling me your name?”

“Raissa,” the beautiful, winged maiden replied. “You don’t have to tell me who you are. Everyone around knows who you are.”

“Only the ones paying a copper to watch me bleed at tournaments,” Allistair muttered dryly.

Raissa put her hand on his neck, and the bruises and soreness began to vanish.

“I like the laurel wreath markings around your neck,” she commented as she healed him.

He startled, bolting up so fast he nearly knocked her over. “Laurel wreath? What?”

She went over to a table that had a small hand mirror on it and brought it over to him. He stared into it, as shocked as if he’d just opened the winning pouch to see gold instead of silver. “Holy feck! That’s new.”

“You definitely earned it,” Raissa beamed. “A laurel wreath is a symbol of triumph, and you definitely triumphed today.”

“Did I?” Allistair muttered, still staring in the mirror, his fingers brushing along the mark. “Look at the game they are playing, Raissa. They ride in demanding five hundred silver, I bleed in the dirt to knock it down to two hundred, and now the whole town is cheering like we won a war, forgetting we are getting robbed blind. That’s still a two hundred silver piece extra tax.”

He set the hand mirror on the table with a dull thud. “It’s the oldest trick in the book. Threaten to take everything, take half instead, and the people will thank you for it while picking their pockets. The people will now be happy that their extra tax is less than half of what was demanded instead of being infuriated that there is an extra tax at all. I don’t believe half the stories the crown feeds us about those kingdoms across the mountains. They’re likely lies to scare people into paying up.”

Raissa gazed at him, taking in every word he said. “Wise. Of course, I should have expected that from you.”

“What?” Allistair laughed. “Everyone thinks because I throw punches for copper, I’m too dumb to count. I’m glad you notice that I’ve got plenty between my ears.” He

winked at her and added, “The muscle is just a nice bonus.”

Raissa blushed. “You do, and I admit I have been guilty of assuming you were all brawn, but when I healed you, I saw the markings on your left arm. You have an inkwell with fire coming from it and a martlet coming from the fire. That makes quite the statement about you. The inkwell is a symbol of literacy. You must know how to read and write. That is unusual for this town.”

Allistair flexed his arm to see how well the healing had worked. “My parents were dead set on me learning to read and write.”

Raissa tilted her head curiously. “I haven’t heard of your father. Should I have?”

“Why would you?” Allistair replied with a dry smirk. “He’s a carpenter, not some lord sitting in a stone tower, so the martlet is fitting. Nobody handed me a title or a bag of gold. Everything I have, I bled for and built myself.”

“Impressive,” Raissa muttered before speaking up so Allistair could hear. “The fire is obvious why you have that. You definitely have passion for what you do.”

Allistair shrugged, a half-grin tugging at he mouth, though Raissa couldn’t tell if he was agreeing or disagreeing. She rubbed her warm hand along his ear and cheek before stepping back. “I’m done. I can’t heal everything with as badly as you were wounded. You’ll be sore for a while, but you won’t have any permanent damage from the cut. It was worse than you thought. Your ear was sliced almost off. I don’t think you even noticed that with all the shock you were in, but it may have lasting effects.”

“Shock?” Allistair grunted, reaching up to feel his ear. “Well, that explains why the ceiling was spinning and I nearly agreed to pay you for kisses.”

Raissa once again ran her hand down his face and chest. “I really can do no more. Perhaps you should go back to the main room and enjoy the celebration. Many people will want to congratulate you tonight.”

He stood up and startedputting his shirt on. Raissa shook her head, smiling at the sight. “What a waste, hiding a chest like that under a shirt. That is one enjoyable benefit about being a healer. I do get to see handsome fighters shirtless. Even better, I get paid for it.” Her eyes went wide and her tone serious. “Of course, not everyone I see is as handsome as you, and I do have to see a great deal of blood and gore. There is a very dark side to my job, but at least I can counter some of the horror by being the light amid the gloom and saving people from death.”

Allistair reached down, as she was over a foot shorter than him, looked in her eyes, and merely responded, “Thank you.” He stayed looking in her eyes for a moment. He’d been healed by her before, as she often was the healer for tournaments in Chesterfield, but he’d never had a conversation with her. Never had he thought of how a faunen must feel putting her hands on a bloody wound or seeing someone dying in front of her and hoping she could heal him.

“You’re welcome,” she responded. “I am happy to have helped.”

“Because you are a copper wealthier?” he teased.

She smiled. “That doesn’t hurt. I might as well make money off what I do. After all, you make money off what

you do."

Allistair rolled his eyes. "Only if I win."

Raissa tensed as she admitted, "I don't generally get paid if I can't heal someone and he dies. Don't think my job is easy. You don't have lives depending on you."

That was true. Perhaps sometimes he'd talk to Raissa and really learn of the faunen. There weren't that many in most cities, as most faunen lived in Bellemar, an island off the east coast. It was inhabited by faunen and courtites, a race of very small people, about three to four feet tall. They were rumored to be excellent gardeners, to love food, and to have a simple life. The noble house there, the house of Garnier, was courtites, but people knew little of them, as they kept to themselves.

Once Allistair had put his shirt and tunic on, he and Raissa headed back to the main room. He was eager to get there, as he wanted to get a hero's kiss from a beautiful maiden, and he knew exactly which one.

The room was loud, so loud that it was hard to hear the lute player, but when Allistair walked into the room, a man roared over the noise, "He's here!"

The crowd raised their mugs and called out, "Huzzah!"

Allistair raised his fists in acknowledgment and cut through the noisy taproom to find Jacob. "I'm ready for that drink, old man," he grunted.

Jacob didn't even look up from the mug he was filling. "Posset or braggot?"

Allistair raised his eyebrows, staring at Jacob as if he'd grown a second head. "Hold on. Did I hear you right? You're actually pouring top-shelf braggot or

posset? Feckin' glorious!"

Jacob turned around and met his eyes. "You saved the town three hundred silver pieces. You know, one time, I rescued a maiden from bandits, and I was given free posset for a month, as the tavern owner in Roifort, where I was, wanted his son to marry her. I'm not giving you free posset or braggot for a month, just one drink, but I think you deserve it. You saved the town three hundred silver pieces."

Allistair clenched his lips for a moment. The people weren't really saving money. They just weren't paying as high of an extra tax. They should all be upset about that, not celebrating a decrease in the tyranny. Yet, Allistair wasn't going to turn down the fancy drink. After all, posset was a spicy creamy wine, with milk and spices definitely good for a healing tonic, and braggot was a rich honey meade, spiced with ginger and cloves, and generally used for celebrations.

"Braggot," Allistair decided.

Jacob filled a mug of braggot and handed it to Allistair, who took it, thanked him, and went over and sat at the table Hartley was at.

"Can I have one of those?" Hartley teased, seeing the braggot. "If you'd told me there was braggot as a reward, maybe I'd have fought Elliot."

Allistair chuckled in response, but made no snide comment because a serving wench with bunny ears and a tail walked over to him. She had very curly hair that came just past her shoulders. Likely, her eyes were some color, but no man ever looked at her eyes with her figure and how low her blouse was cut. She sat beside him and gave him a very passionate hero's kiss. After the kiss, she

rubbed her hand along his shoulders and offered, “When I’m done working, perhaps I can give you an even better hero’s reward.”

He answered her by giving her another kiss. After all, he knew her well. Her name was Sephora, and she was very friendly. It wasn’t the first time he’d kissed her. The crowd around him cheered. He picked up his mug, raised it to them, and then took a drink. Braggot was good. There was a reason it was considered a drink to celebrate a hero.

Sephora winked at him and teased, “Maybe someday you’ll ask me to marry you.” She looked over her shoulder as she turned to get back to work. Allistair watched her go, then went back to enjoying his drink. One that good needed to be savored.

As he swished the braggot around in his mouth to enjoy every spice, Lina stood up in front of everyone and called the noisy crowd to order. Everyone immediately became quiet.

Allistair almost didn’t recognize her, as she’d changed her hair to brown with purple highlights, where it had been blond with pink tips earlier that day, a common problem as many sprites changed their coloring often. She had also changed her clothing. Instead of a formal ceremonial dress, she wore a billowy-sleeved peasant blouse between a fitted burgundy bodice, fastened with small leather buckles and cinched by a wide brown belt. The hip flaps rested over a layered, asymmetric skirt, split up the front to show dark leggings and tall boots. Around her neck, she wore a crystal pendant on a thin chain.

“It’s that time of night,” Lina hollered, hopping onto

a sturdy wooden table with boundless energy. “Prepare to be amazed!”

Everyone knew what she meant, as Jacob had been boasting all evening that she would be singing that night.

The crowd cheered for Lina, clapping and stomping their boots, so she waved her hands wildly to get them quiet. “I’m thrilled to be raising the roof off this place tonight! Are we ready to make some noise?”

The crowd roared back, so she hushed them with a dramatic finger to her lips, and started into a fast, spirited tune, her fingers flying across her lute.

When she finished, she waited for the applause to crescendo, and then called out, “For my next song, who’s brave enough to step up and sing with me?”

No one dared to sing with her except one drunken man who raised his mug, tried to stand up, and immediately passed out cold before taking two steps.

Lina planted her hands on her hips, scanning the room. Was no one really going to take her offer?

“I’ll sing,” Allistair called out, setting his mug down on the table.

“You sing?” Lina asked, her eyes lighting up as everyone in the room gasped in surprise. After all, fighters don’t sing, do they?

Allistair shook his head as he looked around, knowing exactly what they were all thinking, that he could do nothing but fight. He shrugged and walked up to Lina, “I don’t know how well I sing, sweetheart, and I’m definitely no choir boy, but I love music. Let’s do it.”

Lina strummed a few lively bars, and they both

started singing. Allistair knew the words. Everyone knew the words, as she was playing a common folk song.

At the end of the song, the crowd erupted. Lina pointed to dramatically to Allistair, so he took a deep, showman's bow.

When he straightened up, she leaned in close, her eyes glinting with mischief, and whispered, "How are you at improvising lyrics?"

He raised his eyebrows. "Guess we're about to find out. Honestly, I'd rather have time to sit down with parchment and ink, map out my thoughts, organize them, and make the verses sharp."

"Well, you have five seconds to do that," Lina teased as she picked her lute up and started strumming. "Keep up big guy – let's go!"

She then began singing:

"I'm one who has to make her way, through song and wit and fun,
I entertain with energy. I really aim to stun.
I'm not afraid to be myself with dukes or king's or knights.
So don't expect apologies. I'm me, a playful sprite."

She pointed to Allistair and played a few bars of a bridge to give him time to think.

Allistair was supposed to come up with lyrics on the spot with everyone watching, every eye in the room glued on him. Sweat suddenly beaded on his forehead. He'd rather go into a grappling match. There, he knew the rules. All he had to do was punch people. Yet, he was singing, not fighting. He'd have to accept that his verse

wouldn’t be perfect. He glanced the crowd. At least he wouldn’t take a beating in front of them. Finally, his eyes caught Lina’s. She smiled at him, calming his nerves, and he sang:

> “I want to live and die my dream. I want to make my way.
> My path’s not clear to be the man I want to be someday.
> For now I’ll live and seize the day with fights and ale and ham.
> I’m trying to enjoy my life, just being who I am.”

Lina then started singing a chorus:

> “Who I am. Who I am. I’ll be true to who I am.
> Who I am. Who I am. I like being who I am.”

It didn’t take long for Allistair to pick up on the tune and start singing along.

When they finished, the noisy crowd hollered for more. Allistair looked out over them with his eyebrows raised. His words were thrown together quickly, not polished at all, so he wasn’t sure why the people were so excited. Then again, half of them were drunk. He could likely make up a rhyme about squirrels who steal the people’s food, so the people eat them fried and stewed, and still have the drunks laugh at it. Still, he’d enjoy the applause. He’d watched minstrels sing and always wanted to do it.

Lina let him go sit back down and sang a song that started off,

“Do you like me just now, how I’ve changed,
how I’ve grown?
Zounds! I’ll tell you straight out that I’m full of
unknown.
I’m short but bold. Don’t mess with me.
I’ll make you smile quite easily.”

Allistair smiled as he listened to her song. Her energy and innocent look captivated him, but there was more to her – she had spunk! Perhaps sometimes he could hear her story.

He went back to his braggot as he listened to her playful tunes. When he finished his drink, he ordered another, that time a plain ale, as he was paying. He had won some money, so he could splurge a little, but he had debts to pay too.

He and Hartley kept drinking until almost everyone had cleared out for the night. When Hartley fell asleep with his cheek pressed against the hard table, Allistair pushed himself up, walked heavily over to the bar, and dropped on a wooden stool, slamming his mug on the counter, splashing dark ale, and glared at Jacob. “What is wrong with everyone? People so stupid... The crown invents a new tax out of thin air, and everyone just bends over and takes it without question. Yeah, I’m glad I bled to knock it down, but nobody should be cheerig. They shouldn’t be paying a single feckin’ copper extra. They throw a little music and a wrestling match in front of them, and suddenly everyone’s blind to the fact that they’re still getting robbed. When are they going to open their eyes?”

Before Jacob could answer, Allistair finished his mug and then closed his eyes as he swayed on the stool and his

head dropped onto the counter with a dull thud. Teh impact jolted him wide awake, and he snapped upright, blinking rapidly, on high alert.

“People are too trusting,” Jacob agreed. “Back in my day, we handled our own problems. Sure, kings have always made laws, but we didn’t want them in our lives too much.” He sighed. “Honestly, I don’t know if the kingdom west of the mountain is a threat or not. In my day, I’d have gone over there and had a look for myself, but times have changed.”

Allistair responded by again swaying and having his head fall on the counter with a thud. When it hit, the impact again jolted him awake and he snapped back up. “I’m listening.”

Jacob shook his head. His stories would have to wait. “Perhaps you just aren’t thinking clearly. You’ve had a few too many ales tonight. Go to a room.”

“Maybe I feckin’ should,” Allistair muttered, tipping his mug over and giving it a shake, seeing that he’d drained every drop. “Bed sounds like a solid plan. Didn’t Sephora make me an offer? My head’s too foggy to remember, but she’s a dream.” He rubbed his head. “Dreams… Was I dreaming, or did I really get up and sing in front of the whole taproom?”

“Yes, and you were good,” Jacob answered, wiping the counter with a damp rag. “Now, go to sleep before you do something foolish.”

“I like being feckin’ foolish,” Allistair laughed, hitting his hand on the counter. “Truth is, I make a living out of it.” He looked at his empty mug. If only that was true. The drink wasn’t all for fun. Even with his fame as a tournament fighter, and crowds cheering for him,

carrying the weight of a rigged would was exhausting. He didn't reach for the ale because he wanted tohave fun. He drank to escape reality.

"Go to bed," Jacob urged. "Seriously, you've had too much."

Allistair stood up, but wobbled, trying to get his balance by holding onto the stool. He spun around for a moment, trying to figure out which way was the hall to the rooms. It was far too late to try to make it home.

He stumbled toward the fuzzy hallway, but lost his balance and fell to the floor as the door flew open. Elliot strutted in, his head held high. Two lesser knights flanked him, one on each side.

Elliot stormed over, grabbed Allistair's shirt, and pulled him up to a sitting position. "Look at you now. You're pathetic," Elliot mocked. He leaned in, hissing in Allistair's face, "I warned you that you would regret beating me." He pulled his free hand back and struck Allistair with a right hook.

Allistair saw the hit coming, yet the ale had turned his limbs to lead. His brain screamed at him to block, but his body didn't respond. The blow cracked across his jaw like an iron mallet, lighting up his skull in a blinding flash before the tavern floor rushed up to meet him – and everything went black.

Elliot stood up, sneered down at him unconscious on the floor and threatened, "You are going to regret humiliating me."

Chapter 4: A Challenge, Disappointment, and a Hangover

The next morning, Allistair woke up with a splitting headache and barely able to remember the night before. He stumbled down the hall, then realized he hadn't put his jerkin on and headed back to his room. Not being coherent, he opened the wrong door, and a couple in it startled.

"Sorry, ma'am," he mumbled as he started to close the door. Then his eyes popped suddenly awake. "Sephora!" he screamed, turning back around to the couple. "What are you doing?"

Sephora pulled the covers up to her chin. "I can explain, but perhaps now is not the time."

Allistair slammed the door, shaking the doors around, and walked down the hall. The main room was quiet, probably because it was almost noon. Allistair sat

on a stool at the counter and muttered, “I think I need a feckin’ drink.”

“I’ll get you something to sober you up,” Jacob offered. “I have a special drink just for that. I learned it after I had a few too many and… Never mind. That’s a story I’m not going to tell. Just drink it. It’s an infusion in water of milk thistle, dandelion, and ginger.” He handed the mug to Allistair.

Allistair took the mug and drank deeply, letting the cool liquid wash away the bitter taste in his mouth. After a few swallows, he let out a dry, humorless laugh. “Forget the morning tonic, Jacob. Pour me another ale. Turns out I just walked in on Sephora tangled up with some other man.”

“I’ve warned you about her before,” Jacob pointed out, shaking his head. “She’ll tell you how exceptional you are, but tells every other man the exact same thing.”

“Yeah, well, apparently I’m a feckin’ slow learner,” Allistair grunted. He slapped his hand on the counter, immediately wincing as the sharp crack echoed in his already throbbing head. Gritting his teeth against the hangover, he squinted toward the taproom window. “What’s the hour?”

“Almost noon,” Jacob answered.

“Sards!!” Allistair snapped, jumping off the stool. “I’m late!”

Jacob shoved some rye bread at him and helped him out the door.

Allistair hurriedly saddled his horse and galloped to work. He hired out helping build homes, as he was good with wood. His father was a woodworker, but he didn’t

work for his father.

As he rode up to the site of the house he was to work on, his master stormed up to him, yelling, “You’re late again!”

The yelling hammer through Allistair’s pounding head, but he swung down from his horse and forced himself to stand up straight. “Look, I’m sorry,” he rasped, squinting against the noon sun. “There was a tournament yesterday. Did you not hear that I won it, and that I bled to knock that rotten extra tax down by over half? My ribs are still aching today, and my ear is ringing.”

“I did hear about that,” his master snapped, crossing his arms over his sawdust-covered tunic. “I’d forgive today, if you didn’t stumble in past noon every other week smelling like ale. I’ve given you chance after chance, Allistair, but in the state you’re in, you are likely to drop a tree on someone. Go home. I will not pay you anymore. You are dismissed.”

Dismissed? Had he heard right? Allistair stared at the master, the ale-fog burning away in an instant. “Hold on _”

“No excuses!” the master barked, pointing a calloused finger toward the road. “Go!”

Allistair fought back tears. It wasn’t manly to cry, but despite his success in tournaments, life was hard. What would he do? Where would he go? He had some money from the win the day before, but he’d have to find another source of money soon. Even winning tournaments didn’t pay well enough to live off of.

He mounted his horse, slumping over the reins, and started heading back to the Red Wolf.

As he walked into the tavern, he was surprised to see Lina there. Her hair was a creamy peach color that was stunning with her soft features. She was playing her lute and singing for the people while they at their noon day meal.

Allistair pulled up a chair and sat backward on it, leaning on the back to watch. Her song seemed hopeful amid the gloom, but there was a melancholy undertone. Life likely hadn't always been easy for her.

Allistair was pretty good at reading people. Most mokos were. Still, there was a great deal he didn't know. People only saw the face Lina put on as a minstrel, and he knew quite well that people's public face wasn't always real. He was pretty true to himself, but still, there were days he put on a smile and waved to the crowd even though he didn't feel like fighting. Everyone who participated in the tournaments knew that if they didn't put on a good show that the tournaments would stop and they wouldn't make money.

Money… He definitely was going to need more after losing his job.

Jacob walked up to him and handed him another of his hangover remedies to drink.

Allistair drank it as he watched Lina, gazing at her beauty and captivated by her song.

When she finished her grand finale, she passed the hat, then bounced over and sat down by Allistair.

"If you are looking for a coin, you're barking up the wrong tree." Allistair quipped, staring into his mug. "Seriously, tournament purses barely cover bandages, and I was just booted out the gate at my day job."

Lina smiled at him, placing her hand on his arm. He half expected her to feed her some really sweet, consoling nonsense, but instead she laughed brightly. “Their loss. Look, forget this dusty town. Would you like to come sing with me in Roifort? That city is loaded with gold. The nobles should tip tip minstrels well.”

“You really want me… me... to sing with you?” Allistair asked, raising a skeptical eyebrow.

“It makes total sense,” Lina rattled off. “I think you should try it until the next tournament at least.”

Allistair leaned forward and pressed, “Do you think I’m that good of a singer?”

“You’re good enough,” Lina replied with a cheeky grin. She then leaned closer, lowering her voice below the taproom chatter. “All right, full honestly – I have an ulterior motive. The lands have been getting more violent and beasts have been attacking up north. It isn’t safe for a maiden to travel alone anymore.”

“Ah, there it is,” Allistair muttered with a knowing grin. “So you want me as a bodyguard, not a singing partner.”

“I want you as both,” Lina corrected, tapping his arm. “You bring the muscle and the harmonies. I bring the charm and energy to attract the crowd. Now, is it a deal?”

“Do you really trust me?” Allistair countered, his expression hardening. “I just caught the lady I thought loved me tangled up with another man. I lost my job. And half the town knows I drink too much.”

Lina shrugged, seemingly unbothered. “You aren’t a saint, big guy, but I think you are solid. I’d rather take my

chances on the road with you than take my chances getting mauled by a beast or robbed blind. The thieves guild has been running wild lately. Crime is through the roof."

"If I were a Knight Avant I'd tear that guild apart," Allistair growled, his jaw tightening. "Unfortunately, because I bleed in the arena for a copper, everyone assumes I have rocks for brains. Nobody listens to a word I say unless I'm grappling."

Lina's face lit up. "Then perhaps you'll enjoy singing with me. People treat actresses like dirt, yet minstrels are the ones carrying news from town to town, so folks assume we know more than we often do."

Allistair nodded. "Do you travel often?"

"I try not to more than I must," Lina admitted. "Remember the whole not safe for a lady to travel alone part I just mentioned." She sighed, her bright mask slipping for a second. "Still, I have to move around plenty."

Allistair leaned back a little, his eyes fixed on her face as he thought. "Sards, I'm sure you have plenty of men lining up to travel with you."

"Perhaps," Lina smirked, "though most of them are feckless fools. I can see by your markings that you actually have a brain in your head. What do you say? Do we head to Roifort?"

"Let me think on it," Allistair suggested. "When do you want to leave?"

"Tomorrow," she answered promptly. "Although I can wait if I must."

Allistair nodded. "I want to say good-bye to my

family, and Hartley too. Don't worry. They live near."

Lina leaned forward with an eager, curious smile. "How big of a family do you have?"

"Parents and a sister," Allistair answered, genuine warmth softening his voice. "They are good people." Lina noticeably tensed. Allistair caught it. "Okay, I take it you aren't really close to yours."

"I've been surviving on my own since I was fifteen," she admitted. "Don't dig too deep. I don't talk about my past." She looked at him like a lost kitten and sheepishly added, "I guess I should admit that part of my fear of traveling alone is that Counselor Florence hates my guts. That could be dangerous."

"Counselor Florence?" Allistair scoffed. "She's a feckin' fool. How could she hurt you?"

"She could hire blades," Lina whispered, glancing toward the tavern door. "I wouldn't put it past her for a second. I don't even know her well. I only met her once. I was singing in the Pewter Rose – that's a tavern for nobles – and she tried to have me thrown in chains. I think I offended her because I have a way of spitting out the ugly truth without sugarcoating it, or perhaps…" She stopped, biting her lip. "Nevermind." She paused in thought for a heartbeat, then added, "Or maybe it's because the lord she was with couldn't stop complimented my appearance."

Allistair again noticed a vulnerability to her, as she looked like a child worried she would get hit by her drunken father. He gently picked up her hand, looked in her eyes, and assured her, "You have a new partner and bodyguard. I've made my decision."

She threw her arms around him excitedly.

She was hugging him when the door flew open and Elliot stormed in the room. He strutted over to Allistair and insisted, “Stand up!”

Lina jumped up. Allistair stood up, in front of her to protect her, and with a glare that could burn through iron asked, “What do you want?”

Elliot pulled a glove from his belt and slapped Allistair across the face with it. “I challenge you to a rematch for my honor, two days hence, at high noon. Do you accept?”

“No,” Allistair answered calmly. “I don’t care about your honor, and I’m leaving in the morning.”

Elliot reached for his sword. Allistair knew better than to let him, so he jumped up and kicked Elliot back.

Elliot hit a table, rolled over it, and fell to the floor.

“Let’s go,” Allistair urged Lina.

He grabbed her hand and ran out the door with her. As the crossed the threshold, Elliot pushed up to his knees and called to them, “Allistair watch your back. You can run, but you can’t hide!”

Chapter 5: A Story, A Brawl, and a Pretty Dance Partner

Two days traveling north through woods and plains in Lina's wagon with both their horses pulling it brought Allistair and Lina to the Pewter Rose in Roifort, a grand city crowned by the towering stone of the king's castle.

Lina gazed up at the castle walls. "Perhaps we'll get to sing for the king."

Allistair stepped out of the wagon, tied the horses, and helped Lina down as she rambled, "Could you see me singing for the king?" She scrunched her eyebrows as she considered it. "No, Counselor Florence might be there, and I probably shouldn't go near the throne. I'm way too bold, with too much mouth for a royal court I'd probably tell tell to lower taxes, and remind him a king is supposed to serve his people, not shackle them in chains."

“That would land you in the dungeon quick enough,” Allistair quipped. “While we’re dreaming, what do you think my odds of becoming a Knight Avant are?”

“If you can get a shot, great,” Lina chirped. “You are strong, sharp, and brave.” She flashed him a bright grin and tacked on, “You are fun to travel with too – way better company than just my horse.”

Allistair chuckled. “Glad to know I edged out the gelding. Do you have a dog? I wouldn’t even try to compete there.”

“No dog,” she assured him.

They finished tying the horses and stepped into the Pewter Rose. It didn’t look like a normal tavern. The ceiling was high, and many windows let in warm sunlight, so even though it was nearing twilight, the room wasn’t dark and only candle lit. There was a platform at the front of the room. On it, a winged faunen maiden played a pennywhistle while a gati played a drum, and a male sprite played the lute and sang.

Lina nodded. “They are actually really good.”

“They are,” Allistair agreed. “A gati as a drummer is a crafty. Their extra thumb on each hand gives them ridiculous dexterity. That beat is feckin’ glorious.”

They sat on a bench at a table, watching the performers, drawn into the music. They were rather so hooked that they hardly noticed the serving maiden came stepping up to their table to ask what they wanted.

“What’s on the fire tonight?” Allistair asked.

“Roast beef, barley salad, apples, and manchet bread,” the maiden answered. “There’s water, juice, milk, or ale to wash it down.”

Allistair blinked, caught off guard. Had he heard her right? They were having roast beef, not just pottage, and salad, apples, and bread? In Chesterfield, eating beef was a luxury. Folks had venison and fish fairly often, but cows were expensive, and the people who could afford them used them for milk, not for meat. The Red Wolf served pottage with little meat and bread almost every night. That was it.

The prices dealt him a second shock, and settled on one dish to split with an extra piece of bread and just water to drink.

“I’d fight for an ale tonight,” Allistair grumbled, “but we don’t know how full our hats will get in Roifort, so we need to keep the purse strings tight.”

Lina rolled a shoulder. “I’ll be fine without ale. It will be exciting to see what you’re like in a tavern stone sober. Your jokes may actually be funny.”

Allistair gave a forced chuckle, unsure if he’d just been complimented or insulted.

Their food came quickly, and they ate keeping their eyes on the musicians. The sprite had a rich, effortless voice, which wasn’t surprising, as most sprites were born with music in their blood.

The notes carried clearly across the room, as the tavern wasn’t as noisy or bawdy as the Red Wolf. Perhaps due to the hulky giant by the door who escorted anyone who was in a drunken roar out.

“I wish I had the natural talent of a sprite,” Allistair admitted, his gaze fixed on the stage. “My giant blood gives me muscle, sure, but the mokos half just carves my whole life story into my skin.” He pulled up his left sleeve motioned to his forearm. “You have no idea what

it’s like walking around with your life on your arm for every stranger to judge. Sure, the inkwell shows I can read, which is great. But the martlet? That shows I wasn’t born into wealth or a title. It’s a bird with no feet, so it also shows that I have had to work hard from the start and will never get to land until I die. It’s not a marking I’m proud of.”

Lina smiled encouragingly. “Maybe one day it will be. Some day it may be a badge of glory that you succeeded as the martlet.”

Allistair shook his head. “You wouldn’t understand. You are a full-blooded, beautiful sprite.”

“I’ve been through plenty of dirt you don’t know about,” Lina shot back. She leaned over and whispered, “I’m not full sprite. I can’t change my skin color or eyes, only my hair. I am actually part mokos and part elf, just not enough elf to have pointed ears, but where do you think I get all my chaotic energy from?”

“You’re part mokos?” Allistair echoes, his expression showing no more belief than if she’d just tried to sell him a miracle elixir that could instantly give him all the knowledge in the world and cure stupidity.

She pulled her hair back, revealing that she had markings of delicate flowers cascading down each temple.

Allistair almost touched the marks, but pulled his hand back. “Those look sharp on you. You should be proud of them. You must have done something feckin’ splended to get them.”

“Not necessarily,” Lina corrected, letting her hair fall back over her face. “Yes, they are flowers, but notice the thorns. I’ve had to make my way on my own, and I’ve

made some mistakes along the way." Allistair started to open his mouth, but she held up a finger to quiet him. "I don't tell my past."

Allistair stared at her, looking as if she was a ghost.

"What?" she asked, turning her shoulder to him. "It shouldn't surprise you that I'm part mokos. Very few people are entirely one race. All our races evolved from humans. If history is right and the era of magic had an explosion of magic where it all went into people and created different races, then everyone is human at their core. That's why the races can inter-marry. You shouldn't be surprised that I'm mixed."

Allistair shrugged in acceptance. "Still, I wish I had a drop of sprite blood in me. I love to sing. Mokos aren't gifted with artistic talent naturally, and mokos are the rarest bloodline, so I get stared at like I'm a feckin' sideshow."

"You sing well, and if people are staring it's more likely because you are strong and easy on the eyes," Lina teased, nudging his arm. "Just be yourself and don't worry about what others think. I wish there were more mokos. Mokos, if legend is correct, have the ability to know the truth. They naturally have intuition and understand people. Most mokos are very charismatic. You definitely are."

Allistair shrugged. "I may see the truth. I may know that drinking gets me in trouble, but I still overdo it."

"Why?" Lina pressed softly.

"Life is hard," he quietly replied. "And I'm a martlet."

The song ended, and the musicians took a break.

Oddly enough, they didn't pass a hat, which confused Lina.

She glanced around the room. Would she get in trouble for singing?

She didn't have to think about it because the tavern owner, a rather over-weight crevan with a pig tail called over, "You… minstrel, do you have news to tell us? What's the news of the other cities?"

Lina eagerly hopped up. Perhaps she could earn a few coins. She picked up her lute. "I will be glad to tell stories. Everyone gather around. Hear my tales."

She encouraged people to come sit around as she told stories. She could have been loud enough to be heard all over the room, but she was wise enough to know that if she stood up at the front, many people would only half-listen and would talk to each other, and that very few would feel involved enough to put a coin in her hat.

She gathered people around and began to tell the story of the tournament in Chesterfield. She told of different fights and of the final battle between the giant Theo and the hero Allistair. After she told the story, she played her lute and sang:

"The champion Allistair is bold.
His hero status is foretold.
He'll live and die a hero's dream.
One day his name all will esteem.
He's wise. He's strong. He's full of might,
One day surpassing noble knights,
For legend's heroes can't compare,
To our handsome champion, Allistair!"

She then told of how Allistair saved the city from a

brute demanding money, not mentioning the name of Sir Elliot, but saying Allistair fought him and won. After that, she sang the verse again, changing the last few words:

> “The champion Allistair is bold.
> His hero status is foretold.
> He’ll live and die a hero’s dream.
> One day his name all will esteem.
> He’s wise. He’s strong. He’s full of might,
> One day surpassing noble knights,
> For legend’s heroes can’t compare,
> To our noble hero, Allistair!”

The crowd loved the story, and Lina passed a hat. She had hoped more people would put money in. Quite a few snubbed her, but the people who did put money in were pretty generous.

When the crowd went back to their tables, Lina went back over to Allistair. “I did feckin’ grand!” She excitedly jingled her hat. “I can buy you an ale, but I’m only buying one, as I think it’s best if you stay being a hero to these people.”

He smiled a wry grin. “You didn’t mention that I am Allistair. They don’t see me as a hero.”

Lina waved her hand, blowing the comment off. “They’ll figure it out soon enough. There is method to my madness. If I introduce you at the same time that I tell the story, I pass the hat once. People won’t put in more money that way. They’ll put in the same amount whether I tell two stories or three. In a little while, someone will feel quite proud because he realizes that you are the champion from the story.”

Allistair clasped his hands. “You didn’t mention

Elliot, expose the outrageous tax, or reveal the corruption in..."

"I thought it might get us in trouble," Lina interrupted. "It's best to see how the people here feel about the king and taxing the cities before saying too much. Besides, Elliot has connections. Let's not upset important people. I'm rather fond of my head being on my shoulders."

"Feckin' brilliant," Allistair quipped. "You are much more than a beautiful face."

She blushed and called to the serving wench for an ale.

She was right that someone would notice Allistair. One of the serving wenches asked his name, and it was simple to make the connection.

The lady stood up in front of everyone and announced that Allistair was the hero from the song. Cheers rose through the room, echoing in the vaulted ceiling.

Lina took advantage of the situation and called to the people, "Do you want to see the hero perform?"

The people cheered, so Allistair leaned over to Lina and asked, "You sure about this? What am I supposed to do?"

She smiled excitedly. "Trust me. I won't get you bloodied up too much."

An awkward chuckle burst from his lips, hoping she was joking.

She grabbed his arm, pulled him up onto the platform, and announced, "This is the champion Allistair!

Do you want to hear him sing?”

Cheers again rose to the raftrs, so Lina played a song and she and Allistair sang.

After the song, a crevan man called out, “If you’re such a good fighter, let’s wrestle and see who wins. I’m undefeated.”

Allistair did a double take. The man was obviously part crevan, as he had goat horns on his head. He was tall for a normal crevan, only about three inches shorter than Allistair, so he likely had some giant blood too. He wore a sword, but was not dressed like a knight. If he was one, he was not on duty. Perhaps Allistair had a chance against him.

Lena smacked Allistair on the arm, so he suddenly remembered he needed to reply. “This isn’t the place to fight, not in a classy tavern like this.”

The owner’s voice boomed from across the room, “I’ll allow it. Everyone move the tables.”

Chatter erupted as everyone began moving the tables. Why were they? Allistair hadn’t even agreed to the match. He placed his hand on Lina’s arm and leaned over. “What do I do?”

Lina looked around, sizing up the situation. “I think you can beat him. Actually, I’m confident enough that I may take bets. We could make some good money if you win.”

Allistair had no words, nothing, but he stepped into the middle of the recently cleared floor.

The man stepped up to face him, raising his hands up to the crowd. They cheered for him, the classy hall suddenly becoming rowdy. He then mocked Allistair,

“You have chosen poorly. I am Sir Xavier, knight of the realm.”

Allistair heaved a breath of relief, glad the man was a knight of the realm, not a Knight Avant, and very glad that he wasn’t fighting him with a sword. Sure, Allistair was a fair sword fighter, but not trained to the level of a knight.

Both men removed their shirts, as wrestling didn’t work well with them on. That brought cheers for both Allistair and Xavier from the maidens. Allistair held his fist up to acknowledge their cheers and then faced off with his opponent.

The tavern owner called for bets, betting on Xavier winning and challenging people to bet against him. He gave good enough odds that some people did, even though the knight was favored.

Lina countered by jumping on a bench and calling out, “I’ll give odds that Allistair wins! If he loses, I’ll pay double your bet.”

Most of the people laughed at her and eagerly placed bets. Giving those odds on an unknown contender against a knight seemed certain money. If only she could take all the bets, but she didn’t have the money to cover many.

Almost everyone wanted to bet against Allistair. Sure, he was supposed to be a hero, and he was a tournament champion in Chesterfield, but he was up against a knight of the realm, one who served the kingdom under command of the captain of the guard. Lina took the last bet she could cover, hoping Allistair would win.

Allistair looked around at the large crowd, which was growing as people were coming in off the street to

watch, even the musicians were watching instead of playing. All eyes were fixed on him. What had he agreed to? How stupid was he? His chance of winning was slim. Even worse, with the bets, he could not only not make money, but he could lose money. He glanced over at Lina, whose happy smile and total confidence set his resolve. She had great faith in him, so he had to win for her. He clasped his hands to keep them from quivering and took a deep breath to calm down.

The tavern owner barked for the fight to start. Xavier immediately shot out with a brutal kick to the gut. Allistair blocked, yet even with the block, the blow felt like it cracked a rib. That wasn't surprising with Xavier being a goat crevan. Next, Xavier lunged to grab Allistair to slam him to the hard wooden floor, but Allistair ducked under his arms, then snapped up to deflect a strike with his forearm.

Next, Allistair dove in low, grabbed Xavier around the legs, lifted him off the floor, spun him around, and slammed him down, only for Xavier to hook Allistair's neck as he fell and drag him down with him.

Xavier twisted and locked onto Allistair's leg from underneath. Allistair wrenched his hips, whipped his free leg over to break the hold, and rolled back to his feet.

The two men squared off again. Allistair was already gasping for breath, but his opponent was heaving for air too. The two were well-matched, which meant a close, bloody fight.

They circled around each other, each hunting for an opening. As they did, fast, driving music suddenly rang through the air. The musicians were playing fight music.

Allistair wasn't sure if the rapid tempo was

energizing or distracting. He threw his hands out to try to catch Xavier from coming in with a low headbutt, yet the crevan charged right through. Thinking fast, Allistair twisted and shoved down on the base of Xavier's neck, driving Xavier into the floor, so he couldn't land a clean hit.

The brawl raged on, and first blood was drawn when Xavier rammed Allistair and sent him crashing into a table. Allistair hit hard, slicing his arm open on a jagged nail. Shock flashed through him – his fision swam and warm blood trickled down his forearm – but he forced himself to lock onto the fight, not the sting. He hauled himself up. The parted crowd hemmed him in on all sides, and Xavier was already barreling straight at him.

With a sudden surge of energy, Allistair vaulted onto the table, did a back flip over Xavier, clamped onto his horns from behind, and slammed him face-first to the floor.

The crowd erupted into cheers and jeers, depending on who whey had placed their coin.

For a brutal minute, the two men wrestled on the floor, trading short, heavy punches. At one point, Xavier cranked Allistair into an arm bar. Allistair's joint screamed in protest, yet he muscled through, rolled his weight over, and hammered Xavier in the ribs.

They both scrambled away and staggered to their feet, each looking half-beaten already.

"You're dead," Xavier hissed as he barreled in and swung. Allistair fired back, and the wrestling match degenerated to an all-out slugfest.

Both men staggered with every blow, too battered and breathless to keep their guards up. Who would stay

standing?

"Stay up!" Lina urged. "You've got this."

Allistair could barely see straight, as his head was spinning and throbbing. The pounding music didn't help, yet, he locked his eyes on Xavier who was charging in for another headbutt. Allistair snagged one horn and unleashed a crushing right punch. With both hands occupied, he couldn't block Xavier's counter-punch. Both men staggered, and the entire tavern went dead silent, waiting to see who would drop first.

Xavier crashed down to the floor first, with Allistair collapsing only a second behind him. Fortunately, Allistair landed on his knees right beside Xavier and drove one last punch into his jaw, knocking him unconscious. Then Allistair barely managed to raise a shaking hand and mumble, "I win," before blacking out himself.

The tavern exploded into noise, and the tavern owner paid out the wagers, grousing the entire time because he'd lost big.

With nothing left for her to do, Lina patted the heavy coin pouch at her hip – every wager she'd taken was hers to keep. She bolted over to Allistair to check on him and immediately began binding his bleeding arm. She then pressed her hand against a crystal on the necklace she always wore and blew on Allistair's face wounds. Being only part-elf, she couldn't fully heal, yer her magic stopped the bleeding and pulled him back to consciousness.

The faunen who played the pennywhistle ran over and started healing Allistair, as faunen heal better than elves.

Soothing relief came and the faunen rubbed her hot hands over the wound of both Allistair and Xavier, showing her healing to be much stronger than normal faunen. There were few signs of the fight when she stopped her gentle caress, picked up her penny whistle, and played their headaches away.

“That was a feckin’ incredible way to heal,” Allistair noted as his headache drifted off with the notes. “Thank you. How do you do it?”

“I’m not just faunen,” the faunen explained. “I have a little elf in me too, so I can strengthen my healing with stones.” She pulled back her hair to show pointed ears. She then leaned over and whispered, “I have a little Rhys in me too. Don’t tell people, but that is how I heat my hands up. I can’t do fire.”

Allistair put his hand on her arm. “That was feckin’ amazing! You’re the best healer I’ve ever met. I’m ecstatic you were here.”

“I’m glad too,” she agreed with a soft smile. “I made money betting on you.”

Allistair chuckled, patted her arm, and went over to Lina.

“That was quite the fight,” she noted. “I’m glad there was a better healer than me around.” She gave him a hug and excitedly showed him the money she’d made. “This is great tips. Maybe we should get you in more fights to bet on until your fame spreads.”

Allistair raised an eyebrow. “No, thank you. That feckin’ hurt.”

Lina smiled and elbowed him. “But look at this money.” She then chuckled. “Actually, I think many

ladies would bet on you just because of how you look with your shirt off."

"You are a strange one, beautiful, but strange," Allistair noted. "Traveling with you definitely keeps me entertained."

"I am a minstrel, it's literally my job," Lina shot back, snatching a roll from a bread bowl. She squinted at it for a beat. "Maybe I should learn to juggle." She glanced at the roll. "Better yet, you should. I throw like a girl."

Their light-hearted banter cut off as Xavier stormed over, scowling. He marched straight up to Allistair, shoving Lina aside in the process. "You are going to regret this!" he hissed inches from Allistair's face. "I will have my pride back." Without waiting for a response, he spun on his heels and stalked out the door.

Allistair watched him go and let out a heavy breath. "I seem to have a feckin' talent for making enemies. This is not quite how I pictured my first night in Roifort ending."

"Fair enough," Lina conceded, "but it doesn't have to end on a sour note. The night is still young."

The musicians started playing again, and people started dancing. Allistair watched Lina eagerly watching them and asked, "Would you like to dance?"

Lina's eyes lit up. "I didn't know you danced."

"I didn't say I can," Allistair corrected. "I asked if you wanted to."

Lina raised her shoulders innocently. "And what if I do? Are you going to dance with me?"

Allistair shrugged. “Something akin to dancing,. It may look like a three-legged bear with a hangover, so don’t say I didn’t warn you, but shall we?”

Lina jumped up and held her hand out. “I’d love to. In fact I am very curious now. I’ve never seen a three-legged bear, a bear who dances, or a bear with a hangover. This is going to be gold. Let’s go.”

Allistair took her hand and walked over to the center of the floor. He placed one arm around her waist and clasped her hand with his other. He wasn’t the suavest of dancers. He didn’t glide across the floor with a practiced smolder, yet he knew how to enjoy himself, and carried a steady rhythm, definitely better than a drunk bear.

As they danced, the tempo slowed, so Allistair drew Lina closer.

She looked up into his eyes. He was strong, solid as oak, and there was something deeply secure about being held in his arms. She gave him a soft smile, and he returned it. For a moment, they gazed into each other’s eyes, the noise and crowd of the tavern fading into the background as the entire world vanished into a dream.

That was the perfect way to end the night, just the two of them. Allistair would worry about Xavier in the morning, and probably have to deal with both him and Elliiot, but at the moment, he had a pretty girl in his arms, and nothing else mattered.

Chapter 6: Market, The Great Hall, and an Offer that Couldn't Be Refused

The next day, Lina wanted to see the city, so Allistair brought her to the large, bustling market of Roifort, that dwarfed Chesterfield's market. The shops were all close together, some touching side by side, and goods that could only be imagined in Chesterfield graced tables outside shops.

In the morning, most merchants sold wares outside their shops. There were beautiful brass wine goblets, silver tankards, yards of cloth, tables of food, and skillfully crafted swords. Lina stopped at a table with jewelry.

As she looked at the fancy necklaces, Allistair walked over to a shop that sold swords. He picked one up, and the shopkeeper immediately scolded, "Don't touch that. You aren't a knight or noble."

“I’m not,” Allistair agreed. “I’m a tournament champion in Chesterfield. I know how to use a sword.”

“Only knights and nobles may buy swords,” the shopkeeper scolded. “Put it down.”

“I’m just admiring the steel,” Allistair defended, turning the blade slightly in his grip. “I won’t buy it. A blade like this costs more than the king’s tax collectors leave me in a year, but the craftsman who made it is feckin’ incredible. It’s light enough to be easily maneuverable, and the balance is dead-on.”

“Put it down!” the shopkeeper insisted. “I could get in trouble for letting you pick it up.”

Allistair immediately put the sword back, his brow knitted in genuine confusion. “Why would you get burned for that?”

The man shook his head. “First time in Roifort?”

“Close enough,” Allistair admitted. “I’ve been to Fletcher’s Field several times for tournaments, but that’s southeast of here. I’ve never made it this far into the city. Does it feckin’ show?”

The shopkeeper nodded, then leaned in and warned, “Do not even breathe a word to anyone that you know one end of a sword from the other. Since you aren’t a knight or a noble, you will be assumed to be an outlaw. Keep your head down and don’t upset the knights.”

Allistair stiffened, a wry grimace crossing his mouth. “Well, that ship might have sailed already. I wrestled Sir Xavier last night. He beat me up pretty good too, until I won.”

The shopkeeper’s eyes went big, and he warned, “You should probably leave the city soon. I hear Arwood

is a nice town. I wouldn't be eager to go to Montlier. Duke Korbyn is rumored to be very strict." He looked around, then urged, "Now, go. If you have made enemies with a knight, I don't want you near my shop."

Allistair turned heel and went back over to Lina. She had a crowd around her and was playing her lute and telling a story to the music. That didn't surprise him. After all, Lina was a minstrel, and people always turned to minstrels for news, not that she actually had much, as she didn't travel often, but she definitely had good lore to tell and was entertaining.

Allistair was taking in her performance when Xavier and a very tall Knight Avant with tiger ears strode up. Allistair looked as excited as a little boy who had just caught a lizard at the sight of the Knight Avant, but his joy quickly vanished when they halted in front of him and the Knight Avant insisted, "You are coming with us."

"What the charge?" Allistair challenged, crossing his arms.

"We will speak in private," the Knight Avant replied calmly. "I am Sir Perkin of the Knight Avants. If you do not obey me, I may, by right, cut you down where you stand."

"Easy… I'm coming," Allistair conceded, raising both hands to chest level. "No need for force. May I at least tell my partner where I'm headed?"

Sir Perkin nodded. "She may come. Some entertainment in the keep may be appreciated."

Allistair walked over with the two knights, and the crowd around Lina instantly scattered.

Allistair caught her eye, giving a quick nod toward

the knights as he explained he had to go with them and asked if she wanted to come along.

"Come!" Sir Perkin ordered. "That is not a request."

Lina blinked, clutching her lute to her chest before shooting Allistair a look that clearly asked what trouble he'd gotten them into.

Perkin and Xavier escorted Lina and Allistair into the guardhouse at the entrance to the keep. Allistair was in awe as he walked up the stairs. He was actually where the Knight Avants stayed. Merely glimpsing their stronghold was a dream.

He and Lina were brought up a flight of stairs to a large room. There were several knights in there, three giants, two gati, a crevan fox, a half-elf, and a rhys, plus about a dozen women of various races. Obviously, they weren't knights, but they were seeing to the needs of the knights.

A pointed-ear, half-elf, half-giant, standing a few inches taller than Allistair, stood up and stepped over to them. He looked up and down, inspecting Allistair as if he were a sword being considered for purchase. "So, you are the man who beat Xavier in a fight. You do look strong, but I think I'd still beat you in a fight."

"Likely," Allistair agreed, his eyes wide, but trying not to let how intimidated he felt show. "What do you want me here for?"

"To invite you to be a Knight Avant," the elf-giant answered. "Please, have a seat and let me explain."

Allistair froze. Did the man actually say what he heard? They wanted him as a Knight Avant?

"Sit," the elf-giant instructed.

Allistair shook his head to clear it and sat by Lina. The elf-giant began, “I am Sir Guilhem, leader of the Knight Avants. I am offering to have you join us.” He straightened up. “Actually, this isn’t a request. I am informing you that you are now a Knight Avant.”

Allistair’s eyes went as wide as a startled owl’s. “Isn’t there a contest to become one? Don’t I have to prove myself?”

Guilhem nodded. “You proved yourself fighting Xavier.” He leaned forward, glanced over at Xavier, and whispered, “You must be made an Avant, or it makes Xavier look weak. We cannot have that happen. The reputation of the knights, even the knights of the realm must be kept up. We can’t have some lowly wrestler who fights in small tournaments beat our knights. Therefore, I am going to give you a title, so Xavier will have been beaten by Sir Allister of the Knight Avants.”

That sounded really good, and Allistair had to hold himself down to not bounce out of his chair as a child being offered a tart. Allistair almost accepted, but looked over at Lina. “What about her? I can’t leave Lina. I’m her bodyguard and partner.”

Guilhem gestured with a large flourish of his hand. “I’m sure I can get her performing in the castle. I have a great deal of sway. Besides, there is always more room for another beautiful maiden. You have quite the lady there.” He then winked at Allistair.

“We aren’t courting,” Allistair corrected. “I perform with her.”

“Right,” Guilhem chuckled in disbelief. “You two are just partners. If that’s your story, that’s what I’ll tell people.” He then leaned over to Lina and offered, “If it’s

true, I could spend an evening at a tavern with you. You'd enjoy it. No woman can resist my charm." He then posed, showing off his muscles.

Lina raised her shoulders and shrank back slightly. "I think I'll pass."

Guilhem raised his eyebrows and quipped to Allistair, "Just partners, right. There's no way she would reject me if you two were truly only partners." He snapped his fingers, and several ladies came over to him and hung on his arms.

Allistair almost made a snippy come back, but considered it not a wise move since he was about to become a knight under Sir Guilhem.

Instead, he stood up and asked, "When do I start?"

Guilhem motioned where knights were training. "Immediately. How well do you sword fight?"

"That's debatable," Allistair admitted. "I don't have a real sword. We use wooden swords in tournaments to not kill our opponents. I've done very little with real swords, and mostly in tournaments I wrestle."

"Then let's get right to training you with a sword," Guilhem instructed. He turned to Sir Perkin and ordered, "Take him out and train him." He paused for a moment, then added, "Don't bloody him up too much."

Sir Perkin scowled more than a tiger who was about to pounce as he hissed, "Come, Allistair. You have a great deal to learn."

Allistair glanced over at Lina before he walked out, her contagious smile making one burst on his face. She believed in him.

Once he left, Sir Guilhem turned to Lina. “We have a little time before the noon meal. I will introduce you to King Didier there. Until then, why don’t we get to know each other better? If you and Allistair really aren’t courting, I think you might be a good addition to my harem.”

“Your harem?” Lina snipped. “Is that legal?”

“Not for peasants,” Guilhem boasted, “but knights and nobles get some special privileges. Besides, I can’t deny women access to my god-like body.”

Lina held her hands up to chest level. “They can have you. I have no desire to be part of a harem.”

Guilhem put his arm around her and suggested, “Better mine than King Didier’s or Counselor Ormondo’s. King Didier is… never mind. I won’t say anything bad about the king, but I will tell you that Ormondo controls him and makes more of the decisions for the kingdom than he does.”

Lina nodded, her hands beginning to tremble. “So, how do I deal with them?”

Guilhemm waved his hand dismissively. “Just entertain them.” He lowered his voice and warned, “Keep them happy. You do not want to be on the bad side of King Didier or his counselors.”

The tremor in Lina’s hands made its way up her arms. Counselor Florence already didn’t like her. Yet, Lina joked, “They’ll be best off not getting on my bad side either.”

“I’m serious,” Guilhem warned, his voice hard and cold. “You don’t know King Didier or Ormondo as I do. Do not cause waves.”

The trembling spread through Lina's entire body, so she picked up her lute and began playing. Guilhem watched her play, which made her a little nervous, as he seemed to be eyeing her as a hungry wolf. Still, the music was calming.

She played until almost noon, when Guilhem came to her and announced, "It is time to go eat. Come. I will present you to King Didier."

Lina went with Sir Guilhem and the other knights to the great hall for their noon meal. The hall was very elaborate with intricate tapestries full of rich, royal colors on the walls and detailed carvings in the woodwork. A row of tables ran along each side of the hall, and table runners ran across them. Golden candlesticks adorned the tables, and fancy brass sconces held candles on the walls.

Lina Looked around, her eyes wide in awe. "This is what I call a stage. I could get use to this, assuming they don't throw me in the dungeon first." She then turned to Guilhem and joked, "If I break a vase, you're taking the blame."

Guilhem didn't laugh, but warned, "Be careful."

Seated in the hall were the Knight Avants who weren't currently on duty and the king and his royal counselors. His two high counselors were Counselor Ormondo and Counselor Florence. Lina had met Counselor Florence at the Pewter Rose when Florence kicked her out but she'd only heard rumors of Ormondo and the king. King Didier was an Elvish man from the House of Thibaut. His two main counselors were Ormondo, from the House of Farrow, and Florence, from the House of Vinet. Whichever house the king was from, the two main counselors were always from the other two

main houses.

Every five years there was a tournament to determine who would be the king. A champion from each of the four noble houses would compete, although the fourth house, Garnier, was never in contention, and they didn't get a counselor if they didn't win, so they stopped even putting in a contestant two decades before. Thus, everyone looked at them as a lesser noble house.

Lina saw the fancy clothing the king and counselors wore and felt very under-dressed. After all, her dress was very plain, very normal for a minstrel, just a plain underdress with a laced up overdress.

She forced a smile on her face as she was led up in front of the king. Guilhem introduced her, and King Didier requested that she sing for him and tell tales.

She began playing her lute and singing as everyone ate. The food looked very good, fancier than she was used to. Hopefully she would get a chance to get some. But first, she had to impress the king, so she sang a perky song and lit the room up with her radiant energy.

After performing several songs, she did end up getting to eat. In fact she was instructed to sit down with the king and his counselors.

"So you are from Chesterfield," King Didier noted. "I have not been there is quite some time. Perhaps it's time to pay a visit."

"Indeed," Counselor Ormondo agreed. He then addressed Lina. "I understand that you told the story of the champion defeating Elliot. That is the man who we just had join the Knight Avants, is it not?"

"That's him," Lina confirmed, nervously fingering

the spiced banquet bread on the plate in front of her.

“He is a troublemaker,” Ormondo continued, his statement rather casual, but his tone dark. “It is good he works for us now.”

Lina took a bite of food to keep herself from saying anything, but something felt wrong, very wrong. She shouldn’t have brought Allistair to Roifort.

Her nervousness turned to inner panic when she saw Allistair enter the room with Sir. Perkin. Blood seeped from a cut across Allistair’s forehead, and his cheek was bruised. Surely, that wasn’t normal training. Something was wrong. Allistair being a Knight Avant and her a performer for the king was not going to be the dream either of them had expected.

Still, she felt somewhat proud as King Didier stood up and addressed Allistair. “You are the new Knight Avant?”

“Yes,” Allistair confirmed, bowing low to him.

“Very well,” King Didier replied. “I will now swear you in and have you take your oath. Take a knee.”

Allistair was excited as he took a knee, as his dream was coming true. Yet, after what he’d seen of Perkin, there was some trepidation. He looked up at the king. Hopefully, he would not regret the oath he was about to make.

Chapter 7: Beasts, Blood, and a Cute Little Girl

Allistair trained for a week with the Knight Avants.

“Your swordmanship is improving,” Sir Perkin noted as Allistair parried a strike during training. “It is obvious that you have trained with a sword, despite commoners not being allowed to.”

Allistair struck back, but Perkin blocked with his shield. Allistair really wasn’t used to fighting with a shield, so it was taking some time to learn.

Allistair struck hard as he defended, “I see no reason why my class shouldn’t be able to defend themselves. Everyone should have a right to self-defense.”

Perkin face turned red with anger, and hecame in with a massive slash. Allistair blocked the strike with his shield, but Perkin flipped his tiger claws out and cut Allistair on the side. “They shouldn’t!” he yelled.

He then stepped back and ordered, “Stop the bleeding and sit!”

Allistair immediately obeyed. The cuts weren't too deep, as they weren't intended to kill, just to teach Allistair a lesson. He sat and put pressure on them.

Perkin had made it quite clear when training started that he could have Allistair whipped if he didn't cooperate, so Allistair never disobeyed.

Perkin lectured, "We don't want the people to have weapons or know how to use them. They are harder to control that way. The noble houses have a vision, a kingdom where all are united and at peace. The best way to do that is to have us control the people. If they can fight, they might. We do not need war among our own cities. We will be the protectors for them."

"But knights are seldom around while someone is being attacked," Allistar countered, his voice low to not anger Perkin. "If we want peace, people need to all be trained to use weapons. If everyone carries a sword, then people will think twice before attacking anyone. After all, a lady with a bodice dagger is safer than one without."

"No lady should have a weapon," Perkin corrected. "No one who is not noble should have any weapon. We do not want rebellions."

Allistair bit his tongue for a moment to not made a snide comment, then in a very controlled tone, suggested, "If you don't want rebellions, earn the people's trust. The king is not always looked highly upon because of the taxes he imposes, but the Knight Avants are admired and revered. I am honored to be one."

"You shouldn't be one," Perkin sneered leaning toward him. "You are a peasant, only here so Sir Xavier could save face. He is a fool, and I do not care about his reputation, only that of the Avants."

“Avants…” Allistair repeated. “I’ve noticed other knights referring to the group as just Avants, not Knight Avants.”

“It’s shorter,” Perkin explained. “Just say Knight Avants in public, but we’d rather be referred to as the Avants than just the knights. There are other types of knights. Be very proper in public, even with our title. Our reputation is important.”

Alistair nodded. “The Avants do have a good reputation. “I’m proud to be one. I’ve dreamed of this.”

“If you want to stay one, do whatever you are ordered,” Perkin warned. “No questions asked. Understood?”

Allistair gulped. “Understood.”

Perkin stood up. “Now, let’s get training again.”

They both readied their swords and attacked.

They were fighting when a loud bell suddenly rang.

“Come!” Perkin ordered. “We are needed.” He immediately ran toward the front of the keep calling to Allistair, “Keep up!”

Allistair ran behind him, trying to keep up, but Perkin was taller and a tiger crevan, so his stride was longer than Allistair’s. “What’s going on?” he called as he neared.

Perkin did not answer, but ran to where a dozen Avants had gathered.

Sir Guilhem was ordering the knights around. He told Sir Perkin to take a group immediately northwest because the watchman at the tower there had lit a firework. Beasts would be attacking the northwestern

villages soon.

“Come!” Perkin ordered Allistair. He waved his hand and the group that was there all followed him, knowing Guilhem would come soon with more men.

Allistair was on his first quest as a Knight Avant, which felt much like waiting for his first wrestling match in his first tournament. He raised up in his saddle so his horse could go faster.

As he galloped to the fight, he could hear his heart pounding. He’d heard beasts existed, but he’d never seen one. Sure, there were wild animals in Chesterfield, but stories were told of beasts in the mountains who were somehow mutated into chimeric abominations and were big, strong, and deadly.

It didn’t take long to figure out what the beasts were like, as they rode up to a farmhouse where a half dozen beast were fighting eight local knights.

Allistair jumped off his horse. He’d played around with jousting some, but not officially, and otherwise had no experience fighting on a horse.

The family huddled inside the farmhouse was under attack by a beast, so Allistair threw himself between them and the monster. Jaws snapped shut on him. If not for his chest plate, the creature would have torn him to shreds.

The beast looked like a gigantic nightmarish cross between a dog and a bear, with matted dark fur and hot breath. Fear shot through Allistair like a well-aimed arrow. Never had he expected to face such a creature. It made grappling with a giant look like child’s play. Yet, he couldn’t freeze. Innocent lives depended on him, so he swallowed his panic and charged back in.

A beast swiped at him with razor sharp claws. Acting on instinct, he caught a thick foreleg and wrenched the monster's weight to roll it over. As it twisted it clamped his jaw onto his shoulder, so drove a heavy first into its snout to force its teeth loose.

He scrambled back to give himself room to draw his sword, and swung mightily at the charging beast.

Using a sword was definitely a better idea than trying to grapple with a beast, but he'd never been in a real life-or-death sword fight before. It was a hundred times more terrifying than he'd imagined. Focus – he had to focus. He'd been in melee combat in tournaments before, so it wasn't the first time that he'd had to keep his cool among chaos. Yet, it was the first time lives depended on his blade.

He risked a glance over at the family. The father was bleeding heavily. Yet, Allistair couldn't break away to help him, or the beast would rip right through them all.

Allistair locked his eyes back the fight, falling into a pattern of cut and parry, simple moves, but very effective. Honestly, he had no idea what moves to use against a beast, as he'd been training against Perkin. It took several strikes of the beast's claws against his blade to get a feel for how to parry them. One strike slipped past him, slicing his elbow. Sharp pain flared up his arm, but he focused on the fight, not the pain, prioritizing staying alive.

A few strikes later, Allistair found his strategy. He was faster than the beast, so he could get an extra strike in and throw the beast off his rhythm. When he did, he was able to cut the beast across the snout. As the beast reared up in pain, Allistair plunged his sword into the

beast's chest. The creature let out a loud, piercing howl as it crashed to the ground, and Perkin rushed over, driving his blade through the beast and finishing it off.

Both Allistair and Perkin ran over to the family. Allistair immediately started to tend to the father's wounds. Perkin, however, simply told the mother that he needed to talk to her.

The mother was hugging her little girl, way too panicked to talk. Trying to have a conversation with her would have been as productive as trying to give directions to a swarm of bees.

"I can't leave!" the mother cried. "He'll die!" She leaned over her husband, trying to help, but not coherent enough to do anything.

"He should live," Allistair assured her. "He's injured, but I think we'll have time to get him to a healer. Do you have an elf or faunen who heals around here?"

"A few," Perkin answered for her. "This village is in the foothills of the mountains the beasts come from, so we have a watchtower and healers. A faunen or elf will be here soon to heal everyone. Now, we have work to do. Go, help the others. I'll take care of them." He pointed to the family.

"But…" Allistair began.

"That is an order," Perkin insisted. "Go!"

Allistair made sure that Perkin was putting pressure on the wound to stop the bleeding before he left, but obeyed, going to see if anyone else needed help.

There wasn't much else for him to do, as the others had been able to outnumber the beasts and kill them without being severely wounded, all except two of the

local knights, who were wounded before the Knight Avants arrived. Fortunately, an elf and two faunen were already there taking care of them. As soon as Allistair told them of the wounded father, one of the faunens flew that direction.

Allistair sat on a log, winded and hurting. One of the faunens came over to him and asked in a very happy voice for the situation, “May I heal you? You seem to need it.”

“Thank you,” Allistair responded, in too much thought to say more. Why had Perkin been so eager to get him to leave? Why hadn’t he come to the aid of the family sooner?”

The faunen placed her hand on his chest. “Is it your first quest as a knight?”

“Does it show?” Allistair quipped back.

The faunen shrugged. “You seem way too nice for a Knight Avant. Perkin is likely telling the family not to tell anyone that the father was wounded.”

Allistair held his tongue to not make the first comment that popped in his head, and simply asked, “Why not?”

The faunen looked around and whispered, “I’ve said too much. Just keep doing what is right. You saved that family today. Perkin wouldn’t have cared if they died. Last time someone died, Perkin and Guilhem reported that the Knight Avants saved everyone and that the man moved to a safer city.”

Allistair clenched his fists. “That’s feckin’ wrong,”

“Calm down,” the faunen whispered, her voice calm and soothing3. “Relax and let me heal you. You were

brave today."

She was still talking to Allistair as Guilhem and his men arrived, way to late to help, but explaining they had to take a detour to fight another beast.

Guilhem walked over to Allistair and the faunen and asked, "What are you talking about?"

"He was brave today," the faunen explained, her voice happy and vapid. "You have chosen your newest Knight Avant well."

Guilhem nodded. "I hope so. I guess we'll see how he does when he gets into harder situations."

Harder situations? That wasn't a good thought. After all, the fight hurt. Allistair looked up at Guilhem. "I still have a great deal to learn. Are we headed back to the castle?"

"Yes," Guilhem confirmed. "We are going back to the castle by way of the Pewter Rose. I think we've all earned a drink."

Allistair's eyes lit up. "Are you buying?"

"The king will," Guilhem answered. "We get more than just money for our work. We get wine and women. That is what is important in life, and I can't deprive the women of my company. They all want me." He became more serious and instructed, "Do not speak of the attack while at the Pewter Rose. You may say we fought beasts, defeated all of them, and no one was hurt. If anyone asks anything else, just say that you aren't allowed to discuss anything yet. After all, there is information that could be dangerous if our enemies knew it."

Allstair furrowed his eyebrows. "Someone was hurt. And why can't I tell about fighting the beast or the family

they were attacking? That will not aid any enemy."

Guilhem stared coldly at him and replied, "You do not know who all the enemies are."

A shiver of fear surged up Allistair's spine. He didn't trust the king, but it seemed there were many dark dealings he knew nothing of.

Chapter 8: A Fish, a Backdoor, and a Really Inaccurate Tale

Allistair didn't want to wake up the next morning, as all of the Knight Avants had stayed up late drinking at the Pewter Rose. Fortunately, Perkin slept in too.

It was after noon when Allistair finally surfaced. He went down to the kitchen to see if there was any food left. A red-headed, gati, scullery maid was scrubbing the floor.

"Sorry to interrupt," Allistair apologized as he stepped in. "I don't mean to dirty the floor." He sat down to take his boots off to not track dirt. As he did, the maiden bowed to him.

"Don't do that," Allistair instructed, waving his hand dismissively. "You don't need to bow to me."

"But you are a Knight Avant," the maiden replied, barely making enough sound for him to hear. "I am too lowly to even speak to you." She went back to scrubbing.

Allistair squatted down to be on her level. “Do you mind if I get some food?”

“I can do it quickly,” the maiden offered. She stood up, definitely able to do anything quickly. After all, she was a gati, and gati had long legs and six fingers. “What do you want?”

“Anything is fine,” Allistair assured her. “I’m not a picky eater.”

The girl darted around the kitchen and within seconds had a plate of fish, bread, and cheese for him. She bowed as she handed it to him and asked, “Would you like some ale to go with that?”

Allistair put his hand on his still aching head. “I think I’ve had enough ale. I still have a headache from too much last night.”

“I’ll get you water,” she offered, and very quickly handed him a full goblet.

He took the plate, pulled up a stool, and sat at a large table that food was prepared on. The maiden went back to scrubbing the floor.

As he ate, he asked her, “What do you think of the Knight Avants?”

She stopped scrubbing and stared at him. “Are you really asking my opinion?”

Allistair shrugged. “Why wouldn’t I?”.

“I’m a scullery maid,” she pointed out. “Nobles give people like me orders. They do not asked for my opinion.”

Allistair gave a definite nod of his head. “I want it. Please, put down your scrub brush and join me for my

meal. Feel free to get yourself something."

"I've eaten," she timidly responded, "but I will sit at the table."

She did sit down, so Allistair asked again, "What do you think of the Knight Avants?"

The maiden's eyes opened wide. "They are incredible. They are strong, brave, and noble. Every maiden loves them." Her eyes turned from him to his food.

Allistair held his trencher out to her. "Do you want some? Are you sure you're not hungry?"

She eyed it with longing in her eyes. "I've eaten. Scullery maids don't get the same food the nobles do. I had some pottage. That fish is smelling divine."

Allistair handed half of the fish to her and offered, "Eat it."

"But I…" she began.

"Eat it," Allistair insisted. "You don't wish to go against what I tell you, do you? If anyone complains, you can tell them to go to… No, say I ordered you to." He scrunched his eyebrows. "I can do that, can't I?"

"You can," the maiden confirmed as she eagerly took a bite. "Most Knight Avants figure that one out very quickly. You seem different." She shrank back timidly. "Am I out of line saying that?"

Allistair ran his fingers through his hair. "No. I'm not really a formal person, and I don't care about titles."

She blushed. "You are not like the other Knight Avants. They are amazing fighters, but they also are quite proud of their status."

“Hang status,” Allistair replied. He ate another bite, then asked, “What do you know of Perkin?”

The maiden suddenly tensed. “Nothing. I know nothing.”

“Really?” Allistair asked, rubbing his chin. “Do you know nothing, or are you just not allowed to say anything… What is your name? I was about to use it and realized I don’t know it.”

“I’m Nakita,” she answered. “And you are?”

“Allistair. I came from Chesterfield.”

Nakita bounced. “Are you the knight the minstrel told stories of?”

Allistair’s eyes went instantly wide. “Minstrel? Have you met a mostly sprite minstrel at the castle?”

“Yes,” Nakita answered. “Do you want to see her?” She leaned over and pried, “Are you in love with her?”

Allistair didn’t answer immediately, so Nakita shrank back and quickly responded, “I am sorry, sir. I have overstepped my bounds?” She then timidly, but eagerly, ate more.

Allistair chuckled. “No.” He took another bite and finished it before asking, “Is there a way I could get into the castle and talk to the sprite minstrel?”

“Of course,” Nakita answered. “You would have to clear it on Guilhem’s end.”

“I’d rather Guilhem not know,” Allistair explained. “I want to be able to talk freely to her.”

“Talk?” Nakita responded with a knowing nod. “I can get you in to see her. Do you want to go now?”

Allistair pointed to his meal. “As soon as I finish my food.” He handed her some cheese, that she eagerly accepted, quickly ate the last few bites of his food, and stood up.

He suddenly noticed that Nakita hadn’t finished scrubbing the floor. “Will you get in trouble if you don’t finish this now?”

Nakita’s face went white, and she nodded timidly. Then she quickly responded, “I’ll take the punishment. I won’t likely get beaten. I’ll probably only have my wages docked.”

Allistair clasped his hands together in frustration. Then he calmed down and offered, “Why don’t I help you with the cleaning, and then we go?”

Nakita looked more stunned than a deer looking at an archer with a nocked arrow pointed at it. “You know how to clean?”

Allistair laughed. “I just became a Knight Avant. I wasn’t a knight before that, just a champion, and I’ve done plenty of cleaning. In Chesterfield, we really don’t worry too much about titles. I’ve scrubbed plenty of floors. My mother and father raised me to know how to work.”

Nakita smilled. “They sound impressive.”

“They raised me right, even when we had next to nothing,” Allistair agreed. “I have a wonderful family.”

He then went to work with her doing her chores. At least a dozen times while they worked she told him that he didn’t have to help but was amazed that he was. All the while, gawking at him as if he was royalty.

When they finished he asked, “Now, can you take me

to see Lina?"

Nakita put the scrub brushes and bucket away. "Yes. Let's go. You have a pretty maiden to see."

She led Allistair to a wing of the king's keep, but instead of going to the guard at the door, she took him around the back and showed him a hidden door.

"What's this for?" Allistair asked.

"It's used by nobility when they don't want to be seen sneaking into the harem's house," Nakita explained. "If anyone sees you go in, he may question your motives, but you will not be stopped."

Allistair raised his eyebrows. Life in the castle was not how he imagined it would be. After all, weren't Knight Avants and nobles supposed to be role models and very proper?

He followed Nakita into the back of the house. There were many women there. It didn't take long to find Lina among them.

She excitedly ran over and threw her arms around him, exclaiming, "I'm so glad you survived fighting the beasts. I'm going to go sing the tale at the Pewter Rose tonight about the beast attack. I'd love for you to come."

Allistair smiled and teased, "So, I made a song?"

Lina cocked her head. "No. Didn't Sir Perkin kill the beast who was attacking the family and the other Avants kill the other beasts? I was concerned that since you weren't mentioned in the story I heard that you had been wounded."

Allistair stiffened. "No. I actually saved the family. What were you told?"

“I can sing the tale I was told to tell,” Lina suggested. “Would you like to hear it?”

Allistair placed his hand on her arm. “Yes, but first, I want to know if you are all right. It seems you’ve been made part of a harem.”

“Yes,” Lina answered with a bit of a content smirk, “but I made sure that King Didier and anyone else high up doesn’t see me as more than a minstrel.”

Allistair eyed her curiously. “How? Do I want to know?”

She chuckled as she explained, “I told King Didier how handsome he is and how excited I was about being in his harem, and not to worry because the disease that runs in my family that kills everyone young isn’t always contagious. I told him there was an entire ten percent chance he wouldn’t catch it from me.”

Allistair laughed out loud. “That sounds like you. You are creative. Now, that I know you are safe, let me hear the tale.”

Lina picked up her lute and began singing,

“The day turned dark. The knights were called,
to save a town, ransacked,
By mighty beasts with claws and teeth, who
charged in and attacked.
Then came the Knight Avants with speed. They
came to save the night,
And fought with courage, strong and brave.
They charged into the fight.
The local knights, outnumbered by the beasts,
they could not win,
‘Til Perkin led the Knight Avants to fight with
discipline.

Sir Perkin saw a beast approach a child, so small and weak,
Who could not fight the beast off, so her outlook seemed quite bleak.
Sir Perkin fought the beast. It's true. He thrust the killing blow.
He saved her and her family, and asked no quid pro quo.
This tale will be a legend told for years to come and more,
As Perkin's deeds are strong and brave, so worthy of folklore."

She picked up the tempo and added some pep as she sang,

"Now, laud the Knight Avants, the men we've all grown to adore.
They're virtuous and noble. Sin and evil they've forsworn.
So, dance and sing their praises loud. Huzzah for Knight Avants.
They keep you safe and keep the peace, all efforts at detente."

"Detente?" Allistair asked. "I thought I had a large vocabulary."

"The easing of hostilities, mostly between nations," she explained. "There are few words that rhyme with Avant." She shrugged. "Besides, I was told what tale to sing. The court jester actually wrote it."

Allistair furrowed his eyebrows. "Who is the court jester?"

"Jean-Paul," Lina explained. "He's a very good

jester, quite funny. You'd like him. Perhaps you will meet him. He tells me that he is often told what goes into tales and what does not. Apparently, King Didier and his counselors like to control what people get to hear. They definitely want the reputation of the Knight Avants to stay spotless."

"Maybe I've put them on a taller pedestal than they've earned," Allistair grumbled. "Still, I may be able to do some real good from inside the ranks now."

"Hopefully," Lina agreed. "I am learning a great deal that I did not know about our kingdom. I would like to hear more of the different houses. I think much of what we have heard about them is pure nonsense."

"The song you sang definitely was," Allistair scoffed. "I'm the one who saw the beast mauling the family. The father was very bleeding out. I jumped in and saved him. Got my shoulder chewed up, my elbow sliced open, and more bruises than I can count. Trust me; I was a wreck. I'm the one who stabbed the beast. Perkin didn't even show up until the beast had already fallen to the ground. He thrust his sword in at that time, but the beast was already dying. He did nothing. He stopped me from helping the father and threw me out."

"Classic, stealing the glory for himself," A mischievous grin spread across her face. "Perhaps I should rewrite the song."

"No," Allistair warned. "That may land you straight in a cell."

She shot him an expression of more disbelief than a child who had just opened a present to find rocks in it. "Since when are you afraid to stir up trouble?"

"I'm not afraid," Allistair defended. "I just think we

need all the facts first. We can't spread the truth until we know it."

"Fair enough," Lina conceded. "Perhaps we need to see what is really going on. We start with learning what we can of the king, his counselors, and the Knight Avants."

"You have a much better shot at getting close to the king than I do," Allistair remarked.

Lina flashed him a bright grin. "I plan on performing for him, but I think you need to sing with me. I don't see why you can't be a Knight Avant and still be my partner on occasion."

"I do," Allistair countered. "I train most of the day, and I am constantly on alert, having to leave at a moment's notice if there is trouble."

"But I'd really like your help," Lina confessed, tilting her head with a playful smirk. "You can't turn me down. You know it."

"I want to help," Allistair assured her. "I'll see what I can pull off. Let me know when we can sing for the king, and I'll make every effort I can to sing with you. Hopefully, we can do it in a way to make the Avants look better, or I'll be banned from performing with you again." He placed a steady hand on her shoulder. "I'll try, but no promises. The Avants are participating in a tournament soon. Next year is a tournament for the crown, so there will be many tournaments this year. Many from the houses want to practice by fighting the knights. All three houses want to rule for the next five years. Something tells me I'm in for a wild ride."

"Who knows? Maybe you'll win the tournament," Lina teased. "Now, that would be ironic."

Allistair shook his head. “It would be feckin’ glorious, but Perkin would likely be angrier than a wet mountain cat. Fortunately, I don’t really need to win, just make a good showing for the knights.”

Lina strummed a chord on her lute. “The tournament may be a good place to get information.”

“True,” Allistair agreed, “but it also is likely to be a good place to make enemies.”

Chapter 9: A Meeting, a Secret Plot, and Cooked Herring

King Didier, a handsome elf with silver hair, sat with his counselors, Ormando and Florence. Jareth, the keeper of the dungeon, joined them. Ormando was the counselor from the House of Farrow, who lived in the city of Montlier. He was a crevan with fox ears and a tail. His face looked unusually fox-like, as it had coloring that looked as if he might have hair all over. Likely he had some giant in him too, as he was fairly tall. Florence was a gati, who dressed to show off her long legs and curvy figure. That, along with her long blond hair made her look irresistible, and she knew it. Jareth was a rhys, so he had reddish skin and black horns. He was wrapped in a long cloak.

“The crown tournament is coming up next year,” Ormando reminded Didier. “Does the House of Thibaut have a contender for the throne? Are you going to fight?”

“I don’t know yet,” Didier answered.

Ormando smiled. “If you don’t, who will be competing from your house?”

“I’m not sure yet,” Didier repeated. “Duchess Edmee has not made a final decision. Perhaps Sinclair will fight for the crown. Who is going to compete from the House of Farrow? Jacqueline is not a fighter. She cannot compete against knights.”

“Perhaps one of the knights of our realm will,” Ormondo suggested.

“There is rumor Duke Korbyn is thinking of fighting himself,” Didier noted. “Is he hoping to win and then having Jacqueline lead Montlier? She would be next in line in the house of Farrow.”

“Perhaps,” Ormando answered. “I do not know.” He then turned to Florence and asked, “Who will be fighting for the House of Tamur?”

Florence threw her hands up. “I don’t know yet, and if I did, I wouldn’t tell you. I don’t trust you. I know that we all need to be trusting. I try very hard to build relationships so we all are close, but trust takes time. I just hope that whoever becomes king is very handsome and I can keep influence. I also hope that...”

“Wooing a handsome king is the only way you have any influence,” Ormando snipped.

“Enough!” Jareth scolded.

“I’m not done,” Florence insisted. “I think we need to change the rules so the house of Garnier isn’t even allowed to compete. Duke Thayer has many faunen in his city. He could pick a champion who can fly to compete. That would be a huge advantage. None of us want Thayer

as king. He'd be hard to work with, so we just shouldn't allow the house of Garnier to compete."

"I know Duchess Edmee hates Thayer," King Didier added. "I'm not sure why, but I know my house would support that. Yet, as king, I don't know that it's right to change the rules to the crown tournament. After all, it's been being fought as it has for a hundred years. It is a good system. Having a competition every five years and limiting a king to ten years is wise. The rule that if the king dies that his house replaces him is also wise. Having counselors from the other houses is wise too. Honestly, I think it might be good to have a counselor from the house of Garnier."

"That's ridiculous," Florence countered. "The city of Bellemar is too far away to know what is best for the kingdom, and Duke Thayer is so misinformed. Do you know that he thinks royalty should work? He doesn't believe in taxing his people more than to pay his knights. The city of Bellemar and House of Garnier don't even pay all the taxes the other cities do."

"They don't get representation either," Didier noted. "They don't get a counselor to the king. Honestly, it might be good if they did. Duke Thayer's city runs smoothly."

"Because he has it under control," Florence countered. "We need to get the entire kingdom under control, and he will not work with us. He either needs to pay full taxes or have the House of Garnier lose their right to compete in the crown tournament."

"I'll consider it," Didier assured her. "I can see your point, but I don't feel good about changing the rules. Perhaps we can come to some compromise."

“It doesn’t much matter if they compete,” Ormondo argued. “They don’t ever take it seriously enough to win, and their city is made of courtites and faunen. They can’t win. Personally, I think we ought to force them to pay their fair share of taxes. Their city does well. They could afford it.” He looked over at Jareth and asked, “What do you think?”

Jareth laughed. “The house of Garnier is irrelevant and no threat. All of you are wasting time worrying about insignificant things. We need to worry about the beast attacks.”

“What can we possibly do except have the knights fight the beasts?” Didier asked.

“Perhaps nothing,” Jareth answered. Then he added, “Perhaps a great deal. We do not know where the beasts are coming from. Honestly, I suspect foul play. I think magic is involved, likely magic from over the mountains.”

“Magic!” Didier gasped. “Do you really think there is strong enough magic left to mutate beasts? Magic was destroyed years ago. Don’t only remnants remain far north of the mountains?”

“As far as we know,” Jareth responded. “Perhaps the beasts have made their way from the north, but it seems suspicious that they come from from the mountains north and west of Roifort. I think something suspicious is going on in Lamagi, likely dark magic. We need to deal with Lamagi. They are likely somehow mutating the animals. We need to be ready in case they attack. Perhaps we should attack first. Personally, I think we need to send an ambassador to find out what is going on there. Since Ormondo and Florence are needed here, I could go.”

“I could go,” Florence offered. “I really don’t do that much here. Besides, the men on the other side of the mountain may be very strong and handsome.”

“Or perhaps green and scaly,” Jareth pointed out.

Florence instantly stiffened. “Perhaps you should go first.”

“I think we need to prepare for war,” Ormondo advised. “Perhaps we should attack first.”

Didlier contemplated the situation for a moment, and finally decided, “I don’t know. Perhaps we should, but war costs so many lives, and we have no proof Lamagi has anything to do with the beasts.”

“Perhaps we should send in some Knight Avants to infiltrate and kill their leaders so we can take over,” Ormondo suggested. “We must do what it takes to protect our people at all cost.”

“Perhaps,” Didier agreed. “The people’s safety must come first.” He tapped the table they were sitting around. “It could start a war, and I don’t want innocent people hurt.”

Ormondo leaned forward, rolling his hand as if urging Didlier to make a connection. “It’s why we need to fight in their land.”

“I could go as an ambassador,” Jareth again offered. “We also need to address the condition of the Rhys. My people need more help. The city of Varoux is run down and crime is high.”

“Aren’t we giving them tax money to help them out?” Didier asked. “What more can we do?”

“They need representation instead of the House of

Garnier," Jareth suggested. "I am not an official counselor, and my people get no contestant in the crown tournament."

"Varoux doesn't," Didier confirmed. "Yet, neither do Chesterfield or Roifort. Our largest city doesn't even get a contestant because no noble house lives here. That is how the balance of power was designed for our kingdom. That is how it is."

"Then at least make me an official counselor," Jareth insisted. "My people need more."

"Your people have fertile land," Didier noted. "They should not need more than we give them."

"It's not enough," Jareth argued. "My people need more power. We are looked down on by others. We want more power."

Florence perked up. "We could require people to hire Rhys. It is a shame that people are afraid of Rhys, just because all of you have horns and can create fire. Why should people be afraid?" She flipped her hair. "I'm not. Rhys can't catch me, as gati run quickly. The rhys aren't all evil. They may look demonic, but I find it rather attractive. I've been close to a few."

"Not everyone can run away like you," Didier pointed out. "You are a gati, your long legs and quick speed really help you. Your extra thumbs help break a grip too. Other races don't have that."

Jareth leaned over the table, his voice loud and angry. "Just because Rhys are more powerful than other races does not mean we should be shunned. King Didier, you need to help us more, or we will do whatever it takes to have our voices heard."

“Rhys should be helped,” Florence concluded. “I’m just not sure what to do. We need to pressure people to give them more jobs and pay them better.”

“I agree,” Ormondo stated. “We have four priorities right now: helping the rhys, countering the beasts, dealing with Lamagi, and getting everything ready for the crown tournament next year.”

Didier thought for a few moments and suggested, “The knights are dealing with the beasts very well. Perhaps we should hire more. I understand our newest recruit is doing very well. The minstrel has sung tales of him to me.”

“She cannot be trusted,” Ormondo warned. “He was her partner.”

King Didlier raised his eyebrows. “He still is impressive.”

“Not more knights,” Ormondo countered. “More soldiers. If we have too many knights, they will lose their status. We don’t want them common, particularly Knight Avants.”

“Then let’s hire more knights of the realm,” Didier suggested. “That isn’t as high of a status as Knight Avants. Now, we need to deal with the upcoming tournament. It should be exciting. We also need to make sure all the extra taxes are collected from the towns and villages. The people aren’t happy about them. Are you sure it’s a good idea to raise their taxes?”

“It’s necessary,” Ormondo assured him. “After all, it is necessary to take from those who have plenty to help the people who are in need and to protect our kingdom from attack. We fear Lamagi is sending the beasts and preparing for war. We must too.”

“If we must, we must,” Didier conceded. “Now, let’s go to dinner. We can meet again tomorrow.”

They all left, but right after they did, Ormondo and Jareth stepped aside.

“Be careful talking of the beasts,” Ormondo scolded Jareth. “What if Didier figures out that you are the one mutating the animals? You know that if it is found out that you are a wizard that you will be killed, or at least banished.”

“Didier will not find out, and he will do nothing,” Jareth scoffed. “He is too indecisive and very prone to compromise. If he finds out I am a wizard, I will convince him that it is a sacrifice I make for the people and he will struggle with the idea and do nothing.”

“Perhaps,” Ormondo replied, “but we don’t want him getting in the way of starting a war with Lamagi. We could use their resources, and war is a great way to get power. People will give up their freedom to get protection when they feel they are in danger.”

“True,” Jareth conceded. “Yet, I don’t know we need to go to war with Lamagi. Right now, let me deal with them, and we can have a great deal of control without war. We must be patient. For now, we make deals with Lamagi. When the time comes, we can take them over and the war will be easy.”

Ormondo smiled a wry smile. “I want to subject Lamagi to us, better yet, to me. I think you create more beasts and have them attack enough so people die in numbers. Then we blame the beasts on Lamagi and go to war.”

Jareth smiled back. “I can create beasts as quickly as we can capture the animals. Honestly, I make deal with

Lamagi often to get the wild animals. They are more prolific over the mountain."

Ormondo thought for a moment. "This is one of the reasons we need to rule Lamagi. The animals are of use to you, but their resources would be of use to me. They are rich in jewels and ore.

"Patience," Jareth urged.

Ormondo heaved a sigh. "We will discuss it more, but right now, we need to go to dinner. After all, we don't want to cast suspicion on ourselves."

"Of course not," Jareth replied. "No one suspects there is a wizard in the castle. No one suspects anything. Now, let's eat. I hear they are having herring today."

Chapter 10: Another fight, a Truthful Song, and a Round of Ale

Only two days later, Allistair rode out with the Knight Avants to fight beasts again. This time, the attack struck the village just west of the castle. Allistair wondered how beasts had slipped that far east of the mountains without being spotted by a single sentry. Something foul was afoot.

Allistair didn't have time to dwell on it. There were beasts to slay, many of them. It took the Knight Avants reached the village in record time, but already the beasts were rampaging through the streets and had killed several villagers. There were about four dozen Knight Avants in total. Some were away on quests across the kingdom, and some were to never leave the castle unless escorting the king. That meant that only barely three dozen Knight Avants rode into the fray.

There were over a dozen beasts tearing through the

town, and scores of people to protect, so the knights had a brutal fight on their hands. Sir Guilhem ordered the knights to different areas of the village, and once again, Allistair found himself under Perkin's command. Allistair and two other knights ran in to attack a beast that was clawing what appeared to be the lifeless body of a man.

"Help him!" Allistair called to one of the knights. "I'll fight!" It was a bold offer, and he wasn't sure he could win without the help of both knights, but if the man was going to live, he'd need help immediately.

The beast Allistair was fighting appeared to be a monstrous cross between a boar and a moose. It sported curved, ivory tusks, broad antlers, and sharp, jagged teeth. Plus, it was the size of a moose and boar put together, likely weighing twelve hundred pounds.

Allistair wasn't used to fighting against tusks and antlers, but he was improving with his sword. Of course, a bow would do better, as the creature so massive wouldn't be easy to fight up close. Perhaps he'd train with a bow later. Right then, he had to worry about staying alive.

The beast was every bit as nasty and aggressive as a wild moose and boar rolled into one. Allistair knew he couldn't charge in head on. When he first tried, a tusk pierce his armor and gashed his arm. He'd have to fight smart. He leapt back as the beast struck at the other knight and slammed his sword into its sheath.

"What are you doing?" the knight helping the wounded man called out.

Allistair didn't waste breath answering. When the beast lowered his antlers to charge, Allistair vaulted over

its head and clamped onto them. As the beasts reared up with a furious bellow, Allistair swung around to its back, gripped the antlers with his left hand, drew his sword with his right, and drove his blade deep into the back of the creature's neck.

The beast howled in pain and began flailing around, bucking to try to fling Allistair off. Allistair locked his knees and hung on for dear life. The second he found an opening, he plunged his blade into the beast again, and the knight below seized the opportunity to stab the beast in the chest.

The massive creature crashed to the ground, and Allistair had to jump off to keep the beast from falling on him. He hit the ground hard and rolled to absorb the impact. Still, he'd feel the bruises the next day. Scrambling back to his feet, he sprinted to the knight who was helping the injured man.

"Will he live?" Allistair panicked.

The knight shook his head. "He's already dead."

"Why don't we bring healers with us?" Allistair complained, his frustration boiling over. "We always have to wait for local healers to show up."

"Guilhem and Perkin insist it is too dangerous for them," the knight explained. "Come on. We need to go help finish the fight."

Allistair charged off to join the fray against the next beast. As he ran over, he saw Perkin block a strike against a fellow knight instead of protecting a lady. The lady was stabbed with antlers and fell bleeding to the ground. Allistair ran to the lady to stop the bleeding.

"Get up and fight!" Perkin barked.

Allistair looked at the lady bleeding beside him. He couldn't leave her. She'd die for certain. He glance over at the remaining beasts. The knights had the battle under control, so he stayed with the lady, putting pressure on the wound to stop the bleeding until a villager came and took over.

Only then did Allistair spring up and charge into the fray. As he fought, he noticed Perkin deliberately stepping aside and letting a beast slip past him. The beast barreled straight toward a hut. There was likely a family hiding in inside. In fact, a second later, terrified screams pierced the air from behind the shutters. Likely, the people inside saw the beast charging through the window.

Allistair sprinted toward the creature, striking at its hind quarters to turn it's attention from the cottage and to him. "Help!" he shouted to Perkin, but Perkin did not come.

Another knight dashed over to back him up. Allistair was grateful for the help, as he was exhausted, bruised, and bleeding. Yet, he pushed through. He couldn't let innocent people die. He raised his shield to catch snapping teeth and slashed at the creature's flank, while the other knight darted in low to drive his blade into the beast's chest. It didn't take long before they had defeated the beast. Allistair let out a ragged sigh of relief, knowing he couldn't have lasted much longer. The knight fighting beside him, dropped to his knees, gasping for air.

Allistair sheathed his sword for a moment, buried his face in his hands, and muttered, "I need water." If only he had some. He turned around slowly to see if anyone else needed aid. Fortunately, the last of the beasts were also dead, but bodies of slain villagers littered the ground.

Perkin strode up to Allistair, obviously furious, yet, keeping is expression tight with the crowd around, and hissed in a low, venomous tone, “What did you just do? You broke ranks and defied my orders!”

“There are people in that cottage,” Allistair defended. “They needed protection.”

“No,” Perkin snapped. “You need to learn to obey orders. I had strict orders not to protect that house. The family who lives there speak against the king.”

“There is no law against speaking your mind,” Allistair retorted, “and there feckin’ shouldn’t be.”

“They breed unrest,” Perkin hissed. “Do not question. It is not our job to decide who are traitors and who are not. It is our job to follow orders.”

Allistair clenched his jaw shut so hard that his teeth ached. Fighting the twelve hundred pound beast was easier than holding his tongue. He said nothing, but turned and stormed off.

He hadn’t gone far when a ten-year-old boy and a maiden who looked about sixteen ran from the house. The maiden ran up and hugged him, thanking him for not letting the beast get to them.

Allistair pointed to the house. “Who else is in there?”

“Our parents,” the boy answered. “That’s all.”

Allistair stared at the house for a long moment. Was the father really a traitor? From where Allistair stood, the Knight Avants weren’t anything close to what their gleaming reputation made them out to be. He dragged his hand over his face and rubbed his throbbing temples. Was he thinking straight? He’d gone toe-to-toe with a massive beast. Maybe he was hearing wrong. Maybe he was

hallucinating from fatigue. No… no, he wasn't. His head was clear enough, and his gut didn't lie. What was going on? Something in the kingdom was rotten – rotten to the core.

"You are a hero!" the maiden assured him, keeping her arms around him. "I am in your debt."

"It's my job," Allistair responded. "Glad I could help."

She was going to say more to him, but Perkin ordered, "Allistair, help clean up this mess!"

Allistair swallowed his anger, followed orders and went immediately to help clean up the aftermath. While he hauled wreckage and tended to the shaken villagers, he was able to help villagers in need, but his mind was miles away, churning over what he'd just witnessed. The system was rigged, entirely rotten. Good people had needlessly died. Why weren't villages given steel and taught to defend themselves against beasts? Even worse, why were some of the villagers purposely not protected, left to be devoured by beasts? His hunger for answers burned like acid in his gut, but even asking the questions was forbidden.

Allistair was ecstatic when the Knight Avants were called to return to the guardhouse. Sure, he had many questions left unanswered, but staying around wouldn't answer them, so he mounted his horse and joined the other Avants.

They didn't go straight to the guardhouse, as they all stopped at the Pewter Rose.

Sir Guilhem bought ale for all of them. Allistair was happy to accept the drink. He was even happier when he saw that Lina was there. She was singing and telling

stories.

As soon as she set eyes on him, she finished the song she was singing, ran over to him, threw her arms around him, and exclaimed, “I’m so happy you survived! I can’t wait to hear the tale.” She then saw the bruises on his face. “Are you all right? Do you need healing?”

“This is after healing,” Allistair admitted. “Faunen can’t heal everything.”

Lina put her hand on his bruised cheek. Then she held onto the stone on her necklace and blew in his face. It did help, but she could only do so much as the faunen had healed most of what could be healed. She gently rubbed his cheek with her hand. “I wish I could heal you more. I’m only about a fourth elf, so I don’t heal very well. I do better with people I care about.” Her tone instantly changed, and she snipped, “That’s not very many people.”

“Sometimes I’d like to hear your story,” Allistair prodded.

“I’m sure you would,” Lina quipped. “Get used to disappointment. I don’t tell of my past. Now, this is a celebration of the knights’ victory. Let’s go sing.”

Allistair agreed and added, “I’m glad there hasn’t been time for the story of our fight with the beasts to be rewritten yet. Perkin wanted me to let a beast attack a family in a house. I fought the beast anyway.”

Lina leaned in close and whispered, “I have learned a few things while singing for King Didier. There is a great deal of corruption. The king, well… mostly his counselors, wanted there to be many dead in the last attack. They are trying to rile the people up to anger, making them think the kingdom of Lamagi is sending the

beasts, so they can get support for starting a war."

Allistair clenched his fists. "That's feckin' evil. Obviously, the extra taxes and not allowing the common people to have swords so they can defend themselves from beasts or attacks by thugs. That's wrong, but I had no idea there was as much corruption as there is. What feckin' brilliant thing can we do?"

Lina smiled a soft smile at him and suggested, "Let's sing."

Allistair took a quick drink from his mug before they went to the front of the room. It was crowded, as there were not just the knights there.

"What are we going to sing?" Allistair asked.

"Not sure yet," Lina answered. "I may make it up as I go."

"I really like getting to work on songs and get the words right," Allistair reminded him.

Lina urged him to step forward. "There's not time right now. Let's just sing."

She began singing:

"The Knight Avants fought long and hard 'gainst vicious enemies!
They followed orders, as they had been given firm decrees."

Allistair sang the next line.

"Though innocents were saved there still were many men who died.
Perhaps it's time to arm the men to fight where they reside."

Lina then sang,:

"It's not the weapons that cause harm, but men
who wield for might.
A weapon in the hands of good is always used
for right."

Allistair boldly sang out:

"They say that power doth corrupt. They're wise
and truthful words.
To think that knights can't turn corrupt is naive
and absurd."

Lina stepped in front of him, stealing the stage, for her next line:

"So stay the course and fight for right. If not,
then evil wins.
Without strong heroes, all hope's lost, and life
becomes chagrin."

Allistair noticed Perkin glaring at him, so he spun Lina around and added,

"But now's the time to celebrate a vict'ry for
folktales.
Let's have some fun. Let's dance and sing, and
have a round of ale!"

He then called over to Perkin, "How about it? Is the king buying? Is this victory worth another round?"

"Indeed," Perkin replied to the cheers of the knights, who all excitedly went to get their mugs filled.

As they did, Perkin walked over to Allistair and

warned, “There will be no more talk of arming peasants. Do you understand?”

Allistair met his eyes with a firm conviction. “It would have saved lives today. We can’t get to attacks fast enough, and in the time it takes for us to arrive, many people can die.”

“That is not important,” Perkin replied, his tone colder than the depths of a deep, dark cave. “If the peasantry is armed, what is to keep them from revolting?”

“Morals,” Allistair answered, not backing down. “Knowledge. Truth. Good people don’t revolt if not under tyrants. Weapons in the hands of good people keep the peace.”

“I know,” Perkin admitted with an unusual hint of pain. “That is what we are afraid of.” He looked around before whispering, “If there is peace, if the people can defend themselves, then the Avants have little to no power.”

“So?” Allistair quipped, giving a careless shrug like a boy who’d just been scolded for tracking mud across the floor. “I’m not interested in power.”

“We need to keep power,” Perkin insisted, stepping closer. “If the Avants lose control, this land will spiral into chaos. You have no idea how fragile our realm is. Freedom is dangerous. Less freedom is the only way to keep the people safe.”

Allistair pressed his lips into a thin line for a moment, biting back every word that would earn his a flogging. “Understood,” was all he let escape his mouth. He then turned, caught Lina’s hand, and strode off with her. As soon as he was out of earshot of Perkin, he whispered, “We need to figure out what is actually going

on with our feckless leaders, and we need to expose the whole thing."

"They may just be evil, not feckless," Lina corrected, shooting a glance back over her shoulder. She gave a sharp shrug. "Then again, the king definitely fits the bill."

Allistair's voice was low and gritty. "The system isn't what we are told. It's all a big show 'cause they don't want people knowing the truth. It's broken. We can't trust a word our leaders say."

Lina shook her head, a wry half-smile tugging at her mouth. "I know you well enough to know you are going to make enemies, and people in high places will see you as a problem.

Allistair looked her dead in the eyes, his resolve hardening like forged iron. "I'm proud to be a problem."

Chapter 11: Captives, Fire, and an Intimidating Duke

Allistair struck at Sir Perkin, but Perkin parried and hit back, hard, sending Allistair staggering back. After all, being over seven feet tall, Perkin packed a punch.

“Stop,” Perkin ordered. “Our lesson is over now. You’re improving, but your sweep, riposte is still a beat late, which makes it easy to block. You need to keep practicing it.”

Allistair furrowed his eyebrows. “If I need to keep practicing it, why are we cutting practice short? Generally, we go another half hour.”

“We have a job to do,” Perkin replied. “Sir Guilhem has ordered me to take a handful of men to escort travelers to Montlier.”

“Never been to Montlier,” Allistair quipped. “Sounds like an adventure.”

“Just do as you are told,” Perkin warned. “Don’t ask questions, and remember that you’re under an oath of

loyalty."

Allistair blinked, looked as confused as if a maiden had just asked him for advice and replied, "Of course I will be loyal,"

"You will," Perkin insisted, his tone as cold and piercing as icicles. "If you aren't, I will have you flogged."

Allistair's eyes went wide. Flogged? Was he serious? Judging by the cold glare in Perkin's eyes, he definitely was.

Perkin ordered him to grab his pack and meet him at the stables.

That didn't take long. After all, every Knight Avant had to be ready to go on a moment's notice. The fact that Perkins had told him to grab his pack meant it was going to be a trip that would take at least a week.

He wished Perkin had given him a little more time. If he'd had even a half hour notice, he could go say good-bye to Lina. His thoughts drifted to her as he hurried out of the knight's tower. There was something very special about Lina. She was spunky, sharp, kind, and absolutely gorgeous with whatever coloring she gave herself.

When Alllistair reached the stables, three wagons packed with people waited with a guard perched on each driver's bench.

Perkin strode up to Allistair with another knight beside him. Allistair knew the knight, Sir Camden. He was a few years older than Allistair and lethal with a blade. They had sparred a few times, and talked at dinner before.

Allistair was directed to climb onto the front bench

of a wagon beside one of the guards. He hopped up and immediately glanced back, taking in the people behind him. They wore ragged clothes and looked worn down. He started to ask, “What are you…”

“Quiet!” the guard snapped. “We are ordered to take them to Montlier, not talk to them.”

That set off alarms. “Seriously?” Allistair challenged. “It doesn’t hurt to…”.

“We are not to speak to them,” the guard insisted. “We are to take them to Montlier. They must stay silent the entire trip. We are riding past the Freedom Faction command post. We cannot draw attention to ourselves, or they might attack.”

“The Freedom Faction?” Allistair echoed. “What’s the Freedom Faction and why would they attack?”

“Just follow orders,” the guard barked.

Allistair turned back to the people in the wagon. They were all sitting rigidly, looking terrified. For the first time, he noticed that they all had their hands tied.

That wasn’t right. Something was rotten. Every muscle in Allistair’s body tensed, gripped by the cold certainty that something dark was unfolding right in front of him. He leaned over the seat back and dropped his voice. “What’s going on?”

All the people in the wagon stared at him as if he was a vicious, starving monster.

“I’m not going to hurt you,” he assured them softly. “I just want to know why you’re tied?”

No one breathed a word until a boy, no older than ten, started to say something. The adults around him

immediately quieted him.

“What’s going on?” Allistair demanded, raising his voice enough for anyone nearby to hear. “I want to know what I’m involved in here.”

“Just follow orders,” Perkin growled, marching over to him. “Everyone is to make this trip in silence, and we must make it look like these people are prisoners to keep the Freedom Faction from trying to rob them.”

Allistair shook his head for a moment, barely believing what he was hearing. Did he hear right? He knew Perkin wasn’t likely to give him a straight answer, but he still blurted out, “Why can’t anyone speak? Why would them looking like prisoners help? Wouldn’t a group called the Freedom Faction actually try to free people? And why don’t these people have any feckin’ belongings with them? I want to know what is going on. Tell me!”

“You cannot make demands of me. I outrank you,” Perkin snarled with his eyes glaring hard enough to burn through Allistair. “The Freedom Faction is not about freeing people. They are not what they claim to be. Now, no more questions. Just obey orders, or I will have you flogged. Truth be told, I’d love an excuse.”

Allistair didn’t doubt that for a second. A dozen biting comebacks flashed through his mind, but he didn’t think it wise to upset Perkin more, so he sat silently as a wagon full of guards rode up and all the convoy rode out. The entire way, he wondered what was really going on. If only he could speak with the people.

They rode for hours in heavy silence. With every passing mile, Allistair’s hunger for answers grew sharper, yet, none of the tied travelers would speak. They were

allowed out of the wagons when breaks were taken to water the horses, but the people's hands were not untied. Still, nobody uttered a sound, but Allistair caught silent tears rolling down several faces.

He watched for an opening to slip beside one of the captives. Obviously, they were, but surely they weren't criminals.

They were of all races. There were quite a few rhys and many from a race he wasn't familiar with, who all had orange to red hair, were on the short side, and seemed fairly strong.

He walked over to the boy who tried to talk before and whispered, "You can't speak to me?"

"No," the boy whispered back.

"Where are they taking you?" Allistair again whispered, focusing his eyes on the horses, so no one could tell he was trying to speak with the boy, though every instinct screamed to him to cut the boy's ropes and shield him.

A lady stepped over between the boy and Allistair and warned the boy, "Don't say anything, or we will both be killed."

"I'm scared," the boy cried.

The lady put her arms around the boy as best as she could with her wrists tied together.

Allistair desperately wanted to say something else, to uncover what had the people so afraid, but Perkin called over, "Silence, Allistair! Get over here."

Allistair obeyed. As soon as he stepped up to Perkin, he demanded, "What's going on?"

Perkin pointed to a large building at the base of the mountain. “That is the Freedom Faction. Stay quiet!”

Stay quiet… with so many questions? If only Allistair could get answers, but obviously Perkin would give none.

Minutes, everyone was herded back into the wagons. Another several hours of hard riding brought them to the manor at Montlier, a grand city lined with towering buildings that made Allistair feel small and out of place.

In the center of the city was a massive statue of an owl and a shrine to the house of Farrow. Obviously, the people took fierce pride in their noble line.

When the knights arrived outside the gate to the manor, Perkin announced that he was going to meet with Duke Korbyn, and that while he was gone, everyone needed to take the people into a nearby hut, a small wooden building with a thatched roof.

Allistair was able to talk to Sir Camden as the guards shoved the people in the hut. A few tried to fight against it, but the guards would beat them until they submitted.

Allistair stared in disbelief, disgust boiling in his throat, and hissed at Camden, “What the feck is going on?”

Camden glanced around nervously for a moment before whispering, “They are being sold into slavery. There are mines southwest of here that they will work at.”

Allistair opened his mouth to scream, but Camden warned, “Don’t! There is nothing we can do. If we try to stop this, we will be beaten, and they will still be slaves.”

“We have to stop it!” Allistair insisted.

“We can’t,” Camden insisted grimly. “There is so much about our kingdom you don’t know, but you cannot fight the system. It’s broken.”

“Perhaps it’s working just as they want,” Allistair shot back. “Open your eyes. The king and royal houses want us to swallow fairy tales about how noble they are while they commit atrocities. It’s working perfectly – for them. Knight Avants are idolized, but I wish I’d never become one.”

“You can’t get out,” Camden warned, the longing in his voice showing he wanted to. “If you try, you will be flogged or killed. They cannot have people who know too much running around loose. Just get along, so you don’t die.”

Allistair watched helplessly as the captives were forced into the hut, every instinct screaming at him to save them, but there was nothing he could do... Wait... Was there?

Allistair was not small, standing a little over six feet tall and was a champion and knight. Perhaps he could do something.

He hid right outside the hut, near the door, behind a bush, with his heart pounding, and his breath sounding as if it was screaming to everyone about what he was about to do. Hopefully, he wouldn’t be caught. Yet, the risk was high even with the sun setting and darkness creeping in.

From his position, he could hear Perkin and Duke Korbyn when they walked up by the door. Duke Korbyn was more intimidating than facing a chimeric beast. Korbyn was obviously part crevan, as the bear ears and build were obvious. He was part giant too, as he had almost six inches on Allistair. Allistair would bet on him

over a bear even without a weapon. Korbyn and Perkin stepped inside for a minute. Allistair could hear an argument with the captives and a hard strike followed by an agonizing scream. If only he could run in and save the poor victim, but all that would do is get him captured and flogged.

He listened to the strikes, tensing each time, feeling as if he'd failed the prisoners. Yet, he had to wait. If he did, he might be able to later unlock the door and let the people out.

There wasn't much time to. As soon as Perkin and Korbyn came out, Korbyn stated, "They will do. Our deal is complete. Let me know when you can get more."

"That's not hard," Perkin gloated. "Capturing the Rhys makes them more angered and more willing to give us control in the name of protection. The collien are easy to come by. We have men who capture them from the mountains north of us. They are natural born miners."

"Indeed," Korbyn agreed. "You sell impressive goods."

Goods? … Goods? … Allistair had heard right. The people had just been called goods. Again, he wanted to draw his sword and fight Korbyn and Perkin right there – but he couldn't. Perhaps some of the guards would fight with him, but not likely many would. Camden definitely was too feckless to stand up.

Allistair waited until Korbyn offered to have everyone come to the great hall for an ale before making a move. He waited for everyone but the guards who were guarding the hut to leave and then jumped out of the bushes. He put one guard in a choke hold and knocked him out pretty quickly. The other screamed for help,

jeopadizing Allistair's chance of success. Allistair kicked him over and then kicked him in the temple, trying to knock out, not kill; but he may have killed the man. There was no time to check. He immediately went over to the door. It was barred, so he lifted the bar only to find there was a lock too. He had no idea how to pick the lock, so he kicked the door in. He felt his knee pop as he did and sharp pain shot up his leg. He breathed in to help himself focus and tried to ignore the pain, a skill he was too familiar with as a champion and knight.

He quickly stepped into the crowded hut. There was a dead man on the floor, obviously beaten by Perkin and Korbyn. Allistair's heart raced faster than a fox on a hunt. He should have come sooner. Maybe he could have saved the man. No, he couldn't beat himself up. He had to focus.

"Go!" he ordered. "Leave while you can. Guards will come soon."

The people all ran out of the hut with guards already coming after them, hopinv they could make it to freedom.

Allistair couldn't fight the dozen guards, so he did the only thing he could think to – he grabbed a torch from the hut and started lighting anything he could on fire. No one was in the hut, so he lit its roof. Then he lit a few barrels that were near it and a wagon.

As he'd hoped, several of the guards did stop to put out the fires. Still, the people would be pursued. Had he really saved them, or were they going to be killed by the guards?

Allistair spotted the next wave of guards charging in and bolted west – the exact opposite direction the prisoners had fled – determined to lead the guards the

wrong way. It had to work. He had to do whatever it took to buy them time.

He was a fast runner, but a sharp pain burned through his knee, and his head spun wildly, threatening to black him out. Still, he kept going.

The second he judged he was out of the guard's sight, he climbed a tree, as high as he could, and tried not to make a sound so the guards would lose his trail and give up.

The guards didn't give up easily. They combed the woods very thoroughly, torches sweeping the undergrowth while minutes stretched like hours as Allistair clung silently to the upper branches.

Once the footsteps and voices of the guards finally faded, Allistair climbed down from the tree, only to realize he had no idea where to rum. All the Knight Avants were at the Jagged Dagger Tavern drinking. Definitely, he wasn't going there. Yet, where else could he go? He he had to put distance between himself and the manor fast, before Perkin had him tracked down, so he ran southeast until he found a tavern. The sign above it read, "The Hidden Pearl." Whether it was safe or trap, he opened the door and stepped in.

Entirely focused on hiding, not even noticing anything about the tavern, he walked inconspicuously across the room and asked a serving wench there if there was a room for rent. She took his money and handed him a key. He glanced down the hall, handed her extra money, and whispered, "That is for ale, and for silence. If anyone asks, I'm not here."

She looked at the coins he'd put in her hand and eagerly agreed, "You aren't here."

He went back to the room, and sat on the bed with his face in his hands, wanting the drink. What had he done? Where should he go? He couldn't go back to the Knight Avants. Yet, that meant that he couldn't go back to Lina either. What a terrifying thought! She was not like any girl he'd ever met. There was something so intriguing, so amazing about her. Yet, he felt like he had to try to help the captives. He couldn't let them be sold into slavery. He rubbed his face with his hand. Had he helped them? Did they make it to safety? Perhaps they'd been caught, or worse, killed. There was no way for him to know if they had successfully escaped.

His thoughts were broken when the serving wench slipped into the room with a mug of ale. She held it out to him and asked, "Do you need anything else?"

He forced a tight grin. "Information. Until you find any, keep the ale coming." He handed her more coins, sank onto the edge of the bed, and started drinking. He needed the drink. How many mugs was it going to take for him to drown out the noise in his head and feel nothing at all? After all, he had no idea what to do next. He couldn't set foot back to Roifort, and the Avants would hunt for him in Chesterfield. He'd made some powerful enemies, and his reckless plan may have failed completely. How would he ever know if the captives safely escaped or ended up in chains anyway?

He sat alone in the dim room, staring at the floorboards until the door creaked open once more. The serving wench set a fresh mug on the table beside him and slipped back out – leaving Allistair in the quiet with nothing left for company but the ale, his aching leg, and the heavy silence of being a hunted man.

Chapter 12: A Gati, A Sprite, and A Beautiful Faunen

The next morning, Allistair woke up in one piece, relieved that the serving wench hadn't sold him out. He stepped into the main room, painfully aware that he was wearing the clothing of the Knight Avants. If only he'd run away with a cloak.

He claimed a table in the dimmest corner or the room, trying to figure out his next move. The same serving wench brought him some bread. He'd been a little spoiled as a Knight Avant, where breakfast meant bread, cheese, and fresh fruit. Still, he was grateful to have anything. In Chesterfield, he often went straight to working as a carpenter and didn't eat until noon, unless it was a tournament day. He always ate before competing.

He was breaking the bread when a cloaked figure suddenly appeared beside his table, his skin and hair color changing from the drab color of the walls to blond

hair and green eyes. He swept his cloak back to show a forest green tunic, black trousers, and a dagger on his belt.

Allistair startled, one hand dropping to the hilt of his sword. Clearly, the man was a sprite – and part crevan too, judging by his pointed fox ears. Could he be a royal spy or a lesser knight? Allistair narrowed his. “What do you want?”

“To help you,” the man replied, his tone smooth and confident. “I am Phillipe. I belong to the Freedom Faction. We can protect you and train you in the ways of the faction.”

Allistair instinctively leaned back from him, sizing him up with a skeptical scowl. “What exactly are the ways of the faction?”

“We fight for freedom,” Phillipe answered.

Allistair gave a slow, dry nod. “Freedom is a noble cause.”

Phillipe leaned over him. “We believe in protecting ordinary people and keeping them safe, and we believe we should be free to do just that.”

Allistair stared at him for a long beat. Those sounded like decent enough goals, but could he actually trust Phillipe? The Knight Avants sounded noble too, and they were rotten to the core.

“What do you have to lose?” Phillipe pressed. “You need our protection. You have made a deadly enemy of the Knight Avants.”

Allistair tapped his fingers on the table for a moment as he considered what Phillipe had said. “So why stick you neck out for me? You know I’m a problem and will

bring trouble."

"Because you know the inside of the castle," Phillipe admitted. "We do have some spies, but as a Knight Avant, you've been able to go through doors our spies can't."

"Interesting," Allistair noted, one brow raising. "What exactly do you want to do if I hand over the layout of the keep and knight's tower?"

"Purge it of corruption," Phillipe answered proudly.

"No," Allistair immediately refused. "That's feckin' murder. I'm not interested. I don't know that you and I will have the same definition of corruption, or the same methods of 'purging.' I think I'm better off on my own."

"Nonsense," Phillipe corrected. "You are going to be hunted down and butchered. You need our protection."

That was, unfortunately, true. Allistair reconsidered and finally conceded, "I'll see what you have to offer, but I'm not giving you a single detail about Knight Avants or the keep until I see for myself that we actually have the same goals."

"Agreed," Phillipe conceded, nodding once. "Let's ride."

Allistair finished his bread and headed out with Phillipe, who had two saddled horses waiting by the hitching post.

The ride to the faction's complex was daunting. The fortress was massive – an ancient stronghold carved straight into the base of the mountain. It had stood abandoned for years before the faction claimed it.

They rode up a steep road cut through the stone the complex was built on and up to the main gate, which was

thick and iron banded. Phillipe whispered a code word to the guard at the gate, not that he needed to, as they greeted him by name the second he rode up. Phillipe led Allistair into the courtyard inside the gate where stable hands stepped forward to take their horses.

“Follow me,” Phillipe instructed.

Allistair followed Phillipe up a staircase to a large room where two dozen men were practicing fighting.

“How many men are in the faction?” Allistair asked.

“About fifty,” Phillipe answered. “Plus a few cooks and workers. Now, do not talk, come with me.”

Phillipe led him through the fighting practice and up to a man who was obviously a gati due to his long legs and six fingers. Phillipe pointed to the gati. “This is Raphael. He is our leader.”

Raphael stepped over and looked up and down at Allistair, obviously sizing him up, before requesting, “Let’s see what you can do.”

Allistair eyed him warily. “What do you mean?”

Raphael ignored, instructing a man, “Both of you fight.”

“Wrestle,” Phillipe informed Allistair.

Allistair walked over to the man and held out his hand. “I’m Allistair. You are?”

“Devil’s Blight,” the man answered, looking at Allistairs hand but not shaking it.. “You can call me Blight. Let’s fight.”

Both men took their shirts off. Allistair had several more markings. The sign of the Knight Avants was on his

chest, meat hooks were over his shoulders, and a rope went loosely around his neck and down his back.

Yet, his markings weren't important. His opponent was. He stared at Blight, unsure what the rules were or how he was supposed to know when to start. It didn't take long to figure out, as Blight charged immediately in. It was also easy to see it was not going to be wrestling, but a full out brawl. Allistair had done that before. He preferred wrestling or grappling, but he'd been in plenty of fist fights. Champions were supposed to fight by cleaner rules, but they didn't always.

As they fought, Blight grew more desperate and vicious, as if something horrible awaited him if he lost. That made no sense. After all, the fight was supposed to just be a sparring test for Raphael to see what Allistair could do.

Despite that, the fight still felt deadly serious, and Allistair couldn't shake the gut feeling that more was riding on the outcome than he knew. What really was the faction?

He didn't get a chance to dwell on it, as Blight whipped into a vicious move known as the "slicer," forcing Allistair to twist hard out of the hold and scramble back before Blight broke his arm.

The grapple raged on until Allistair managed to wrench Blight face down on the floor, locking his arm into a tight arm bar.

Allistair looked up at Raphael and announced, "I won!"

"Not yet," Raphael corrected coldly. "Break his arm."

Allistair froze, looking as stunned as if he'd just opened a cupboard and seen a rattlesnake. "No," he refused flatly. "That's feckin' barbaric. I have nothing against him and nothing to prove."

"I disagree," Raphael replied. "You have everything to prove to us. You need our protection." He stepped closer and ordered, "Get up."

Allistair pushed himself to his feet. He didn't compliment Blight on a good fight as champion manners would require. After all, Blight had fought dirty, and Allistair was feeling the pain from the cheap shots.

Still, Allistair's stomach churned when Raphael ordered two men to drag Blight out and administer ten lashes with a whip for his loss.

Raphael then calmly stepped up to Allistair. "You are a very remarkably skilled fighter. I am impressed. Now, I wish to hear your story."

Allistair was surprised that instead of being instructed to practice with the other men that he was brought up to a room that wasn't like the others he'd seen in the complex. It was large, not to the size of a great hall, but still quite large. There were women dancing in it and a large table of food.

Raphael placed his hand on Allistair's shoulder. "We do well enough here to afford some luxuries. You will very quickly learn the rules to the faction. If you do as you are told and your missions are successful, you can have wine and women. If not, you will be punished."

Punished, likely whipped… That sounded less like a brotherhood and more like another cage. Allistair swept his eyes around the chamber. "What are you actually fighting for? I'm not convinced it's freedom, or you

would have freed the slaves yourselves."

"We intend to," Raphael explained. "That would take more numbers than we currently have. We have saved a few. That is where some of these women come from. Now, let's not talk business. Have some wine."

A beautiful lady came over with a bottle of wine for him. A tinkling sound rang as she walked. Allistair noticed the cord with bells on the end. That was the sign of a lady of ill repute. He looked around. All but one of the women in the room wore them.

"It appears that you feckin' drag the women from one form of slavery straight into another," Allistair snarled, disgust thick in his voice.

Raphael merely chuckled, waving a dismissive hand. "Just have a drink and enjoy."

The lady with the wine introduced herself as Marie. She had long brown hair and green eyes that had a hint of sadness to them despite her smiling face. Her coloring and her small wings showed she was obviously a faunen, likely not entirely full faunen, as her wings were too small to fly.

"Come," she offered. "Let me make you happy."

She took him over to where he could sit on a cushioned couch and gave him wine. As he drank it, she, and other ladies, danced for him.

Allistair drank the wine. It was strong, stronger than any wine or ale he'd ever had, but it went down deceptively smooth, so sweetly intoxicating that he ended up draining the entire bottle.

After enough wine, he danced with the girls, sang at the top of his voice, and did many things that he couldn't

remember the next morning.

The next morning, he woke to find himself in a room. Marie was there. She had rye bread and cheese on a plate that she handed to him. She also gave him a large mug of something.

“I don’t need more ale right now,” Allistair complained. “I have a headache that could kill a beast.”

“This will help,” Marie assured him, again handing him the mug. “It’s not ale. It’s an herbal drink to help with the hangover. You’ll still have a headache, but you need to be able to function today.”

Allistair timidly reached for the mug. “What will I be doing?”

“Mostly training,” Marie answered. “Raphael will teach you to be an incredible fighter. You’re already amazing, but you will learn even more. There are few as skilled as the faction.”

Allistair took a sip of the drink. Definitely, it wasn’t alcohol. “What’s the faction really fighting for?”

Marie shrugged. “Does it matter? I’m here because they saved me from slavery in the mines. You’re here because you are hiding from the Knight Avants. If either of us leaves, we will likely die.”

Allistair held the mug with both hands, thinking instead of drinking. “Why would you die? No one should be after you.”

“You never know,” Marie answered. “Korbyn’s men do not like slaves leaving. Even if I ran far away, I wouldn’t be safe. Raphael could very well sell my location out to Korbyn.”

Allistair swirled the liquid around in his mug. “How would he know?”

Marie glanced around, then whispered, “Raphael can find anyone. He is an excellent tracker and has informants everywhere. You cannot escape. If you upset him, he’ll have you assassinated.”

Allistair rubbed his forehead and concluded, “We can’t leave. That’s not good.”

“But you do need to get to practice,” Marie informed him. “You made a very good impression yesterday beating Blight. I suggest you keep impressing Raphael. If he respects you, your life will be much better.”

Allistair guzzled the drink and stood up. He swayed for a moment, but then followed Marie out of the room.

He was greeted by Phillipe and led to the same room they were fighting in the day before.

Allistair really would rather have gone back to sleep, but Raphael decided to personally train him.

Raphael was every bit the fighter everyone said he was, but Allistair knew enough unusual moves to really make a good showing for himself, even with his massive hang over.

The day of training was long and tiring. Allistair expected Raphael to question him afterward, trying to get him to draw a map of a keep, but Rafael didn’t. Instead, he took him to the harem of maidens again and gave him plenty of wine.

Allistair looked at the bottle of wine. He didn’t just want it; he needed it. So much had happened. He left the Knight Avants with his dream of being one crushed and came to the faction, knowing better than to trust them.

Yet, it was the situation he was in. There was nothing he could really do about it. The wine would be his escape. It was strong wine, and it would take little for him to forget everything. That's what he wanted – to forget, to feel nothing.

He chugged the wine and watched the women dance. Marie was quite beautiful. She seemed to have a good attitude about her situation, but still seemed to have so much pain inside. Perhaps he could help her – No, he couldn't. He could do nothing. He looked at the bottle of wine. It was empty. He held it up and called out, "I want more."

A wry smile crossed Raphael's face as he motioned for a maiden to bring another bottle. "Of course. Drink all you want." He then elbowed Phillipe, who was beside him, leaned toward him, and whispered, "Soon, he'll be entirely under our control."

Chapter 13: Misery, Mistakes, and a Spiked Whip

Weeks dragged on, and Allistair found himself trapped in the same grind day after day. He spent his mornings training to fight, ran missions for Raphael by afternoon, and drown his evenings in wine and women, always trying to escape into a bottle.

The toll showed plainly on him. One side of his face now bore the dark mark of a skull with horns. He wasn't sure if it was a symbol of the corruption he'd walked into with the Knight Avants or if it was showing a real demon taking root inside him.

Trapped. That was the only word for how he felt. Yet, what could he do? He refused to go back to the Knight Avants, but had nowhere else to turn. Maybe he could go home, but he'd feel like such a failure going back. How could he let his family see the wreck he'd become?

He had a mission waiting, so there was no time to dwell on it. The faction regularly robbed from those they decided deserved it and redistributed the money. It was feckin' despicable. Allistair knew every bit of it was wrong, but he justified going along by convincing himself that he didn't have a choice. Perhaps he didn't. After all, the wine was strong and viciously addicting. He needed it.

The mission he was to do that day was risky. He was to help a group into the castle courtyard and rescue one of theirs who was supposed to be executed.

It wasn't really that hard to get in the castle courtyard even though there were guards all around. That part wouldn't be any trouble.

Allistair pulled his hood lower over his face. He really wanted a drink, but it was early in the day and there was no chance to get one.

He glanced inconspicuously around the courtyard. Something seemed odd. If an execution was about to take place, the square should have been busier. After all, executions weren't so common that people ignored them. Allistair thought for a moment. Maybe they were. There had been two while he was a Knight Avant, and each of those times several men were executed. Allistair assumed they were the criminals he'd been told they were, but then again, they might not have been. If only he'd learned what was really going on earlier, not that he was doing better since he left. The faction was just as corrupt, just corrupt in a different way. They said they fought for freedom and helped eliminate criminals, but what they deemed crimes and what he did were often different.

He looked around warily. Phillipe leaned over to him

and requested, “Show us into the keep. Where would they be keeping a prisoner?”

“He won’t be in the keep,” Allistair corrected. “The dungeons are under the guard tower. I don’t think we can break him out of there. It’s too well guarded, and I’ll be recognized.”

“It’s better than having to try to rescue him during the execution,” Phillipe noted. “How about leading us to the king so we can negotiate for his freedom?”

Allistair eyed him suspiciously. “No.”

Phillipe sneered back, “You will regret this.” He then pulled out a whistle and blew it.

Almost instantly, Sir Guilhem, Sir Perkin, and a dozen Knight Avants were surrounding him. A dozen guards stood behind them.

Every muscle in Allistair’s body tensed. “What’s going on?”

“We made a deal,” Phillipe explained. “We want our man. They want you.”

Allistair felt helpless. There was nothing he could do. He didn’t have an ally anywhere. He raised his hands to chest level.

“Are you surrendering or getting ready to fight?” Phillipe asked.

“He’s surrendering,” Perkin gloated. “He knows better to even try to draw his sword.”

Allistair did know better. He also knew he couldn’t fight all of them with any weapon. “I surrender,” Allistair conceded.

Perkin was far too smug as he ordered the knights to capture Allistair. As soon as he did, he had his men turn over the prisoner to Phillipe.

Allistair held his head high as he retorted to Phillipe, “I knew you were a thieving fox and yaldson, but I seem to have overrated your character.”

“I am a clever fox,” Phillipe quipped back. “You cannot doubt my intelligence.

Allistair chuckled in response. “I never accused you of being intelligent. I am glad to be free of you.”

“Quiet!” Perkin demanded. “Allistair, you are coming back to the Knight Avants. I have orders to bring you there. You have disgraced us, sullied the sacred name of the Avants, and will need to be taught a lesson.”

That struck fear through Allistair, and he tried to hide the shiver that ran through him and his heart racing as if it was trying to get out of his chest and run away.

Once Phillipe and his men left, Allistair was taken by Perkin and the other knights to the dungeon.

The main room of the dungeon, where guards took their shifts guarding the prisoners, was very nice, even though the Knight Avants were not over the prisoners; Jareth was. The ceiling was high and there was fancy arch-work around the cells. A large table and padded chairs afforded the guards luxury while on duty.

Yet, the cells were not so nice. Allistair was thrown in a small cell. The ceiling was high enough that he could stand, but the cell itself was only about six feet by eight feet, and there was nothing in the cell but barren stone walls and rat droppings.

He sat on the filthy floor defeated, his hands tied and

nothing to do but anticipate whatever torture they were planning for him. That wasn't a pleasant thought. He'd either be tortured and killed or left there to rot. Either way, he would die a painful death. How had his dream of being a Knight Avant turned into such a nightmare?

He didn't sit in the cell long, as Perkin came personally with Jareth to see him.

"So, this is the prisoner you told me of," Jareth noted. "He is quite the troublemaker."

"He is," Perkin agreed. "I would like to recondition him so he learns his duty."

Jareth stepped over to the cell and sized up Allistair. "You really thought you could hide in the Freedom Faction? You are a fool. You are now not only guilty of interfering with the mission of the Avants and leaving them, but of thieving. I can see that the king sentences you to death."

Allistair almost cried. What had he gotten himself into? He'd failed at everything. His dream of being a Knight Avant had been a miserable failure. He'd joined the Freedom Faction against his better judgment, and was addicted to their wine. He had committed crimes. He'd set out to be the hero, but ended up in a dungeon likely to die. "If you are going to kill me, do it quickly," he pleaded.

Perkin laughed at him and mocked, "I am not letting you off that easily. I have never liked you. You didn't deserve to become an Avant. It was only because of that fool, Sir Xavier, that you did. You are a disgrace. You came in with your ideals and wanting to be a hero. It was pathetic." He stepped closer and hissed through the bars. "You are pathetic!"

“I’ve done nothing to you,” Allistair countered.

Perkin glared at him. “You have. You have gone against my orders, not conformed, and sang of corruption, exposing secrets, and denying my tales.”

A dawning of understanding struck. Apparently Allistair had damaged Perkin’s reputation, which meant far more to him than any morals.

“If you want a better reputation, stop lying to people,” Allistair suggested. “Stop being part of the intrigues.”

“Silence!” Perkin yelled, clutching a bar of the cell with such might that Allistair thought it might bend.

Perkin then turned to Jareth. “I want to recondition him myself. Let me beat him.”

“Approved,” Jareth agreed. “I do enjoy torturing prisoners, but this one is yours.” He then nodded to Perkin, added, “Don’t kill him yet,” and walked out of the room.

Perkin smiled wryly, gloating in his victory over Allistair, and had him escorted to the torture chamber.

The torture chamber was only a room over, but Allistair was bound and surrounded by guards as he was walked to it. The few steps were laden with a foreboding aura of the pain he knew was to come.

Perkin had Allistair’s shirt removed and his hands cuffed in irons that hung from chains anchored in the ceiling. Then Perkin stepped up and hissed in Allistair’s face, “You mocked us! Now, I get to punish you for it. I will make you loyal to me and the Avants. I will break you so you believe anything you are told by me or Guilhem without question.”

Allistair wasn't sure what Perkin was going to do, as he hadn't seen prisoners punished before, but he'd heard rumors of horrible tortures. There were stories of people being buried in the ground up to their neck and their faces smeared in honey so the bugs and rodents would eat them. There were rumors of tortures that were even worse. Honestly, Allistair felt some relief when Perkin picked up a whip. Unfortunately, it wasn't a normal whip, but a barbed cat-o-nine. That was going to cut.

Allistair thought himself brave, as he'd fought men and beasts, but he felt so helpless. "Give me a fighting chance," he challenged. "You and me, Perkin. It is a coward who has to tie a man to beat him. Let me go and fight me fairly."

Perkin laughed, a mocking, haunting laugh. "You are in no position to make demands. I don't need to fight. I have won. Now, I get my prize, seeing you suffer!"

How could anyone get pleasure from seeing someone else in pain? Allistair didn't know. He'd never delighted in someone else's suffering.

"Beg for mercy!" Perkin sneered.

"Never," Allistair refused. "You don't even understand the word."

That was a bold thing to say in his position, and it angered Perkin, who immediately threw the first strike.

Allistair braced himself for the hit, but as the barbs sliced across his back, there was nothing he could do to stop the burning pain that cried out to him as a testimony of the cruelty of the knights he once admired. Yet, he couldn't let himself scream. He couldn't give Perkin the satisfaction, so he clenched his lips shut and held his breath for a second to keep the scream from coming.

The next strike came, and that time, it was harder to not cry out. The searing burn and sharp pain was followed by the feeling of blood running down his back. Perkin was hitting hard and cutting deep for only two strikes.

The next strike came. Still, Allistair did not cry out; but by the tenth strike, he could no longer keep the agonizing cries suppressed. He screamed in pain, and Perkin laughed a mocking, sadistic laugh which made Allistair tense so the next strike hurt more.

Soon the dungeon echoed with the cries of Allistair as the whip struck across his back with a biting sting and the barbs ripping through his flesh time after time.

When Alllistair was weak enough that he could not hold his head up, Perkin walked over and mocked, “Not as strong as you thought? Now you see where your place is.” He then kicked the sides of both of Allistair’s knees. An audible crunch indicated they likely were broken. Allistair’s howl of agony drowned everything out, so even he could not hear the noise of the punches that followed.

Perkin laughed. “You aren’t so bold now, are you?” as he pulled his sword and cut Allistair’s ear half off.

Blood ran down Allistair’s face, and he passed out.

He didn’t wake up until the middle of the night, when he felt something. He’d been dreaming of a beautiful maiden, and was surprised that when he woke up, there was one over him.

“Lina!” he exclaimed with eyes wide.

“Shh!” she warned. “Come.”

How could he come? He’d been beaten. His back

was in pain, and his knees were likely broken.

"You'll make it," Lina assured him.

Allistair tried to stand up. It hurt, but he could do it. "How?" he asked. "How am I standing?"

"My healing magic," she explained. "I did what I could for you. You're going to hurt, but I used my healing stone." She blushed as she admitted, "And I kissed you. That can heal better from an elf."

"What?" Allistair asked, again with wide eyes.

"Just get over it," Lina retorted. "We need to go."

"How did you get in, and why aren't we being stopped?" Allistair asked.

"Come," Lina ordered. "Answers later."

As they left, Lina explained that she had bribed the guards. At least, she gave them strong wine and they passed out.

She led Allistair out of the dungeon and carefully out toward the main gate.

"We'll never get through," Allistair warned.

"Yes, we will," Lina assured him. "I have this planned. Follow me."

She led him through the gatehouse. The guard on duty did not even look at them as they went behind him.

"How?" Allistair asked as they headed out the door to the outside of the wall.

"That guard is named Claude," Lina explained. "He is sympathetic, and is willing to let you and me escape, but he wants to be able to say he did not see us. Now, into the wagon."

She pointed to her wagon. They both hurried over and hopped in.

It was late as they rode off, and the sound of the wagon rang through the air, cutting the silence and calling to all about their escape.

“Where to?” Allistair asked, suddenly stopping the horse. “I have no place to go.”

“Yes you do,” Lina answered. “You’re going home.”

Allistair clasped his hands and fought back his emotions as he confessed, “I can’t. I can’t go without the faction’s ale without feeling horrible. I have betrayed everyone who cares about me, everything my parents taught, and I left you behind.”

Lina put her hand on his arm and smiled encouragingly. “Your parents will still love you. They will help.” Her eyes lit up as she assured him, “I will help you too.”

Allistair looked into her eyes. “But I bring trouble. I’ve made some bad enemies.”

“True,” Lina agreed, “but you still need to go home. It’s our best option.”

Allistair flicked the reigns and started the horse moving again. Perhaps going home was his best option, but how could he face his family? He’d failed at everything. He gripped the reins tightly with trembling hands.

“Nervous?” Lina asked.

“Partly,” Allistair answered. “I’m shaking from not having the faction’s wine, and I’m terrified of what trouble I am about to bring to my own family.” He shook

his head, “I don’t even know what I’m going to do in Chesterfield. I am not recovered enough to fight as a champion. Perhaps I can go back to carpentry.” He straightened up and decided, “I have no idea, but I’ve hit rock bottom, and it’s time to move up. It’s time to get sober and make some changes.”

Chapter 14: Recovery, a Goal, and a Suitor

The next few months were really hard. Allistair's parents welcomed him home with outpouring love. They found Raissa and had her heal him. She was happy to do it, for a price, of course. Still, his knees would likely get injured again easily. Fortunately, when healing his ear, he hadn't lost any hearing.

The hardest part of the recovery was trying to break the addiction. A faunen couldn't heal that. The faction's wine was incredibly strong, so Allistair couldn't sleep without alcohol. His hands shook. He sweated almost constantly, and he had horrible headaches for a while. There were times he hallucinated and scared everyone around him, but his parents, Hartley, and Lina were great supports.

His mother offered to get his sister, Millie, to come help, as she was good at making healing elixirs, but Allistair refused. After all, Millie was married and she and her husband, Hayden, lived in Tamur, which was

overseen by Duke Berenger, who was a gati. Allistair knew more than he wished to of Berenger. Duke Berenger spoke a great deal of fairness and equality, but he taxed the people with incredibly high taxes and gave them freedom only as long as they used it how he wanted them to. Allistair saw that wasn't true freedom, which was one of the reasons he no longer lived there. He had grown up in Tamur, but he and his parents had moved to Chesterfield where they had more opportunities. His sister stayed in Tamur because of her husband and job. Still, he visited often. As an outsider, it was easier to see the feigned freedom and how Berrenger was controlling his people.

For the first time in Allistair's life, he wasn't sure he wanted his sister to see him, not as he was. Withdrawal was ugly, and he'd done some things with the Knight Avants and faction that he really regretted.

"Beating yourself up over the past won't help," Lina reminded him as they sat out on a quilt under a starry sky one night. A soft breeze blew, and Lina shivered a little.

Allistair took off his jerkin and handed it to her to wear. "You look good in my clothes," he teased as she put it on.

She laughed and hit him in the arm as she exclaimed, "What? Are you implying something?"

"Oh, you can take a joke," he replied. Then his face went serious again. "I don't know what to do now. I thought the Knight Avants were what their reputation claimed, but they aren't. Nothing is. The knights are corrupt. King Didier is corrupt. Duke Korbyn is corrupt. The Freedom Faction is corrupt. Is there anyplace that isn't corrupt? I think all the houses are."

“I don’t know they all are,” Lina corrected. “I heard a great deal while living in the castle. I was allowed access to travel some, as minstrels need to hear news. Kind Didier isn’t corrupt. He’s weak. He knows what is right, and he wants it, but he doesn’t have the backbone to stand up to the other houses. From what I understand, that’s how the elves are. They see themselves as peacemakers, but what they really do is give in to get along so there are no arguments.”

“That’s not peace,” Allistair noted. “That’s servitude. Didier may mean well, but not standing up for what is right is its own form of corruption. Evil wins if good does nothing.”

“True,” Lina agreed. “Didier is weak. Ormondo is from Montlier, and they want power for their house. The end justifies the means to them, so they will do anything to get what they want.”

“Definitely, they will use slaves,” Allistair noted. He sighed. “I don’t know if the slaves I freed made it to freedom or were captured and killed. I hope I helped.”

“You tried to,” Lina assured him. “Stop beating yourself up over the past. If it was the wrong choice, God knows you were trying to help, and he forgives. Personally, I think you assume that they made it to safety unless you have reason not to.”

Allistair shook his head. “Didier is corrupt. His counselors are corrupt. The Knight Avants are corrupt, so is the faction. We know the corruption in Tamur. You say the elves are weak. Is there anyplace that isn’t corrupt besides Chesterfield? It’s not corrupt yet, but with all the extra taxes, it’s headed to control by Roifort. At least I lowered the extra tax.”

Lina put her hand on his arm. “Maybe I shouldn’t tell you this, but your parents told me that a month later, Sir Elliot announced an even higher extra tax, so they ended up paying the extra money anyway.”

Allistair shook his head, “And the people just paid it? How do we get people to wake up to what’s going on around them? I don’t think anyplace is going to be safe soon.”

“Perhaps Bellemar would be,” Lina suggested. “They are rather isolationists, so people don’t know much about them, but I’ve visited there before. It’s where I learned to be a minstrel.”

“Really?” Allistair asked. A slight smile came to his face. “It’s good to have you open up, even if it’s only a little, about your backstory.”

“Bellemar is mostly populated by faunen, sprites, and a race called courtites.” Lina continued. “The house of Garnier is made up of a mix of faunen and courtites. Courtities are short, love to eat, and love to garden. They are simple people, but very hard-working. They appreciate minstrels, as they work hard during the day and really enjoy entertainment when they get it.”

“I’ve heard of a fourth house from there that gave up being involved in politics long ago,” Allistair noted.

“They did give up competing,” Lina confirmed. “I told you courtites are small. They are under five feet tall. They aren’t fighters, so they can’t win the crown.”

“Maybe you are part courtite,” Allistair teased. “That could be why you are so short.”

She slapped him in the arm playfully and scolded, “I’m five foot four. That’s not that short.” Then she

smiled at him. There was a great sincerity in her voice as she admitted, “I may look innocent and weak, but I don’t need to be afraid. I have the best protector ever.”

“I wouldn’t be so sure,” Allistair countered. He looked away. “I failed you, Lina. I left you alone. You had to save me. You deserve much better than me. In fact, if you get a different protector, you will be much safer. I have enemies.”

“I don’t want a different protector,” Lina corrected. “I want you. After all, you are my partner. I’m impressed that you have made it through what you have and come out strong. You have been sober for two months now, and I think you will stay that way.”

“I’m never drinking again,” Allistair assured her.

“I’m not either,” Lina added. “We’re in this together.”

“I’m not even sure what we’re in,” Allistair pointed out. “Lina, I’m not sure of my next step. I can’t really go back to being a champion. My knees will get injured too easily. I have lost all desire to be a knight. I tried to go off on my own, but ended up with the faction, and trust me, they are corrupt. I have no idea what to do now.”

“That’s not hard,” Lina replied. “You’re my partner. I think we go around and sing.”

“Sing,” Allistair muttered as he thought about it. “That’s half of an idea. How about if we sing of the corruption and try to wake people up?”

“Wake them up to do what?” Lina asked. “Are you trying to start a rebellion?”

“No,” Allistair answered. “I don’t want bloodshed. I just want people’s eyes opened. I want the truth out. Then

I want to get some conversation going. It is interesting to me that no one sees themselves as the bad guy while horrible atrocities are done. First, we find all the truth. Then we get it out to everyone. That's our first step. I think my first song will be called 'Dear Knights.' Perhaps I can reach some of them. If not, maybe I can expose them."

Lina bounced excitedly. "This sounds like a plan. I think you are back to your lovable self."

"Lovable?" Allistair asked. "Are you implying that…" He paused for a moment and looked into her beautiful brown eyes. Her hair that day was a soft peach, and her smile melted him. "You are so beautiful, so full of life, so fun, and still so smart. I constantly thought of you while we were apart."

"I thought of you too," Lina admitted, her gentle smile glowing.

Her eyes sparkled as he gazed into them. He put his strong arms around her. He'd held plenty of maidens in his arms, but Lina was different. She was amazing. Perhaps one day he'd write a song for her, but no words could do her justice.

He pulled her closer and whispered, "You're beautiful, Lina." Neither could deny the connection between them. There was something neither had ever felt before. He put his hand to her face and brushed her hair from her eyes revealing the flowers with thorns along her temples. They were beautiful. Everything about her was beautiful, and not just her appearance. She was innocent, but spunky, so feminine, but so strong. He'd been through so much, but with her in his arms, he felt as if he could take on the world.

“You are beautiful,” he whispered again before he pulled her in closer. Feeling her up against him sent a wave of excitement rushing through him, but nothing compared to the rush of joy as he leaned in and kissed her. Her kiss was so pure, so genuine.

After the kiss, he held her in his arms. “I will try to protect you,” he assured her. Then he added, “Lina, I’m not good enough for you, but I want to be your suitor. May I court you?”

“I’d love that,” she answered with her already glowing eyes brightening. “I think we make a great couple.”

“Even though I have enemies?” Allistair asked. “I’ve already made several, and singing to expose the corruption will make more.”

“I know,” Lina assured him. She raised her shoulders demurely. “I’m with you through the good and bad.”

“I’m afraid I may bring more bad than good,” Allistair warned.

She smiled coyly. “I’ll take my chances. I trust you.”

Allistair shook his head. “I’m not sure that’s wise. I’ve messed up my life pretty badly.”

“I have faith in you,” she assured him. “I think your song ‘Dear Knights’ is a great idea.”

He smiled. “I’ll get writing it.”

“Right now?” she asked.

He chuckled in response. “I have something I need to do first.” Once again, their eyes met and he gave her a kiss. All the problems disappeared for a moment. All Allistair could feel was hope. Lina was like no other lady

he’d ever met before.

After the kiss, he caressed her cheek gently and confessed, “Lina, seriously, I’m not good enough for you, but I hope I can keep you fooled. If I’m not mistaken, I think this might be love.”

Chapter 15: A Song, an Argument, and a Spicy Lime

A week later, Allistair and Lina found themselves at the Spicy Lime Hub, an inn southeast of Roifort. It was very near Fletcher's Field where tournaments took place, so everyone was familiar with it.

The Spicy Lime Hub also had a wide variety of visitors, as it was located in the center of the kingdom, so many people stopped there when traveling.

The place was full that night, and Allistair was a little nervous as he and Lina stood up.

They had written a song for the occasion, but instead of the lute, Lina was playing the drums. They had decided to just go with a beat and have him speak the words to a rhythm instead of singing a melody, so people would listen to the words not just the music.

Allistair sang:

"It's so easy for knights to just do what they want, to forget what they stand for and who they should be.
They complain that life's hard while they drink and they wench, and they don't ever think of the small guys like me.
But while coopers, and potters, and tinsmiths need skill, all the knights have no concept those skills are so hard.
I had dreams that I'd grow up to be a strong knight, but they're shallow, so I'd rather live as a bard.
They crushed all my dreams, all my faith, all my hope, 'cause they look at their job as no more than a game.
Still I wanted some heroes who I could respect, so I looked up to them, but they only want fame."

Lina picked up her lute and played as Allistair took over on the drums and they both sang:

"No, no, no. I'm disappointed.
No, no, now I'm full of shame.
No, no, no. I've been bamboozled.
No, no, now I know your game."

Lina went back to the drums as Allistair again spoke to the rhythm:

"So I don't want to hear of the knights and their tales. They're all lies that they tell you to make them look good.

They are fronts to control and to kill who they want. They've no backbones to stand up and do what they should.
Then the king and the dukes say the kingdom's at peace, when they know there are slaves and oppression around.
They work with the thugs, and the thieves, and the scum, and then act like they're servants just serving the crown.
If you listen to truth, and you think with your head, then you'll see through the fraud, the deception, and lies.
They're conditioning you to just give what you're told. Their demands should be met with 'I will not comply.'"

Again Lina played the lute and Allistair the drums as they both sang:

"No, no, no. I'm disappointed.
No, no, now I'm full of shame.
No, no, no. I've been bamboozled.
No, no, now I know your game."

They finished the song to a very mixed reaction. A few people cheered for them. Most clapped politely. Many stared at them, stunned at what had been said, and a few became very angry.

"You don't know what you're talking about!" an intimidating rhys called out. "The king is there to take care of us."

"No," Allistair countered. "The king and the Knight Avants are supposed to protect us from war and

criminals. We are supposed to take care of ourselves."

The man and several other rhys stormed over to Allistair. "You just want to hold us down! You don't understand the life of the rhys. Our people go missing, and without the king and knights, we would be killed by beasts. There are many beasts around Varoux. We need more tax money than we get to make up for it. The king gives us some, but we need more. We don't even get representation in counselors. Jareth needs to be made a counselor."

Jareth? Allistair knew him all too well, as he was over the dungeon. Allistair didn't know much about him except that he was cold and cruel to prisoners. He didn't know much about the beasts either. He'd fought a few, but had no idea where they came from. They never came to Chesterfield.

"Chesterfield doesn't get representation with a counselor either," Allistair pointed out. "I'm not saying that is right. I'm not saying the system is good."

"We need to fix the system!" the man insisted. "We need to give them the power to give us more."

Did he hear himself? Allistair shook his head. "Maybe the system isn't broken and needs to be fixed," he suggested. "Perhaps it's the people."

"We need more!" the man yelled. "The rhys are held down. Our city is run down. We don't have the privileges of people in Roifort or other cities."

"Then fix up your city," Allistair suggested. "You can always move to another and get a job."

"It's not that easy for a rhys," the man complained. "What job would I get?"

“What skills do you have?” Allistair asked.

“I don’t have the privilege of being born with skills,” the man argued.

“Most people aren’t,” Allistair countered. “I worked hard to learn carpentry and to learn to fight as a champion. If you don’t have a skill, I suggest that you start as an apprentice somewhere. That’s how I learned.”

“I shouldn’t have to work!” the man insisted. “You have no idea what you’re talking about.”

Lina stepped over and suggested, “Let’s dance, Allistair. Don’t argue with a fool. He’s not going to see reason. Arguing with fools merely pulls people down to their level where they can beat you with experience.”

Allistair turned to her and asked, “Would you like to dance?”

There was a lute player playing music, so they started dancing. Allistair wasn’t a dancer, but it did give him an excuse to hold Lina in his arms.

They danced throughout the night, and between dances many people talked to them. His song had sparked something. In some, it sparked anger. In others, it sparked thought. Several people talked to him about what he knew, how he knew it, and what they should do, although most of them did not have the strength to stand against corruption.

A crevan man stormed over to him and accused, “You’re trying to raise a rebellion!”

“No,” Allistair corrected, standing boldly against him. “I’m not trying to move anyone to violence. That’s honestly what they want. I’m just trying to get people to see the truth.”

“And do what?” the man hissed.

“Those who see the corruption are less likely to support it,” Allistair explained. “I want people to not be fools and blindly follow those who are not acting in their interest. We need to hold those in charge accountable for their actions.”

“I think you’re trying to cause a revolt!” the man again accused.

Allistair shook his head. The man wasn’t going to listen.

“Let’s dance again,” Lina suggested.

Dancing with Lina was more fun than arguing with fools, so Allistair again took her to dance.

The dancing was fun, and Allistair was surprised how much more he enjoyed not drinking. He’d always thought that ale was part of a good night, but he didn’t need it. Lina was a delight and very fun without a single drink of ale. Best of all, he’d remember the good night and have no regrets and no hangover.

There was a great deal to enjoy about the night, mostly Lina. Dancing with her was dream-like. She made him feel like a hero, like he could stand up against the world.

Everything was going really well until Sir Elliot showed up. What was he doing at the Spicy Lime?

“Allistair,” Elliot hissed as he walked up to him. “You seem to be causing problems.”

“I’ve done nothing wrong,” Allistair insisted. “A minstrel is free to sing any song he desires. You cannot arrest me for singing.”

Elliot took a step closer and threatened, “I can’t right now, but watch out. I’m watching you, and you’ve made some bad enemies.”

“I know,” Allistair replied without a hint of his fear showing. “Now, I’m going to go dance with my lady.” He took Lina’s hand to go dance.

As they stepped away, Elliot hit his hand on a table and fumed, “You are going to regret this!”

Chapter 16: A Raid, A New Guild, and A Lifeless Halo

Allistair and Lina drove their wagon through the northeast section of Tamur. They had both lived there before, so they were familiar with the city, but not that part of it. Duke Berenger of the House of Vinet ruled over the city. He was very controlling, and insisted that everyone in Tamur was to be equal. Of course that didn't apply to those of the House of Vinet. They had many luxuries and privileges others didn't.

Allistair and Lina rode into a small village on the edge of the city. It looked as if there had just been a battle there. Wagons were turned over, cottages were burned, and faunen were healing injured people.

As soon as Allistair and Lena stopped and hopped out of their wagon, Allistair stopped the first person he could, a lady with a small child, and asked, "What happened? Can we help?"

“I don’t know,” she answered. “You should talk to him.” She pointed to a man who was working and giving orders to others. “I doubt you can do anything unless you have food or can help rebuild.” She noticed the lute. “I doubt tales or music will really do much.”

“You might be surprised,” Lina corrected. “There is great power in music. If any of you are to have hope, music will help.”

“I can help rebuild,” Allistair added. “I am not only a minstrel. I’m a carpenter.”

The lady smiled, and Allistair and Lina went to talk to the leader of the village. He was a bearded gati, named Samuel, and he was more than happy to have extra help. He put Allistair straight to work.

As Allistair worked to rebuild a torn down fence, Samuel noted, “You are quite good. You must love your craft.”

“No,” Allistair admitted. “Swinging hammers in the hot sun or freezing cold is not something I really enjoy, but it’s paid bills and helped make me who I am. Now, will you explain what happened here?”

“Of course,” Samuel agreed. “Duke Berenger sent his knights to raid our village. They claimed that Tamur was attacked by several beasts and that they destroyed farms and food and the people needed our food. We keep supplies in case times get rough. They stole our food, insisting that it wasn’t right for us to horde it, and that everyone needed food as badly as we did so they were taking it for them.”

Allistair tried to suppress the anger that boiled inside him. After all, it wasn’t Samuel who had done anything wrong. He breathed deeply to control his tone before

replying, “That’s not right! I’m sure you would give to those in need, but that should always be by your will, not by force. Do you have enough to feed your village?”

“I don’t know,” Samuel answered with obvious pain. “Why can’t the people of Temur see what is going on?”

“Because they’ve been told lies all their lives,” Allistair noted. Then he added, “And because people are stupid! They believe what they want, and everyone being equal or taking from those who have and giving to those who don’t sounds good, not realizing how hard the people worked for what they have. They choose not to think about the implementation until they are the victims.”

Samuel looked around at the fence. “We’ll have to go cut down some trees. There’s too much fire damage to save some of this.”

“I’m on it,” Allistair assured him, and the two went to work.

As they worked, Lina helped try to salvage food and hunt for edible plants. When she had breaks, she sang for everyone. The music definitely helped everyone pick their spirits up.

She sang:

> “I know you did your best. You did nothing to blame.
> They don’t know all the work you put in. It is a shame.
> So they think you are lucky. They think it’s a breeze.
> They don’t know how you’ve worked for the things that they seize.
> It’s true everyone suffers, and life can be hard.

I sure know it's not easy for me as a bard.
We should all see each other with love and respect.
We should listen, not be quick to judge, then object."

A lady stopped her when she sang that and asked, "How are we supposed to love people who treat us so badly? They just stole everything from us. Duke Berenger doesn't care about us. King Didier doesn't care about us."

"I know," Lina agreed. "I'm not saying what they are doing is right. Yet we need to forgive and love. We need to choose to be happy. We have to forgive others for our own sakes, not theirs. Allistair and I are taking big risks to try to inform people of the truth. I'm sure there is more truth that we don't know. Still, I've chosen to be happy. That's a choice. Standing up for what is right is too. Allistair and I aren't trying to raise a rebellion. Our enemies would love a bloody revolt. That would give them an excuse to use force to eliminate those who oppose them. We just need to make our voices heard and not stand down. We need to not be afraid to stand for what is right."

"You are brave," the lady noted.

"I can be," Lina responded. "I have a great protector and partner."

The lady smiled knowingly. "So, you and him?"

Lina blushed, and a huge smile came to her face as she admitted, "Yes, he is my suitor."

Allistair happened to walk up right at that moment. He was sweating from the hard work. Lina came to hug

him, but he stepped back and warned, “I’m really sweaty.”

“I don’t care,” she assured him, and she gave him the hug.

He didn’t turn down the hug. He kept her in his arms as he stated, “I hear there’s food. I’m starving.”

That didn’t surprise Lina at all, so they sat down together to eat. The meal was simple, as most of the villagers’ food had been stolen, but everyone was happy to have food at all.

Allistair looked around and sighed.

“You’re worried,” Lina noted. “You want to help everyone and can’t.”

“True,” Allistair agreed. He pointed to the newest markings on his face. Where he had a skull with horns on one side of his face, the other had a face with a halo. He really wasn’t sure what that meant. The face seemed lifeless, and the halo seemed out of place. “What is this? Is it a bad omen?”

“I don’t think so,” Lina answered. “I think it shows that you are going up against demons but you aren’t going to let them corrupt you. You are going to keep speaking the truth and standing for what is right.”

“Most people don’t want to hear the truth,” Allistair quipped.

“But these people do,” Lina countered. “That’s good. They need some push to stand up for what’s right, but they are good people who see what’s going on.”

“True,” Allistair agreed, picking up his mug of water. “They know, but they don’t feel they can do anything.”

“They can’t really,” Lina pointed out. “I think we need to see what is going on around all the kingdom. We need to get the word out, and we need to build a group of people who will be a support group for each other, like family. That way, everyone can feel safer standing up for what’s right.”

“Good idea,” Allistair agreed. “What should we call our group of followers?”

“I don’t know,” Lina answered, “but I’m sure it will come to us.”

It did come to them later that night. Everyone went back to work until it was too dark to continue. Then the owner of the local inn informed everyone that he didn’t have all his barrels of ale taken, so he was going to pass it out for everyone.

The people drank and tried to forget the horrors of the knight’s invasion.

Allistair and Lina did not drink, but they understood why the others wanted to.

After two hours, the inn keeper suggested to Allistair, “You said you wanted a name for all of us that believe you and support what you stand for. How about the Hangover Guild? After all, I’m sure most of them are going to have a hangover tomorrow.”

“Allistair and I don’t drink,” Lina pointed out.

“I like it,” Allistair countered. “It’s not about hangovers. It’s about friends and camaraderie. It fits that we have fun together but then face the realities of what’s going on in our kingdom, just as everyone has to face the reality of drinking the next day. All of those who are with us are now part of the Hangover Guild.”

Chapter 17: A Song, a Hint, and a Big Coincidence

Allistair and Lina stayed a few days in the village and helped them rebuild. It didn't all go smoothly, as a large beast attacked. Allistair had no idea how a beast would have been able to get all the way to the village without being fought. After all, the Knight Avants were supposed to do that. Then again, the Knight Avants may have purposely let it through. He could see Perkin ordering him to not fight. He didn't think about it long, as it didn't really matter. Someone had to fight the beast, and that someone was him. He was trained with a sword. The villagers weren't even allowed to use them. They had to use farm implements.

Allistair did win the fight, and afterward the people cooked the beast. That made the fight worth it to Allistair. After all, the people were hungry. How could a government take what people had worked so hard for?

He and Lina did what they could to help the people, but they couldn't stay more than a week. They were headed to see Allistair's sister. During the week there, the idea of the Hangover Guild spread, and most of the people in the village joined, backing Allistair in his goal to expose the system and help people stand strong. The leader of the village even took up a collection to help Allistair with the guild.

At first Allistair refused, as the people of the village had little food, but the leader of the village assured him it was fine, that their food had been taken from them and their village, but they had before been a very stable, not poor, village. Allistair decided to accept the money.

Both Allistair and Lina were very grateful for the gift, and even wrote them a song in return, which they sang at the tavern the night before they left.

Allistair began the song, again speaking in rhythm to a drum so the people would focus on his words.

"I feel overwhelmed. How can I lead a guild?
The pressure is heavy. I could get men killed.
Yet, I know submission is never the way.
But still will the vict'ry be worth what we pay?

I know what it feels like to hit a real low,
I've seen all my dreams crash. It's really a blow.
I've been very drunk, been addicted to drugs.
I've worked for the knights, and I've worked for the thugs.

I've seen such corruption. I'm now wanted dead.
I'm sure calls to kill me are very widespread.
I don't want the pressure. I don't want the guilt,

If something goes wrong, and I'm sure that it
wilt.

The Knight Avants hate me. I know their true
deeds.
The "Freedom" assassins have horrible creeds.
And I can expose them. They want me dead too.
Then Korbyn of Montlier's sure to pursue.

I warn everyone, there are risks that we take.
By standing with me, there is much here at stake.
There's plenty to gain, but so much can be lost.
It's always true, freedom has come at a cost.

Don't just follow blindly. Think clearly. Be
smart.
And follow your head. Don't just follow your
heart.
I'll stand up for freedom and truth. It's a must.
But you must decide where you're putting your
trust.

I'm not someone special. I'm only a man.
And though I'm not perfect, I'll do what I can.
Our Hangover Guild will stand strong for what's
right.
By spreading the truth. Let our banner unite.

Who's with me? Who's in? I won't judge if
you're not.
But make your decision, and give it some
thought.
I don't want the burden, but I will stand strong.
As letting corruption take over is wrong."

Lina then sang to a beautiful melody,

"I know life is hard. I've had no place to go,
With no one who cared and a life full of woe.
I don't do backstories, but somehow we must
Keep freedom from dying. In God we must trust.

I put on a smile, and I choose to love life,
But that doesn't mean that I haven't had strife.
Corruption is rampant. You saw your town
wrecked.
That happens when power is rendered
unchecked.

I'll stand beside Allistair through thick and thin.
And hope we can bring the truth. Somehow
we'll win.
We need understanding, for people to talk,
Instead of just judging. Take action. Don't balk.

Our kingdom is failing. Corruption runs wild,
While people sit by. They're content and
beguiled.
I'm sure to be mocked. I may even be killed,
I'll still stand for the code of the Hangover
Guild."

There was great applause and a big discussion that followed. Allistair feared that the people would want their money back and to have the guild disbanded, but he also feared that they wouldn't. After all, the responsibility of being a leader hung heavily on him.

The people overwhelmingly supported the idea of the

guild and wholeheartedly agreed to help spread the truth and expose the corruption.

Allistair knew other villages wouldn't be so quick to understand the corruption, but that one had been raided by command of Duke Berenger, who was supposed to protect them.

After a great deal of discussion, Allistair finally had a moment to sit by himself and think.

Lina sat beside him. "How can I help?"

He held his arms out to her, so she moved into them. As he embraced her, he noted, "This helps."

She hugged him back, and the two stayed in each other's arms in silence for a few minutes before Allistair asked, "Are you ever going to tell me your backstory? You seem so happy all the time, but it seems you've been through a great deal too."

"I have," Lina admitted, "but I really don't do backstories. Just trust me that I know what it feels like to be entirely alone with no one who cares, a lost girl. You have felt alone, and felt like you've disappointed those who care, but you have a great family, so you have always had people who love you. I haven't."

"You have me," Allistair assured her. "I'm not planning on leaving you. Honestly, I'd like to stick around. Even if they kill me, I'll likely stick around you as a ghost."

Lina's bright smile sparkled. "You said before that you think you love me. Did you mean it?"

"I wouldn't say it if I didn't," Allistair assured her.

The noise of the tavern all went away as they once

again gazed in each other's eyes.

In a playful voice, Allistair teased, "Who knows? I really don't want to ever be without you. I'm planning on keep you around as long as you'll have me."

Lina smiled. "I guess I have something to look forward to."

Her radiant energy blossomed as she anticipated the kiss. "I think I love you too," she assured him before he gave her the expected kiss. It didn't disappoint. She'd found her hero, her dream man.

That's how they would have loved the night to end, but it didn't. They heard mighty roars outside of the tavern. Beasts were again attacking.

That seemed very odd to Allistair. The chances of beasts attacking that same village again was too low to be coincidence. Was Duke Berenger trying to have the village destroyed to hide what he'd done to them? That was ridiculous. People couldn't control beasts. Or could they?

It didn't matter. Allistair pulled his sword and ran outside to fight the beast.

Chapter 18: A Legend, History, and a Mock Sword Fight

A week later, they rode back toward Chesterfield. They had left the village they helped the morning after the beast attack, happy that the villagers had more meat from the beast Allistair had killed the night before. It was large and would provide several meals for the village. Allistair was very thankful for the faunen who lived in the village, as she healed him, so he was well enough to travel.

They spent the next week with Allistair's sister and her husband. Allistair and his sister, Millie, were very close. She was a healer. She had inherited some faunen healing from her great-grandmother, but mostly she studied herbs and knew how to use them to heal.

It had been a wonderful visit for the most part, but Millie was concerned about what she was seeing in Tamur. Duke Berenger and his counselor Isabelle were

much more of feelers than thinkers. They were always eager to go along with anything that sounded good. Obviously, they backed taking the food the village had stored in case of emergency in the name of fairness. How it was fair to take from people who had put effort in to preparing for times of need and giving that to people who had put in no effort didn't make any sense, but Duke Berenger and Isabelle never questioned their own reasoning. If it sounded good to them, it had to be right.

Allistair was frustrated with what he'd heard from his sister, and wished he had the money to help her, but there was little he could do. Hopefully some day he'd be able to do more.

Millie was excited to join the Hangover Guild and promised him her full support.

Besides the news of the city, the visit was wonderful, and Allistair didn't really want to leave, except when his sister told embarrassing stories about him, like the time when he spilled his dinner on a girl he was eating with, or when she dropped hints about how wonderful marriage was and how she thought he and Lina were a good couple.

Unfortunately, Allistair and Lina did need to leave. Honestly, Allistair worried that if he and Lina stayed too long then he'd bring trouble to his sister. After all, he had people after him who wanted him dead.

Allistair and Lina left early one morning. The sunrise was beautiful, with vibrant oranges and yellows with a hint of pink glowing over the treetops, but the weather was already getting hot. They knew it was going to be a sweltering day. Yet, they traveled happily.

Allistair found it very easy to be happy while

traveling with Lina. She was so bubbly and so full of energy. With her beside him, he felt like anything was possible.

As they traveled, they sang songs and told stories. Lina even gave some hints of her backstory to Allistair, admitting that been a lost girl. He knew the feeling of being lost all too well, and was impressed by how far she'd come, and how she could be so happy and delightful in spite of it.

Traveling from Tamur to Chesterfield, where they were headed took two days. It was a closer trip than going from Chesterfield to Roifort, but there were small mountains between Tamur and Chesterfield, so they either needed to be crossed or gone around.

There was a small inn in the mountains for travelers, but it only had two rooms for rent, as the mountains weren't traveled often.

The owner of the inn was named Jean, and his wife was Jenae. They were an older couple who liked living away from any city, and enjoyed the company of travelers when they came by.

Allistair had stayed with them before, as it wasn't uncommon for Allistair to visit his sister when he could.

Allistair and Lina were welcomed into Jean and Jenae's home and given an evening meal. After the meal, they all sat down to talk.

Jean and Jenae were both very interested in hearing Allistair's story and weren't surprised at all by the corruption in the knights. The slave mines didn't surprise them either.

After hearing the story, Jean offered to let them come

hide at his home if they needed to, but warned them not to let anyone besides family know where they were going, as he wasn't eager to have trouble follow.

Allistair and Lina both thanked him for the offer.

Lina had never met Jean or his wife before, as she seldom crossed the mountains, and when she traveled, if there wasn't an inn near, she usually slept in her wagon, as it was covered.

While they were there, Jean suggested that they might do well to spend some time in Bellemar to let some of the enemies Allistair had made calm down some.

"What's Bellemar like?" Allistair asked. "I know little of them. After all, they don't compete in the tournament for the king. They have no counselor, even though they once were a royal house, and they don't really interact with people on the main land."

"They don't," Jenae agreed. "Let me give you a little history." She offered them some spice cookies to eat while they talked, then explained, "There are four noble houses. Yet, people seldom ask how any of them got their nobility. After all, none of the houses seem related. The house of Farrow in Montlier is a mix of giant and crevan. The house of Vinet in Tamur is mostly gati. The house of Thibaut is entirely elven, as they are careful to keep the royal bloodline pure. The house of Garnier in Bellemar is courtite and faunen. Have you ever questioned why the leaders of the mokos, sprites, rhys, and others don't have any representation?"

"Not really," Allistair admitted. "I grew up in Chesterfield and honestly haven't traveled much, only to tournaments at Fletcher's Field."

"I've traveled a great deal," Lina pointed out. "I've

also listened to every tale I could hear, as I want stories to sing of. Yet, there is little history of our lands. Apparently, it was not kept, and there are not many oral legends. Those still around have likely been changed so much that they cannot be trusted."

"What tales are there?" Jenae asked.

Lina began singing:

Each noble house achieved its name.
Through deeds that earned heroic fame.
Each house showed courage, strength, and might,
By standing up for truth and right.

In Montlier, a monster raged.
The house of Farrow did engage.
They fought with boldness, with great skill,
At risk of life, they made the kill.

Tamur saw famine, hunger, pain,
Which led the House Vinet to reign.
They sent out hunters, their elite,
Who fought wild beasts and brought back meat.

In Arwood savage thieves did rage.
They caused great fear as they rampaged.
The house of Thibaut set up traps,
Catching thieves. Their guild collapsed.

For Bellemar, they earned their rights,
By saving knights wounded in fights.
Beloved knights too near their grave,
The house of Garnier did save.

Four houses shone above the rest,
Through acts of courage, they were blessed,
To rule as counselors and kings.
Their valiant deeds, the minstrel sings."

Jean laughed out loud.

"What?" Lina asked. "I know it is poor verse, but I didn't write it. I'm only singing the tale. I know the accent is off on 'rampaged,' their modifiers aren't clear, and their..."

"I'm not laughing at you or at the meter," Jean assured her. "It's just the song has nothing to do with reality. Let me tell you what really happened."

"How would you know?" Allistair asked.

Jean walked over, pulled a book from a shelf, showed it to Allistair and Lina, and explained, "History of our kingdom has been destroyed and rewritten. There was a conscious effort to destroy history. Many years ago, books were burned and minstrels killed. Yet, I have a history book. Tell no one." He looked into Allistair's eyes. "I know you well enough to trust you. Still, I warn you to tell no one. If you tell the story, it will make you a target. You can make that choice, but do not associate me or the book with the tale. I do not want trouble. I am too old to fight against the system."

"I won't mention the book or your name," Allistair assured him. "I can't promise to not tell the truth."

"That's your decision to make," Jean responded. "I'm just too old for trouble. Jenae and I moved out here to avoid any. We want to stay out of everything and live a simple life in peace."

"If that's what you want," Allistair replied. "I want to

hear what really happened."

Jean's expression went very serious as he explained, "Many years ago, the House of Garnier ruled the land. The courtite and faunen are a very peaceful people. The courtite like to garden, love to cook, and are very nimble. The faunen are also very in tune with nature and heal very well. They made good leaders because they believe that a leader is a servant, that the purpose of leadership is not to be served, but to serve others. They helped people with their crops and healed many people."

Lina furrowed her eyebrows curiously. "So, what was the problem?"

"Secret societies bent on power," Jean answered. "There was a group who called themselves the 'Vanguard' who worked to destroy the rule of law, families, and religion."

"Vanguard?" Lina asked.

Jean explained, "It means the foremost part of an army or a group with new ideas."

"That makes sense," Lina noted.

Jean continued, "They were led by men from the houses of Farrow, Vinet, and Thibaut, who decided that law, religion, and families were restrictive and needed to be overthrown to gain real freedom. The Knight Avants were originally formed to fight against them."

"Hold on," Lina urged. "Doesn't avant mean innovative or original? It's often used to mean elite. Why are the knights called that if their purpose was to fight the Vanguard?"

Jean answered, "Avant can mean innovative, but it also means 'before' or the 'front,' as in the foremost part

of an army, the same as vanguard."

"Interesting," Lina responded.

Jean continued, "Where the House of Garnier was very kind, they did not tolerate crime at all. Criminals were given fair trials, but the king insisted that he would not let a criminal free and have the blood of the criminal's victims on his hands."

"I take it the Knight Avants failed," Allistair noted.

"Indeed," Jean explained. "They succeeded at first, but over time the Vanguard was able to brainwash people, convincing people to join their cause, teaching them that families, God, and morals held them down. Many of the people followed, not really thinking through what was being taught, but going along as what they were being told sounded good. After all, some people have very hard lives, like orphaned children who have to steal to survive."

"There are other ways," Lina noted. "I know it's hard for a girl who has to make it on her own. That's why I became a minstrel."

"True," Jean agreed. "The biggest problem came when the Vanguard infiltrated the Knight Avants. They had men of theirs join the group and made it sound virtuous to put loyalty above principle and to put image over substance. The Knight Avants were conditioned to do what the Vanguard wanted when they took over."

"How did they take over?" Allistair asked.

"By chasing the House of Garnier away," Jean answered. "They convinced the people they were being oppressed, even though the people had freedom and good lives. Yet, there was a rebellion. The king at the time did

not wish to fight the people, as they didn't realize what the secret society really stood for. He realized that if he fought the Vanguard, the Knight Avants would mostly fight on their side, and there would be a blood bath, so he decided to step down, telling the people that they could have what they wanted. That is when the House of Garnier moved to Bellemar and took themselves out of the society to be their own kingdom."

"So, originally, were they from Roifort?" Allistair asked.

"Yes," Jean answered. "The castle there was built by the House of Garnier."

Allistair nodded and next asked, "Aren't they part of the kingdom?"

"That is debatable," Jean answered. "They are part of the kingdom by name only. They do minimal trading with the kingdom, but do not pay taxes as the rest of the cities. They instead pay a tax on their trades with the other cities, so their taxes depend on the amount of trade they do. That isn't much. They are very self-sufficient. They do not consider themselves part of the kingdom, but the king does, as he wants to claim rule over them."

"Maybe we need to visit Bellemar," Allistair suggested. "It seems there is much we have been lied to about, and there could be much to learn in Bellemar."

"You have already learned a great deal," Jenae pointed out."

"Right," Lina quipped. "I learned not to trust minstrels." She laughed at her own joke, and the others laughed with her.

Allistair tapped his fingers together in thought for a

moment and decided, “I’m going to write a song about the real story.”

“Just don’t mention my name or the book,” Jean reminded her.

“I won’t,” Allistair assured him.

“Expect a backlash,” Jean warned.

“Oh, I know I will make enemies,” Allistair stated. “I am going to do what is right despite the consequences. I see what is going on, and if anything is going to change, it is going to be through getting the truth out.”

“You are brave,” Jenae noted. “I admire that. My husband and I can’t travel or take the risk you will, but know that you are both welcome to hide here when needed.”

Lina and Allistair thanked her, and then Jenae suggested that they all get to sleep, as it was late.

Jean and Jenae went off to bed, leaving Allistair and Lina alone in the main room.

“This is a great deal to take in,” Allistair noted. “I’m not really sure how to fix any of the problems.”

“I don’t know either,” Lina responded. “It’s late, and I don’t want to worry about it now.” She held her finger out as if it was a sword and challenged, “I will defeat you!”

The two started jumping around in a mock sword fight, which Allistair, of course, had a great advantage in. Lina decided to jump up on a table to try to get position on him, but she slipped, falling on him. He caught her, but fell, taking the hit to protect her.

She ended up on top of him. “I have you trapped

now," she teased. "You cannot get away."

He responded by tickling her, so she grabbed his wrists.

There was a bit of a playful wrestling match going on when Jean walked in and asked, "What's going on?" His eyes widened as he saw them both on the floor.

"Nothing, really," Lina answered, putting on a good innocent face.

Allistair pointed to her and responded, "Her fault. She attacked me."

They both started laughing, and Jean replied, "Do what you want, but keep the noise down. I want to sleep. Honestly, both of you should too. We have two spare rooms." He then went back to bed.

"We need to be quiet," Lina whispered as she stood up. "What can we do that doesn't make noise."

Allistair responded by kissing her. Then he suggested, "We should get some sleep. I have a feeling tomorrow we are heading into some big adventure."

Chapter 19: Good News, A Mother, and a Meeting with a Lord

The next day they didn't head off to Bellemar, but decided they would visit home first, so they headed to Chesterfield.

Allistair's parents were excited to have them back.

"I have been so worried," his mother, Anne, explained. "We heard that there was some trouble with a village in Tamur that was raided, and that you fought beasts. What happened?"

"Hold on," Allistair replied. "Where did you hear that?"

"From a trader who came from Tamur," Anne answered. "He said that you are making quite the name for yourself, that people headed north came through, saying you had freed them from being made slaves, and that..."

“Yes!” Allistair exclaimed. “Yes!” He picked up Lina and spun her around.

She gave him a quick kiss and then told his parents, “He has been so worried that they didn’t make it to safety. He had to lead the Knight Avants and guards the other direction.”

Of course there were many questions as Allistair hadn’t told the whole story to his parents during his months of recovery, so he explained everything to them, and told of the village that Samuel lead.

They were quite excited to hear that Lina was his girl and about the Hangover Guild, but they were very worried about the enemies he had made.

Due to the concern of his enemies, they were all on edge when an unexpected knock came on the door. That was odd, particularly since it was nearing sundown.

Allistair put his hand on his sword hilt as he walked to the door and answered it. His eyes widened in shock as he saw who was there.

Two of Lord Urvan’s personal guards stood at the door. “Lord Urvan requests your presence,” one of them announced. “Please come with us now.”

Allistair didn’t refuse. Lord Urvan was a good leader of the city. He was known for caring. Unfortunately, he had no power outside of the city, so he could not stop the additional taxes that were levied by the king or do anything about Sir Elliot, as Elliot was a knight of the realm and ambassador to Chesterfield. King Didier had a few of his own knights as liaisons to every city.

Allistair and Lina both hurriedly stepped into the carriage the guards came in, and went to Lord Urvan’s

manor house. Lord Urvan didn't live in an elaborate castle as King Didier did or in as fancy of a manor house as Lord Korbyn or Duke Berenger, but his manor house was nice.

Allistair had been in front of Urvan before, as Urvan oversaw many of the tournaments of champions. Yet, never had Allistair been in the manor house. Lina had been. She said she'd gone in as a minstrel and sang for Urvan.

"He's just a man," Lina assured Allistair. "You have nothing to worry about. He is very nice."

She was right, but Allistair was still nervous. Fortunately, when they actually stood before Lord Urvan, he made them feel very welcome and comfortable.

He explained that he had heard of Allistair's deeds, and that he was shocked to find there were slaves, but very impressed at Allistair's courage to do the right thing.

Allistair wasn't sure how to respond. The first words out of his mouth were "People are stupid. What they were doing was wrong. I had to save who I could."

"I admire that," Lord Urvan replied. "I did not know of the slave mines in Montlier. I am sure there is much corruption that I don't know about."

"There is," Allistair confirmed. Allistair explained about how corrupt the Knight Avants had become and how the nobility actually hired the Freedom Fighters to do dirty work. He explained about the raid on the village in Tamur where the supplies were stolen. He even admitted that he thought something very odd was going on with the chimeric beasts that had been attacking.

"I have heard of those," Urvan noted. "I have not

seen them, but I heard of one in the woods north of us and sent guards to fight it. They said it was a very unusual creature and a very hard fight. The men would have likely died had Raissa not gone with them in case they needed healing."

"Raissa went," Allistair noted. "I bet that cost you a large amount."

"Not as much as you would think," Urvan corrected. "Raissa's head can be turned by a handsome man with broad shoulders. She was pretty eager to go with the men."

"She can't have you," Lina joked to Allistair. "You're mine."

"Definitely," Allistair agreed.

They then went back to discussing business. Once Urvan had no more questions they could answer, he admitted, "I have a quest for you, Allistair, if you will accept it."

Allistair tensed. That didn't sound good.

"I will pay you well and cover expenses," Urvan continued. "I want to know what is going on in the mines. Are there really slaves? It would be good to get the Knight Avants' help. Perhaps King Didier will help if he can. Do what you must to free the slaves, just don't take an innocent life. Honestly, I'd like whatever information you can get on the corruption in the cities. We cannot make changes if we don't know the problems."

Allistair looked at him warily. How could he free the slaves? He really had no power but to get some of the truth out through song.

"Will you accept?" Urvan asked. "I would like you

to make an oath of loyalty to me."

"Yes and no," Allistair responded. "I will accept the quest and the money, but I refuse to make an oath to anyone. Lord Urvan, from what I know of you, you are a wise and kind man. Yet, I thought the Knight Avants were noble and made an oath to them that I had to break. My conscience wouldn't allow me to keep it. I am not going to make an oath to anyone again. I will do what is right. I will help. I will not pledge obedience and loyalty and then find that you want me to do something I am morally opposed to. I am not going to become like the Knight Avants are now."

Urvan nodded. "That is wise. I will accept your service without an oath to me. I only need a promise that you will not turn on me as long as I am acting with virtue."

"I promise," Allistair assured him, bowing slightly to the Lord.

Lina bounced excitedly. "I don't know if I should be this excited, as the quest is going to be dangerous, but I'm eager to see if we can make a difference."

Allistair shook his head. "You are attractive when you are so excited, but I fear you shouldn't be. There is so much at stake, and I am a wanted man."

Chapter 20: A Chimera, An Exposing Song, and An Unwanted Order

The next evening, Allistair and Lina rode up toward the Spicy Lime, the tavern by Fletcher Field, where large tournaments were held.

They were fifty feet from the Spicy Lime when they heard a loud roar from the west.

Allistair tensed. He knew exactly what the sound was, another chimeric beast, likely either headed to Tamur or Chesterfield.

He pulled the wagon to a stop, told Lina to stay in it, grabbed his buckler, jumped out, and drew his sword. Hopefully, the beast wouldn't be too big for him to face alone.

The beast came quickly, and Allistair almost froze in terror. He'd fought beasts, but this one was eight feet tall, had the body of a gorilla, claws of a bear, the head of a

hyena with a jaw that jutted out like a crocodile, and horns like a buffalo. How was he going to fight it? He took a breath, ready for the fight. He had to win. He couldn't let the beast get to Lina. If only he had a ranged weapon. Using a sword was much more likely to get him hurt, and his wrestling wouldn't help at all.

Yet, he stood his ground and fought against the beast when it came. He spent a great deal of his time dodging blows, unable to get a hit.

Think... he had to think, but there wasn't time to analyze. Time… he didn't have much, but if he used his time right, he could maneuver, as the beast was faster on the run but not as dexterous.

Allistair dodged a strike from a claw, knocking it away with his buckler and slashed at the beast, cutting a small cut on its arm. The beast riled up and smashed at Allistair in a rage. Allistair was knocked back ten feet and hit the ground hard. Yet, he stood back up to fight.

The fight was brutal, but at least the beast didn't breathe fire. Still, Allistair had no idea how he was going to win.

Lina watched on in horror. How could she help? She needed to do something, but if she tried, she might be a liability.

She picked up a few rocks and threw them at the beast, hoping to distract it so Allistair could get a killing blow.

It did distract the beast, but it also made the beast notice her. That wasn't good.

As it turned to her, Allistair struck it in the side and dove over between her and it. The beast hit him hard as

he did, and Allistair only kept from being impaled by a horn because he had a buckler.

Lina tried not to scream out and distract Allistair, but he needed help, and she felt helpless. All she could do was watch.

She watched as Allistair strained with his buckler against the beast, trying to push it back as it struck around the shield with a sharp claw. Allistair was cut across his back. It felt very much like getting flogged.

Fortunately, he was able to slide his shield down the beast's arm to get position to plunge his sword in the beast's chest.

The beast reared on its hind legs, howling in pain, and Allistair stabbed it again.

The beast hit Allistair with a backhand, and then fell to the ground dead.

Allistair didn't get up, but stayed collapsed on the ground, moaning, "I'm not moving."

Lina grabbed the stone on her necklace with one hand, blew on Allistair, and healed him as much as she could. It did help, as when she finished, he was able to stand up.

They were getting back into the wagon when the Knight Avants rode up.

Sir Perkin was leading them. He jumped off his massive horse as soon as he saw Allistair, ran to him, and insisted, "What are you doing here? You are coming with me to be punished!"

Allistair looked up at him. Perkin was always intimidating, being a giant with sharp tiger claws. Still,

Allistair mustered his courage and defied, “No!”

As soon as he said that, Lina took off running toward the Spicy Lime.

Allistair didn’t worry about that. Instead, he looked over at the beast and told Perkin, “I am doing nothing wrong. I fought the beast to protect the people. What’s a beast doing out here?”

“You deserted the Knight Avants,” Perkin sneered. “You need to return, take your punishment, and do your duty.”

“And if I refuse?” Allistair asked.

“Then I kill you now,” Perkin threatened, pulling his sword.

“Hold on,” Allistair urged, holding his hands up to chest level trying to deescalate the situation. “Let’s all go into the Spicy Lime and discuss this.”

“There is nothing to discuss,” Perkin argued. “Draw your sword and prepare to die!”

Perkin raised his sword, but didn’t bring it down on Allistair, as a crowd of people from the tavern started running out toward them. Lina was with them.

The people all ran up to Allistair and started thanking him for fighting the beast. Apparently, many had watched the fight instead of helping. Of course, he didn’t expect the ladies to help, and some of the men were too old to fight, but some of them could have. He looked over them. No, perhaps they couldn’t. Only knights and guards were allowed swords in the cities north of Chesterfield. Allistair often forgot that, as Lord Urvan didn’t enforce that rule in Chesterfield.

Several people offered to buy Allistair a drink, and they started leading him toward the tavern. Allistair looked back at Perkin with a victorious smirk.

Perkin glared back with eyes that could kill.

Of course, Lina went into the Spicy Lime with Allistair. Perkin and his men followed.

“That was brilliant,” Allistair whispered to Lina as they sat down at a table. “I guess there’s a reason I love you.”

“Love?” she asked. “Do you really think you love me?”

“I think so,”Allistair admitted. “Definitely more than a good posset, and that’s something.”

“You don’t drink anymore,” she pointed out.

He shrugged. “I know.” Then he admitted, “I could not really understand love and be wrong, but I definitely think you are the most incredible maiden I’ve ever met, even when you are jumping off tables.”

She laughed, and her playful smile glowed. Where she would love to have just spent the evening flirting, she pointed out, “This isn’t over. The people bought you time, but Perkin will not let us go.”

Allistair nodded and put his arm around her, then whispered, “He won’t let me go, but he will let you. I am going to need your help when I’m captured.”

“Anything for you,” she assured him, running her hand up his arm. “I am your girl.”

“And very brave,” Allistair added. “Now, let’s make a plan. I didn’t count on Perkin being here. That was bad luck. We need to think.”

“We need to get the truth to the people too,” Lina suggested. “We need to spread the word. The Hangover Guild needs to grow.”

“Perkin will be so mad,” Allistair sighed. “I am going to take such a beating.”

Lina gasped and hugged him tightly. “He can’t do that to you.”

“He can,” Allistair corrected. “He has before. Now, I have instructions I need you to follow if I am going to stay alive.”

That sounded terrifying, and for a moment, she couldn’t say a word, but finally, she choked out, “Whatever you need.”

He explained his plan and she held him tightly as he did, so worried about what Perkin would do to him.

When they were done discussing what to do, they noticed that Perkin was telling people that they had come out to fight the beast, but fought another on the way. Allistair knew that was a lie. Not one of them looked as if he’d been in a fight.

Allistair shook his head, stood up, and called to everyone, “Do you want to hear a song?”

The crowd cheered their approval. After all, Allistair had just single-handedly killed a chimeric beast. He definitely was their hero that night.

“Are you sure about this?” Lina whispered as they stepped up to the front of the room. “I don’t want you hurt worse, or killed.”

“It needs to be done,” Allistair replied. “Let’s just do it and deal with the repercussions.” He then began

singing in his style, pattering to a drum.

"Listen, there's a system trying to convince you all,
Of enemies beyond the mountains, who I don't recall.
When have we ever been attacked? It's all about control.
The system pulls you down, but then their praises you extol.

I'm sworn a Knight Avant. They're known for virtue, strength, and might.
But underneath facades, their hands are blood-stained, not pure white.
They follow orders blindly, when they should protect the one.
Ignoble are their actions. As for scruples, they have none."

"Enough!" Perkin yelled. "You will not insult the Knight Avants. Stop telling lies!"

"They are not lies," Allistair corrected. "I am a Knight Avant. That is a title only the king can revoke, and he has not. I have free speech." He then turned to the crowd. "Do you want to hear the rest?"

The people cheered him on. Allistair looked over at Perkin, showing no fear. Perkin's hatred burned through his eyes, but he did not dare show his true colors to the people, so Allistair continued:

"I warn corruption's lurking in the shadows to extort.
Assassins work with nobles. Opposition, they must thwart.

The Freedom Fighters are a ruse, a name meant
to deceive.
They kill for gain, and then are praised, as
people are naive.

And even history is skewed. The tales you're
told are lies.
But never are you told the truth. You can't see
through the guise.
The House of Garnier should be king. Their
noble blood is pure.
The other houses formed a coup. The throne they
did secure.

So, listen, there's a system, the corruption's
deeper still.
Let's learn the truth and stand for right. Please
muster up the will.
Insurgency's not called for. No rebellion. No
unrest.
But learn the truth. Stand strong for right, for
that's a noble quest.

Where ignorance is useful, idiots can be
controlled.
The wise and educated aren't deceived into the
fold.
Now join with me and give support. My guild is
growing strong.
Its goal's to spread the truth abroad through
dialogue and song."

Perkin walked up to him, and with a sugary tone, explained to he people, "The Knight Avants are your

protectors. We fight beasts, protect the people, and vow to devote our lives to serving you. Allistair disobeyed orders and fled from the guild. He is merely trying to discredit us because he could not stand up to the level of being a Knight Avant."

"Not true," Allistair corrected. He then explained to the people, "I went with them to escort people to Montlier, only to find those people were being sold into slavery to mine. I set them free and had to flee for my life. I have no reason to lie. I don't want power. I just want a kingdom I can live happily in with my girl."

Everyone turned to Lina, who bounced excitedly, and the people cheered.

"Enough!" Perkin yelled. He then turned to Allistair and put on a very sugary tone. "Please, come back to the Knight Avants where you belong. I have many questions for you. If indeed what you are saying is true, then we need to find the corruption and clean it up. I had no idea those people were being sold as slaves. I want to know what made you think that. I need your report."

He snapped his fingers and other Knight Avants came to escort Allistair back to a room.

"Get Lina too," Perkin instructed. "I'm sure she has information we could use to know."

"No!" Allistair insisted. "I will go with you, even though I know you don't want to question me, but to beat me into submission, but I only come with you if Lina is guaranteed to be able to go free. Promise in front of the owner of the Spicy Lime and all the people here that they will see her go free. She doesn't know anything I don't." He looked to the people and called out, "They don't want me back. They want me dead, but can't kill me without

King Didier's decree. Support me. Together, we are the Hangover Guild, and we support each other as friends."

"Hangover?" a man called out. "How is a drinking group..."

"I don't drink," Allistair interrupted. "The name is to indicate those who play together but still support each other when it gets hard. Who is with me?"

There were mixed reactions, but the man responded, "If we are being lied to, I want to know." He turned to the rest of the group. "Don't all of you?"

A cheer rang through the crowd and the people started chanting, "Hangover Guild! Hangover Guild! Hangover Guild!"

Allistair wasn't sure how many of them were really behind him and wanting to learn the truth and how many were just drunk, but it definitely made a statement to Perkin, who was forcing a tight smile to not look bad in front of the people.

Perkin raised his hand to quiet the crowd and announced, "The Knight Avants have much to do tonight, so everyone, it's time to go to your rooms. Tomorrow we will take Allistair and hear of the concerns to see if they have merit. Trust me that we as the Knight Avants will look into all the claims, so you don't have to. We will protect you." He then motioned for his men to take Allistair away.

Allistair did not budge. "I want a promise Lina will be left untouched and free to go where she pleases. She is not part of this. I want her safety. I love her."

There was an audible "Aww" from the crowd, so Perkin didn't dare try to stop Allistair when he walked

over to Lina.

Allistair put his arms around her, gave her a kiss, and then confessed, “I love you, Lina. I’m serious that I want a safe world for us to be together in.”

Her smile was brighter than the torches on the walls, and she threw her arms around him, exclaiming, “I love you, Allistair!”

Allistair held onto her until Perkin called, “You need to get to sleep, Allistair. We will leave early in the morning.”

“And Lina is free to go where she pleases?” Allistair asked.

Perkin looked at the people, who obviously were behind Allistair. “Of course,” he conceded. “Are you sure she doesn’t need our protection? There are beasts around. You just killed one.”

That brought a cheer from the crowd, as Allistair was their hero for the night.

“Let her go,” Allistair insisted, his voice firm and unyielding.

“Of course,” Perkin conceded. “I just worry that something bad could happen to her.”

“I’m sure it will if you have your way,” Allistair accused. “She goes free.”

There was no more talk. Perkin told everyone the night’s festivities were over and had Allistair escorted to a room.

As soon as the people were gone, and Allistair was confined, Perkin ordered Sir Camden, “In the morning, escort Lina to our stronghold. I fear that she will not be

safe traveling alone."

"Didn't you promise to let her go free?" Camden asked.

"I am not breaking my promise," Perkin assured him. "We are not taking her freedom, just escorting her into Roifort for her own safety. Once she is at the stronghold, and I know she is safe, I will let her go free. I did not lie."

Camden tensed. "Perkin, permission to speak freely?"

"Granted," Perkin replied.

"We did know those people were going into slavery," Camden corrected. "We do know that we follow orders that are wrong in the name of loyalty."

Perkin put his hand on Camden's shoulder and explained, "There is a bigger picture, and there are sacrifices that need to be made to achieve it. You must trust the king and his counselors, knowing what they want is for the best for the kingdom as a whole."

Camden stared at him, doubting his ideals.

"Do I have your cooperation?" Perkin asked. "You can do as I ordered, or I can assign someone else to do the job and have you punished."

Camden breathed deeply, then conceded, "I will do as ordered."

Perkin smiled victoriously. "Very well. I thought you would see it my way."

Chapter 21: A Deal, A Beating, and a Long Shot

Early the next morning, while the darkness of night still cloaked the land, Lina wished she could get to Allistair, but there was no way she could. He was being guarded too well. She crept quietly down the hall to try to sneak out of the tavern to follow Allistair's plan. Unfortunately, Camden was sleeping in the main room and woke the moment she walked in.

"I knew you would have to come this way to sneak out," he noted, instantly becoming alert. "You are not leaving alone. It is too dangerous. I have been ordered to escort you."

Lina shuddered and stepped back, only to find her back against the wall. "Where do you intent to escort me to?"

"The Knight Avants' stronghold," Camden answered. "That is my order."

"From Perkin?" Lina asked. "Didn't you hear him

agree to my freedom?"

"I have my orders," Camden responded. "I cannot defy them."

Lina breathed deeply as she tried to decide how to handle Camden. "What is your name?"

"Sir Camden," Camden answered.

At the name, Lina perked up. "I have heard of you. Allistair speaks highly of you. He said you are a decent man, but don't feel you have the power to stand against what is going on."

"I don't," Camden agreed. "I must follow orders. I made an oath to the Knight Avants."

"You made an oath to uphold the standards they are supposed to have, did you not?" Lina asked. She stepped closer and put her hand on his arm. "Camden, you know what is going on is wrong. You know there is corruption. Do you want to see Allistair beaten or killed? Perkin will likely try to beat him into compliance, but when he sees he can't, he will try to kill him. I have little time. I need your help."

"What do you want me to do?" Camden asked.

"Escort me out," Lina answered. "In all honesty, if you help me, you will be obeying your order, as I want you to escort me and protect me. I even want you to take me to the Knight Avants' stronghold. I just don't want to go directly there. I want to make a detour first."

"Where to?" Camden asked. "You have my interest. If I can obey my order and help you, I am willing."

Lina looked around and whispered to him what she wanted him to do.

After listening to the plan, Camden agreed, “I am at your service, my lady. Let’s go.”

The two walked out of the Spicy Lime, sat in her wagon, and rode off into the darkness.

*****

Allistair was pulled from the room he was kept in after sunrise and taken out the back door. There were plenty of other knights sleeping in the room, so there was no chance of escape.

Allistair felt defeated. Yet, he tried to hold his head high as he stood with his weapon gone and his hands tied in front of Perkin.

“Where’s Lina?” Allistair demanded. “You agreed to let her go in the sight of the people.”

Perkin shook his head mockingly. “Tsk, tsk. It is sad, but she apparently has already left. She snuck out this morning, but being the kind man I am, and concerned about her safety, I assigned Camden to go with her and escort her to safety.”

“Safety?” Allistair snipped. “I bet you mean captivity.”

“She will be brought to the stronghold where she will be safe,” Perkin replied.

Allistair lunged at Perkin and almost managed to pound him with his tied fists, but several other knights grabbed him. “You liar!” Allistair yelled. “You promised her freedom!”

“And she shall have it,” Perkin smirked. “After we have obtained any information she has, she has agreed to keep quiet, and we have used her to subdue you. I am a man of my word. I did agree to her freedom. I did not say when.”

Allistair pulled away from the guards holding his arms and again lunged at Perkin. That time, he managed to grab him, but did not succeed in taking him down because of the other knights.

Perkin laughed. “You are bold, but foolish. Revealing your feelings for Lina will make me able to use her against you. I bet you will do whatever I order to keep her from getting hurt.”

Allistair couldn’t break loose from the knights holding him, but seethed, “You son of a…”

Perkin slapped him across the face to silence him as he yelled, “Fool! You will pay!” He pulled his sword and almost struck Allistair, but the other knights were watching, and some might report him to Guilhem. Sir Guilhem took no issues with obeying any order King Didier or Counselor Ormando gave, but he did not put up with his knights breaking rules, defying orders, or taking the law into their own hands.

Perkin sheathed his sword and hissed in Allistair’s face, “I will enjoy beating you, and I will get the approval to have you killed.”

Unfortunately, that was likely true, and Allistair was in no position to stop him. “Fight me one on one,” Allistair challenged.

Perkin laughed, grabbed Allistair’s hair, and pulled his head up to look down in Allistair’s eyes. “I don’t need a fair fight. I have already won. You will be thrown in the

dungeon and beaten every day until I break you or you are sentenced to death. I will enjoy it."

"Seriously?" Allistair asked. "That's your idea of fun? You need a girl."

Perkin slapped Allistair's face, then threw his head down and ordered the other knights, "Take him. Let's go before people start coming for breakfast."

They immediately pulled Allistair out of the tavern, and he was thrown over Camden's horse. His arms were tied to his sides with his hands tied in front of him.

Ropes were put around the horse's reins, so others could lead the horse, and they all headed back toward the castle.

Allistair wished a chimeric beast had attacked. It would likely give him cover to escape. Still, if Lina was being brought to the stronghold, that's where he needed to be.

The ride hurt, as Allistair was flung over the saddle. Blood was rushing to his head, which caused intense pain. His head throbbed, pulsing, and jolting with each step the horse took.

He was relieved when they reached the castle, and terrified. Being taken off the horse helped his head, but he knew it wouldn't be long until Perkin was dishing out punishment with eager excitement, enjoying every moment of Allistair's pain.

Allistair looked at the other Knight Avants as they pulled him down the stairs to the dungeon. Were they as eager to torture as Perkin, or were they following orders, too scared to defy them, even though they knew they were wrong?

He looked around. Camden wasn't there. Was Camden really bringing Lina there? Allistair's heart sank in utter despair. His only hope was Lina, but she couldn't do what he'd asked with Camden holding her captive.

Allistair wanted to sit on the floor of the cell and cry, but he wasn't going to be lucky enough to get put in a cell, not yet.

He was pulled to a back room where there were many items to torture people with. Last time Allistair had been punished, it was with a cat-o-nine. What would it be this time?

It didn't take long to find out. Perkin had Allistair's shirt removed and his wrists cuffed above his head.

"What shall it be this time?" Perkin gloated. "What will break you fastest?" He walked around Allistair, sizing up his prey. "I could have you slowly impaled on a stick, but that would not make the Avants look good, as you have not been convicted of a crime yet, even though I know you are a monstrous traitor."

Allistair demanded, "Fight me in a fair fight. Are you afraid?"

"No," Perkin answered. "It's not fear keeping me from doing it, but I want to see you tortured, and have the pleasure of stabbing you through the heart wait until I can get the decree for your death. That shouldn't take long."

Perkin walked over and picked up a whip. It wasn't barbed, so Allistair hoped it wouldn't cut as much. "This will work nicely," Perkin gloated. "Evidence of it will be entirely covered by your shirt, so you will look fine to everyone while still being in pain.

Perkin took the whip and threw the first strike. The

whip stung and cut across Allistair's back. It took all his strength to not cry out.

The next strike came. Strike after strike came until Allistair's back was striped with bleeding cuts and his head hung from not having the energy to hold it up.

After the punishment, Perkin had Allistair thrown into the cell. Allitair collapsed on the floor, and Perkin hissed, "Sleep well. I want you rested for tomorrow. Then I will have a faunen heal you so I can beat you more. Lina should be here by then too, and you will do whatever I instruct, or she will be next to be punished."

Allistair tried to push himself up to fight Perkin, but couldn't.

Perkin again laughed, a haunting laugh that echoed as a testament to his cruelty, and then walked out the door.

Allistair was defeated. His only hope was Lina, and she was with Camden, captured by the Knight Avants.

Chapter 22: A Secret Meeting, an Open Meeting, and a Demotion

“What?” Ormondo yelled, hitting his hand on the table he was standing by.

“It’s true,” Perkin repeated. “Allistair sang about corruption in the Knight Avants, how the Freedom Faction is hired, and even how the house of Garnier is supposed to rule but the other houses overthrew it.”

“That is not a good precedent,” Ormando fumed. “We can’t let the people know of the necessary dealings that are needed to run the kingdom. They need to live lives where they are not worried, trust us, and blindly obey.

“The chimeric beasts have been attacking more often,” Perkin noted. “Do you know where they come from?”

“Perhaps,” Ormondo answered. “That is not

information I will give. You only need to fight them or let them destroy those who oppose us."

"What do we do about Allistair?" Perkin asked. "I have him captured, and he is too weak to escape. I can let him rot in the dungeon, but it may be better to make an example of him. Can you get King Didier to sign an order for his execution?"

"Likely," Ormondo answered. "King Didier usually follows my advice, especially if Counselor Florence agrees with me." He laughed. "That's not hard to get her to do. She is from the House of Vinet. It is fitting their symbol is a swan. She is beautiful, but has a brain the size of a bird. All I need to do is appeal to her vanity and show her a good time, and she will do whatever I advise."

Perkin chuckled. "You aren't the only one who has schmoozed her to get what you want. We all know how she rose to become the counselor from Tamur. I personally don't find gati very attractive, but many men do."

"It doesn't matter if she's attractive," Ormondo countered. "It matters the power she has, and as a counselor to the king, she has power."

"Then I can count on getting the execution order for Allistair," Perkin gloated.

"Soon," Ormondo assured him. "Didier is an elf. He wants so much to have peace that he will compromise any principle for it. It makes him so easy to control."

Perkin clasped his hands together. "I fear the people won't be if they keep listening to Allistair. I hope his death doesn't rile them up. Perhaps I'll have to keep him in the dungeon for a while to let the people forget him or give us time to turn them against him. That shouldn't be

hard."

"Time does help," Ormondo agreed. "It's why patience is a virtue. People do not even question the houses' rights to rule and Bellemar having no part in it."

"They may now," Perking pointed out. "Thanks to Allistair."

"Perhaps it's time that we deal with Bellemar," Ormondo decided. "If the people see them as the enemy, it will not matter what Allistair says. No one will want them ruling. We can make Bellemar look bad."

Perkin smiled. "We could use it as a divisive point. Let's demonize their race." He stopped and thought for a moment. "We can make Bellemar an enemy, but we may want Allistair alive, as much as I want to kill him. With him alive, we can demonize him and divide people, causing hatred to anyone who associates with his guild or its causes.

Ormondo nodded and with a smug smile added, "That's a start."

*****

Lina and Camden walked up to King Didier early in the morning before breakfast.

"We need to talk, your majesty," Camden requested of the king.

Didier noted he was a Knight Avant and replied, "Of course. I will get my counselors."

"In private," Camden requested. "This is for your

ears only."

"Please," Lina added. "We need your help. If we go someplace private to talk, I will entertain after we do."

"Agreed," Didier conceded. He led them to a private dining room and ordered his guards to let no one in and ordered a personal guard to come with him. Didier invited Lina and Camden to sit and offered them food.

Lina and Camden were happy for the breakfast. It was much more lavish than either was used to, and the Knight Avants ate well.

As they ate, Lina explained to King Didier about the corruption in the Knight Avants, about the slave mines in Montlier, about how there were dealings with the Freedom Faction to assassinate people, and how those deals were coming from inside the castle.

King Didier was shocked. After all, his kingdom ran smoothly, except for the beasts attacking, and the people were happy. He had not heard of the village in Tamur that was raided for hoarding food, or about the family Allistair was told not to protect. He definitely thought Allistair bold and brave for standing for what was right.

"Then you will help us?" Lina asked eagerly. "We need to free Allistair, free the slaves, and stop the Freedom Faction. We also need to figure out where the beasts are coming from. There is something odd about them. We also need to go across the mountains to see what the situation with Lamagi is. We keep being told that we have to pay more taxes to protect from them, but when have they ever attacked?"

"They don't attack because the Knight Avants and knights of the realm hold them at bay," the king explained. "If we didn't have so many guards and

soldiers, they would invade."

"How do you know?" Lina asked. "Have you tried negotiating with them? Who is the leader of Lamagi?"

"I have no idea," Didier answered. "I haven't talked to them, but Ormondo is the expert on the kingdom west of the mountains. If he says it is needed to raise taxes to protect from them, I trust him."

"Perhaps you shouldn't," Camden corrected. He explained about the corruption in the Knight Avants and many of the orders he had received that he did not want to follow but did in fear of being tortured.

King Didier was shocked and agreed something needed to be done, but he explained that he didn't really have much power, that if he tried to go against the counsel of Ormondo that the people would likely revolt against him. He explained that the elves just wanted to live their lives and be left alone, that as long as they were safe that they didn't worry. They would not come to a call to back him unless they were really feeling the problem. He explained that Counselor Ormondo and Counselor Florence tended to be united, and where the Knight Avants and king's guards were under his command that many of them would support Ormondo if he disagreed with him. That wasn't what Lina wanted to hear.

"You need to take action!" she pleaded.

"I wish I could do more," King Didier apologized. "Honestly, I fear that the beasts are somehow being controlled, but I have no idea where to even get information on that. I fear that magic might be involved, and magic is dangerous. Ormondo and Jareth think that perhaps they are being magically mutated in Lamagi and sent here to destroy us."

“Do you really know that’s true? Lina asked.

Didier thought for a moment. “I don’t know what’s true. Seriously, I have little power.”

“You are king!” Lina exclaimed, raising her voice much more than she intended. “You have more power than anyone if you are man enough to use it!” She suddenly realized what had blurted from her mouth. She could be killed for saying that to the king, so she immediately lowered her head. “I am sorry. That was out of line.”

“But deserved,” Didier replied. “You will not be punished… if you entertain for us when we are through.”

Lina sighed in relief. She’d already agreed to entertain. “Surely, you can do something to help.”

“Yes,” Didier assured her. “I can pardon Allistair for any and all crimes he has committed, and I can order his release from the dungeon. If you like, I can release him as a Knight Avant.”

“He needs to stay as a Knight Avant,” Lina suggested. “He needs some authority to act, and that gives him some. But I will appreciate the pardon and release.”

“Very well,” King Didier noted. “Now, there is only one thing to do.”

“What’s that?” Lina asked.

Didier perked up. “Sing for me,” he answered. “You did promise that if I met in private that you would entertain.”

Lina started playing her lute and began:

“All hail our king. Let’s give support,

As evil men seek to extort,
The innocent and helpless folks,
And burden them with heavy yokes.

So, praise the man, our mighty king,
His praises and his glory sing,
So sing with joy. Sing ‘fa la la,’
And give our king a grand huzzah!

Let’s celebrate and praise his name,
His dictates will cement his fame.
Be known for good or ill’s his choice.
If he’ll be strong, we’ll all rejoice.

So, praise the man, our mighty king,
His praises and his glory sing,
So sing with joy. Sing ‘fa la la,’
And give our king a grand huzzah!”

Now, stand for truth and right so firm,
That evil will feel fear and squirm.
Be bold. Be brave. You know what’s right.
Now, show the people you’ve got might.

So, praise the man, our mighty king,
His praises and his glory sing,
So sing with joy. Sing ‘fa la la,’
And give our king a grand huzzah!

So sing with joy. Sing ‘fa la la,’
And give our king a grand huzzah!”

Lina then stepped up to the king and praised, “You are doing the right thing supporting Allistair. Now, let’s

talk. You can do more."

"But I don't want to start a war," King Didier countered. "Ormondo has great power. Honestly, greater than I do."

Lina took a breath to keep from scolding him, and in a soft tone replied, "Only if you let him."

*****

Lina, Camden, and one of the king's personal guards, a half-giant, half-crevan named Benoit, walked up to the door of the Knight Avants' stronghold. Allistair wasn't sure what animal Benoit's crevan side took after, but whatever it was, Benoit was solid, strong, and had huge arms. Given that they seemed a little long, Allistair suspected gorilla.

"By order of the king, you will let us in," Benoit announced.

The guard at the door did not dare even question Benoit. Everyone who knew the king knew who he was.

Lina, Camden, and Benoit walked immediately into the stronghold and announced that they needed to see Guilhem immediately.

It didn't take long for Guilhem to come. He invited Benoit, Camden, and Lina to have a seat and suggested that he get Perkin to come hear what they had to say.

"We will talk before Perkin comes," Benoit insisted, "but do fetch him. I do have business with him."

Guilhem offered them something to drink, but Benoit

refused, insisting they get straight to business.

The first order of business was for Benoit to give the parchment with the written pardon of Allistair, with the king's seal on it, to Guilhem.

Guilhem read it and at first made no response.

"He will be delivered to us now," Benoit ordered. "Bring him here."

"We do not have him," Guilhem replied. "If we do, I do not know of it."

"He is here," Lina insisted. "Check the dungeon. Perkin will have him there."

Guilhem ordered knights to get Allistair. As they went to get him, Benoit explained that King Didier knew of the corruption of the guild and asked, "Where are your orders coming from? They are not from the king."

"Ormondo," Guilhem answered innocently. "We are to obey him. He represents the king."

Benoit clenched his fists. "Ormondo is supposed to report any order he gives to you to Didier." He stood up, obviously trying not to show his anger. "Ormondo will hear about this! I expect Didier will request a new counselor from Montlier." He then put both hands on the table, leaned toward Guilhem, and warned, "I will not be surprised if he also demotes you to a regular Knight Avant and puts a new leader in charge of them. If what Camden has told us is true, you are more concerned about wine and women than what is actually going on in the guild. You just admitted that you didn't know Allistair is here and that you blindly follow obviously corrupt orders without checking with the king."

Guilhem shuddered and defended, "I have done no

wrong. I have been true to my oath to obey my king."

"Your oath includes protecting the people," Benoit scolded. "Yet, I hear from Camden that they have had orders to deliver slaves, to let so-called traitors die, and to lie about deaths so the Knight Avants' reputation is upheld."

"I don't know of any orders to not protect people," Guilhem insisted. "Perkin leads the advances. Those orders may come from him, but they don't from me."

"You should lead them," Benoit countered. "Perhaps you are as hedonistic as I've heard."

Guilhem glared at Camden, pure loathing obvious. Yet, Guilhem put on a more noble expression as he explained to Benoit. "I cannot charge out with the first wave of knights. It is my job to organize them and oversee them. I cannot do that from the front. I will look into what Perkin is doing; I assure you. I have done no wrong. I assumed Ormondo had informed the king of all commands he gave us. This is not my fault."

"Perhaps not," Benoit replied. "Perhaps the king will find you innocent, but the situation will be reported, and I suspect action will be taken."

Guilhem did not reply. Instead, the door flew open and Allistair was brought in. He showed no signs of the beating he took, as there were no marks on his face, but he was obviously weak.

"What did they do to you and who did it?" Benoit asked.

Allistair leaned over and whispered, "I don't want to give details around Lina, but this is with healing from a faunen, and you should see the stripes on my back."

“We will talk in private later,” Benoit replied. He then turned to Guilhem. “Where is Perkin? I asked to have him delivered.”

“It may take time to find him,” Guilhem answered. “He is likely patrolling to make sure everyone is safe. We have a bell to ring to have all Knight Avants report. They will all come to the call soon, and Perkin will report.”

Perkin did come about fifteen minutes later. He walked tall as he entered the room and asked, “How may I help you?”

“Stand for inspection!” Benoit ordered.

Fear struck as Perkin suddenly realized that he was in trouble. Yet, he said nothing and stood with his feet together and hands by his side.

Benoit stepped up to him, looked into his eyes, pulled a parchment from his belt, and handed it to Perkin before announcing, “You have been accused of ordering knights to let innocent people die, of delivering slaves to Montlier, and of beating Allistair without authority. How do you plead?”

“I have done nothing wrong!” Perkin insisted. “I have always been a faithful Knight Avant.”

“Then the king will hear your defense,” Benoit replied. He then turned to Guilhem and instructed, “Provide knights to escort Perkin to the king.”

Perkin stepped back and argued, “There is no reason to do any of this.”

“There is,” Benoit corrected. “King Didier commanded me to inform you of the crimes you are being charged with and bring you in. I am his loyal guard, and I will do as he instructs. You will come by

your own free will or by force. Either way, you are having the title of Knight Avant taken from you until this is cleared up. I am guessing that you will be stripped of the title permanently. Camden gave quite the testimony against you."

Perkin glared at Camden and hissed, "You are the one who isn't worthy of being a Knight Avant."

Camden made no remark back, but Benoit ordered, "Perkin, turn over your insignia and sword. I will keep them until after the king hears your defense. Then I will return them only if you are declared innocent.

Perkin glared at him and looked around the room, seeing that there were many knights and knowing they would not defy Benoit. There was no way to fight his way out. Benoit alone would be an issue, as no one wanted to go against his strength. He became one of the king's most trusted bodyguards because he was such a good fighter. Perkin handed over his sword and insignia. The insignia was on the tabard all the Knight Avants wore, but there was also a pin they wore on their shirts even when not on duty. Perkin removed the pin and handed it over. He then glared at both Allistair and Camden.

"Take him," Benoit ordered.

As other knights followed orders, Perkin turned to Allistair and hissed, "You will regret this. I will kill you!"

Chapter 23: Singing, Dancing, and Big Threats

That night, Allistair, Lina, and Camden had dinner in the Pewter Rose. They had been requested to attend the trial for Perkin the next night, and Benoit had informed Allistair that the king wanted to discuss him taking over as head of the Knight Avants.

“What do I do?” Allistair asked Lina. “Being the leader of the Avants could put me in a position to help clean up some of the corruption, but I don’t really want to be beholden to anyone. I don’t want to be sworn to obey any order I’m given. King Didier is a decent man, but he is weak. I think Ormondo runs the kingdom more than he does.”

“Didier is going to replace Ormondo,” Camden pointed out.

“That will do no good,” Allistair countered. “Lord Korbyn will replace Ormondo with someone just as bad. Korbyn wants to hide the slavery in his city and wants to keep slaves coming.”

“True,” Camden agreed.

Lina finished a bite of food and suggested, “Camden, you should be the leader of the Knight Avants. Allistair, you don’t want to be, and I think that may be wise. I think you can work with the king, but only on quests you agree to.”

“I like that idea,” Allistair agreed. “Yet, the money would be nice. As is, we are going to have to find a way to make it.”

Lina stood up and picked up her lute. “Then I suggest we get performing. You get the drum. You are really good at beats. It is amazing how much the people love your music style, where you mostly talk to a beat. It really emphasizes your message, and you have a good message to get out. Shall we sing?”

“I do have an idea I’ve been going over in my head,” Allistair agreed. He picked up his drum, and he and Lina walked to the front of the room.

Lina called to the crowd, “Do you want to hear a song?”

The people in the tavern cheered, so she started playing.

Allistair played a good drumbeat as he pattered:

> “This might offend, but I don’t care. You need to hear the truth.
> Corruption’s running rampant. You’re the sheep. They’re wolves, forsooth.
> I’m not controlled by anyone. I’m independent, sure.
> My oath’s to God, not man, not fame, not power, wealth, or more.

Awake, arise, and see the truth. Don't fall to what's to come.
See slavery, and murders, thieves, and lies at maximum.
It will get worse, and soon you'll see our freedom is at stake.
It's time to open up your eyes, united and awake.

United, people standing up don't budge. They can't be moved.
To see deception, lies, deceit, quite clearly we're behooved.
Unite together for what's right, and truth's our sword to wield.
With clarity, not hangovers, embrace our rising guild.

Awake, arise, and don't be sheep. Don't trust in men who lie.
Then, use your brain and facts to learn, then teach and vivify.
This is no call for violence, just to wake and see the light.
For evil wins if we stand by. In virtue is our might."

Lina then picked up a melody and sang:

"Listen, he's my best of friends, leader of the guild, the guild.
He's heroic, I contend. He protects the guild, the guild.
Listen friends, he leads with strength from the front, the guild, he's skilled.

Stand united for the cause. Join up so we build the guild."

When she finished, she passed the hat, and people put money in. A huge discussion followed. Some people thought Allistair was a rebel, a traitor to the king.

One man, who likely had had too much ale, came up to Allistair and yelled, "Zounds! You just want power for yourself! You want people to fight so you can get power." The then threw a punch at Allistair, a hard right hook.

Of course, Allistair blocked the punch. The man then tackled Allistair. That was a mistake. After all, Allistair was a champion wrestler before he became a Knight Avant. It didn't take long for Allistair to have the man pinned to the ground, lying on his stomach and his arm pulled back.

Once he won, Allistair corrected, "I'm not asking people to fight, nor do I want power."

He then stood up and explained to the people, "I want people to see what is going on. I want people to to know the truth. Leaders have only as much power as the followers under them give them. I'm not calling for a revolt or a revolution. I don't think the king should be overthrown or there should be a bloody insurrection. That is a sure way to bring in more corruption, as men like me will not lead it, and the men who will are the types who want power and will be more corrupt. What I want is for people to hold our leaders accountable. I want the people to get a say in who becomes king or counselor from their city if their house wins the tournament. I want all cities to have counselors to the king. I want changes, through peaceful means. That can be done."

“I want to learn to fight,” a man who didn’t appear drunk called out. “Beasts are attacking more often, and it takes time for knights to come defend us.”

“I will agree with that,” Allistair responded. “Every man should be able to protect himself and his family. I do not have the authority to approve carrying weapons for people who are not knights or nobles, but I am happy to teach people to fight. Unfortunately, fighting a beast without a weapon is not really possible. Yet, many of you are farmers, and there are definitely things that can be used as weapons on farms. Even a large stick would help to fight a beast. It is better than nothing.”

A big discussion arose, which became pretty heated, and ended up in a fight.

Allistair stood on a table and ordered the fight to stop. As a Knight Avant, he could do that, and those who did not obey could be punished, so only three drunk men continued fighting. Allistair stopped that fight by going into it and winning it.

The tension in the air could be felt, so Lina jumped up on a table and announced, “Everyone, Allistair and I are going to sing. Everyone dance.”

They didn’t try to expose the truth in their song. They’d already done plenty of lecturing. Instead, they sang a fun, lively tune:

> “Oh, we’ve had our lows, but we’re headed up high.
> We’re watching our dreams as we reach for the sky.
> We’ll never give up ‘til the vic’try is won.
> But now, on this night, we just want to have fun.

We don’t need an ale. We can dance. We can sing.
We’re happy and having fun doing our thing.
So, Join us in lighting this tavern up bright,
And make some great memories. This is our night.

Now, sing along, dance with us. Don’t be refined.
Get lost in our music and put cares behind.
Enjoy being foolish. Sing out if you’re thrilled.
Let loose and have fun with the Hangover Guild.”

They kept singing, and everyone in the tavern danced. It was really the break Allistair needed.

They kept playing and singing until very late in the night.

Finally, Allistair announced, “We have to get to sleep. Lina and I must speak with the king tomorrow, so I need to be coherent. Everyone have a good night.”

Before they left for their rooms, Lina passed a hat, and they made very good money. It was a wonderful note to end the night on, especially since they knew the next day was going to be intense.

*****

The night was not as enjoyable for everyone. As Allistair and Lina enjoyed their evening, Ormondo walked down the stairs to the dungeon and ordered the

guards to let him in the cell Perkin was being held in.

“You need to help me,” Perkin pleaded. “Talk to the king. Threaten him if you must. Get me out of here.”

“I will see what I can do,” Ormondo replied. “Unfortunately, I have my own hide to worry about. It is rumored that tomorrow the king is going to hear your case, but unless you can convince him, you will be not only removed from the Knight Avants but charged with working with the Freedom Faction. If there is enough proof to link you to ordering murders, you could lose your head. I will do what I can, but I don’t know what I can do. Be grateful if you get away with your life.”

Perkin clasped his hands together, but did not raise his voice. After all, he did not want the guards hearing what he was saying. “Can you get me out of here?”

“Not right now,” Ormondo answered. “My first priority will be to keep myself as a counselor.”

“You must help!” Perkin demanded. “I want out, and I want to kill Allistair. He has brought nothing but trouble.”

“Indeed,” Ormondo agreed. “I think we all would like him dead, but that would look rather suspicious right now and is not where our energy needs to be yet. After I meet with King Didier tomorrow, then we can get Raphael to dispose of Allistair, but first things first.”

They discussed the meeting the next day, and when they were through, Ormondo went to Jareth’s chambers and knocked on the door.

“I’ve been expecting you,” Jareth stated. “It seems that you have gotten yourself in some trouble and are now crawling to me for help.”

“You could be exposed too,” Ormondo retorted.

“No,” Jareth responded. “I can’t. Who is going to expose me? You? Fortunately, I have no authority to give orders, so they all have to come from you or the king or Guilhem. No one has anything on me.”

“I do,” Ormondo countered. “I know you are creating the chimeric beasts using alchemy and dark magic.”

“Indeed,” Jarth agreed. “Yet, do you have any proof? It would sound ridiculous. After all, who could possibly alter wild animals that way? It’s impossible. It will sound foolish, and it will be your word against mine.” He leaned closer and glared at Ormondo. “I think your word won’t be very trusted with the accusations against you. I think you are best off cooperating with me.”

Ormondo tried not to yell and be heard, but he did raise his voice. “Are you trying to betray me?”

“Of course not,” Jareth replied casually. “I am trying to keep you loyal. You will be, or I will see that you are broken.”

Chapter 24: A King, A Threat, and a Wishy-Washy Verdict

The next morning, Allistair, Lina, and Camden were brought in front of King Didier. There were two guards with Didier. One of them was Benoit. He stood tall and confident, but with his hand on his sword hilt, as if he was expecting trouble.

“Perkin will be brought here soon,” Didier explained. “Allistair, I wish to talk to you before he or Ormondo come. They will be here in half an hour.”

Allistair bowed to the king, as that was proper. Then he asked, “What do you want from me?”

“To hear what you have to say,” King Didier answered. “I believe that Lina and Camden have reported correctly about the slaves and about Avants being beaten. I have also heard though that you are trying to cause a revolt against me. What do you have to say? That is a

serious accusation."

Allistair hadn't been nervous about meeting with the king, but he suddenly tensed and could feel sweat forming on his brow. Yet, he tried to remain calm. He wasn't guilty, so there really was no need to panic. Still, he'd been innocent and still punished before.

"I am not trying to cause a revolt," he defended. "I assure you of that. What I have been doing is trying to get people to open their eyes and see the truth." He stepped closer and very bluntly told the king. "I have insisted that people don't revolt, but you of all people should see why we need to get the truth out. As king, you should know all about your kingdom, and you had no idea that people working for you hire assassins from the Freedom Faction, who are thieves and cutthroats. I know. I shouldn't admit this, but I worked with them for… not long, but longer than I should have. I never killed anyone, but I did protect thieves so they could rob. I will own that and take punishment for it. The faction keeps people loyal by giving them a type of drink that if they don't keep getting they will get very sick."

"You are confessing to a crime," Didier pointed out.

"I know," Allistair admitted. "Let me continue. When I saw who the faction really was and found a way out, I took it. If you want to kill me for it, take a number. King, you need to open your eyes. I've made mistakes. I've hit rock bottom, but I've come up and am trying to be a hero. Now, you have made mistakes too, not the same kind, but in your kingdom, there are slaves working in the mines of Montlier and someone giving orders to the Knight Avants to not protect people so they die. Someone with some authority is working with the Freedom Faction to eliminate enemies of the government. Honestly, I had

questioned if it was you."

"It's not," King Didier defended.

"I believe you," Allistair replied. "I don't think you are corrupt, but I think you have no idea what is going on in your own kingdom. You have sat by trusting your counselors and the reports that you get, and you assume that since your life is good that everyone's is."

King Didier gave a tense smile. "You are bold in front of me. Most men would not have the courage to tell me I'm wrong or clueless to my face."

"Perhaps you need men like me as your counselors," Allistair suggested. "Of course, I don't pull my punches. Think about this. Did you even once think to question where the chimeric beasts are coming from?"

"They are wild animals," Didier responded.

"I think you just answered my question," Allistair smirked. "Yes, they are wild animals, but not natural ones. What is deforming them? Where do they come from? Perhaps you need to find out."

"I understand they come from over the mountains," Didier explained.

"Have you gone over the mountains to see the situation there?" Allistair asked next.

"No," Didier answered. "Lamagi is barbaric and preparing for war. I am giving everything I can to help the Knight Avants and knights of the realm to be ready just in case. Ormondo is negotiating with them to keep them from attacking. It is why we've had to raise taxes."

"Not we," Allistair chided. "You." He paused to let the idea sink in, then continued, "You raised taxes, on

people who are already struggling. Now, I find that it is to pay off Lamagi so they don't attack. That's wrong."

Didier rubbed his chin for a moment as he thought. After a few moments, he conceded, "You have a point."

Allistair continued, "Have you even been over the mountains to see if any of what you are being told is true?"

"No," Didier admitted. "My counselors think that a king should not leave his kingdom as he is needed if something goes wrong."

Allistair shrugged. "Or they don't want you to leave Roifort, so they can lie to you." He shook his head. "Didier, you are the king, and I do not wish to lose my head, but you need to find out what is really going on. Go over the mountains. Learn what Lamagi is really like. Go to the slave mines. Close them. Get to know the people you are raising taxes on."

"It's not safe," Didier argued. "Where it would be good for me to go, what if the people in Lamagi try to kill me."

Benoit had not said a word, as guards weren't really supposed to talk, but he spoke up. "I will protect you, king. I think Allistair speaks wise words to you." He pointed to the other guard and stated, "Hugo and I will protect you."

"No doubt," Didier replied. He tapped his fingers nervously on the arm of his chair and whispered, "But if I leave, what happens to my kingdom? If my counselors or the Avants or those under me are as corrupt as you say, then if I leave, they could do things they are afraid to do with me here." He looked around nervously before continuing. "The houses are at odds with each other. I

know there is corruption, and I know that I cannot trust my counselors, but I am also afraid that if I stand up against them that Montlier and Temur will come to war against us. Yes, I command the knights and soldiers, but I worry that many would follow Ormondo over me. He has great power. Honestly, I feel that I am doing a good job as king if I keep him from taking over and reigning through fear."

Allistair let out a breath. "I may offend you by saying this, king, but honestly, I don't care if I offend you."

Lina leaned over and warned him, "Be careful. He could have you beheaded."

Allistair whispered back to her, "Let's hope that he really does want to be a good king." He then told the king, "You need to stand up for what is right. You need to have some courage. There are hard decisions that need to be made, but it is your job to make them. You need to find out what is going on in your kingdom and in Lamagi. Do you have the courage to step up, or are you going to sit back and do nothing in the name of peace. It's true peace is good. I am not advocating war, but is life so dear and peace so cherished that they are worth giving up freedom for? There are people working to gain more control and take more freedom away. Now is the time to stop them. No one ever won their freedom by complying with tyrants. Once those tyrants get full control, they will be hard to stop."

Didier's eyes were wider than gold coins and his shock very apparent. No one spoke to a king that way. It took him a moment to think clearly, but after almost an entire minute of silence, he stated, "You have a fair point. I will discuss this with my counselors and Duchess

Edmee and her counselor Sinclair."

Allistair leaned over to Lina and whispered, "Who is Edmee?"

"The ruler of Arwood and head of the house of Thibaut," Lina answered. "Edmee will do anything to avoid conflict."

Allistair then responded to Didier. "You are the one who should make the decision, not them. I think rather than consult with corrupt counselors or leaders who do not know of the corruption, it is best to find out what your kingdom is really like."

"Perhaps," Didier agreed. "Now, we will meet with Ormondo and Perkin. They should be waiting to be summoned."

Didier had both Perkin and Ormondo brought in. A dozen knights of the realm walked in with them as Didier was not trusting the Knight Avants.

Ormondo walked right up to the king and asked, "How may I help you? I am sure there is much to discuss and much to consider. What have you been told?"

"That Montlier uses slaves to work the mines," Didier answered. "You are being accused of not only dealing in a slave trade, but in going behind my back to give orders to the Knight Avants to not protect those who oppose your views and with working with the Freedom Faction to have people killed. These are serious charges, very serious. If they are true, those are crimes punishable by death."

"That is ridiculous!" Ormondo argued. "Of course there are no slaves in Montlier. I'm sure there was some other explanation for what Allistair saw." He stepped

over to Allistair and hissed in his face, “Did you go into the mines?”

“No,” Allistair admitted. “I didn’t.”

Ormondo threw up his hands and laughed. “Then there is no basis for the accusation.”

“There is,” Camden argued. “I have not been in the caves, but I have been on more than one trip to deliver slaves, and all of us knew what was to be done with the people. We just didn’t stand up for what was right because we hid behind it being orders. I have learned from Allitstair and Lina that it’s wrong to excuse away doing nothing when action needs to be taken.”

Ormondo turned to the king. “Camden merely wishes to take Guilhem’s place as leader of the Knight Avants. He wants power; that is all.”

“No,” Camden countered. “Honestly, I think Allistair should be made leader of the Knight Avants.”

“That is a good idea,” Didier agreed. “Allistair, would you like to accept the position as leader of the Knight Avants?”

“No,” Allistair answered to everyone’s surprise.

King Didier shook his head. “You are seriously refusing?”

“Yes,” Allistair confirmed. “I refuse to vow loyalty to you or to anyone. I will not fulfill a command I do not think is moral. I will not blindly follow you, Ormondo, Florence, or anyone else. I am happy to help you, but I will do it one mission at a time and will do only what I feel is right.”

King Didier stared at him, not used to being spoken

to with the boldness Allistair used. After a moment, he replied, “I do respect your bluntness and your refusal to compromise morals. Would you accept a charge to choose a team and go into Montlier to see the conditions of the mines and how the slaves are being treated?”

“There are no slaves,” Ormondo argued.

“There won’t be by the time we get there,” Allistair pointed out to Didier. “Ormondo will warn Korbyn that we are coming, and the slaves will be moved. Everything will look good if they know someone is coming.”

Didier looked down for a moment and conceded, “True.” He then met Ormondo’s eyes. “Perhaps we need to talk.”

“Indeed,” Ormondo replied. “Why don’t we dismiss everyone and analyze this?”

“No,” Didier refused. “I need to deal with Perkin.”

Everyone turned to Perkin. He had been surprisingly quiet. He held his tied hands up and tried to wave at them.

King Didier then announced, “Camden has presented very good evidence against you.”

Perkin stepped forward and defended, “I have done nothing wrong. All I have done is loyally followed orders. I have been a stalwart Knight Avant. You have no evidence that I have done anything else. Yes, I have helped deliver the slaves to Montlier, but I was only following orders. When I have done anything, I have only been following orders. If there are problems with what I have done, blame those who ordered me to do it. I am merely a victim.”

Didier tapped his fingers on the arm of his throne.

Perkin had a point. After a moment of thought, he decided, “Ormondo, I am releasing you as a counselor. I believe that you have usurped power and given many orders I would not approve.”

Ormondo laughed in response. “Release me! That would be ludicrous.” He stepped forward and hissed in a low whisper, “Remember that Korbyn will be who chooses my replacement, not you. He will choose someone more devoted to his cause, likely someone who will kill you. You are still alive because I have let you live. I think I am better than your other options. Perhaps you are better off with the devil you know than with a counselor who you are always worried is trying to kill you.”

Didier stiffened. Ormondo did have a point. He stepped back from Ormondo and announced, “I still need time to consider all of this. Ormondo will stay as my counselor until I figure out what I need to do. Perkin will be taken back to the dungeon while his case is being considered. Guilhem will be taken down as leader of the Knight Avants and Camden will lead until a leader is chosen. Allistair, if you will lead a quest to find out what you can about the slaves, Freedom Fighters, and beasts, I would appreciate that. I will pay you well. Choose who you want with you.”

“I will accept the quest,” Allistair agreed, “but I will speak boldly and tell you that I think you are making a big mistake not taking stronger action.”

“Perhaps,” Didier agreed. “Perhaps you can find the evidence that is needed for me to take stronger action.”

Allistair nodded to him and asked, “Are we through here?”

“Almost,” King Didier answered. “There is one more thing we need to do.”

“What’s that?” Allistair asked.

Didier pointed over to Lina and answered, “I think this has all been so intense that we need some entertainment now. Lina, would you please sing?”

Lina chuckled, pointed to Allistair, and started singing:

> “Watch what you ask for. Be aware,
> That I make him look debonair.
> I’m short and cute, but I have spice.
> I’ll boldly tell you my advice.
>
> You have a jester. He’s a fool,
> But never should the foolish rule.
> This situation needs regard,
> Not foolish antics of a bard.
>
> I sing. I dance. I entertain.
> I research secrets, the arcane.
> I’m sad if I don’t vivify.
> If you choose wrong, then men will die.
>
> So think, be wise. This is no game,
> So choose with care what you proclaim.
> My lecture’s done. I’ll dance instead,
> Because I’d like to keep my head.”

She then danced for a little over a minute and ended with a curtsy.

“Nicely done,” the king replied. “You are indeed full of spice.” He looked over at Allistair. “You are a

fortunate man to have such a lady."

"I agree," Allistair responded. "Lina is amazing!" He bowed slightly and asked, "May we go now? I have a quest to fulfill for you."

"Indeed," Didier agreed. "Good luck! Report back a soon as you can." He then dismissed everyone.

As soon as everyone left, Ormondo went immediately to Jareth and warned, "Allistair is getting way too bold. We need him dead."

Jareth smiled. "That can be arranged. I have just the beasts to do it. If that does not work, there are other options."

Chapter 25: A Beast, A Faunen, and a Rhyme War

Allistair and Lina sang as they rode in their wagon the next day. The weather was nice, and they were both happy to be leaving Roifort, although Allistair was still trying to figure out how to get the information they needed. Lina suggested that the best way to get information was to go around as bards, entertain, tell stories, and talk to people. Allistair liked the idea. He still wasn't sure how he was going to see what was going on in the mines, not without becoming a slave.

Yet, he wasn't going to go first to the mines. He was going back to Chesterfield for a quick visit. His plan was to go there, then to go to Montlier.

They stopped singing as three big, black dogs with glowing red eyes and blood dripping from their teeth came charging at them. Allistair had never seen beasts like them, but figured a sword through their chests would kill them.

He grabbed his buckler, jumped out of the wagon,

pulled his sword, and called to Lina, “Stay back!”

Even though Allistair had experience fighting beasts, he still could feel his heart pounding. He tried to look brave to not worry Lina, but three huge dogs against him was not good odds.

The dogs charged, and Allistair wished he had a larger shield. Of course, the buckler was better than nothing, and being small was very maneuverable.

He hit one dog in the mouth to defend against getting bitten as he struck at another. Unfortunately, that gave the third a chance to get behind him. Being surrounded meant sure death. Yet, he slid between two of them, using his training as a champion to get to a better position and started fighting again.

It was a brutal fight, and Allistair wouldn’t have won it if Lina hadn’t picked up rocks and started throwing them. Her strength wasn’t enough to do damage, but she was able to distract the dogs to stop them from getting several bites on Allistair.

One of the dogs did go after her, but Allistair dove on it, and she hid behind the horse.

When the fight was over, Alllistair was exhausted. He had been cut by teeth and had blood dripping down his forehead. If it hadn’t been for his armor, he likely would have been dead.

Lina ran over to him and started to throw her arms around him, but he backed up, pointing out, “I’m bloody and sweaty. You don’t want to hug me.”

“I do,” she corrected, and she threw her arms around him. She gave him a kiss. Then she put her hand on the crystal on her necklace to do what healing she could.

“Let’s get to Chesterfield and find a faunen,” she suggested. “You need to be healed.”

The rest of the trip wasn’t as pleasant as the morning had been. Allistair was very quiet and rather obviously trying hard not to show that he was in pain.

He was very tense as they rode through the woods north of Chesterfield. Never before had he been so nervous there, as he knew the woods well. He’d made plenty of trips through them, mostly to go watch the tournaments of knights at Fletcher’s Field. Yet, the woods seemed eerie. Beasts could attack, people wanted him dead, and woods were a great place for them to hide.

He was relieved to get through them without trouble, and it didn’t take long after that to ride home.

His parents were ecstatic to see him, and his best friend, Hartley, came over as soon as he heard Allistair was back.

After hearing the story of their adventure, Hartley offered, “I’ll go with you to Montlier. Zounds! You went on adventures and came back with a beautiful maiden. I’m signing up.”

“Seriously?” Allistair asked. “You think this is about maidens?”

Hartley shrugged. “You shouldn’t get to have all the fun.”

“Adventures are not fun,” Allistair corrected, his tone turning very serious. “Our quest is dangerous, and I have people who would love to have me dead.”

Hartley put his hand on Allistair’s shoulder and with all soberness explained, “I know it is dangerous, but I still want to help. I can be an asset.”

Where Allistair didn't want to put his friend in danger, Hartley was right that he could be help. He'd done a great deal of training to fight with Allistair. After all, Allistair had to have someone to practice with, and Hartley used to always joke, "What are best friends for if not to beat up." Allistair sighed and conceded, "I will consider it."

There was a big discussion, but Lina and Allistair couldn't stay too long. They next went to report to Lord Urvan and talked to him over dinner. Urvan was very interested in all the news and very supportive of Allistair's quests to expose the slave mines, get proof of the corruption, and find out what was going on with Lamagi and the beasts.

"You seem to have made yourself indispensable to the king," Urvan noted. "I guess you won't have time to help around here."

"What's going on here?" Allistair asked.

"Sir Elliot," Urvan answered. "He has insisted that he has the authority to meet out punishment in the name of the king as his ambassador to Chesterfield."

Allistair tensed. Didn't he have enough trouble? Why couldn't other people step up? Was everyone too blind or too afraid? "What's he doing?" Allistair asked, not really wanting to hear the answer.

"I am not sure," Urvan answered. "People have gone missing from the town. I sent Theo to find out what was going on, but yesterday, he was found dead."

Allistair steadied himself. He would have likely fallen from the news if he hadn't already been sitting. Theo was a champion, and while all the champions were rivals on the field, they all had respect for each other and

knew each other. “I will figure out what is going on and expose it,” Allistair assured Urvan. “I may not have the ability to stop it, but you may.”

“I hope,” Urvan responded. He put his goblet down and very seriously declared, “Allistair, you have sanction from me to act as needed, even if it is necessary to kill. It is better to destroy evil than have the blood of those they would kill on our hands.”

That wasn’t something Allistair wanted to think about. He was fine with killing beasts, but never would he want to kill a human. What made the statement more eerie was that he’d talked to King Didier before he and Lina left Roifort, and Didier had said something similar, just not in the same way. He’d told Allistair that he didn’t like violence, but that he gave Allistair permission to use even fatal force if it was absolutely necessary.

Allistair breathed out audibly, letting out his nervousness.

“What do we do first?” Lina asked. “We need to go to Montlier, but Elliot must be stopped.”

“We see if we can find and stop Elliot?” Allistair answered uncertainly. “Honestly, I don’t think he’ll be hard to find, as he likely will find me. I did humiliate him, and he will want revenge.”

“I don’t really understand revenge,” Lina noted. “It seems a fool’s errand.”

“It is,” Allistair agreed. “Now, Let’s make a few plans and head out.”

“What plans do we make?” Lina asked. “There are so many factors that we just don’t know. There are so many ways this adventure could go. There are many

unknowns, and so much can go wrong. I think a good healer should come tag-along."

Allistair laughed out loud.

"What?" Lina defended. "It's a good idea. We do need a better healer than me. I'm part elf, but all my healing can do is hopefully keep you alive. We need a faunen."

"The idea is fine," Allistair agreed. "I was laughing because you have been making songs up on the spot so often that you sometimes accidentally talk in rhyme."

"Sorry," she responded. Then she teased. "I'm just that good. You're just jealous."

"Oh, me jealous," he teased back. "You say I'm jealous. It's not true. I improvise as well as you. With time I'll have my words concrete, but I can think fine on my feet."

She then replied, "Oh boy, you want a rhyming war. Challenge accepted. I'll do more. I'll make your rhymes sound obsolete, as I do four iambic feet."

Allistair chuckled, but continued, "Iambic feet, I'll play along. Tetrameter is good for song, so is my rhythm and my beat. With great finesse, I can compete."

A smug smile crossed Lina's face as she replied, "You can't beat me. I'm sure to win, exploit your weakness to the end. So make your choice. Choose to remiss, for one conciliatory kiss."

Allistair almost missed a beat from laughing, but added, "You know my weakness, that is true, as I'd do anything for you. I cannot hide my love for you, and hope someday you'll say 'I do.'"

She missed a beat as she stared in shock at him. Then she threw her arms around him. “Do you really mean that or did you just say it to shock me and throw me off my rhythm?”

“I said it to throw you off your rhythm,” he admitted. “Yet, I’ll admit that I think you are amazing, and am looking to see how our relationship develops. I’m hopeful that we have a future together. Right now, I’m rather in over my head and not in a stable position to make such a major commitment, but maybe someday. Let’s enjoy it and see where it goes.”

Instead of the conciliatory kiss, he got a victor’s kiss, or just perhaps a kiss because Lina was so excited. She was so beautiful when she was excited. Fortunately, her bubbly personality frothed over often.

“I do love you,” Allistair assured her. “Now, as much as I love holding you in my arms, I think we need to get our plan made and get moving on our quest.”

Lina nodded. “I do think we need a faunen to heal.”

“I could ask Raissa,” Allistair suggested. Then he elbowed her playfully. “Ooo… competition. You may need to up your game.”

Lina laughed. “I don’t think I need to worry. I have you wrapped around my little finger.”

“Touche,” Allistair agreed. “Now, let’s go.”

They did immediately head out. The first place they went to was the Red Wolf tavern, hoping to find Raissa there. She was often there, as she worked there.

As soon as Allistair stepped in the tavern, Raissa ran up to him and gave him a hug. “Are the rumors we’ve been hearing true?”

“What rumors?” Allistair asked.

“Saving people who were going to be made slaves and starting the Hangover Guild,” she answered, as if it ought to be obvious.

“I’m no hero,” Allistair noted. “I am trying to do what is right, but I’ve made many enemies.”

“I’m so sorry,” Raissa responded. “Is there anything I can do to help?”

Yes, there was, but Allistair was hesitant to ask. Raissa had seen plenty of bloody wounds, but that would likely be nothing compared to what they were going into. She really didn’t need to be pulled in. How could he possibly ask her to do something dangerous? Yet, he had to, so he went ahead and asked, “Would you be willing to come with us on a very dangerous quest? I warn you that this is very dangerous. That’s why we need you. I am sure I’m going to need healing.”

Raissa’s eyes popped open, obviously not expecting the request. “I’ll have to consider it. I have many questions.”

That was a good response. Allistair had been worried that she’d innocently agree without even considering the danger or just ask how much it paid. “What questions do you have?”

“Who all is going?” she asked first, her expression becoming pragmatic. “Where are we going? What’s the plan? Can I have a bodyguard? Let’s start with those.”

Allistair looked around cautiously and answered, “The quest needs to be discussed in private, but I should be able to get a bodyguard for you. Hartley asked to come with us. He is very strong.”

Raissa smiled at the idea. Hartley was strong. He wasn't built like a giant or a crevan bear, but he did have handsome pointed ears and a monkey tail. He was thin and agile. With his dexterity, he could protect her very well. She agreed, "Hartley is strong and incredibly handsome. It wouldn't be bad traveling with you and him… Oh, and Lina too. I still need to hear the quest, but if I go, I will need to find a way to make up for lost wages."

"You little mercenary," Lina teased.

"That I can help with," Allistair assured Raissa, ignoring Lina's comment. "I have the backing of both Lord Urvan and King Didier. The money should not be a problem."

"Wonderful!" Raissa exclaimed. "I like money. Perhaps we should go talk. I need to know the danger, all the gory details."

Allistair eyed her. "I doubt you can handle gory details."

"Oh, you might be surprised," she corrected. "Think about it. I am often brought in to heal very bad wounds, and I am brought to events where people can get hurt. I have seen a great deal of gore. Generally, I can heal it, but not always. I just try to put a smile on my face and keep going."

"Let's hope you can keep that smile through what we are going into," Allistair responded. "Now, is there someplace we can go to talk?"

They ended up going to Allistair's parent's house, as they wanted to get Hartley and see if he still wanted to come. He did. Allistair then explained the quest and the few plans they had made. Raissa was scared at the idea of

going, but thought it a very good cause and wanted to help, so she did decide to come.

She was very worried about getting hurt herself and no one to heal her, as faunen healed well, but could not heal themselves as they did others, so she suggested that perhaps it would be wise to bring a larger group and more faunen to heal.

Allistair did consider going with a large group, but he thought they needed to go in stealthily first to observe. Then if they needed to come back for numbers, they could. After all, the slaves had been slaves for a long time, and it was better to take a few weeks to save them than to rush in and fail.

Raissa was still scared, so Hartley knelt in front of her and swore, “Raissa, I am no knight, but I am quick agile, and determined. I have practiced fighting with Allistair for years. Yes, he is better with a sword, but I will fight hard to protect you. You can feel safe with me.”

“I’m sure you will do an amazing job,” she replied with a blush. She looked over at Allistair and asked, “When do we start?”

“Tomorrow, after meeting with Lord Urvan,” Allistair answered. “I need a few things from him. I need backup and for him to pass a message to Camden in Roifort. We may need the backing of some of the Knight Avants.”

*****

The next morning, Allistair said good-bye to his parents, and he, Lina, and Hartley went to the Red Wolf

Tavern to get Raissa.

She bounced in, excited to get the adventure started. At least she said she was excited. Allstair still thought he heard some fear in her voice.

Hartley held his arm out for her. “I am going to enjoy getting to keep an eye on you. You are quite beautiful.”

Raissa blushed and suggested, “Perhaps we should get going.”

They headed to talk to Lord Urvan. The visit didn’t take long, as Allistair had already discussed the plan with him. There were only a few details to see to. Urvan did agree to send someone to get the message to Camden.

It was while they were talking to Urvan that the trouble came.

A page ran into the room with a parchment in his hand. “This is for you!” he announced, handing it to Allistair, not Lord Urvan.

Allistair took it, trying to keep his hands from shaking. Somehow, he knew it was bad news. There was no reason to write to him to send good news.

He opened the rolled up parchment and read it silently.

“What is it?” Lina asked, seeing that his eyes were wide with shock.

Allistair handed the parchment to her and announced to everyone, “It is signed by Sir Elliot. He says that in the name of the king, I am to turn myself in by noon today for crimes against the crown and deserting my post as Knight Avant. He says that if I don’t turn myself in by noon at the tourney field that he has my parents, and they

will die."

A shocked gasp went through everyone in the room. Was it true? That was fast! He'd have had to capture them right after Allistair left that morning. Of course, he may have had men waiting. It was possible. He could have had the note ready. Unfortunately, it was likely true.

"You'd need to leave right now to get there by noon," Lina noted. "That doesn't give any time to think about this."

"That can't be right," Urvan noted. "With what you have told me, King Didier gave you a pardon for letting the people captured to become slaves free and leaving the Knight Avants. Haven't you been pardoned for everything by him?"

"Yes," Allistair answered, "but it does not matter. "Elliot apparently has my parents, and if I don't turn myself over to him, he will kill them."

"I'll have his head!" Urvan fumed. "That is a death penalty here, even if he is a knight and ambassador. I have proof of his guilt with this letter."

"It would be nice to be able to arrest him and bring him to justice," Allistair agreed, "but can we even find him, and can we keep my parents safe if he is arrested? He may have people ordered to kill them if he is captured. I fear I am going to have to face him."

"That's not too hard," Lina assured him. "You beat him bare-handed against a sword before."

"True," Allistair agreed. "But he will have a plan, likely cheat, and this fight will be to the death."

Lina threw her arms around him, and Raissa assured him, "As long as you don't die, I will heal you."

Allistair heaved a sigh and replied, “That’s a big ‘if.’”

Chapter 26: A Trap, Mercenaries, and a Lord's Guards

The message said for Allistair to turn himself in before noon at the field the tournaments were held in. That was a good location for Elliot as it was north of the city, so once he obtained Allistair, he could take him into the woods.

In order to get there by noon, Allistair had to leave immediately. Lina, Raissa, and Hartley came with him, but Urvan didn't leave immediately. He promised to gather guards and come quickly.

Allistair galloped on his horse toward the tourney field, hoping he wasn't too late and fearful of what he was riding into. Likely, it was some sort of trap, perhaps an ambush. He wasn't really even sure if Elliot really had his parents, but likely he did. Allistair couldn't take the chance.

It didn’t take long by horse to get to the field, as it was just north of the town. Before going onto the field, Allistair stopped just outside of the stands. There were wooden stands on opposing sides of the field with benches for spectators to sit on.

“It’s a trap,” Allistair noted, looking around and seeing mercenaries stationed around the field. “Hartley, stay here with the ladies. I’ll go in alone.”

“I feel safer with you,” Lina countered. “Let me come with you.”

“I could fly around and see how many mercenaries there are,” Raissa offered.

“No,” Allistair refused. “It’s too dangerous. Someone could shoot you down. All an arrow would have to do is hit your wing and you’d plummet to the earth. You may heal well, but I’m not taking that chance.” He looked at the others and asked, “Do we stay together and all go in?”

“There is safety in numbers,” Hartley replied.

“And more people to die,” Lina added.

Allistair wasn’t sure if she was serious or joking, but he decided to have them all stay together, so they all went onto the field.

“Come out, Elliot!” Allistair called. “Do you really have my parents?”

“Yes,” his mother’s voice answered. He turned to see that she was being pulled into the stands by two mercenaries. Two other mercenaries had his father.

Elliot stepped out onto the field and ordered, “You will now turn yourself in, by command of the king. I speak for him here. You are guilty of crimes against the

crown."

Allistair stepped up to him, not letting his fear show and hoping that Elliot could not see that he was actually trembling. After all, his parent's lives were on the line, and Lina's, Raissa's, and Hartley's were too. "You are the one guilty of crimes against the crown," he accused. "You are using the name of the king without his approval."

"I am his ambassador," Elliot hissed. "I have the authority to act in his name."

"And I am on a quest for him," Allistair countered. "I have likely spoken to him more recently than you have, as I just came from Roifort, where King Didier offered to make me the leader of the Knight Avants and pardoned me of any crimes."

Elliot laughed. "I don't see the symbol of the leader of the Avants on your tabard. You lie!"

"No, I don't," Allistair corrected. "I said Didier offered me the title. I turned it down. Instead, I am on a quest for him. I think he will find your parchment to me quite interesting. It is proof that you are misusing his name. That was rather foolish of you to put the threat in writing. You have created the evidence to use against you, stating you are guilty not only of misusing the king's name, but of kidnapping. I assume you are the one who killed Theo too."

Allistair could see the panic strike Elliot, and see the panic turn to rage. "I will kill you!" Elliot yelled. He took off his gauntlet, walked up to Allistair, and slapped his face with it, hard. Yet, Allistair wasn't going to give Elliot the satisfaction of knowing it hurt.

"I don't need to accept," Allistair responded. "I have nothing to prove. Now, let my parents go, and we will

leave."

"No!" Elliot fumed. "You humiliated me. Now, you threaten to strip me of my title, and perhaps have me beheaded. I want you dead!"

"Don't blame me that you were fool enough to put usurping power in writing," Allistair countered. "Don't blame me for your foolishness. Now, let my parents go, and this can be over."

"Don't lie!" Elliot yelled. "If I let you go, you will go to the king and see that I am taken from my position or beheaded. I would rather die now. Even better, I'd rather have you die. Accept the challenge or see your parents die." He motioned to the thugs holding his parents, and one pulled a knife and put it to Allistair's mother's neck."

"No!" Allistair called. "I accept!"

Elliot laughed. "Prepare to die. I killed Theo. I can kill you too." He drew his sword, and Allistair drew his.

Everyone else backed off. As much as Hartley wanted to join the fight and help Allistair, he knew that if he did that the mercenaries Elliot had hired would come fight for Elliot, so Allistair had a better chance of staying alive if he stayed out of the fight.

"I don't want to look!" Raissa cried, and she buried her face in Hartley's chest, as she was too short to reach his shoulder. Hartley put his arms around her. Sure, she'd seen many fights, but never a barbaric fight to the death. Unfortunately, someone would likely die if she wasn't there.

Lina was more panicked than Raissa. She tried not to show it, but reached over and clung to Hartley's arm as

she watched the fight.

Elliot came out strong with a quick succession of strikes that Allistair parried with no chance to counter-strike.

Allistair then came back with a series of strikes, but Elliot's quick reflexes made him hard to hit. The hyper-senses of the crevan made him able to predict his opponents' moves well.

Allistair had beaten Elliot before, but Elliot was out for blood. Still, Allistair was better trained. As he backed Elliot up against he split rail fence around the arena, Elliot pulled a knife from his boot and stabbed it into Allistair's gut.

Allistair's eyes went wide from shock, but he couldn't lose concentration.

Focus… he had to focus. He put his hand in the bloody wound to try to stop the bleeding and knocked Elliot with the hilt of his sword.

Elliot staggered for a moment, so Allistair took advantage of the opportunity and elbowed him in the back of the shoulder while sweeping his leg. Elliot fell to the ground, and Allistair stood over him with his foot on Elliot's sword arm and his sword ready to plunge into his chest. "Surrender!" Allistair called. "Surrender or die!"

"If I die, your parents do," Elliot hissed.

Allistair had been so focused on fighting for his life that he hadn't even thought of his parents. He looked over, surprised at what he saw – Lord Urvan was there with men.

As Allistair was distracted, Elliot grabbed his leg with his left hand and tried to pull him over. It almost

worked with as dizzy as Allistair was from loss of blood, but Allistair didn't fall. Unfortunately, he did stumble back and off of Elliot's sword arm. Elliot started to get back up to fight, so Allistair kicked him unconscious.

Allistair then fell to his knees, holding his fist in the wound. Raissa flew quickly over and started healing him.

As she healed him, Lord Urvan had guards catch the mercenaries who hadn't fled. He'd already freed Allistair's parents and arrested the men holding them.

His men bound Elliot. When Raissa finished healing the stab wound on Allistair, she healed Elliot so he would become conscious.

"You can't do this to me!" Elliot yelled. "I am an ambassador."

"I can, and I am," Urvan corrected. "You have committed crimes punishable by death, and I doubt King Didier will come to your defense when you've been misusing his name. I will discuss the situation with him and will not have you put to death until after I do. Until then, you will be locked in the dungeon." He then ordered the guards who were holding Elliot, "Take him away!"

Elliot complained the entire time he was being taken away, but it did no good. Urvan knew he was guilty.

Urvan's next action was to check on Allistair. Allistair was mostly healed, but still weak. Yet, Allistair forced himself up. "Thank you, Urvan. I hate to think what would have happened if you hadn't come."

"I told you I would," Urvan replied. "Yet, it is I who should thank you. Elliot has been a problem, and I needed proof to arrest him. Thanks to you, I now have that. You have just made Chesterfield safer. We can all sleep well

tonight,"

"No," Allistair countered. "First, Lina, Raissa, Hartley, and I have a quest to see how to free the slaves. Second, even with evidence, arresting Elliot will bring trouble. I have no doubt that King Didier will not fight you on it, but if Elliot works with Ormondo at all, you may have just made a very bad enemy."

Lina stepped over, gave Allistair a hug, and asked, "Do we go back into town and let you rest or go immediately off into danger?"

"Go immediately," Allistair answered. "Let's go. Is everyone ready?"

"No," Lina answered. "Let's do it.

"I'm ready for lunch," Hartley joked. He looked around and saw no one was laughing and asked, "Not the place for jokes?" He then smiled to lighten the mood and asked, "If we are going as minstrels, should I play the fool? It would be so out of character and sounds like fun. I can juggle, actually quite well. I can even walk on my hands."

"That could be entertaining," Raissa responded with a smile. "Your humor will help through this. After all, we are charging off to Montlier where I'll likely have to heal Allistair again and try to heal a bunch of slaves. I've seen enough morbid wounds, and I'm about to see what is done to slaves."

Everyone stared at her. She was right that they were going into something horrendous and none of them were prepared for what they were going to see.

"Do you need me to send men with you?" Urvan asked.

“No,” Allistair answered. “This part needs to be stealth. “Just get the message to Camden.”

“I already sent someone,” Urvan replied. “Now, go. Be careful. I’d like all of you back alive.”

Raissa responded with a smile and a hint of sarcasm, “Don’t worry, they likely won’t kill us. They’d be more likely to beat us and force us to become slaves and mine.”

Allistair tensed and replied, “Not encouraging.”

Hartley decided the situation was way too tense, so he grabbed his mug from his belt, a small pouch of coins, and the knife Allistair had been stabbed with and started juggling.

Raissa laughed. “It’s a good thing I’m here to heal you when you cut yourself with that.”

“Thanks for the vote of confidence,” Hartley quipped back as he caught the knife by the handle and started a fancier juggle.

Chapter 27: A Really Bad Song, A Game, and A Spy

Allistair, Lina, Hartley, and Raissa rode in Lina's wagon toward Montlier. They had considered only taking horses to be stealthier, but finally decided that having Lina traveling as a minstrel was their best cover, especially if Allistair hid in the covered wagon while in the city.

Hartley had never been to Montlier, but both Lina and Raissa had. Lina had been to most cities as a minstrel, and Raissa at times went to trade with other taverns. Generally when she did, her father sent a protector with her. Allistair had been with the Knight Avants.

Allistair did not wear his tabard showing he was a Knight Avant into the city, as he didn't want to draw attention to himself.

They approached the city from the eastern road. As they did, Allistair hid in the wagon. Hartley sat on the bench at the front between Lina and Raissa, noting that

he had a beautiful maiden on each arm.

"Stop!" a guard at the road called. "Who are you and why are you here?"

"I am Lina," Lina answered. "These are my companions. We have come to perform. Would you like to hear a song?" She picked up her lute and started singing,

"We're minstrels coming into town to sing a song or two.
We hope that we can fill our hats with coins from our debut.
We never miss a beat, not us. We're way too good for that.
Why, we've performed for lords and kings, the best aristocrats.
Oh, minstrels are important. Yes, we are above the norm.
So many want to hear our tales and cheer as we perform.
So, come…"

"Enough!" the guard interrupted. "Don't waste my time with silly rhymes. We need to search your wagon."

Lina's heart skipped a beat. Was Allistair about to get caught?"

Fortunately, Hartley saved her. He laughed, "Go ahead. I'll sing as you do. He took Lina's lute, that he had no idea how to play, and strummed the open strings as he purposely sang off-key:

"I may just be the bodyguard, but I can rhyme words too.

I'll make a song up on the spot about, um, my left shoe.
Of course it's made of leather, and the right is leather too.
So, next I'll sing about my nose. It's not the color blue.
But how I make rhymes on the spot. It's easy, so ask how?
It's not too hard to do it if you have a big brown cow.
Now sing with me..."

"Enough!" the guard yelled. "Quiet! Just go." He pointed them through before he'd even moved the blanket Allistair was hiding under.

"Good thinking," Lina whispered to Hartley after they passed the guards. "Very clever."

"Where to now?" Hartley asked as Allistair came from the back of the wagon and knelt behind them.

"To a tavern," Raissa suggested. "Personally, I like the Hidden Pearl. It's pretty upscale, and I've done business with them before. But, if you want to get information from mercenaries, I'd suggest the Jagged Dagger."

"Have you ever been there?" Lina asked. "I have performed at the Hidden Pearl before, but I've never gone to the Jagged Dagger. I was warned it's rough and not a good place for a girl like me."

"That's what I've heard too," Raissa added. "I have not been to the Jagged Dagger, but my father has. He says that the tavern owner there will pay very well for very strong drinks."

“Let’s try the Hidden Pearl first,” Allistair suggested. “I’ve been there before when I was hiding from Perkin. If we need to go to the Jagged Dagger, then I’ll go alone and leave Hartley to protect both of you.”

“Leaving me with two beautiful maidens,” Hartley joked. “And I thought this trip was going to be dangerous. I think I’m getting the good end of it.”

“It will get dangerous,” Allistair warned. “This is no joke.”

They rode up to the Hidden Pearl, gave a copper to the boy at the nearby stable to tend to their horse and wagon, and then went inside the tavern.

Most of Montlier looked very cold and strong, not overly friendly. The buildings were solid and many had domed roofs. The outside of the tavern looked much like the other buildings, but inside the main room was very inviting. There were runners on the tables and bright tapestries on the wall. The place was brightly lit and very clean.

The people were eating a meal that smelled wonderful. Yes, there were a few drunk people, but the tavern owner was a crevan and had someone there to keep people in line who was obviously part rhys, and likely part giant. Surely, no one would cross him.

“How do we get information?” Allistair asked. “If I draw a crowd, I may be recognized, and Ormondo may have people here wanting to kill me.”

“You let us get the information,” Raissa suggested, pointing to herself and Lina. “I’ll start by talking to some of the girls who work here. I know several of them. I don’t know the owner well, but I have talked to him before. He’s a rather typical fox crevan in some ways, but

he is honest."

"Typical fox crevan?" Hartley asked.

"They are known for being shrewd traders and getting good deals for themselves," Lina answered. "You really have never traveled out here before?"

"No," Hartley answered.

Raissa walked off to get information, so Hartley followed to protect her, noting to Allistair. "I get to keep an eye on the beautiful maiden. I like this job."

"What do we do now?" Allistair asked Lina as he watched Hartley walk off.

"Talk to people," Lina suggested. "I don't know. I've never done anything like this before. I just sing and tell stories."

Neither of them were actually good at knowing how to act casual and get information, so finally, they gave up and started singing. Allistair played a drum and sang, but he kept the hood of his cloak up and let Lina do the performance part.

Lina didn't really want to get in trouble for being controversial so she sang a lively tune:

> "Here's something merry, something fun.
> So just relax. My song's begun.
> Oh, I've got rhythm. I've got style,
> Forget your cares and stay a while.
>
> Oh, I've got songs for everyone.
> My talent will impress and stun.
> So, let's step out. Don't be a bore.
> Let's make this night one to adore.

Now, lift your glass and drink a toast
To hidden pearls and our great host.
Now don't be shy. Don't be uptight.
Let's have some fun. Enjoy your night."

The people cheered and Lina passed the hat. She didn't get much, so she decided to tell a story and asked if anyone would chip in to hear news of the land. It was a little risky, but it would pay better.

Allistair motioned for her to come to him, and he whispered, "We don't need the money. We have both Urvan and Didier paying us. It's probably best not to take chances."

"True," Lina agreed. She stood back up in front of everyone and announced, "I suggest a game. Let's all make up a song. Someone can call out a question to the beat, and I'll answer it with a rhyme to it. Does that sound like fun? It's definitely not easy, so you can give me a real challenge."

A man, who was likely a little drunk, called out, "What can I do to get a kiss?"

Lina sang back, "Go treat a girl like a princess." She knew the accents were off, but it worked and the people were happy.

The next question came, "Why do beast attack, what is your hunch?"

Lina shrugged, "I guess that we taste good for lunch."

The people laughed and the game continued with people asking questions and Lina responding:

"Have you performed before the king?"

"Oh yes, he loves to hear me sing!"

"Is he, as rumored, quite the fool?"
"He listens well. Don't ridicule."

"In Roifort is corruption deep?"
"It is all over, due to sheep."

"They're sheep? Pray tell, what do you mean?"
"They blindly follow. It's obscene."

Allistair had been staying back to not draw attention to himself, but the temptation was too great, so he got up and sang:

"Oh, people, don't be sheeple. Use your brains.
Think for yourselves.
And never be deceived. Be smart if giants, rhys,
or elves.
No matter what your race, if mokos, gati, faunen,
sprite,
You can find truth, and use your heads, and stand
for what is right.

Why underneath your noses, men around
manipulate.
While sheeple follow blindly, trusting evil with
their fate.
Wake up and smell the roses. Smell the stench,
the rot, and more.
You shouldn't let it happen, evil's something to
abhor."

A man called out, "There's nothing any of us can do to stop anything! The noble houses have all the power,

and even talking about it could get us punished. Are you saying we should revolt?"

"No," Allistair explained. "I'm saying that evil has no power if it has no support. Sure, one man can do damage, but one man can be stopped, if the people stop him."

"It still sounds like you are trying to start a revolt," the man argued."

"No," Allistair corrected. "I'm trying to get people to realize that the people in power only have power because people give it to them. Do you know that the noble houses aren't really supposed to rule? Bellemar is. The crown was usurped from the house of Garnier. It's the true noble house."

"Why should I believe you?" a woman called out.

"You shouldn't," Allistair answered. "Don't blindly trust me. Don't blindly trust anyone. Yet, there are records. I have seen them. I wish I could tell you where, but I can't. I'm urging you and everyone to seek the truth. Seek for solutions, real solutions, not just things that sound good in theory or symbolism over substance. I want all of you to think. Use your brains. Evil cannot win if it does not have support. Suppose someone was capturing people to make them slaves on a farm, could one man alone capture the slaves? No, he'd need followers. Could one man alone transport the people, or keep them from escaping? No. For evil to thrive, people must comply, knowingly or unknowingly. Don't comply to evil. Don't be sheep following a shepherd that is not good."

That made sense to some of the people, and a discussion began. One of the men noted, "I've heard

rumors of people joining some guild called the Hangover Guild who supposedly encourages people to find truth. Do you know anything about that?"

Allistair didn't want to admit that he was the leader of it, as he really didn't want to draw more attention to himself. He likely had drawn too much already. Instead, he answered, "I'm a minstrel. I've heard a song about it. Would you like to hear it?"

The people cheered, so Allistair started playing his drum and had to think quickly to make something up. If only he had time to really get it right. Yet, he sang:

"The Hangover Guild is about finding truth.
And using your brain whether old or a youth.
And never complying to those who control,
Manipulate, lie, deceive, then kill your soul.

It's true evil needs to have sheep, useful fools,
Who'll blindly support all the underhand rules.
The Hangover Guild says 'Wake up" and be strong.
Together unite. Let's all join in the throng.

So, join with the guild. There is nothing to pay.
The guild wants no money. That's not the guild's way.
The Hangover Guild's about knowledge and right,
Where truth, values, morals, and love win the fight.

So, stand against evil. Don't watch it and say
There's nothing you can do and then look away.
So open your eyes, lives of good are fulfilled.

And stand against wrongs with the Hangover Guild.”

Allistair thought it poor verse and really wanted to clean it up and perfect it, but it was what he could do on the spot. Fortunately, it did get a good reaction from the crowd… Well… Mostly.

The part rhys, part giant man who kept the tavern under control came over to Allistair and ordered, “Out! We don’t need trouble here, and your words will bring it.”

That was disappointing to Allistair, as the man was proving his point. People were afraid to talk freely. They were afraid to question the system. Where the man was meaning well, trying to keep civility in the tavern and not have arguments, his actions were supporting those like Ormondo who wanted the people to live in fear of questioning the nobility or saying things they shouldn’t.

“We’ll leave,” Allistair conceded, and he and Lina went over to get Raissa and Hartley to leave.

Raissa and Hartley joined them, and they all headed to the door. As soon as they stepped out, a man was waiting for them, a man not of a common race, but he looked strong and clean cut.

He looked around to make sure there were no ears listening and explained, “I know you are Allistair and have come to find the truth of the mines for the king. Word spreads quickly through some groups. You will be being watched and expected. Be careful.” He looked around again and whispered, “They are expecting you to try to break out the slaves at night where they sleep, but there is a secret exit from the mines. I too have studied

some."

Allistair looked around. "Is there a better place to talk? Perhaps our wagon?"

"Perhaps a room," the man suggested. He motioned for the others to follow him.

Knowing they couldn't go back in through the front, the man led them around to an entrance to a back room in the tavern. The owner of the tavern was there and whispered, "This way."

Allistair hoped he wasn't being brought into a trap, but it was the best lead they had.

When they stepped in the room, the man shut and locked the door. He then explained, "I am… Well, you don't need to know my real name. You can use the name 'Dusk' for me." He noticed the girls staring at him and explained, "I am fully human. I am from over the mountains. I come here often to keep an eye on activities for my ruler."

"What is it like over the mountains?" Lina asked. "Are they preparing to go to war against us?"

"Not to my knowledge," Dusk answered. "Of course, there are several kingdoms in the west, and I come from a southern city, so there could be plans I don't know of in the northern kingdoms. That is not my problem. My king has spies for those kingdoms. My responsibility is spying here to know if there is trouble coming."

"It seems quite the coincidence that you found us at the Red Wolf Tavern," Lina noted.

Dusk laughed. "Coincidence had nothing to do with it. I am a spy. I planned this. I have heard of orders coming from Ormondo to intercept you and not let you

see the slave mines. They will take you to a small mine north of it to make all look good."

"Why are you telling us this?" Allistair asked skeptically.

"Because on the occasion there are slaves who escape, they often come across the mountains and into the city I am from. We try to help them get to their homelands, as most come from across the northern mountains, but now it is hard due to the beasts. My king has spies trying to investigate those. Something is odd about them, but that does not affect this situation. If you announce yourself, you will be shown to the small northern mine, and all will look good. Men will be paid to say they work there for good money. I suggest you see the real mines."

"What can you tell us about them?" Allistair asked.

Dusk answered, "There is one main entrance, so the guards will be watching for you there. They will also increase the number of guards on the wall around where the slaves sleep. It is in buildings in a walled area in the woods just south of the mines."

"That will be hard to get the slaves out of," Allistair noted. "I wish I knew the layout."

"I do," Raissa admitted. "While in the tavern, I talked to a cook there who said a faunen escaped several months ago. She was being used to heal the slaves when they'd been too beaten to work. She was able to get loose and fly over the wall. She couldn't keep flying as she was being shot at by arrows. She stopped at the inn and begged for help. One of the cooks helped her. I've heard a great deal about what the faunen said of the mines."

"Do you know the layout of the mines?" Allistair

asked.

"No," Raissa answered, "but I know that the entrance to where they sleep is in the wall is to the north, toward the mine. It is a short distance to walk, and the guards beat anyone who tries to get out of line going to and from the mines. There is a watchtower on each corner of the wall, about a dozen roaming guards inside the wall, and two guards at the inside of the entrance and two on the outside. It will be hard for the people to escape."

"There is another way," Dusk admitted. "I do not know the layout of the mines, but the mines were actually first started by people from the west of the mountains. They dug the mine, but then abandoned it several years before Montlier discovered it from this side of the mountains."

"Why did they abandon it?" Allistair asked.

"Because a better, closer mine was dug," Dusk answered.

"And what's this have to do with the slaves?" Raissa asked.

"Simple," Dusk answered. "There is another exit. Perhaps it has been buried, but if it can be uncovered, it can be used."

"Clever," Allistair noted.

"I hope," Dusk replied. "There is a reason I am a spy. Now, I must go. I cannot help you. I must not reveal that I am from over the mountains or do anything to cast suspicion on myself. Yet, I wish you luck."

With that, he opened the window, stepped out, and disappeared into the night.

“What do we do now?” Lina asked.

Allistair breathed deeply, taking everything he’d heard in. “We investigate the mines, make a plan, and hope we don’t die.”

“How do we get inside the mines to see if we can find the other exit?” Lina asked.

“You don’t,” Allistair answered. “It’s too dangerous. I think I need to go in.”

“You can’t sneak in,” Lina pointed out. “You are part giant.”

“I wasn’t thinking of sneaking in,” Allistair countered. “I was thinking of turning myself in.”

Lina gasped. “Not a good idea! That is a death wish.”

Allistair stiffened. “I know, but does anyone have a better idea?”

Chapter 28: The Mine, A Secret Passage, and Glowing Green Moss

Early the next day before the sunlight broke over the horizon, Allistair, Lina, Hartley, and Raissa crept quietly on foot to the mines. The entrance to the mine was at the base of a mountain, south of the main city of Montlier and south of the mine where the slaves the Knight Avants dropped off were kept. Dusk had been right about the small mine that was mostly for show. Perhaps that is one of the ways that Ormondo got Guilhem to deliver slaves. No, likely it was threats or blackmail. It didn't matter. Slavery was wrong, even if the slaves were treated well.

Allistair, Lina, Hartley, and Raissa hid in nearby trees to observe the area from the outside of the mines. Dusk had reported correctly that their was a walled area with a cluster of small buildings where the slaves slept.

What were they going to do? Allistair had no idea. Perhaps he should map everything and bring it back to

King Didier. No, that would do no good. Didier was weak. Ormondo would heavy-hand Didier into doing nothing. Ormondo ran the kingdom more than King Didier, and Ormondo was evil. It was going to up to Allistair to do something, and he needed to do it immediately. If he went for back-up and brought more people in, it would end up a blood bath.

His thoughts were broken as the gate in the walled barracks was opened and armed guards stood on both sides of the path from the gate to the mine while the slaves walked out. The slaves were varied in races, some of them strong and some very small. Allistair was surprised at the number of short races and children. Was that because they were easier to control?

“What do we do?” Lina asked, gripping his arm.

They both cringed as a small collien boy who looked to be about ten stepped over and took the hand of a girl a little older, likely a sister, and the guards hit them and told them to walk in single file.

Lina started to jump out of the tree to do something, but Allistair stopped her, warning, “Rushing will not help. This has to be done right.”

“What do we do?” Lina cried. “We have to help.”

“We do,” Allistair agreed. “We know the only way to get in. Let’s do it, plan B.”

That wasn’t what any of them wanted to hear. They’d discussed several plans, and some sounded better than others. Plan B was risky, very risky, but it did seem the best option given what they were seeing.

They left immediately, sneaking through the woods, as there were many things that they had to do that day to

prepare.

The first place they went was to try to find guard's uniforms that would fit both Allistair and Hartley.

Knocking out guards and stealing their clothes would be discovered and draw attention to them, so instead, they crept around the city, looking for where the guard's uniforms would be washed. They ended up in the castle laundry.

They didn't try to sneak around, taking the chance that the women in the laundry would help them.

They were surprised to find that the women in the laundry were also slaves. From what they heard from the women, almost all of Montlier was run off slave labor.

Allistair wasn't sure what to do about that. He couldn't free all the slaves in Montlier. He couldn't even assure that if he freed the slaves in the mines that other slaves wouldn't just be moved there. Yet, he'd worry about everything else later. His mission then was from the king himself and was to find out the status of the slaves and mines and free the slaves if he could.

There weren't many uniforms being washed that day, so the fit of the guard uniforms wasn't perfect for either Allistair or Hartley, but hopefully they would be good enough to pass.

They didn't immediately put the uniforms on. They next went to the Jagged Dagger Tavern where they bought some strong ale. After that, they found a peasant and bought her new clothing in exchange for the old clothes she was wearing, which they took and distressed more. The lady was ecstatic to have new clothes and promised not to tell anyone where she got them.

Once the preparations were made, they had to wait. Waiting was torturous. The seconds seemed long, and after what seemed hours, only minutes had past.

“What do we do?” Lina asked. “We have to do something to take our minds off what we are going to do tonight.”

“I don’t think anything could take my mind off of this quest,” Allistair admitted.

Lina surprised him by suddenly giving him a kiss, a very nice kiss. “I bet I just took your mind off of everything else for a moment.”

“Guilty,” Allistair conceded. “I’m not complaining, but I don’t think we can do that until it gets dark. What do we do now?”

They took the wagon into the woods, as they didn’t want to be seen by anyone. Allistair paced nervously. Lina took his hand and walked around with him.

Raissa flew up into a tree, stood on a branch, and looked out through the woods.

Hartley climbed the tree up to her. He very nimbly swung from branch to branch to get up, as he had strong arms and the use of his tail. “Are you all right?” he asked Raissa.

“Very nervous,” she answered. “When I agreed to come on this quest, I figured I’d be in the back of the action waiting for injured people to heal. I never imagined I’d be a key player. I know the first part of this all rests on Allistair and Lena, but I’m worried that I won’t be there to heal them. What if they die? What if we are caught while we wait? If they succeed, I have important jobs to do, and lives depend on me. I have had

lives depending on me healing them, and I usually can, but this is different. This is terrifying."

"It is," Hartley agreed. "I practice with Allistair, so I know a few things about both sword fighting and fist fighting, but I have never done anything like this either."

She hugged him, holding on tightly to help her nerves. He put his arms around her and assured her, "I'll take care of you. I promised I would, and I will."

She smiled up at him. "I guess this will make a good story. We need to live through it so we can tell it."

They stayed in each other's arms, waiting. Finally, Allistair and Lina came over and told them that they were going to have dinner and get ready to go.

They made dinner, but everyone was too nervous to eat much.

The sun set as they packed the dinner up. Normally the beautiful oranges and yellows of the twilight sky would be romantic or calming, but the colors made them feel that the sky was blood-stained and eerie.

They went as silently as they could to where everyone was sleeping. Allistair was dressed as a guard, and Lina as a slave.

"Good luck!" Lina whispered, and she gave Allistair a kiss. Then both she and Allistair climbed the wall. As they did, Raissa flew behind them, helping pull them up and over. She wasn't strong enough to pick someone up and fly over, but she could help.

As they started going over the wall, Hartley went through the woods a little south and set a fire quickly. It didn't take long for it to get big enough for the guards to notice, and it did distract them, as they had to put it out,

so no one watched as Allistair and Lina made it over the wall.

Allistair took Lina's hand and they snuck through the dark of night, hoping to find a good place to hide. There were bushes, so they hid in them.

"Do you think Hartley and Raissa will make it back to the wagon safely?"

"Raissa can fly," Allistair pointed out. "I'm more worried about Hartley, but he can swing through trees pretty well. Right now, we need to focus on our part and need to be quiet."

They held onto each other and both did actually fall asleep for a few hours.

They woke up in the morning when a loud horn was blown.

The quiet night suddenly became awake, and people started coming out of the buildings. Guards were standing with whips to make sure everyone went where they were supposed to. The slaves all came out and stood in a long line that started at the gate.

That was good. It wasn't too hard for Lina and Allistair to fit in. There were between two and three hundred slaves and at least fifty guards. That wasn't surprising, as the guards would be heaviest as they brought the slaves to and from the mine.

Allistair wished he had a whip, as the other guards did, but hopefully he didn't stand out. He blended in with the guards and Lina stood in line with the other slaves.

Allistair made sure that he kept his eyes on Lina as the slaves were all given a piece of biscuit bread and led out. All of them had to stay on the path. If anyone tried to

stray, surely, he'd be whipped.

The walk into the mines felt as if he was walking to his doom, and the sad, hopeless faces of the slaves filled Allistair with despair. How were they going to work hard on only a piece of biscuit bread?

The situation became worse when he saw the condition the people were working in. The reason so many collien and children were used in the mine was because they were small and could get into small areas. At times they were lowered down shafts to chisel out ore. Hopefully, the old entrance wasn't down a shaft. There was no way Allistair could fit through anything small.

He made sure that he watched Lina, and as soon as he could, he went over, told the closest guard that he needed that one because she had some elf in her and they needed her knowledge of gems and took Lina away.

They then started searching the mine. It wasn't that hard to do. The main part of the mine was a very large cavern. There had been paths carved into the sides for people to walk on, and there was a large pit in the middle.

Other than that, Allistair had noted a cavern near the entrance that was obviously used to torture disobedient slaves and four branches off the main part.

It didn't take much to decide which branch to follow, as two of them went the wrong direction of where to look. To figure out which of the other two to take, Lina went over and worked beside another slave. Allistair stood near, watching them, so no other guard would. Lena whispered softly to the slave, "Where do the two corridors to my left go?"

The man looked shocked that she spoke, but whispered back, "To the same wall, but one to the west

leads to an unused corridor because it goes to water."

A taskmaster then whipped him and called to Allistair, "Don't let them talk. The filthy scum could plot an escape."

"Come!" Allistair called to Lina. "Away from him!"

They headed to a the western corridor. It was honestly hard to tell direction in the mine. It was hard to tell time too, as there was no sunlight. Everything was dark and lit only with torches. The smoke from the torches and lack of fresh air made the mine very stuffy.

As they headed to the corridor, they heard a whip crack and a man scream. They turned instinctively. "Keep going," Allistair warned, grabbing Lina's arm so she wouldn't go try to stop the guard. "As much as I want to help, if we try anything now, we will end up dead and that won't help the slaves. We need to do this right. Let's hope this corridor leads to the exit."

"I may dig my way out if it doesn't," Lina joked. "This place is horrific, even worse than I expected."

"True," Allistair agreed. "Let's see what we find."

The corridor only had one guard at it. Allistair could knock him out, but they didn't want an unconscious guard. He would be noticed and people would find him and pursue them. Instead, he picked up a rock – there were plenty of those – and threw. It hit another rock and made a loud noise. As the guard turned to see what made the noise, Allistair and Lina grabbed a nearby lantern and sneaked past him into the corridor.

No one was in there, no guards, no slaves, no one. There was a river. The slave had been right about the water. Allistair wasn't sure how deep it was, but it was

about fifteen feet wide, so it could be fairly deep.

"Let me see how deep it is," Allistair offered. "I hope it's shallow enough that we don't have to swim. That's hard to do with my chest plate, sword, and boots."

"This isn't hard to swim in," Lina noted, grabbing her skirt, which was lightweight and tattered. "I'm not wearing shoes at all."

Allistair stepped in the water. It wasn't deep, only five feet. The problem wasn't the depth for him, but as soon as he reached the center to see how deep it was, he found that something lived in that water, something that seemed to be a cross between a crocodile and large fish. It didn't matter what it was. What mattered was that it was trying to bite him.

He ended up wrestling the sea creature in the water. He'd done plenty of wrestling, but never in water and never had his opponent had fins and crocodile teeth. He made sure as he wrestled that he held the creature's massive jaws shut. That made it hard to attack, so they ended up flipping around in the water. It was hard when the creature was on top, as Allistair could only hold his breath for so long, and the lack of air made him feel desperate.

He ended up having to let go and step back. That gave him a moment to pull his sword and strike. As he plunged his sword into the creature, it bit his leg. Fortunately, not full strength, as it quickly died, but still, Allistair's leg bled.

He made his way out of the water to Lina with a trail of bloody red water behind him.

She immediately held the stone around her necklace and blew on his leg. It stopped the bleeding. He would

live, but it would hurt. If only she could do more, if only they had Raissa.

“What do we do?” Lina panicked. “We can’t get across the water.”

“We probably can,” Allistair corrected. “I killed the creature. As long as there isn’t another, we are safe.” He then looked at her and teased, “All right. I can get across the water because I’m not pint-sized like you.”

Lina could swim, but Allistair ended up carrying her on his shoulders, so she wouldn’t get as wet. He, of course, was already soaked from the fight in the water.

When they reached the other side, he took his shirt off and wrung it out.

“That’s new,” Lina noted, pointing to his chest.

He looked down to see what she was talking about. There was a marking of a lion. “That is new,” he agreed. “I wonder what it means.”

“That you have a loud roar?” Lina joked. She then seriously answered, “Perhaps the lion being the king of the animals shows you are now the leader of the guild. Or perhaps it shows that you are strong and bold and working for the king on quests you deem worthy.”

“I guess it doesn’t matter,” Allistair noted. “Right now, we need to focus on finding the old exit. Guards may already be trying to find us.”

They both looked around. The cavern they were in was fairly large, and it had two corridors branching off of it, one headed north and one east.

“I am guessing the eastern path is our best chance,” Allistair pointed out. “Since the people over the

mountains started the mine, they likely dug from the west or south of here. The northern cavern would lead to more mountains."

"That way," Lina agreed, walking toward the west corridor. She really wished she had her lute, as music would make the situation less terrifying, but obviously making noise would be foolish, so she didn't even sing.

"This will make a good tale," she whispered as they walked down the corridor.

Allistair was slightly in front of her, holding her hand. He had his sword drawn and in his other hand, ready to fight if attacked.

They walked through the caves, always staying on the larger paths, as they figured that if there was a path to the mine, it would have to be large enough that people could walk through it with carts or it wouldn't be practical to mine.

The walk itself wasn't bad, but the temperature was. There was no light, and the cave was cold. They had to walk through several shallow rivers, which didn't help. Each time, Allistair would pick up Lina and carry her, so her bare feet and exposed legs would not get colder. She was already often shivering.

He took his tunic off and let her wear it to warm her up some, but she still shivered.

"Do we need to go back?" Allistair asked. "I don't want you freezing to death, and we can't make a fire down here."

"I'll keep going," Lina answered, jumping up and down to try to warm up some.

Allistair rubbed her arms and then hugged her. Then

she tried to warm her hands over the waning flame in the lantern.

After a few minutes, she urged, “Let’s go. I want this over.”

They continued through the corridor. As they went, the lantern flame burned lighter and then flickered out.

“We’ll never make it,” Lina complained. “We are going to freeze to death, and can’t see to get out.”

Allistair again held her close. “I’d give you my boots, but they won’t fit.” Once he spent a few minutes trying to warm her up, he picked her up and carried her, hoping that she’d be warmer without her feet on the cold ground and hoping that his body heat could help warm her.

It was slow-going, and the total darkness was intense. The land could drop off in front of them at any moment and they could plummet to their death, or a beast could be lurking around a corner.

He was relieved when he saw a green glow coming from moss on the side of the cave. At first it was very faint, but there was more as he walked, and soon he could see a chamber lit dimly with it, but lit enough so he could see the entire chamber. There were corridors breaking off the chamber, and one of them had light coming through it, actual sunlight.

He picked up his speed, and hurried down the corridor until his feet stepped on soil outside of the cave. The sun was very bright compared to the cave, and all he or Lina could see was blinding light for a moment. At least the sunlight felt warm.

“We made it!” Lina exclaimed with as much

excitement as she could muster given her exhaustion. “Now what?”

“I fight,” Allistair answered, pointing to a wild boar charging toward them.

Chapter 29: Boar Meat, a Sassy Girl, and an Unfinished Tale

Allistair really wasn't up to fighting a boar. He was tired and hadn't eaten since breakfast, and it was late afternoon. Yet, he had no choice. He couldn't let the boar kill them, so he pulled his sword and engaged.

Lina watched as he fought. They were both weak and cold, and Allistair wasn't fighting with his usual strength. A wave of despair ran through her. How would they make it? They couldn't have come so far just to fail.

She watched as Allistair first tried to keep the boar back with his sword, so he wouldn't get skewered with the boar's tusks. It wasn't a fair fight. The boar had a huge advantage, but Allistair grabbed a tusk and struck with his sword. The boar shook his head and broke loose.

Lina screamed, afraid the boar was going to turn and pierce his long tusk through Allistair's chest, but when

she screamed the boar turned and charged at her.

Allistair grabbed the boar's hind legs and tried to flip the boar over. The boar struggled, flailing around to try to keep from turning over, but Allistair mananged to flip the boar onto it's side and sink his sword into it.

Allistair then fell to his knees, exhausted. Lina ran over, with what energy she had, fell to her knees beside him, and hugged him.

"What are we going to do?" she cried. "We're going to die out here. We have no idea where we are, and we'll never survive the night."

"We won't die," Allistair assured her. "I am going to make a fire and cook some of the boar meat."

Lina hadn't even thought about eating the boar, despite her hunger, as she was only concerned with Allistair surviving the fight. The boar meat sounded like a wonderful idea. They would survive.

The first thing she did was hold her crystal on her necklace and blow in Allistair's face to help heal him. It definitely helped.

He then put his arms around her and assured her, "We are going to make it. This plan is going to work." He ran his hand along her cheek, gently caressing it, tilted her chin up, and gave her a kiss. "I'm going to take care of you."

She smiled back at him and teased, "And I'm going to keep making it hard for you to." She then started singing:

> "I just can't help it. I'm that way,
> For women are as men portray.
> We're fun, but sassy. We have spunk.

You can’t predict what we have thunk.”

“Thunk?” Allistair asked as he took a knife from his belt and started cutting up the boar.

“With how I feel, that was a great rhyme,” she defended. “At least I didn’t say something like, ‘We’re fun, but sassy, we have spunk. We nag all men unless we’re drunk.”

Allistair laughed. “For some women, that is true.” He shook his head and corrected, “I’ve known women who nag worse when they are drunk.”

Lina smiled. “I like you better since you’ve become sober.”

“I definitely don’t do as many things to regret,” Allistair replied. “I like that.” He stood up and started gathering some wood to build a fire. Lina helped.

It didn’t take long before they had a fire going and were roasting meat over it. The smell was incredible, as they hadn’t eaten since breakfast, but it seemed to take forever for the meat to cook, even though they cut off small pieces that they put on sticks so it would cook quickly.

They ate by the fire, and the misery of the day washed away in the warmth of the whisking flames.

“Do you think the fire will call enemies to us?” Lina asked.

“No,” Allistair answered. “I’m more concerned about it calling wild animals, but I don’t know that there are chimeric beasts in these parts, and I think we are far enough away from Montlier that the guards over the slaves will not see the smoke rising.”

She put more meat on her stick. “I wish we could cook all of this and take it back with us. The slaves could use food, and I don’t know how long it will take for us to get back. I have no idea where we are. The caves entirely disoriented me, and I’m not even sure which way is Montlier.”

“That way,” Allistair answered, pointing east. “You can tell by the sun.” We’ll just head east and hope we get back tomorrow. If not, the slaves will survive a few more days. I’d rather do this right than fast. Besides, I had Urvan send word to Camden to bring the Knight Avants to the Hidden Pearl to help us. He’s supposed to be sending men south too.”

“Oh,” Lina replied a little nervously. “Don’t you think that will be noticed? It will make them a target and will make Duke Korbyn watch for an escape attempt.”

“Perhaps,” Allistair agreed. “Yet, Camden and the Knight Avants may be a big distraction. In my message to him, I asked him to go to Korbyn with the accusations of using slaves and to try to negotiate and look at the mines that Korbyn chooses to show them.”

“Do you think you can trust Camden?” Lina asked. “He has not always stood up boldly.”

“True,” Allistair agreed, “but we may really need him. We need his distraction, and if we are caught, we need his authority to free us.”

Lina sighed. “Let’s hope that he really has changed and takes a stand if he needs to.” She put more sticks on the fire and asked, “What do we do now?”

“Sleep,” Allistair answered. “We can sleep near the fire so we are warm, and I’ll sleep on my sword in case there is trouble.”

It wasn't comfortable to sleep on the ground without even a blanket, so Allistair stretched out on the dirt and Lina laid her head on his chest to sleep.

Despite the uncomfortable ground, they both were tired enough that they fell asleep.

They were fortunate that no wild animals attacked during the night. No guards from Montlier found them either, but they were awaken by the sound of horses riding up.

Allistair jumped up and drew his sword, calling to Lina, "Stay back!"

Allistair could feel his heart race as the horses approached, but it slowed, and his panic turned to relief as he saw through the darkness that it was Hartley and Raissa riding up.

"How did you find us?" Allistair asked as they stopped and dismounted their horses.

"I fly," Raissa reminded him. "Once we got out of sight of the mines, I flew up over the trees and saw the smoke from the fire. It just took us a few hours to get here. I'm glad you made the fire. It would have been hard to see you, particularly at night, through the trees."

"You are a sight for sore eyes," Allistair responded. "Lina and I weren't eager to walk back. This has been a difficult trip."

"But I see you found the exit," Hartley noted. "So, can we go through with the plan?"

"I hope," Allistair answered, "but the cave is cold and dark, and with that many people, the trip will be slow-going. We will need to prepare well."

“Let’s get on it,” Hartley suggested. He looked over at the nearly burned out fire and asked, “Can I have some of that boar meat? It smells wonderful, and I’m hungry. I haven’t had breakfast yet.”

“It’s not morning,” Lina pointed out.

Hartley stared at her with a bewildered look. “So?”

They didn’t immediately eat. Hartley and Raissa had blankets in their saddlbags and they had been riding most of the night, so they all needed sleep.

They shared the blankets, and Hartley and Allistair took turns taking watch as they slept.

In the morning, they rose early and ate more of the boar meat. Then they each mounted the horses to head back to Montlier.

Allistair and Lina shared a horse, as there were only two horses. Hartley and Raissa shared the other. She could fly, but trees got in the way, so if one of them got off the horse to scout ahead, it was usually Hartley, as he could swing through the trees using his tail.

They made it safely back to Montlier, but had to be careful in going near the mines to not be seen.

“Do we head to the Hidden Pearl?” Lina asked. “Do you need to talk to Camden? I sure wouldn’t mind a bed to sleep in.”

“I don’t dare go there,” Allistair answered. “Talking to Camden would be nice, but it is risky. There will be many eyes on the Hidden Peal with the Knight Avants there. Let’s go back to your wagon.”

They went back to the wagon. The first thing Lina did was change back into her normal clothing. Then they

all went over their plan, making changes as needed due to what they'd learned.

When they had finished making all the plans they could, they went quietly to the woods near where the slaves slept. They carried with them bottles of alcohol, strong alcohol.

"Are you ready?" Allistair asked Raissa.

She heaved a breath to let out tension. "I hope so."

Allistair and Hartley went out in guards' clothing and patrolled the area. When it was safe, they motioned to Raissa.

During the day, the guards did not stand guard in the towers on the wall around where the slaves slept. They were all in the mines instead or outside near the entrance.

That meant that Raissa could take the bottles of alcohol up to the towers and leave them there.

At one point, a guard from the entrance to the mines came over to Allistair and Hartley and asked, "Did you see a faunen flying around? I thought I saw one? We may have an escaped slave."

"I saw nothing," Allistair answered. He looked over at Hartley and asked, "Did you see a faunen flying around?"

"No," Heartley answered. He then told the guard, "You need to be at your post. We'll look into it." He then motioned to Allistair, and they both walked off toward the wall, hoping the guard went back to his post.

They found Raissa hiding in a tree near the wall.

"Did you finish?"Allistair asked.

“Almost,” Raissa answered. “I still have one more tower to put the bottles in, but I’m being watched for.”

“Then don’t do it,” Allistair instructed. “We’ll find another way.”

“Can you fly them to the top of the wall and reach up and put them on it without your head going over the wall?” Hartley asked.

“Yes,” Raissa answered, “but the guards won’t even see it there.”

“They don’t need to,” Hartley assured her. “You get it on the wall, and I’ll get it in the tower.”

She flew the bottles to the top of the wall being careful only to reach her hands up that high so she wouldn’t be seen. Then Hartley climbed the wall, took the bottles, and scampered along the wall to the tower. He flipped over the railing on the tower using his tail, as his arms were full of bottles and put them in.

He quickly came back down and announced, “Mission accomplished!”

“Thank you!” Raissa exclaimed, throwing her arms around him. She then joked, “Just because you helped doesn’t mean I’m splitting my payment for this quest with you.”

Hartley shook his head. “You little mercenary.”

Since the alcohol had been placed in the towers and at the front door in the wall, they all went back to the wagon, where once again, they had to wait.

“What do we do while we wait?” Lina asked. “We’re all going to be nervous wrecks until we can do this.”

“What do I want to do?” Allistair asked. “I’m not

sure I should answer that."

Hartley suggested, "How about if we write the tale of this adventure as a song? I think we could fill our hat with coins from this tale, particularly if I juggle to it."

"But we don't know how it's going to end," Allistair pointed out.

Lina smiled back. "We write the song assuming we succeed."

Raissa added, "If you fail, you won't be alive to sing the tale, so that's a good idea."

"You do have a dark side," Hartley noted.

Raissa shrugged. "I don't have to pretend anything here. I'll get paid the same." She then looked at Allistair. "You aren't allowed to die. This mission must succeed. I'm guessing we don't get paid if you die."

"I'll try not to die," Allistair assured her. "I'd like to keep us all alive."

"Why don't we write that song now?" Lina suggested.

Chapter 30: Sunlight, A Story of Corruption, and An Unexpected Kiss

Late that night, Allistair, Lina, Hartley, and Raissa waiting in the trees watching the wall around where the slaves slept and hoping all would go as planned.

The plan was to have Camden invite Korbyn, his counselors, guards, and other important people to the Hidden Pearl to talk, better relations between Montlier and Roifort, and drink. Hopefully, that was going well.

Hopefully, the guards would drink the strong ale left for them too. After all, even though they were on duty watching the slaves, didn't they at least deserve some ale since they didn't get to go to the Hidden Pearl?

As Allistair and the others watched from the trees, they heard the guards in the nearest tower laughing loudly and singing at the top of their voices. That was good. They had obviously been drinking. Hopefully, the

other guards would too.

It took several hours of waiting for the guards to pass out from the strong ale. When they did, Allistair, Lina, Hartley, and Raissa walked up to the front gate. There were two guards there. One was passed out drunk and the other was very drunk.

“What do you want?” the drunk guard asked.

Since Allistair and Hartley were dressed as guards, Allistair answered, “We’re bringing these two in as new slaves. Let us in.”

The guard tried to let them in, but couldn’t put the key in the lock, so Allistair took the key and helped him. Once he did, he pocketed the key and thanked the guard. The guard didn’t realize Allistair kept the key. He went back to guarding the door.

Most of the guards inside were passed out drunk. There were only two who were not, and Allistair punched them unconscious very quickly so they couldn’t scream out, not that screaming would help as the other guards were too drunk to come.

Once the guards were taken care of, Allistair, Lina, Hartley, and Raissa quietly woke up all the slaves and told them to follow them, as they were there to free them.

They crept out silently, passing the guard at the gate who had passed out.

Instead of taking them out through the woods, they took them and hid them in the mine. That was a wise thing to do because it didn’t take long for the passed out guards to be noticed and for people to realize the slaves had escaped.

In fact, they were still walking into the mine when a

guard from a tower noticed they were gone and sounded an alarm.

“Follow me!” Allistair ordered the slaves. “Men will be searching for you all over the city and all through the woods. Hopefully, the last place they think that you would escape to is into the mine. Yet, if someone thinks to look here, I want all of us through to the secret corridor quickly. Come!”

He lit torches and lanterns that the miners used and had them all follow him.

The slaves were all good at obeying orders, and eager for their freedom, so they followed Allistair.

The slaves did not complain, even though they had to walk through the six foot deep water, and many of the taller slaves made several trips back and forth to carry the smaller slaves who couldn’t swim well.

When everyone was on the other side of the water, Allistair gave them a little time to dry off, but couldn’t take too much time, as if the guards decided to check the mine they might see the light down the corridor and pursue.

The walk was long and just as cold for the slaves as it had been for Lina, as the slaves were not dressed for warmth, but most of them were used to being cold or uncomfortable, so they did not complain.

As they sank deeper into the caverns, the cave became darker and the torches and lanterns began to go out. Allistair did bring two lanterns that had not been lit, so he could light them when the others started to give out so they would still have some light. He had brought a pack of food and several blankets, but he, Lina, Hartley, and Raissa could not carry enough blankets for everyone.

The shivering slaves made their way through the dimly lit corridor with whispers of hope and fear. They'd dreamed of being rescued, but did not know the plan or if it would work, and the darkness and cold penetrated them and cut through much of their hope, replacing it with doubt.

As they stepped out of the cave, the morning sun blinded them, but the slaves made no complaint, and many of them breathed in the air around with a breath of hope.

Raissa went around and healed slaves who had been damaged from the cold. She also ended up healing wounds from whips, as many of the slaves had been beaten. Raissa was very happy to do it for them, and kept track of how many people she healed, so she could negotiate good payment.

Allistair and Lina went to trying to find a way to let everyone sleep and to get them some food. Allistair had brought a pack full of rations and several blankets.

They took the rations and passed them out. The group had over two hundred people, so there was little for each person, but no one complained.

Allistair didn't take any food, neither did Lina. After all, the slaves needed it more than he did. He sat beside Lina and noted. "And I thought my life was hard."

Lina took his arm. "They have been through so much, but look how grateful they are. It is easy for people to take what they have for granted, but people with nothing appreciate the little things. They are strong too. Otherwise we never would have been able to bring this big of a group through the corridors."

"What do we do now?" Allistair asked. "I know the

plan is to have Urvan's men meet us south of the mines at the foot of the mountains, and I'm not sure if they made it. I also don't know how we get this large of a group there." He ran his fingers through his hair. "I should have had Hartley and Raissa come with your wagon and a load of food and blankets. I just didn't know how much resistance we'd have getting the slaves outside the wall or if we'd be caught in the mines, so I wanted Hartley's help. I'm afraid I didn't calculate most of this right."

"No," Lina chided. "Don't beat yourself up over things you didn't know. Your plan has worked this far, and I think we will succeed."

"But if we don't, all these people could be beaten or killed," Allistair countered. "I have so much responsibility on me. I don't want people dying because of me."

"You are doing what is right," Lina assured him. "No, there are no guarantees, but at times risks have to be taken. You have tried to account for problems that will arise. We'll make this work. And this isn't all on you. You did not force any of the slaves to come. They could have chosen to stay. They all know there is risk in escape."

"They still are putting great trust in me," Allistair noted. "I don't want to fail them."

"You won't," Lina assured him. "Don't let it go to your head, but I think you're smart. You certainly are doing well as a minstrel. I'm so happy that I made you my partner."

"Singing with you is definitely more fun than fighting," he assured her, "and much less painful. He stood up. "I think I'm going to get Hartley and a few men and see if we can hunt for more food."

“Be careful,” Lina warned. “There may be guards scouring the woods.”

“If so, it’s best we go hunting,” Allistair noted. “It will also give us the chance to be the forward scouts.”

Hartley and Allistair did get some men and go hunt. They were gone for several hours. When they came back, they had a boar and some small game.

It took time to cook it all and let everyone eat. The slaves were very patient and very grateful.

“I wish I had my lute,” Lina noted. “I think some music and dancing would really help. The slaves have probably not had a chance to enjoy music and dancing as long as they have been captured.”

“We haven’t,” a voice responded to her surprise. She looked over and saw a short man with a beard, obviously a collien, walking toward her. “I heard you,” he noted. “No, we have not heard music or danced since we have been slaves. I have been for two years.”

“How did you become a slave?” Lina asked. “And what is your name?”

He had to think about what his name was for a moment before answering, “Haeghun. I am from Kir Daral.”

“Where’s that?” Lina asked.

“In the mountains north of Arwood,” Haeghun answered. “We have a city built into caverns in the mountains.”

“And you are a collien, right?” Lina asked.

“Yes,” Haeghun answered. “My people are natural miners. We have built a huge underground city, so Duke

Korbyn wants us as slaves."

Allistair stared curiously in thought. "How do they get in to kidnap your people? I would think that since you know the threat, you would have good defenses at any opening to the outside."

"That would be intelligent," Haeghun agreed. "Unfortunately, Kir Daral has its share of problems. The kidnappers sneak in at night and pull people out. That is how I was kidnapped."

"How do they get in?" Allistair asked. "Aren't there guards?"

"Yes," Haeghun confirmed. "I told you our city has its corruption. Our king, King Gloridge, puts on a very good face to the people. They all love him and think he is really working hard for their best interest, but behind their backs, he makes very shady deals, and often if anyone knows anything about his dealings, they are sold as slaves."

"Sold?" Allistair asked.

"Not officially," Haeghun answered. "They are somehow kidnapped and brought to the slave mines here, along with others that King Gloridge doesn't see as useful."

"Not useful?" Lina asked.

"King Gloridge thinks that with a limited amount of space to build our city in that we have to keep the population down," Haeghun explained. "Thus, King Gloridge blames the disappearances on kidnappings, which he assures people are not often and he is working to solve, and on people getting lost or killed by wild animals when they leave the city to the outside world."

“So, he lies,” Lina concluded.

“Indeed,” Haeghun confirmed.

Allistair shook his head. “Seriously, people are evil. What did he have on you?”

“I found out about the kidnappings, and that the kidnappers were being let in the city and shown to the people Gloridge wanted to be taken,” Haeghun explained. “I met in secret with some men I thought I could trust to try to expose what was going on, but one of the men betrayed me. He turned us in to the king for treason.”

“Were you kidnapped during the night?” Lina asked.

“No,” Haeghun answered. “I was locked up, and the next time the kidnappers came, I was given to them, along with the other men I was working with. We were brought straight here.”

“I’m confused,” Lina admitted. “If you were brought straight here, why would Knight Avants take slaves to Montlier?”

“Because the kidnappers are often not from Montlier,” Haeghun explained. “Most of them are from Varoux. They catch us and send us to the Knight Avants to take, so they are not seen. Their appearance stands out. Rhys are noticeable. In my case, I was a prisoner, so Montlier guards came for me. No one had to sneak in during the night.”

Allistair clasped his hands together. “Is there any city besides Chesterfield that isn’t entirely evil in our realm?”

“Bellemar isn’t,” Lina answered. “It’s a very nice city.”

“But there’s so much corruption!” Allistair

complained. “How are we supposed to stop it?”

“We can’t alone,” Lina noted. “That’s the reason for the Hangover Guild. There is strength in numbers.”

“And more people to die,” Allistair added. He clenched his fists and started to walk off, but Hartley ran up to him.

“Come!” Hartley urged, in a very happy tone. “The people are fed and happy and I just promised them some entertainment. You and Lina are going to sing for them.”

“You promised,” Allistair snipped. “You sing, or juggle, or whatever.”

“Good idea,” Hartley agreed. Then he purposely sang off key:

> “I’ll sing like this. It’s stratagem,
> For you refuse to sing to them.
> Then soon they’ll beg and you’ll agree.
> To stop my singing that’s off-key.
>
> But take your time. Why rush? Be slow.
> There’s no where for the slaves to go.
> They’re captive to my…”

“Fine,” Lina conceded. “We’ll go sing. Come Allistair.” She grabbed his hand and started walking toward the group.

He followed. “Shouldn’t we be doing some scouting and figuring out where the slaves need to go? If we take them back to Kir Daral, they may get sent back to the mines.”

“No,” Lina answered. “It’s been a hard day for them. Yes, they are free, but their lives just changed. Most of

them don't know what they will go back to. They are going to be very afraid. We don't need to add to that by having them learn that their king has been lying to them and working with the slave trade."

"You're right," Allistair agreed. "I wish you had your lute."

"You can beat on something to use as a drum," Lina suggested. "Let's just have some fun."

"I still wish that I had time to work on the lyrics," Allistair complained. "I like to get them just right."

"Fine," Lina joked. "You have about thirty seconds to perfect the lyrics. Come!"

He did have more than thirty seconds, but in that time, he didn't get to even think of what he was going to sing, as so many people had questions for him.

Before he answered everyone's questions, the people started calling for him and Lina to sing.

Lina started the song by improvising:

> "You're free, so celebrate tonight.
> You're free, so thank our Avant Knight.
> You're free. You get a needed break.
> You're free. The future's yours to make."

She turned the song over to Allistair. He'd been quite happy letting her sing, but everyone was watching him, expecting something, so he changed the beat he was playing and sang:

> "Everyone dance around. Be bold and brave.
> For now you'll go home. You're no longer a
> slave.

Be merry. There's food for each girl and each boy.
Then think of the future with hope and with joy.

I'm making this up, all the rhymes as I go.
Perhaps I will sing how we'll conquer our foe.
Perhaps I will sing of a beast with a tail.
We'll fight him, then cook him, and eat him with ale.

I don't really drink, so I'll get no refill.
And so it's ironic I started a guild,
The Hangover Guild. We all stand for what's true,
And educate people who don't have a clue.

So many around don't know what's right or wrong.
They can't tell the signature key of a song.
They get so confused. What is up? What is down?
What's right, and what's left? Is their shirt blue or brown?

But you're not that stupid. You'd never be sheep,
Believing you don't have to sow what you reap.
Believing false praises and flowery speech,
Believing the lies that corrupt men will teach."

Lina elbowed him to remind him that it wasn't the time to preach, and he needed help them relax. She took over singing:

"Don't preach to them, not today. It's time for smiles.

So, entertain brightly. Let's show them our styles.
First, Hartley can juggle. Raissa can dance.
While we sing a song that is sure to entrance.

It's time to relax. Taking breaks' not remiss.
Perhaps while they do, you can give me a kiss."

That was a request she didn't have to make more than once. Allistair stepped over and gave her a kiss, a rather playful one that the crowd quietly cheered for.

"Can we do that?" a boy called out. "We weren't allowed to have relationships as slaves."

"You're welcome to," Allistair assured him, "but not with my girl. You'll have to find your own."

The boy jokingly called out, "Any volunteers," and was shocked that a girl very timidly raised her hand to chest level.

The boy took the opportunity to give her the kiss, and after it exclaimed, "Wow! I like being freed."

"You aren't entirely yet," Allistair warned. "I'm afraid the rescue has just started. I let everyone have a rest, but what we have done so far is the easy part. We all need to get walking. Now we head into the dangerous part of the quest. If all doesn't go perfectly as planned, people will die."

Hartley put his hand on Allistair's shoulder and assured him, "It will all go fine."

"I wouldn't count on it," Allistair countered. "There's too much that can go wrong. It's going to be really hard to get over two hundred people dressed in rags through Montlier unnoticed."

“Maybe I’ll entertain and distract everyone as you do,” Hartley offered. “I’m working on some great juggle tricks.”

Allistair shook his head. “This is no time for jokes. There is so much that can go wrong, and I have a bad feeling about this. There’s no way I could plan for everything.”

Chapter 31: A Dungeon Break, Mutton Sandwiches, and a Proud Woman

Ormondo walked down the stairs to the dungeon to find Jareth. He was often there, as he was over the prisoners, so whenever Jareth was not in his room in the top of the tower, Ormondo looked for him there.

He went in without knocking. There was no need. The front room was empty except for one guard who was sitting at a table eating bread with butter. Ormondo looked around and did not see Perkin, but he knew where to find him, as he could hear chilling screams coming from down the hall.

Ormondo proceeded down a short corridor to the room Jareth tortured prisoners in. Jareth was there, as expected, so was Perkin, but Perkin was tied with his hand above his head, and his back was bloody with

stripes. The only other person in the room was a faunen girl who sat in the corner with her arms around her knees looking in fear at what was being done.

Ormondo watched for a moment as Jareth threw a strike with a flail, and Perkin's scream of pain echoed through the dungeon.

Jareth looked over at Ormondo and noted, "It is interesting to see the effects of the different weapons. The flail cuts deep. The whip stings as it cuts, and the rod causes blunt force. I can usually hit hard enough to break bones. I prefer pain to instant death. If I torture a man, I can have him healed and then torture him more. It is a good experiment. Knowledge of weapons are useful to know what different characteristics of beasts will do in a fight."

He threw another strike of the flail, and Perkin howled. Jareth showed no sympathy, but calmly stated, "I think this could use a slightly longer chain. It would give me a little more force on my hits."

"Jareth," Ormondo replied, "I have not come to discuss weapons. We have issues to deal with?"

"We, or you?" Jareth asked. "Is this about Perkin?"

"Yes," Ormondo answered, "but it is more about Allistair. Apparently, he has succeeded in freeing the slaves from the mine in Montlier. No one knows where he is hiding over two hundred people. Montlier is being monitored and searched, but there is no sign of them. There are not even tracks to follow."

Jareth switched his weapon to a regular whip and struck. After Perkin's scream died down, Jareth asked Ormondo, "Have you checked the mine?"

“Not entirely,” Ormondo answered. “The mine was not our first place to look, but some guards did look in it. What type of fool would escape to the place they want to escape from?”

“A wise fool,” Jareth answered. “Could they be hiding there, hoping that is not expected, and are going to wait until the search for them stops to sneak out? Could the slaves have found another way out?”

“I will have the mine searched immediately,” Ormondo conceded. “Perhaps Allistair is slicker than I had given him credit for.”

“Which is why you are here,” Jareth concluded. “You are livid that he nearly got you released as a counselor and has now freed the slaves, and you want him to pay for it, likely with his life, so you need my help. What is it you want? Beasts? Perkin?”

“Let me go!” Perkin pleaded. “Ormondo, save me!”

“Both,” Ormondo hissed, ignoring Perkin. “Allistair is slick. I want him dead, and I want to use all our power to see to that.” He raised his voice and yelled, “He is trying to destroy everything we are working for. His guild is growing in strength, and people are starting to ask questions. If he does not die, we may lose a great deal of control!”

“I can help,” Jareth responded calmly, “but killing him may not be the best path. If he dies, he will become a martyr to his followers and that will embolden them. I think what we need to do is discredit him, humiliate him so people feel like fools for ever believing him. Sometimes there are much better ways than death to deal with an enemy. I can send beasts, just remember that I have little control over them. I can arrange for Perkin to

escape the dungeon. Now, sit. We need to plan. I have some ideas."

Ormondo sat. "I'm listening."

Jareth looked over at Perkin. "Perhaps this is a conversation best done in private."

"Perhaps," Ormondo agreed.

Jareth called for the guard in the main room to come get Perkin and bring him back to a cell. He then ordered the faunen, "Heal him. Do it in his cell. We want privacy."

The guard untied Perkin's wrists and then threw him over his shoulder and carried him out. The faunen didn't make a sound as she followed after them.

When the others were gone, Ormondo and Jareth sat down to talk.

"I have an idea," Jareth repeated. "You will get your revenge on Allistair, so will Perkin."

*****

About an hour later, Ormondo walked down the short hall to the cells. A guard was in the main room, and the faunen again sat in a corner. Ormondo ordered the guard to leave and let him in to talk to Perkin in private.

The cell Perkin was in was small, but he had been healed, so he stood up and glared at Ormondo. "Why didn't you come sooner? Why didn't you order them not to beat me?"

"I didn't know they would," Ormondo defended,

“but it is of no consequence, as you are fine.”

“Now,” Perkin argued. “You have no idea what they did to me. I am only fine because of the faunen.

“There are more important issues to discuss than torture right now,” Ormondo insisted. “I need to get you out of here, and we need to stop Allistair.

Perkin’s eyes lit up. “What’s the plan?”

“You are going to escape,” Ormondo explained.

A victorious smile crossed Perkin’s filthy face as he eagerly asked, “Do I get to kill Allistair?”

“Perhaps,” Ormondo answered, “but hopefully not. I have been discussing the situation with… I won’t say, but it’s someone with power. He thinks it is best to leave Allistair alive but humiliated and criminalized, a man who must live the rest of his days in hiding for his crimes.”

“What crimes?” Perkin asked. “The king would pardon him from anything. He is going to free the slaves on the king’s orders, not that he could. They are too well guarded, and there are many of them.”

“He already has,” Ormondo corrected to Perkin’s surprise. “We think he may be hiding with them in the mountains, but the mountain range is large, so they could be anywhere. We sent some faunen flying over, but they either came back saying they saw nothing, or flew off to freedom, as most faunen in Montlier are slaves.”

Perkin clasped his hands and seethed, “Faunen lie. They likely say they can’t find a group that large because they are hoping Allistair will free the rest of the slaves in Montlier.”

“Perhaps,” Ormondo agreed. “We had family of most of the faunen, so they would at least return, but we have no way to tell if they really saw the group or not.”

“Do you want me to find them?” Perkin asked.

“No,” Ormondo answered. “I have a more important quest for you. I want you to humiliate him, to frame him for some horrendous crime. Right now, I can’t sneak into the Freedom Faction. King Didier does not trust me, and I am being watched. You, however, will be thought to still be in the dungeon, so you could go in and recruit them to act like they are part of the Hangover Guild and commit some act of violence or treason. Then Allistair can be blamed for inciting an insurrection. If we kill him, he will be a martyr. If we destroy him, his name, and everything he stands for, then when he is executed, the people will cheer his death.”

Perkin tapped his fingers together as he thought. Finally he decided, “I like the idea of criminalizing him. If I kill him now, my name will not be cleared, but if he is seen as a traitor, then his testimony against me will be dismissed, and I should be able to return to being an Avant.”

“Perhaps,” Ormondo agreed. “Now, shall we discuss the plan for how you are to escape? It’s really quite simple. All that needs to happen is for you to sneak out in the middle of the night. The guard is going to conveniently have something in his drink at dinner and fall asleep. Once he does, another guard will sneak in with a key and free you.”

“Can you trust the guard?” Perkin asked.

“Yes,” Ormondo assured him.

Perkin then asked, “Why don’t you just order me free

now?”

“Your escape need to look like neither Jareth nor I were involved, so neither of us will order you free,” Ormondo explained. “Didier is getting more distrustful of me, so I must be careful.”

“Perhaps what I should frame Allistair for is Didier’s death,” Perkin suggested. “I would not mind revenge on the man who stripped me of my knighthood.”

“No,” Ormondo refused. “Who knows who Arwood would replace him with? I fear Edmee would replace him with her counselor Sinclair. He would be much bolder than Didier.” He leaned closer and whispered, “I have a plan. I cannot go to the Freedom Faction for help right now, but you can. They can help you frame Allistair for a horrendous crime in Montlier. If the crime is done in Montlier, Duke Korbyn will be able to try Allistair and sentence him to death before King Didier can get involved. Korbyn hates Allistair.”

Perkin smiled a wry smile. His revenge was at hand. “I like this plan. Let’s work out the details, and I will leave tonight.”

They discussed the plan until the guard came back in carrying a tray and announced, “I have stayed away as long as I can.” He held out the tray. “Do either of you want a mutton sandwich?”

*****

Camden and the Knight Avants were called to Duke Korbyn’s manor when the news of the slave escape reached Korbyn.

Camden walked into the great hall with his head high and looking very confident. He had two dozen Knight Avants with him, and they all stood in formation behind him.

Korbyn had Jacqueline, his main counselor, and many guards there too, so the situation looked like a battle was about to start.

Camden still held his head high and showed no fear. “What is it you want?” he asked Korbyn.

“You will bow before me,” Korbyn demanded. “I am a duke, and of a noble house.”

“And I am the leader of the Knight Avants,” Camden replied. “That is as high of a title. I do not have to obey your orders, as I only have to obey the king, and I do not need to bow to anyone but him.”

Camden could see Korbyn’s chest heave in anger, but Korbyn replied calmly. “Where is Allistair?”

“How would I know?” Camden answered. “I came to see if there were really slaves here as accused. You assure me there are not. I still think I should look around more of the city. Now, you must have called us here for a reason. Is there a problem?”

“Yes,” Korbyn hissed. “Allistair has…” He couldn’t say “freed the slaves,” as he had been insistent there were none. “He has convinced the mine workers to revolt, and they have run away.”

“Well, they are adults,” Camden responded, trying hard not to say something he shouldn’t back. “They have the freedom to leave. I suggest you get more workers. With what you say you pay them, there should be many interested in taking their place. How many were in the

mine? When I saw it, there were about three dozen, right? I wouldn't be too concerned. It's not like he freed slaves that don't exist, and people here have free speech, do they not? I don't see any crime on Allistair's part. If he convinced them to leave, that is fine. I don't see a revolt."

Korbyn stood up and glared at Camden, knowing full well that Camden knew of the slaves and Allistair helping them escape, but he could not admit to it. "Very well," he conceded. "But Allistair is a troublemaker. I want him found, returned to his city, and never to come here again."

"Take that up with the king," Camden replied. "I take my orders from him, not from you. Do you need anything of us? I came to inspect the mines. You have convinced me that I will find no slaves in your mines, so we will be leaving now." He turned and motioned for the knights to come with him.

Once they left, Korbyn turned to Jacqueline, his counselor. "What do we do about them? They know of Allistair and the escaped slaves. They may even know where they are, but I could not admit there were slaves."

"Men," Jacqueline complained. "Let me handle it. I can go to Camden and demand the information from him. If he says I admitted there are slaves, I will deny it, and it will be my word against his. If I need to, I can seduce him for the information."

"You may try," Korbyn agreed. "I want Allistair found. I want the slaves returned, and preferably Allistair dead so he cannot tell tales."

Jacqueline gloated, "You can count on me. I will get done what none of you men can."

“Watch your mouth,” Korbyn warned. “I could have you executed.”

“You won’t,” Jacqueline retorted. “You need me.” She then turned and strutted out of the room.

Korbyn hit his fist on the arm of his throne and seethed, “All of you will show me more respect. I will gain more power!”

Chapter 32: A Morose Song, A Panicked Faunen, and an Unsuccessful Lie

Allistair and Lina led the slaves south through the mountain, constantly watching for pursuit and fearing a faunen flying above and reporting them to Duke Korbyn.

They had sent Hartley and Raissa back for the wagon. Raissa had offered to go alone, as she could fly, but Hartley thought it way too dangerous and reminded her that he had promised to protect her, and he intended to keep his promise.

Lina walked beside Allistair, singing to herself:

> "Our friends aren't back. Perhaps they're caught.
> Their noble quest is all for naught.
> What if they're lost? What if they're dead?
> Or beasts are waiting? What lies ahead?
>
> Perhaps we'll win. Perhaps we'll lose.

In dungeon's dark, we'll be abused.
The legends tale of us will tell
Of how we tried, but efforts failed.

We walk in fear. We…"

"All right," Allistair interrupted. "That's probably not what people need to hear right now, and really not like you."

"Sorry," Lina apologized. "I don't mean to scare anyone. I'm really scared and was just thinking out loud."

"Some thoughts may be better kept to ourselves," Allistair suggested. "We can either stay quiet, so we're less likely to draw attention to ourselves, or we can sing something happier."

"Fine," Lina conceded. She then sang:

"Be happy as you walk along.
Don't think the plan will go all wrong.
We've failed before, our hopes all fell,
We may all die and go to…"

She stopped singing and said, "Montlier."

"I meant something encouraging," Allistair scolded.

"Got it," Lina teased before he sang:

"Be happy. Keep a blissful mood.
If monsters come, we may be food,
But that's not likely. No it's not.
We may though in a dungeon rot.

The guards are searching. Monsters roam.
We may get lost in catacombs.

But do not fear, and be at rest.
We have you here, so all are blessed.

We'll walk through woods so full of beasts,
We'll fight, and cook, and have a feast,
Now don't you fear the..."

"Enough!" Allistair scolded. "You don't get the idea of encouraging the slaves."

"They aren't slaves now," Lina pointed out. "You freed them."

"Not yet," Allistair corrected. "We still need to get them south to Urvan's men and hope that Camden can keep the guards at Montlier from coming south. As you noted, we could end up fighting beasts too. I don't want anyone dying. Those deaths would be on me."

Lina reached over and took his hand. "We'll make it work. Let's prepare for the worst, but hope for the best, and just deal with whatever happens."

Allistair squeezed her hand. "How did I get so lucky to have you choose me to work with?"

She smiled flirtatiously and answered, "Wouldn't you like to know."

For a few minutes, they were able to talk with smiles on their faces, forgetting the worries of what could go wrong, and not thinking of their hungry stomachs as the wagon had not arrived with supplies.

Unfortunately, the smiles didn't last. As the sun started to set, they decided not to camp and to keep walking the two more hours it was going to take to reach Urvan's men. Raissa flew into the woods from above and

in a very panicked voice explained, “They have Hartley! We were found on our way here. That means that they know the direction to head to find you, and they are coming! They also issued a warning to me to go get you because if you don’t turn yourself in by noon tomorrow, they will kill Hartley! You have to save him!”

“Hold on,” Allistair urged. “Who caught Hartley? I assume guards.”

“Yes, guards,” Raissa confirmed. “You must go, now!”

“I don’t have a horse,” Allistair pointed out. “Can you go get the wagon and meet us at the foot of the mountains south of here. We’ll head toward Urvan and his men, and when you catch up with us, hopefully, I can come with you. That should get us there in time. It won’t take too long by horse.”

Raissa started crying, “I should have thought to bring the horse. I was just so panicked. Hartley was really wounded from fighting them to get me free, so I had to bargain with them to let me heal him or I wouldn’t come tell you. After all, why would I help them if Hartley is dead? They let me heal him and then told me that I had to have you back by noon tomorrow. I panicked and hurried off, as flying was the fastest way to go. I am faster than a horse through wooded mountains, as I can go as the crow flies. I guess I really caused problems. I should have…”

“It’s fine,” Allistair assured her. “Calm down. We’ll make it. Noon tomorrow will mean I don’t get much sleep, but we’ll make it. That is, if you go get the horse.” He looked around to see if there were any male faunens in the group. Male faunens were rare. They had to be almost purebred for their faunen part to show. He scoured

the area and saw none. What was he going to do? She needed a protector, but one who could fly.

“I’m headed back,” Raissa informed him, and she quickly flew away.

“Do you think she’ll be safe?” Lina asked.

“I don’t know,” Allistair answered. “I have no idea if the wagon is where she left it. They may want her bringing the horse back so I’ll come. I have no idea if she will get there safely. Beasts are changing quickly, so she could run into one that flies. Honestly, I’d like to say it will be fine, but I don’t know.”

He then gathered the people, passed the message that Raissa had given, and informed them that they all needed to hurry south, that they would reach Urvan and his men in only a few hours and then he’d return for Hartley.

Everyone picked up the pace, and no one spoke, except an occasional hushed whisper if it was necessary.

Allistair put Haeghun in the front, told him where to lead the people, and stayed in the back himself. He kept watching behind them, knowing they would be pursued. It was just a matter of time.

They had moved to the foot of the mountain so they could move quickly, but it would make them much easier to spot, and the guards now knew where to look for them.

Allistair constantly found himself looking over his shoulder, his heart racing as it always did in anticipation of a fight. “Go to the front,” he ordered Lina. “Go ahead, and tell Haeghun to have everyone run. I am going to try to distract the guards.”

Lina stiffened. “Do you hear something?”

“Yes,” Allistair answered, “And I need all of you out of sight before they come. Now, don’t follow me. I need you to do as instructed. The lives of everyone here, including mine, may depend on it. You must get them to Urvan and tell Urvan to come for me. I am counting on you.”

“But I can’t let you…” Lina started to argue.

“You don’t have a choice,” Allistair interrupted. “This is my call, and I’m not letting the guards get to the slaves. Get them to Urvan. Send him to help. Hopefully, Raissa meets you on the way. Now, go!”

She stared at him for a moment. How could she leave him to turn himself in so the guards focused on him not the slaves? “I can’t…” she started.

“You must,” he urged. “Now, go. And no matter what happens, know that I love you.”

The tension was high as the two looked into each other’s eyes, each seeing the other’s fear and desperation.

He then kissed her, pouring out all the emotion into the kiss. Where the kiss was so full of the love he’d confessed, there was still a fear in each of them that it would be their last. They both knew Allistair could be going to his death.

“I love you too,” Lina admitted after the kiss. “Isn’t there another way?”

“I don’t have a better plan,” Allistair admitted. “I wish there was. Now, go, before I lose the courage to do this.”

He gave her a quick kiss, and then she took off running, telling everyone as she did to pick up the pace and follow her.

As she ran to the front to tell Haegan what was going on, Allistair veered off eastward. It didn't take long for him to get out of the woods and into the clearing east of them. From there, he could see the guards approaching on horseback. They were coming, coming for him, and for the slaves. There were several dozen. That was more than he expected. He took a deep breath, trying to calm his nerves, and he walked north, toward the men who wanted to capture him.

Being able to see them coming across the plain made every second of anticipation seem torturous. Yet, he hurried toward them, hoping to meet them far enough north that they didn't see the others headed south.

"You are under arrest!" a large guard who looked to be part lion crevan announced, as the guards all rode up to him and circled their horses around him. "I am Captain Leon. You will surrender and come with us."

Allistair held his hands to chest level to show he was not going to put up a fight, but asked, "Do you have Hartley? Is he safe?"

"He is being escorted to the manor right now," Leon answered. "Now, come."

"Is the faunen who was with him safe?" Allistair asked.

"That one, I do not know," Leon admitted. "I did leave a few guards at the wagon in case the girl returned, so I assume she will be captured, but I don't know." He then smiled, "But we did enjoy some of the food packed in it. You fed us well."

Allistair wanted to draw his sword and strike Leon down, but controlled his temper. How could Leon be so heartless as to try to recapture the slaves? How could he

laugh about stealing food from starving people? Yet, at the moment, Allistair needed to worry about his own life. “What do you want me for?” he demanded. “I have done nothing wrong.”

Leon laughed a mocking laugh. “Freeing the slaves is doing nothing wrong?” He then dismounted his horse and motioned for a few other guards to join him.

As they walked over to Allistair, Allistair defended, “What slaves? There are not and never were slaves in Montlier! That is what your leader says. How could I possibly have freed slaves that do not exist?”

The guards grabbed his arms and started tying them behind his back as Leon stepped up close to him and hissed in his face, “There is no reason to play games with me. We all know of the slaves. We all know what you have done.” He slapped Allistair across the face and added, “We now know they are headed south. Now, tell me where they are going?”

“No,” Allistair refused, so guards grabbed his arms while Leon hit him again.

“Tell me where the slaves are going!” Leon demanded. “Are they headed to Chesterfield or across the mountains to the west?”

Allistair didn’t answer, so Leon struck his again. Allistair glared at him, but answered, “To the west.”

“Search south!” Leon answered. “That was a lie, so they are headed to Chesterfield. That means that they will have to cross the field someplace between here and the sea. Find them!”

One of the guards tensed as he objected, “But there are only a few dozen of us and over two hundred of

them."

"They are unarmed," Leon pointed out. "Surely, you can subdue a few slaves. Go!"

Leon kept a half dozen guards with him to escort Allistair to Korbyn's manor, and the other guards headed south.

Allistair watched them go. What had he done? He'd meant to send them off into the mountains, but Leon saw through his lie. What if the slaves were caught? What if they were killed? If they were thrown back into the slaves mines, Lina would be too. What had he done? People were counting on him, and he'd failed them. Could they make it to Urvan and his men in time? Did Urvan and his men even make it to the rendezvous point?

Allistair didn't get to think about it too long, as the guards grabbed him and forced him onto a horse. Once he was on, they headed north. Allistair wanted to cry. He had wanted to lead the guards away from the slaves, but he'd failed. Now, he had turned himself in to save Hartley, but even if he did, even if he could negotiate for Hartley's freedom, he would be killed. There was no way Korbyn was going to let him get away with freeing the slaves. He would be executed. He had no doubt.

Chapter 33: Lies, More Lies, and a Challenge to the Death

Perkin, wearing a cloak and mask over his eyes, left the Jagged Dagger Tavern with forty men from the Freedom Faction, including Phillipe and Raphael himself. Raphael seldom went on missions, as he usually stayed at their headquarters and ran the faction, but he was livid that Allistair had escaped and personally wanted to see to his demise, so he led the group himself.

Perkin let Raphael lead the group and stayed near the back of it.

All the men from the faction wore hoods and masks and walked down the street. Even though it was only an hour until noon, they had a torch with them.

When they reached the shrine, there were people there, as the shrine was used for people to come pray to the Farrow ancestors. They believed that if they lit

candles and prayed that the smoke would carry their message to the spirit world and call for help.

Raphael led his men into the shrine with all of them chanting, “Hangover Guild! Hangover Guild!” They then started destroying the sacred relics and chopping up the candles. The man with the torch set a tapestry on the wall on fire.

There were fourteen people in the shrine. They started screaming and running for the door, but members of the faction blocked the door, called out, “Death to those who support tyrants! Long live the Hangover Guild!” They then attacked the fleeing people.

They pummeled people. Even when women and children called out for mercy, or a mother begged them to not hurt her child, they beat everyone in there.

Some of the men did try to fight back, so the members of the faction pulled knives to stop them. Two men were left bleeding on the ground, likely dead, and wounded people were scattered all over moaning and crying.

As one of the members of the faction took an incense burner in the shape of an owl and smashed it on the floor, another at the door called out, “Run! They are coming!”

All the members of the faction ran out of the shrine as quickly as they could and ran into woods that were nearby.

As they ran off, a faunen flew into the shrine and started healing.

Perkin did not run. He took off his cloak and mask and handed it to Raphael. Then he went back to the shrine and acted like he was shocked at what had happened.

A group of guards rode up, and Perkin ran to them.

“What happened here, Perkin?” the captain of the guard asked. He was obviously part giant and part crevan, as many in the city were. By his ears, it was easy to tell his crevan side was a hound. “I did not know you were in Montlier.”

“It is good to see you, Fenrir. I came after Allistair,” Perkin explained. “He is the one who freed the slaves. He is also the one who orchestrated this attack. I saw it all.”

“Good,” Fenrir responded. Then he ordered his men to go in, put out the fire, clean up, and help the faunen with the injured people. Then he turned back to Perkin and asked, “What happened?”

“Allistair,” Perkin answered. “The men were all part of his Hangover Guild. They were chanting as they destroyed the shrine and beat people. It’s obvious that Allistair has been trying to start a revolt. He was likely in the group. It was hard to tell since everyone was wearing hoods and masks, but even if he wasn’t. He incited the revolt.”

“Do you know which way the people ran off?” Fenrir asked.

“There were guards who went searching for them,” Allistair answered. “Hopefully they catch him and bring him back soon.”

Perkin and Fenrir went into the shrine to help with the mess. The faunen had been able to heal everyone except for one man, who was dead before she arrived.

“What happened?” Fenrir asked as he walked in.

The people then started telling him about how the men had come in, destroyed the shrine, and shouted about

the Hangover Guild.

Once the people had been questioned, they were free to go. Fenrir, his men, and Perkin kept cleaning.

They were almost done with the cleaning when Leon and the men with him rode up with Allistair, who had his hands tied behind his back.

Leon pulled Allistair off the horse he was on and brought him to Perkin, announcing, “I believe this is the man you are looking for.”

“Perkin!” Allistair exclaimed. “What are…”

Leon slapped him to get him quiet.

Perkin smirked at Allistair, “Surprise.” He then told Leon, “He goes to Fenrir, not me.”

Leon pushed Allistair over toward Fenrir and reported, “We found him south of here.”

“Did you see the rest of the group with him?” Fenrir asked.

“No,” Leon answered. “He was by himself. I don’t know why he left his group, but we figured you would want him immediately.”

“Indeed,” Fenrir responded. He motioned to his men and ordered, “Take him with us,” pointing to Allistair.

Allistair felt helpless. There really was nothing he could do to fight them. He sighed in despair as he was pulled back on a horse and taken to the manor. Fenrir and Perkin led the men who were guarding him so he could not escape.

As they neared the manor, he saw the hut he had rescued the slaves from before. Freeing them is what

started the path he was on, and his life had changed so much.

He glanced around. The Hidden Pearl wasn't in sight. If only he could talk to Camden. Was Camden still there? Could he order his release? Could he save Hartley? Where was Hartley? Was he in the dungeon? Had he been beaten? So many questions ran through Allistair's head, and he didn't have answers to any of them.

Allistair was becoming all to familiar with the feeling of fear. Once again, he could feel his heart race and the palms of his hands become sweaty. His muscles tensed. He'd never met Korbyn face to face, but if the rumors were true, Korbyn would not go easy on him.

Allistair hardly noticed the majesty of the manor as he was taken in. It looked bold and strong, with columns and archways. There were statues of great warriors, and all the ceilings were at least fifteen feet tall, which wasn't surprising, as the building was made when a full giant led Montlier.

Allistair was pulled in front of Duke Korbyn, who sat on a throne on a dais.

Korbyn was part giant, part crevan, as all in the house of Farrow were. His crevan part was bear, and Allistair would give him even odds against one barehanded. His giant side was strong too, as he was likely six inches taller than Allistair.

Fenrir pulled Allistair in front of Korbyn and pushed him to his knees. One of the guards pushed Allistair's head down, scolding, "Bow to the Duke."

Allistair didn't have to bow to anyone but the king, as technically he was still a Knight Avant. Yet, he put up no fight.

Fenrir then announced, “This is the man you are looking for, the one who leads the Hangover Guild who destroyed our shrine.”

Duke Korbyn stood up and stormed over to Allistair. “That shrine was sacred! How dare you and your men defile it!”

Allistair raised his head. “What? What shrine?”

“Don’t play dumb with me,” Korbyn warned. “Our sacred shrine was destroyed. People were wounded. One man was killed. You know what happened. It’s reported that you were there. Even if you were not, it was your people, your Hangover Guild, who attacked the shrine. You lead the guild, so you are responsible for inciting a revolt.”

“No!” Allistair argued. “I really have no idea what you are talking about. I have not even heard of your shrine being destroyed, and I teach the members of my guild to educate themselves and find truth. I specifically tell them I don’t want people revolting. What makes you think it was my guild who destroyed the shrine?”

“It was,” Perkin accused, stepping forward. “I saw it all. They were all wearing hoods and masks and calling out, “Hangover Guild. Hangover Guild.”

“That doesn’t mean it was them!” Allistair defended. “Do you really think they would want to do something and admit to it? It may have been people trying to frame them.”

Perkin laughed. “Of course they would want the credit. They want the cause to spread and the revolt to spread under the banner of the Hangover Guild. They did not fear saying their name because they wore hoods and masks to not be identified and because there is no

headquarters to be arrested at. It sounds like a plan that you would come up with."

"No!" Allistair argued. "I didn't. I didn't even know of the shrine. Leon captured me far south. I couldn't have been here to destroy a shrine. I had been freeing slaves and was captured by Leon while the shrine was destroyed." He looked up at Duke Korbyn, hoping that Korbyn would accept alibi.

"Nonsense," Korbyn replied. "Montlier does not use slaves. Slaves are forbidden in the kingdom of Renaud. You know that. It is a lame excuse."

Allistair tensed. They were all in on the lie against him. "I want Sir Camden brought here. He and the Knight Avants are at the Hidden Pearl."

"Indeed," Korbyn replied. He ordered guards to go fetch Camden and then continued. "We have been working with their investigation. They will testify that there are no slaves here."

Allistair was going to argue that, but he suddenly remembered Hartley had been captured and was supposed to be killed at noon. "Where's Hartley?" he blurted out. "Is he alive?"

"Hartley is of no concern to me," Korbyn answered. "I do not know where he is. Perhaps the guards have him. He was only of use to get you here. Now that you are, he is unimportant."

"Is he alive?" Allistair demanded.

"I don't know," he admitted. He turned to Leon. "Do you know what happened to him?"

"He escaped," Leon answered.

Allistair breathed a sigh of relief until Leon added, “But I sent a dozen men after him. They will catch him, and this time, they will tie his tail and bind his arms better. Apparently, the man is very dexterous, even with tied hands. He is an escape artist.”

“Do you know if they have him?” Allistair pleaded. “Is he safe?”

“If he is, he won’t be for long,” Leon hissed. “No one escapes from me and doesn’t end up caught again and paying for the humiliation.”

Allistair’s mind raced with horrible possibilities of what could be happening to Hartley. Hartley was his best friend.

He really wished Hartley would walk through the door and announce all is well, but he knew that wouldn’t happen. If Hartley was there, it would be because he was captured.

The next person through the door was Camden. He came in with Knight Avants and the guards Korbyn had sent for him.

“What are you doing?” Camden demanded of Korbyn. He suddenly turned his head, noting that Perkin was there. That couldn’t be good.

“Is Allistair one of your Knight Avants?” Korbyn asked.

“Yes,” Camden confirmed. “What are you doing with him?”

“He and his Hangover Guild have defaced our sacred shrine to the House of Farrow,” Korbyn accused. “That is a crime punishable by death.”

“Hold on!” Camden urged. “I know nothing of the Hangover Guild doing anything, and I really doubt Allistair did anything to your shrine. Let’s hear what Allistair has to say.”

“I could not have possibly destroyed their shrine,” Allistair defended. “I freed the slaves from the slave mine. I will take credit for that. Then I heard Hartley was captured and would die if I didn’t turn myself in, so I came. Leon and his men captured me, so I have the perfect alibi, Korbyn’s your own soldiers. There is no way I could have done it.”

“He lies!” Perkin argued. “He didn’t coincidentally show up right around the shrine. I heard the men chanting Hangover Guild. Even if he was not with them, which I think he was, he incited the revolt.” He pointed to Allistair, but kept his eyes locked firmly on Sir Camden.

“There is no evidence that you are not guilty,” Korbyn accused Allistair. “Thus, you will be…”

“Wait!” Allistair interrupted. “Shouldn’t I be innocent until proven guilty?”

“You already have showed you are guilty,” Korbyn explained. “You used the excuse of freeing slaves. There are no slaves in Montlier. There never were.”

“You lie!” Allistair accused. “I know there were slaves in the mines. I freed them. I know there are presently slaves all over. The women in the laundry are slaves.”

“What?” Duke Korbyn yelled. “You are accusing us of having slaves!” He turned to Camden. “You know there are no slaves. Allistair lies. We took you to the mines. We’ve taken you around the city. All is well. Did you see any slaves.”

“Not where you took me,” Camden confirmed. “That does not mean there are not or were not any, only that you did not want me to see them.”

Camden and Korbyn glared at each other.

“You will release Allistair to me, and I will let King Didier deal with the issue,” Camden ordered.

“No!” Korbyn refused. “I am a duke and this is my city. It is our sacred shrine, and he will face his trial here.”

Camden didn’t respond for a moment. What was he to do? He did have the authority to command that Allistair be given to him, but he didn’t have the number of men needed to enforce it, even though the men with him were all Knight Avants. “He deserves a fair trial,” he finally requested. “And I’d like to have it set in three days, so I can get King Didier to come to it himself. Didier assigned him the quest of finding out if there were slaves and freeing them.”

Allistair added, “Send for Lord Urvan, and he can verify that there were slaves.”

Korbyn laughed. “Yes, we have heard Urvan has brought men south of our city. I hear he is kidnapping people from my city to use as slaves in Chesterfield. I have sent men out to fight them and return my citizens. Urvan will not succeed. He may not even survive the battle to come to the trial.” Korbyn walked up close to Allistair and hissed, “They will never make it back to Chesterfield. You have failed. We know where they are, and they are being fought.”

That wasn’t a pleasant thought. Had Allistair freed the people from the mines only to have them slaughtered? What would happen to Lina? She was in that group, and

she was no fighter. If only he could be there to protect her.

“Enough!” Camden scolded. “His trial will be set for in a week to get time to gather information and witnesses.”

“No!” Korbyn refused. “He has defiled our sacred shrine and killed an innocent man.”

“I did not!” Allistair argued.

“Silence!” Korbyn yelled. “You will not take that tone with me. I could have you killed just for being disrespectful to a duke.”

“No,” Camden countered. “He is a Knight Avant. That is as high of a rank.”

Korbyn glared at him. Then he took a breath, feigned a smile, and sat on his throne. “I have made a decision. Perkin, step forward. Allistair, step forward.”

Perkin stepped forward, and Allistair was pulled forward by guards.

Korbyn then explained, “Perkin, you say you are an eye witness to the destruction of our shrine. Right now, there is no evidence that Allistair is not guilty, as his alibi is freeing slaves that don’t exist. Yet, there is no evidence of his guilt except for your eye witness. Therefore, we can have the trial in three days, or we can have a trial by arms. It is the way many accusations are decided in Montlier if the verdict is not clear.”

“The verdict is clear!” Allistair argued. “You can’t be serious about this. I was with your own guards, so I…”

“Silence!” Korbyn commanded. “You are very close to being sentenced to death for your defiance.”

Allistair became silent, and Korbyn asked Perkin, “Do you wish to have a trial in three days, or a trial by arms tomorrow?”

Perkin smiled victoriously. He then took his glove off, stepped over to Allistair and slapped him across the face with the glove. “I challenge you to a fight to the death. The winner is right, and the loser has been given justice.”

“No,” Allistair responded. “I want the trial.”

“You must accept,” Korbyn informed him. “The fight will be in the arena tomorrow at noon.”

Allistair’s heart sank into his stomach, and he felt sick. How could anyone believe he had anything to do with the shrine being destroyed? “I didn’t do it!” he defended. “I will guarantee those were not members of my guild either. Anyone can use the name. I am being framed.” He glared over at Perkin. “I know by who.”

“Then there is a double accusation,” Korbyn noted. “I guess tomorrow, we get to see who is right, and who is dead.”

Again, Allistair felt sick. Justice was not going to be served. They wanted him dead. They didn’t want the fact they had slaves getting out. What if they pursued Urvan and killed all the slaves to keep them from talking? What if they killed Lina? What if they made her a slave? His thoughts filled with panic, but he had to keep a calm head. “Make the fight in three days,” he begged. “The king and Urvan can be fetched by then.”

“I don’t need them to help settle disputes in my city,” Korbyn insisted. “The challenge has been made, and it will be at noon tomorrow.” He then ordered the guards, “Take Allistair to the dungeon. He will stay there for the

night so he does not flee."

"Wait!" Allistair begged. "May I speak with Camden first?"

"No," Korbyn refused. "Take him off."

Allistair was grabbed and taken out the door, all the time wishing Camden would order for him to get to talk to Allistair, but he didn't. Camden had grown bolder, but…

As he went out the door, he could hear some conversation, and heard Camden and the Knight Avants being dismissed. Why was Camden obeying Korbyn? Perhaps he had no choice or felt he didn't have the numbers to stand against him. Still, Allistair felt hopeless, like Camden was his only hope, and he was doing nothing.

Allistair was led down the stairs to the dungeon. It wasn't as nice as the dungeon in Roifort. The stench was horrendous, and rats scampered along the floor. The cells were all small and open, with iron bars separating the cells and holding the prisoners in.

Allistair was thrown in a cell. Fortunately, his hands weren't tied, so when he was shoved in, he didn't hit the ground hard.

He sat on the floor and watched as they locked him in. At least he wasn't being taken to a torture chamber.

"Don't get too smug," one of the guards warned. "You will be beaten, but Perkin wants the honor of doing that himself."

Any hope Allistair had shattered. He was going into a fight to the death, against Perkin, who had trained him, and he wasn't even going to be starting it at full health.

He was going to die.

Chapter 34: A Bloody Battle, Tied Prisoners, and a Bunny Guard

Lina and Haeghun led the slaves as quickly as they could south, hoping to get to Urvan and his soldiers, and hoping to get them to send help to Allistair and Hartley.

Lina had never had to walk the number of miles she had in that day and was exhausted. She kept asking the former slaves if they needed to rest or if they should keep going. They decided to keep pressing on. After all, they all wanted the safety of Urvan's soldiers and wanted to help Allistair. Plus, they were used to pushing on even when exhausted. They were all too used to going past what felt like their limits, and they assured Lina that the fast pace through the woods was much better than the whips they were used to enduring.

They had been going along the edge of the woods at the base of the mountain, but once they headed west, there was no cover, as the area was mostly a large field.

There were a few trees, but no longer the cover of thick woods. They could see Urvan and his soldiers waiting for them, but they could also see Korbyn's soldiers headed to them from the north.

"Run!" Haeghun ordered. "Women and children run south of Urvan's men. Men, let's help!"

As they began to run, Urvan's men saw them and ran to join them. They had barely caught up with each other when Korbyn's men rode up to them.

"Surrender!" the leader of the guards called out to Urvan.

"No!" Urvan replied. "It is clear that your kingdom has been using slaves, and we are freeing them. Stand down!"

"Attack!" the leader of the guard called to his men. "Spare no one!"

The guards did attack, and the soldiers with Urvan engaged in the battle. Urvan's men were at a disadvantage because the people from Chesterfield were more human than most other cities. Most had some other race mixed with them, but they definitely weren't as naturally strong as the guard from Montlier, who were almost all part giant and part crevan. Yet, Urvan's men did have numbers, especially with the slave men fighting with them. Of course, those men did not have swords or armor. They were fighting mostly with sticks they picked up in the woods, so the soldiers had to protect them. The women and children were a liability in the fight too, as they couldn't fight, but needed protection.

Still, Urvan's men had more reason to fight. They had people to protect, where the guards were just doing a job, so the soldiers fought harder.

Nevertheless, both sides fought hard, as neither wanted to die, so the clanking of swords and screams of wounded men rang through the air, screaming of the horrors of battle, but they were remote enough that no one in the cities could hear their cries. Men were dying while people went merrily about their daily lives.

Lina watched the battle with horror, and when the first of Urvan's soldiers fell, she and the faunen among the slaves ran to heal him.

As soon as she did, soldiers stepped near them to fight the enemy off so they could work.

"The wound is bad," the faunen noted, and she immediately started to heal the man. As she did, another man fell. Saving his life was up to Lina. She didn't have the healing power of faunen, but if she couldn't heal him, he'd die. She ran to him, putting her hand on her crystal.

The battle raged on, and Lina was aware of very little around her, as she tried to focus on healing through the sounds of battle. With each clanking of a sword, she knew some man could be about to die. Each scream of pain called to her, making her entire body tense, as she knew if she and the faunen couldn't get to all of them, they'd die. Yet, she had to focus. She had to heal. She put her hand on her crystal and tried to funnel the healing energy from it through her as she blew on a wounded man's chest.

*****

While the battle in the south raged, Raissa sat tied to a tree.

“Why are you doing this?” Raissa cried to a guard with rabbit ears near her. “I have done nothing to you. I just heal.”

The guard laughed at her. “We aren’t after you. We are after your bodyguard. He will come for you. We want him distracted so he can’t help Allistair.”

“What’s happened to Allistair?” Raissa panicked. “Is he going to be executed?”

The guard leaned over her and seemed to enjoy explaining, “An execution might make him a martyr to his guild. Instead, Allistair will fight a battle to the death at noon tomorrow against Perkin. He is sure to lose.”

“Allistair can beat Perkin,” Raissa defended.

“No,” the guard gloated. “Perkin trained Allistair, and has much more experience fighting. Perkin will win. We don’t want Hartley or anyone to help Allistair, so you are our trap for Hartley.”

“Are you planning on killing Hartley?” Raissa gasped.

“If needed,” the guard explained. “We prefer to put both him and you in the slave mines. Now that you have freed the slaves, we will have to find more. I think you could be useful. Faunen are always needed to heal. It is poetic justice that the people who helped free the slaves take their place.”

Raissa began to cry, but then stiffened and refuted, “Hartley will save me.”

“Hartley can do nothing,” the guard argued. “Notice that I am part rabbit crevan. I am fast and have a killer kick. Hartley cannot outrun me. One of the guards is part giant, part crevan panther. He can catch Hartley in the

trees." He pointed to another guard who had a monkey tail. "He's crevan monkey as Hartley, and the other guard with us is part fox, and he can track anyone. There is no way Hartley can come to save you and get away. I have no doubt he will come. We are counting on it."

They were right that Hartley would come. It was late at night when he did. He came through the trees and waited in the tree Raissa was tied to, happy that he'd made it that far unseen.

He looked around. Two of the guards were asleep. The part giant, part crevan panther was on watch, as was the crevan fox. That was wise, as both would have good night vision.

That was a huge disadvantage of Hartley's. He didn't have night vision, nor did Raissa. He was going just off of what he could see in the moonlight, which fortunately was bright that night. Still, he thought night the better time to attempt the rescue, as at least some of the guards would be asleep.

He watched the guards walk around, looking for a pattern to their movement. They didn't have one, but Hartley found the break he needed when the panther guard walked to the edge of camp, and turned his back on all of them.

The other guard turned to see what was happening. It didn't take long to see the other guard was just relieving himself, but that moment gave Hartley the break he was looking for. He quickly lowered himself from a low branch by his tail and cut the rope binding Raissa with a knife in his hand. "Fly off," he then ordered her. "Meet me south of here at the creek." He then pulled himself back up into the tree.

The guards quickly noticed something was going on and turned to Raissa, but she easily slipped from the cut ropes and flew up in the air. She looked down, worried that Hartley would be caught. Could she really leave him there? Yes. She had to. Likely, he had a plan, and she needed to follow his instructions. She turned south and headed toward the creek.

As she flew off, Hartley started swinging through the trees. He breathed heavily as he tried to outrun the speed of the panther, monkey, fox, and rabbit.

The fox and rabbit stayed on the ground, but the panther pursued in the trees. Fortunately, the guard also being part giant made the panther large enough to be slowed by the narrow openings in some of the branches. The crevan monkey gave Hartley a good pursuit, but fortunately, Hartley had a head start.

Hartley scampered through the trees, able to outrun the panther, as cats are made for sprinting, not distance. The fox though, had good endurance, and the monkey crevan was on the same level as Hartley. The rabbit crevan was fast, but would sprint, stop often, and then run again.

As Hartley neared the creek, he was breathing heavily from the long sprint and was worried that he was drawing attention to Raissa.

He stopped in a tree as he came to the creek, hoping Raissa was hiding and wouldn’t be seen. He turned, and grabbed a rope he had set up. That was his trap for the guards following in the trees. He pulled the rope and it caught the monkey crevan man by his feet and hung him upside-down. That would give Hartley some time to get away.

The panther man suddenly started sprinting toward him, but from out of nowhere, a branch fell on him.

Hartley looked up to see Raissa. “You can thank me later,” she called to him. “Better yet, pay me. What’s the plan now?”

Hartley looked down to the ground. Unfortunately, both the fox and the rabbit crevan were climbing up the tree. After all, they were humanoid, so they were capable of it. Hartley started pulling small branches off of the tree and throwing them at the men climbing up.

Hartley started to panic. How was he going to fight both of the guards climbing the tree?

He almost jumped to the ground, but didn’t. He had the advantage in the trees. Likely his balance was much better than either of theirs.

The fox crevan man grabbed his leg and bit it. That hurt. The man had sharp teeth, and the bite was deep. Blood flowed down his ankle and over his foot.

Hartley held himself with his tail, so he could kick the man down the tree.

By then, the rabbit crevan guard was in the tree. He kicked Hartley, hard. Hartley flew back, hitting his back against a large limb, and then fell from the tree.

He started to grab a limb with his tail, but he suddenly felt arms around him. Raissa had him.

“Hold on,” she urged. It’s hard enough to fly with you holding on.”

He grabbed around her, wishing he could help, as he could see how much she was straining with his weight.

“You can do it,” Hartley assured her. “You don’t

have to go far. We just have to lose them."

"I am flying as far as I can," she replied, struggling to get the words out, as she was straining so much to keep her wings flapping.

She wasn't able to fly high with him, but she did make it far enough to see the fire from the camp Urvan and his men were at. She'd made it to safety.

She landed and put Hartley down. "I owe you really big," he noted. "Thank you. I wish I had money to pay you with."

"I was joking about the money," Raissa assured him. "I'm not in this adventure for the money. You and Allistair are heroes. I want to help."

Hartley hugged her. "Thank you for saving me."

"Thank you for saving me," she countered. "You are my hero tonight. Might I reward you with a hero's kiss?"

"I won't turn that down," Hartley assured her. Their eyes met and he assured her, "I will try to keep being your hero, Raissa. You are amazing."

"You are too," she admitted with a sincere blush.

There were no more words spoken as they gazed into each other's eyes and slowly moved in to kiss. The kiss they gave each other was pure and hopeful.

"We make a good team," Raissa noted after the kiss.

"We do," Hartley agreed. "On that thought, can you heal my ankle. It really hurts."

Raissa looked down at it and asked, "How are you standing on it? Sit down. I'll fix it."

Chapter 35: A Coward, A Winner, and a Magic Trick

“Coward,” Allistair mumbled, as blood dripped to the floor and his nearly lifeless body hung limply from cuffs around his wrists and above his head.

“I am not!” Perkin fumed, as he struck Allistair with a hot iron.

“Then heal me and fight fair,” Allistair begged.

Perkin stepped up and hissed in his face, “I intend to have you healed before the fight. I can beat you in a fair fight. I trained you. I know every move you have. I do not need to cheat. You will be healed by a faunen, but I get to enjoy my revenge.”

“I haven’t done anything to you,” Allistair mumbled.

Perkin hit him hard with a left hook as he yelled, “You had me stripped of being a Knight Avant. Because of you, I was thrown in a dungeon and am now an outlaw. But I will get my status back. When I kill you, your testimony against me will mean nothing.”

“Camden will still tell the truth,” Allistair argued with as much energy as he could muster in his weakened state.

Perkin laughed. “He is weak. If threatened he will deny anything you said to stay alive.” He stepped back and suggested, “Shall we get back to business?”

“No,” Allistair cried. “I can’t take more.”

Perkin laughed victoriously and struck him again, that time with a hot iron.

Allistair had never experienced the extreme pain he was in before. What Perkin did to him made the whippings before seem mild.

He was barely conscious when Perkin decided he’d had enough and took him and threw him in a cell.

Allistair collapsed on the ground, unable to get up. There was no comfortable position.

Never had he felt so hopeless. He’d been through so much, but he was beaten, defeated, and likely going to die the next day at noon.

He had no idea how long he’d been in the cell, as it felt like hours with the pain he was in. He may have even slept for some hours, but he had no idea. All he knew was that he was in pain and the world around him was a blur when a faunen girl was let in.

“Thank you,” Allistair mumbled, unable to even turn to her, and hoping he wasn’t being delusional. It was hard to trust his eyes because his head was hurting so badly and the room was moving around. His senses were all incredibly disoriented.

The faunen immediately went to work healing him. It

took time with as badly as he'd been beaten, but in time the pain subsided and the wounds healed.

"How you you feel?" the faunen asked.

"Weak," Allistair answered, "but much better. Thank you. What is your name?"

"Amilie," the faunen answered. "I am sorry that you took such a beating. Perkin is indeed a nasty man. I do hope you win the fight."

"I'm not sure how I can," Allistair replied. "I'm weak. I'm hungry. I'm dehydrated. Perkin is a better swordsman than me. He taught me what I know of sword fighting. I fear I have made a mess of everything and failed everyone."

"What makes you say that?" Amilie asked. "You freed the slaves, didn't you?"

"From the mines," Allistair answered. "But they may all be captured again and being punished, or they may be dead. I don't know. I didn't get them safely to Urvan at the meeting spot. I turned myself in to save Hartley, and that seems to have been a foolish thing to do, as he escaped and I'm caught. I was hoping Camden would be able to help more. He's becoming stronger, but he's still weak. My guild was framed, and that will bring problems to anyone in it. I have failed."

"You haven't," Amilie consoled. "The slaves may have reached Urvan and all gone smoothly. As far as Hartley, he escaped. Yes, Raissa was captured, but he may have already saved her." She paused in thought. "Perhaps he was caught in an attempt to. I don't know."

Allistair almost broke down. "I've done nothing! I worked on a symptom but didn't fix the problem. I don't

know if the slaves I freed made it to safety, but more people will be enslaved, and Korbyn will deny it and put on a good show, and Didier won't see through it. I've taken too many risks and put so many people in danger, and the problem isn't solved! I have failed."

"No," Amilie assured him. "Now, you need to pull yourself together and win the duel."

Allistair looked into her eyes. "Do you know where Lina is? Is she safe?"

"I don't know." Amilie admitted. "I know faunen were sent to heal people in a battle south of here against Lord Urvan and soldiers of his, as our side was expected to take casualties, but I don't know how that battle turned out."

Allistair could feel his hands shaking. "I need to know if Lina is alive. I need to know if she is all right."

"I'm sorry," Amilie apologized. "I don't know. Whether she is or not, you need to pull yourself together. You are about to go into a fight to the death."

"I don't want to kill anyone," Allistair countered.

"I know," Amilie responded. "Yet, this duel was not your choice. It was Perkin's. He chose this, and so if you kill him, it is justified."

"I don't care if it's justified," Allistair complained. "I am fine with killing beasts, but I don't want to kill men."

"You many have to," Amilie pointed out. "He will kill you. He is boasting to people that he is going to. You must win this."

Allistair shook his head in despair. "Maybe the kingdom would be better off if I didn't. Before I got

involved, Lina, Hartley, and many more were living normal lives and the kingdom seemed peaceful."

"You did not cause the problems," Amilie assured him. "You are exposing them, but if you, Lina, and Hartley went back to how things were before, there would still be slaves. There would still be beasts attacking and towns having food confiscated, Knight Avants helping in the slave trade and having people who know too much die, and there would still be people up high working with the freedom faction. You didn't cause any of that. You are exposing it."

"And that has activated them more," Allistair countered.

"No," Amilie corrected. "It has just exposed them. Trust me that they do a great deal of horrible things." She leaned close and whispered, "I even have reason to believe that there is dark magic in the land and that is why there are chimeric beasts."

Allistair perked up. "What makes you think that, and do you know who is behind it?"

"No, I don't," Amilie answered. "I suspect that Ormondo knows something, and that the beasts attacks are somehow planned. I don't know more than that."

"How do you know that?" Allistair asked.

Amilie put on a very innocent face and admitted, "People tend to say things while faunen are healing people. They tend to not think about us being there, or perhaps think we are so focused on our work that we don't hear them. Whatever they think, faunen hear a great deal while healing."

Allistair looked into her eyes. There was an

innocence and sadness in them. A thought occurred to him, so he asked, “Are you a slave?”

“I am,” she answered.

His eyebrows furrowed. “Why don’t you fly off?”

“Because my brother is a slave too,” she answered. “If I escape, they will kill him.”

Unfortunately, Allistair didn’t doubt that was true. “Was he in the mine? Is he a faunen?”

“No,” she answered. “No to both. My mother was faunen, but he took after my father who is a mokos, like you, only not part giant. She pulled her sleeve up to show the marking of a lotus flower on her arm near her shoulder. “I have a little mokos in me.”

“What are they making him do?” Allistair asked.

“My brother works as a cook,” Amilie answered. “It is not as bad as being in the slave mine, but he still has no freedom and is whipped if he ever displeases Korbyn.”

Allistair clasped his hands nervously. “I’d rather be a slave in the kitchen than go into this fight, not that I’m approving of what is being done to you or your brother. I just am honestly terrified.”

“I understand,” Amilie consoled. “Now, you need to pull yourself up and fight hard. In the frame of mind you are in, you won’t win.” She moved to look into his eyes again. “Allistair, you are a hero. You have given many people hope. The story of the slaves being freed has spread all over Montlier. All the slaves everywhere are hoping that you will expose the slave trade and stop it. We all want to be free. You have given people hope against other wrongs too, and you will continue to, but you must live. Your Hangover Guild stands for truth. You

need to live to lead it."

"I'll just put more people in danger," Allistair complained. He put his face in his hands. "For all I know, Lina could be dead. She could be captured. She's better off without me. I was supposed to be her protector, and I ended up bringing her into trouble."

Amilie put her hand on his arm and asked, "Are you in love with Lina?"

"Very much," Allistair answered. "I'm just not good enough for her."

"Stop!" Amilie ordered, then in a very soft voice, she scolded, "I'm not trying to be harsh, but you need to pull yourself together. You are soon going to have to go to the arena and fight. You need to go in confident and motivated, not discouraged and planning on failing. I am going to be at that fight, and I don't want to be sent to you on the off chance you can be healed and have to announce that you are dead. You have no idea how hard it is to kneel over a body and not be able to save the man. Now, go out there and win. If you kill Perkin, I can announce he is dead and feel justice is done and there is hope for the truth getting out and all of us slaves being freed. If I have to announce you dead, not only do I have to feel helpless, but me, and every other slave will have our hopes die right there. Go out there and win this. Do what you must, and win! People are counting on you. All the slaves are. If Hartley and the faunen with him are caught, they are counting on you. I don't know where Lina is, but she has some elf in her, so she'll heal well. I bet she is alive and wants you to win this so you can hold her in your arms again. Right now, you don't really have the privilege of getting to feel sorry for yourself. You need to think of all the people counting on you and go out

and do what you need to do."

Allistair stared at her, not expecting a beautiful faunen to scold him like that, but she was right. He needed to stop thinking of himself. He needed to not give up on Lina and the others until he knew the facts. "Can you get me some food?" he asked Amilie.

Her smirk gave the answer, but she still added, "Didn't I just say my brother is a cook?"

Allistair tensed. "Will he get punished if you get food for me?"

"It will be worth it to him if you win," Amilie responded. "I'll get you food." She then called to the guard to open the cell and let her out.

Allistair was eager for the food, but before she came back with it, guards came to get him.

"Come," a guard ordered. "It's time to take you to the arena."

"Can I have some food first?" Allistair asked.

One of the guards gave him a piece of bread and ordered, "You can eat it on the way."

There were four guards, so Allistair couldn't fight them.

His hands were tied behind his back, so he couldn't eat the bread they had given him, and he was taken to the arena.

He was put in a room where the fighters waited for the battle. There was a room on each end for the opponents. They were large, as at times beasts were fought in the arena.

Allistair was put in and the door locked. He could see the arena through a barred gate on the other side of the room. Guards were placed at the door and the gate.

Allistair waited nervously, knowing he'd likely be dead soon.

He was pleasantly surprised when the door opened and Amilie came in with food.

"How did you get it past the guards?" Allistair asked as he took it from her. "And thank you."

"I just told them I was supposed to bring it to you," she answered. "Remember how I said people say things around faunen? Well, they don't tend to question us either when we come to help someone. It is good. Now, eat. You need your strength."

"I do," Allistair agreed. "It may make me tired though."

"You will not be tired," Amilie assured him. "You will be fighting for you life. You have to win this. People are counting on you."

That wasn't a pleasant thought, but Allistair did enjoy the food. Once he ate it, he felt much better.

"Do I get a sword?" he asked Amilie.

"They will give you one as you go out of the gate," she explained. "Now, fight and win!"

Only a moment later, Allistair heard a horn blow. Duke Korbyn then announced the battle to everyone and called both Allistair and Perkin to the field.

The gates on both ends of the arena field opened, and Allistair and Perkin both came forward. Allistair was given a sword, as Amilie had said he would.

They both approached the stand where Korbyn was and faced him. Allistair had tried everything he could to convince himself there was hope, but standing there, he could see none. So much pressure was on him, and likely he'd failed at everything.

"Prepare to die!" Perkin hissed so Allistair could hear but people in the stand could not. "I am looking forward to this. I trained you. I know I am better than you."

He was right; Allistair knew it. Was there hope? If only Lina was in the stands cheering him on, but she wasn't. He had no idea where she was or if she was even still alive.

Korbyn announced, "Allistair is charged with leading his men to revolt and destroy a shrine."

"I object!" a voice rang out.

A shocked silence came over the crowd, and everyone looked over to see who had said it.

Allistair had hoped it would be Camden standing up for him, maybe even Camden with King Didier, but he knew Camden's voice. It wasn't him. He was in the stands with the other Knight Avants, but said nothing

Everyone in the crowd turned to see who it was. No one could see his face, as it was covered by a hood, but the man explained, "I am Dusk. Allistair was rescuing the slaves from the slave mines. That is a fact. There is evidence of it, as the slaves have made it south of here and are indeed safely with Lord Urvan's men. There were casualties on both sides, but Urvan won." He then called to Allistair, "Lina is alive!"

"Arrest him!" Duke Korbyn called. "He dares to be

about my city and tries to defy my accusation."

"Wait!" Dusk insisted. "I have proof."

"We will see it after the duel," Korbyn responded. "Guards, detain him so I can speak with him after this."

Guards came after him, but he threw his cloak around him and suddenly vanished.

Everyone was shocked, and there were gasped and exclamations of horror at the sight of magic.

"Magic!" Korbyn yelled. He then turned to Allistair, his face red with rage. "Allistair, you obviously are associating with people who do dark magic! I should have your head, but I will let Perkin get it for me. The duel may begin."

Allistair and Perkin faced off.

"You will die now!" Perkin sneered.

Allistair did not respond. Dusk had just defended him, and likely was a good ally to have if he had magic. Even better, he said Lina was alive and well. That likely meant the slaves had made it. Perhaps he hadn't failed. Perhaps he wouldn't fail now.

Perkin called another taunt to him, but Allistair didn't even listen to it. He had to get back to Lina. He had to win.

A herald blew a horn to signal for them to start fighting.

Perkin came out with a strong advance. He had a sword, a buckler, and a dagger on his belt. Allistair wished he had his buckler. He'd never been trained to sword fight without a shield, and a battle to the death was not the place to learn.

Allistair parried the strikes but could not get in a counter-strike. If only he had his buckler.

He blocked another strike, wishing there was something in the terrain he could use, but the field was flat, entirely flat with nothing on it, just barren land.

The walls around the arena were eight feet high, and there were seats above the walls for the spectators, like a coliseum. There was nothing to use.

The onslaught from Perkin kept coming, and Allistair felt helpless. He needed his shield. The crowd was booing at him, but he wasn't going to make a foolish advance to try to please them. The fight wasn't for entertainment. It was for his life.

He kept parrying until he saw an opening. He knocked Perkin's sword away and struck, but Perkin parried.

"You can't kill me," Perkin hissed. "I know all your moves, and I am better than you."

That was true. Allistair knew it. He blocked a high strike. As he did, Perkin hit him with his shield. That was unexpected.

It threw Allistair off, so he missed the next parry, meeting Perkin's blade but not stopping it in time to keep Perkin's sword from getting around his and getting a cut on his upper arm.

A burn ran down his arm, and Allistair could feel blood trickling from the cut.

He threw his sword to his left hand and started fighting that way, as his right arm was feeling weak from the wound. It surprised Perkin, and Allistair got a good hit on Perkin's chest, but nothing happened. Apparently,

Perkin had armor under his tunic. No wonder Perkin was so confident he could win. He had a shield, a breast plate, and an extra dagger. The fight wasn't fair.

There was a great amount of noise from the crowd, and the wound hurt, but Allistair had to focus. He'd fought beasts before. Perkin was not stronger than a beast. Maybe he could beat him, but he needed a plan.

Perkin got another hit, as Allistair didn't fully block a strike, that time on the side of his hip. Again pain shot through him, and he had to fight hard not to go into shock. He didn't dare look at it, as the sight of blood from it would be overwhelming.

Focus. He had to focus. He couldn't let the pain stop him. He charged forward with a series of advances, but Perkin parried well or blocked with his shield, and Allistair had to get a hit that wasn't on the chest.

Allistair had to think quickly. He was cut and if he didn't win soon, he might pass out, but what could he do? Perkin had the advantage.

Panic struck, and he could almost feel the presence of death watching the fight, waiting for him. He parried a blow and glanced in the stands. Death was not there, but Amilie was. She needed him to win. All the slaves needed him to win. The people needed someone to get the truth out and take a stand.

"Die fiend!" Perkin yelled as he swung hard. Allistair blocked with his sword, but Perkin swept his legs.

Allistair fell to the ground and Perkin stepped on his sword arm and slashed his throat. Allistair was about to die, so he reached his right hand up and grabbed Perkin's wrist, struggling to keep the sword from coming down on his neck. As he did, Perkin hit him repeatedly with the

buckler, and Allistair had no way to block. He could do nothing but take the pounding, or could he? Allistair had been in some tough holds while wrestling. Granted there were no swords involved then, but he had some moves. He tried to fight through the pain and twisted to get his arm free. Then he grabbed Perkin's other arm, threw him off balance, and rolled on top of him. Allistair punched him in the face, but Perkin drew his dagger and stabbed Allistair in the gut. Allistair jumped back, shocked at the blood and feeling light-headed.

Perkin stood up, and the two faced off again. Perkin made the first move. He began to charge, but Allistair turned and ran.

He ran toward the wall with Perkin gaining on him. As he reached the wall, he ran up it as far as he could and flipped back over Allistair, landing behind him. He then took his sword and hit Perkin in the head with the hilt of it, knocking him out.

Allistair looked down at Perkin and held his sword up to stab him, but couldn't do it. He couldn't kill an unconscious man, even though he knew Perkin would have killed him. Then again, with as hard as he hit Perkin, he might be dead.

Amilie flew over to try to heal Perkin, but Allistair tried to raise his hand in victory, but instead passed out. Amilie landed by him to heal him first.

Some in the crowd were cheering, and some booing. Allistair wasn't conscious of any of it.

After a few moments of Amilie healing him, Allistair woke to a great commotion. The people were loud, way too loud for his hurting head.

Allistair looked up into the crowd. Duke Korbyn was glaring at him, obviously unhappy with the outcome.

When Allistair stood up, the crowd cheered for him. He'd won. Korbyn couldn't do anything to him.

At least, that is what he thought, but it wasn't true. He couldn't order Allistair's death immediately, not after he'd just won and taken such a beating, but after the cheers died down and Allistair walked to the edge of the field, Korbyn's guards were waiting for him, many of them. He was surrounded. Leon was leading them.

"You are coming with us," Leon him.

"But I won," Allistair argued.

"I know," Leon replied calmly. "You are coming with us to the dungeon, Duke Korbyn's orders."

"No," Allistair defied, reaching for his sword.

A guard behind him immediately pulled his sword and hit Allistair in the head, knocking him out. In all the commotion, they dragged him off. He was going to the dungeon to await his fate.

Chapter 36: Demands, Whining, and a Killer Raccoon

It was late the next afternoon, at least that was what Allistair thought, as it was hard to tell time passage in a dungeon, when guards came for him.

“Come!” Leon ordered.

“Where are you taking me?” Allistair asked.

“To Duke Korbyn,” Leon answered. “This should be interesting. Apparently, Lord Urvan is here, and Camden has informed Korbyn that he sent knights to get the king, so he should be here soon too.”

“This should be interesting,” Allistair noted with a smile.

He was taken to see Duke Korbyn, and Leon had reported correctly that Lord Urvan was there. To make the day better, Lina was with him, and so was Hartley and Raissa. That had to have a story behind it.

Camden was there with Knight Avants too, so likely what Leon had said was right about that too.

Allistair had many questions, but he first ran to Lina, who threw her arms around him.

“I’ve been so worried!” she exclaimed. “I hear you fought Perkin in a battle to the death.”

“I was so worried about you,” Allistair replied, not even thinking of her question.

It didn’t matter that they were in a great room with two leaders of cities, he gave her a kiss, one very fitting of the situation, and most of the people in the room smiled at it, not Duke Korbyn.

“Enough!” Korbyn insisted. “We have business to attend to.”

“We do,” Lord Urvan insisted. “You will return Allistair to me. I’d like to take custody of Perkin too. He was let loose from the dungeon in Roifort. He likely will be here too. I want him held in Chesterfield.”

Urvan could see Korbyn’s chest rise in anger before Korbyn seethed, “You cannot order me! I am the ruler of a noble house, and you a mere lord of a small city.”

“You will do as I demand,” Urvan argued. “I may not be on duke level, but the slaves Allistair rescued are being taken to my city. I have proof you have been using slaves and will take that to the king.”

Korbyn laughed in response. “What will that matter? King Didier doesn’t run this kingdom, Ormondo does, and he was appointed by me. I am the real man with power in this kingdom. You can do nothing. At the next tournament, I plan to enter myself, so I will have the title of king. Now, be gone!”

“I demand Allistair and Perkin,” Urvan insisted. “I am not leaving without them.”

Korbyn waved his hand, “Fine. You can have both Allistair and Perkin. I have no need for either. Take them and be gone.” He then stood up, walked down the steps of the dais his thrown was on and straight to Urvan. He glared at him as he warned, “You and your little town of Chesterfield need to beware. I will be king after the next tournament, and I will get revenge on you and your so-called city.”

He then stepped over to Allistair and hissed, “You are banished from my kingdom. If you ever return, you will be killed on sight.”

“Seriously?” Allistair responded. “Do you really think I want to come back? I’d rather dive naked into shark infested waters or wrestle a crocodile in a pool of…”

“Stop!” Urvan ordered. “Let’s just go.”

Urvan and his soldiers led the group out of the great hall.

“Where do we go now?” Allistair asked. “Should we head to Chesterfield of to Roifort?

Allistair was surprised that Camden came up from behind him and answered, “You go to Chesterfield. I will take the Knight Avants back to Roifort and give a full report to King Didier. I suggest once you are sure everything is fine with the former slaves and your city is safe that you come to Roifort. I am sure the king will want to meet with you and get your full report.”

“I agree,” Urvan added. “I must go back to Chesterfield. The former slaves need help either settling

in to a new life or going back to their land. I must also make sure defenses in our city are heightened. After all, I have made a bad enemy of Korbyn. He has great power and many more resources than I have."

"Then let's go to Chesterfield," Allistair agreed. He then thanked Camden for his help, since the distraction of having the Knight Avants inspecting for slaves really did help.

Camden took his knights and headed north, while Lord Urvan took Allistair, Lina, Hartley, Raissa, his soldiers, and Perkin to the horses they had waiting for them to return to Chesterfield on.

The ride to Chesterfield seemed longer than it should, as Allistair kept worrying about Korbyn sending men to try to kill him.

Perkin was tied and put on a horse, and complained the entire trip. Allistair was very tempted to bind his mouth.

"You will regret this," Perkin hissed at Allistair. "I will get out of the dungeon again, and you will pay for what you have done to me."

Allistair laughed back. "Seriously? You think someone is going to let you out? You don't have allies in Chesterfield."

"I do," Perkin argued. "Sir Elliot will…"

"He's in the dungeon in Chesterfield already," Allistair explained. "Now, you were saying?"

Perkin became very quiet.

"Good," Urvan noted. "That is a very good choice. You do realize I could order your execution? You falsely

accused Allistair, had him beaten, and tried to kill him. I suggest you watch what you say."

Perkin put on a very humble look and replied, "But of course. I would never want to upset you, Lord Urvan. I have always admired you, and how smoothly you run you city. Perhaps I can somehow assist you."

"You aren't getting out of being thrown in a dungeon," Urvan scolded. "Good behavior may keep you from a death penalty though. Now, quiet!"

Perkin did remain quiet the rest of the trip back to Chesterfield. It was a long day's ride they had to make, so they ended up camping in the woods, as they had a late start.

They tied Perkin securely and the rest of them sat around a camp fire.

Everyone seemed very happy, except for Allistair. He sat there staring nervously at the fire.

"Don't worry," Lina assured him. "You won. The slaves are free and all is well. I'm sure King Didier will give you a hero's welcome on your return."

"And I want my promised money," Raissa called to them, as she was sitting close enough to hear, and beside Hartley.

"I thought I was paying you," Urvan noted.

"You both are," Raissa explained. "You aren't getting out of it. Getting paid by two sources for the same job is called good business."

"You little mercenary," Hartley joked. "How about if you and I go to the top of a tree and make sure there is no trouble coming?"

Raissa looked over at Urvan and noted, “I came as a healer, but have done much more than that, so we need to renegotiate my pay. I think I earned more than agreed to.”

“Did we even have a number that was agreed to?” Urvan asked.

“No,” Raissa answered, “but you did say you’d pay well. We may have different definitions of well. I want well by my terms.”

“We’ll see,” Urvan replied, shaking his head and chuckling. “Go check for trouble.”

Raissa jumped up in the air and started flapping her wings, and Hartley jumped into a tree. The two were quickly off.

“They make a cute couple,” Lina noted.

“We make a better one,” Allistair noted. “I am fortunate to get to court you. I just wish I actually had the chance.”

“Hopefully, we will,” Lina replied.

Allistair shook his head. “I fear this is just the start of our adventures.”

As if on cue, Urvan called over, “Allistair, we have a great deal of planning to do. I didn’t want to tell you this before, but two men died in the battle with Korbyn’s guards. One was a slave. The other was Louis.”

Allistair gasped. He knew Louis. Louis was his age and was courting a lovely maiden. Allistair took a moment before he could speak. “Didn’t you bring faunen to heal?”

“Yes,” Urvan answered, but the enemy’s sword went through the slit in his helmet. He died before a faunen

could get to him."

Allistair stood up and walked away from the fire with his back to everyone.

Lina followed him. She hugged around his chest. "I am sorry. I know that this is hard on you, that you feel that every death is due to you. That has to be hard, but it's not your fault. You are doing what is right, and you are forcing no man to follow you. Louis chose to be a soldier of Chesterfield. He knew the risk."

"You didn't," Allistair responded. "When we started traveling together, I was coming as your protector. Instead of protecting you, I have pulled you into danger."

"True," Lina agreed. "Yet, I choose to continue with you. If I wanted out, I could find another protector and go back to just being a minstrel, but I want to come with you. I want to support you. What you are fighting for is wonderful, and you are fighting through peaceful means. I plan on staying by you as long as you will let me. That is my choice."

He put his arms around her and admitted, "You're too good for me."

"I know," she playfully teased. "Now, you've been through enough. Let's enjoy our night. We'll deal with the problems when we must."

Unfortunately, that didn't happen. As soon as they sat back down by the fire, Urvan stated, "We need to plan."

They suddenly heard noise in the woods and all jumped to alert, wondering why Hartley or Raissa hadn't warned them of danger.

They figured it out quickly and all burst out in laughter as a raccoon came walking toward them.

“Beware, the killer raccoon!” Allistair joked. “I wonder if they taste good.”

Chapter 37: A Medal of Honor, An Insult, and a Juggling War

After spending a week in Chesterfield to help Urvan with the aftermath of the adventure, Allistair, Lina, Hartley, and Raissa rode to Roifort and met with King Didier. He was excited about the success and decided to award Allistair a special medal of honor. The ceremony took place the next week, so people could be informed and come to the ceremony.

Allistair's parents and sister came, as did Lord Urvan. Many people from Chesterfield showed up, and ceremonies always had a good turnout from the people of Roifort.

The ceremony was done in the courtyard, so everyone who wanted to come could see it, but the celebration afterward was in the great hall and was by invitation only.

Allistair was happy that his family was allowed in. He wished he could sit at a table with them, but he was put at the head table with the king, his counselors, Lord Urvan, Lina, Hartley, and Raissa. Having Ormondo there made him rather uncomfortable, but he tried hard to ignore Ormondo's looks that could kill.

There was more food than Allistair had ever seen in his life, and he was very happy to get to try new flavors. The turkey legs alone would have been a grand treat for him.

After the banquet, there was dancing, so Allistair danced with Lina. It felt good to get to hold her in his arms and enjoy his success at freeing the slaves. Sure, there would be more trouble, but for the night, he could enjoy his success.

After everyone had danced long enough to need a break, King Didier called for entertainment.

Jean-Paul, the court jester sprite, who currently had blue hair and eyes, came out to perform. He started with making an act of changing colors. He would do things like blow on his thumb and change colors, or try to match colors to look like someone in the crowd. He pulled a maiden up and asked her to describe her dream man, and he changed colors to try to match it and sang a short love song to her.

When he was done with that act, he sang a few little ditties. He ended with:

> "Oh, I'm a fool. I want to be. I do it to myself.
> I make a better fool, than any mokos, rhys, or elf.
> So, laugh at me. It makes me smile. Laughs scream, "Huzzah!" to me.

I love to play the fool. It's true. I do it naturally.

We fools all love applause. To us, it's music to
our ears.
We're more impressive when we're high on
rowdy, raucous cheers.
Oh, I'd do anything to please a crowd, for you
deserve
Great foolishness and antics. It's my life. I'm
glad to serve."

He took a bow and then he started juggling. The act became even funnier as Hartley swung onto the floor and stole a ball from him. Jean-Paul and Hartley then started a juggling competition and made quite the show of it.

Allistair enjoyed watching the entertainment and getting a chance to relax, and was very surprised when King Didier called for Lina to entertain.

"I guess we're up," Lina told Allistair. "Shall we sing?"

"Were you expecting this?" Allistair asked.

"No," she answered, "but minstrels always have to be ready to perform at a second's notice. Get up."

Allistair couldn't refuse Lina, so he got up and went to the center of the floor where the entertainers had been performing.

"What do you want to hear about?" Allistair called to the crowd. "Shall we sing of our adventure or do you want some happy song to celebrate?"

"Happy," Lina suggested, even though there were calls for both from the crowd.

She began playing her lute, and Allistair drummed as he sang:

"Let's seize the night. Let's have some fun. Let's stay up 'til we fall.
Let's celebrate. To feel the joy, we don't need alcohol.
If you don't drink, you'll keep your head. You won't act like a fool.
Embarrassing mistakes you'll thwart, no need for ridicule.

You won't go dancing with a mop, or think the broom's alive.
Or jump into the fireplace, our dinner to revive.
You won't start howling at the moon, or singing way off key.
You won't be foolish and undress. That's great! You should agree.

You won't go kissing strangers and end up with a black eye,
Or get into a food fight, throwing biscuits made of rye.
You won't expose dark secrets, telling what you're thinking of.
You won't talk to a stranger and confess you are in love.

Enjoy your night. We've earned a rest, relaxing with some fun.
Tonight we celebrate our quest, the victory we won.
Now slaves are free. The knights are led, by Camden, a good man.

Now Perkin's in a dungeon. Zounds! I think I like that plan.

So dance and sing, make merry. Fill the hall with light and joy,
Just try to keep it sober, so your actions don't annoy.
I've sung a song. I've entertained. I hope you all had fun.
So please can I go back and sit? I think this song is done.

He took a bow, and walked back to the table he'd been at. Lina took over and sang a song. Then she told the tale of how they'd rescued the slaves, and the crowd kept looking over at Allistair with looks of approval. At least most of them did. Ormondo glared at him all through it.

Allistair tried his hardest to not let Ormondo ruin his night. After all, he'd been given a great honor and earned his break.

But later in the night, as he was dancing with Lina, Ormondo walked up to them and asked, "May I cut in?"

Lina wasn't sure how to respond, so she looked over to Allistair who saw her fear.

"Seriously?" Allistair responded. "You want to dance with my girl? What for? Do you intend to threaten her?"

"No," Ormondo answered. "I intend to threaten you. I was going to tell her to warn you to stay away from Roifort." He stepped closer to Allistair, and in a very cold, but quiet tone, so others couldn't hear, threatened, "Stay away from Roifort. Dissolve your guild, and watch

your back. You can run, but you can't hide." He then snubbed Allistair and walked off.

"I'd rather dance with a killer raccoon!" Lina called after him, then she turned to Allistair and asked, "What do you think he's going to do?"

"I don't know," Allistair answered, "but I think what we went through already is going to look small compared to the adventure to come."

Lina smiled at him. "So, you aren't giving up?"

"Do you know me?" Allistair asked. "Their threats motivate me more. I am determined to expose the evil and intrigues. Perkin tried to discredit the Hangover Guild, but I want to see it grow."

"I hope it does," Lina agreed. "You know I'll follow you."

Allistair stopped dancing for a moment, and stood in thought.

"What?" Lina asked.

He shook his head. "Don't worry about it. I was just thinking that this situation is going to get harder, and I think we need to make a trip to Bellemar. It may be time to see if there's a way to put the rightful rulers back in power."

"That sounds ambitious," Lina noted. "Let's worry about fixing the kingdom tomorrow. Tonight, let's enjoy the celebration. After all, it's for you because you are such a hero."

"I'm no hero," Allistair responded. "I just do what needs to be done."

"I think you are a hero," Lina corrected. She put her

hand on his chest and added, “You are definitely my hero.”

They were interrupted again, as people began calling for them to entertain again.

“I’ll take care of this,” Lina assured Allistair. She stood up in front of the people and started singing:

> “This quest was a success, but it’s only the beginning.
> There’re battles still to fight, so let’s hope we keep on winning…”

As Allistair listened to her sing, Ormondo stepped up behind him, leaned over him, and sneered, “You may have won a battle, but you won’t win the war!”

Allistair tried to keep his fear from showing, and calmly replied, “I guess we’ll see.”



DeBokton Book

Find your hero within!

DeBokton.com

Don’t miss the exciting sequel:

Knight Errant!

Allistair has freed the slave in the mines in Montlier, but has made many enemies, enemies with great power. Now, if he is going to expose the corruption and get the evil men out of power, he has to find a way to put the rightful rulers back on the throne. To do that, he’s going to have to risk his life and hope he doesn’t endanger everyone in his guild and the people he loves most.